



VOLUME 11 • NUMBER 4



THE RUSSELL SAGE JOURNAL OF THE SOCIAL SCIENCES

RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation
Journal of the Social Sciences

The US Deportation System and Its Aftermath

VOLUME 11, ISSUE 4, NOVEMBER 2025



The US Deportation System and Its Aftermath

ISSUE EDITORS

Caitlin Patler and Bradford Jones

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Russell Sage Foundation

112 East 64th Street
New York, NY 10065

ISSN (print): 2377-8253
ISSN (electronic): 2377-8261
ISBN: 978-0-87154-835-1
ROR: <https://ror.org/02yh9se80>

The US Deportation System: History, Impacts, and New Empirical Research



CAITLIN PATLER^{id} AND BRADFORD JONES^{id}

The United States is unique in the size and scope of its deportation system. Between 2001 and 2022, US Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) carried out nearly 6.5 million deportations. Deportation is often framed as a singular event that happens to an individual. We conceptualize deportation more broadly as a system that encompasses premigration, within-US, and post-deportation contexts and outcomes. In this introduction, we explain this conceptualization, establishing the existence of differential paths into the deportation system that begin even prior to migration, depending on migrants' access to paths to legal entry, which are shaped by political and economic factors. We then review multidisciplinary literature on the implications of the deportation system for individuals, families, and communities in the United States, as well as for the US economy, politics, and political outcomes. Finally, we review research on post-deportation outcomes in countries of origin and how deportation can lead to remigration to the United States, thus rebooting the deportation system. While a broad and interdisciplinary literature has helped illuminate the deportation system, there is still much to learn. To that end, we end with a description of the contributions of this issue and directions and challenges for future research.

Keywords: deportation, immigrant detention, immigration enforcement, immigration policy, crimmigration, unauthorized immigrants

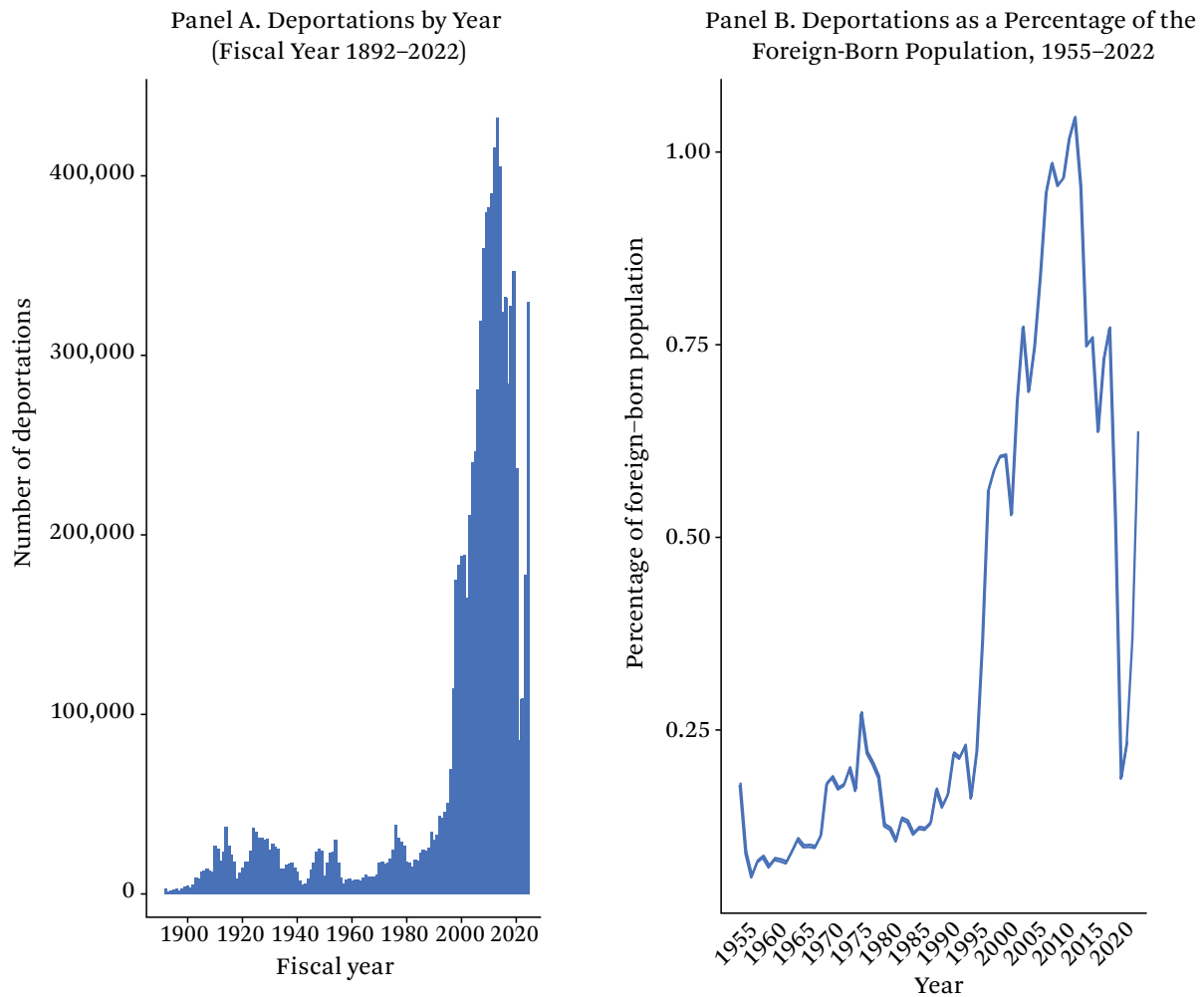
The United States is unique in the size and scope of its deportation system. Between 2001 and 2022, US Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) carried out nearly 6.5 million deportations. This represents a stark departure from the approximately 17,000 average total an-

nual removals from 1892 to 1995 (Patler and Golash-Boza 2017). Figure 1 illustrates this dramatic change by plotting removals from 1892 (the first year the US government officially began reporting deportation statistics) through 2022 (panel A) and deportations as a percentage

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Patler, Caitlin, and Bradford Jones. 2025. "The US Deportation System: History, Impacts, and New Empirical Research." *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 1–24. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.01>. The authors are grateful to Suzanne Nichols and the anonymous reviewers at the Russell Sage Foundation. Direct correspondence to: Caitlin Patler, at patler@berkeley.edu, Goldman School of Public Policy, University of California, Berkeley, 2607 Hearst Avenue, Berkeley, CA 94720, United States. Bradford Jones, at bsjjones@ucdavis.edu, One Shields Avenue, Davis, CA 95616, United States.

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Figure 1. Deportations over Time and as a Percentage of the Foreign-Born Population

Source: Deportation data from Department of Homeland Security and foreign-born population data from US Census Bureau.

of the foreign-born population from 1955 to 2022 (panel B). Panel A shows that around 80 percent of all deportations have taken place since the mid-1990s.¹ Panel B shows that at the peak of mass deportations, over 1 percent of the total foreign-born population in the US was deported each year.

Deportation is often framed as a singular event that happens to individuals. We conceptualize deportation as a system that encompasses premigration, within-US, and post-deportation contexts and outcomes. Regarding

premigration contexts, for many immigrants, the potential for exposure to the deportation system starts even before an immigrants' journey to the United States, depending on their access to paths to legal entry, which themselves are shaped by political and economic structural forces. Within-US refers to the experiences of migrants and their families and communities in the context of US immigration laws, policies, and enforcement patterns. Post-deportation outcomes encompass the experiences of deported people and of de facto

1. This number does not include removals by US Customs and Border Protection, which made over 9.4 million arrests between 2008 and 2022 (Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse 2022). It also does not include voluntary removals, whereby eligible migrants placed in removal proceedings can leave the US on their own within a specified period, instead of being formally removed (Goodman 2020). Since the United States began reporting voluntary removals in 1927, over 49 million individuals have left via voluntary removal status.

deportees who are not themselves directly expelled but leave with the deported person, along with social, economic, and political responses to deportation and deported peoples. Deportation can also lead to decisions to return to the United States in an irregular status, thus restarting the deportation system cycle with an additional layer of vulnerability. Our conceptualization of deportation as a system furthers the theorization and documentation of the direct and indirect impacts of the deportation system and its aftermath.

This article begins by providing additional background on the size, scope, history, and political context of US deportation policy. We then expand on the deportation system as a framework for understanding the vast and multifaceted impacts of US immigration laws and law enforcement, as well as broadly describe the empirical underpinnings of this framework. We conclude with a brief description of the methodological challenges facing researchers studying the deportation system, specifically issues related to data access and transparency. Finally, we preview the contributions of the articles in this issue.

THE DEPORTATION SYSTEM IN CONTEXT

The United States has a long history of forcibly removing noncitizens (Goodman 2020). The Alien and Sedition Acts of 1798 first granted presidential power to detain and deport noncitizens, and the 1891 Immigration Act solidified federal control over immigration laws. The Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882 provided the gatekeeping architecture that characterizes most of contemporary US deportation policy by reinforcing restricted access to citizenship while establishing “new bureaucracies, modes, and technologies of immigration regulation,” such as passports, residence documents, and regulations surrounding unauthorized immigration and deportation (Lee 2006). Throughout the twentieth century, the US engaged in several high-profile deportation efforts, including massive repatriation and deportation efforts in the 1930s and the infamous Operation Wetback in 1954. These efforts explicitly targeted Mexican immigrants together with Mexican American citizens, collec-

tively resulting in the removal of millions of people, and caused significant economic and social harm.

Though deportation has long been a feature of US immigration policy, as noted previously, 80 percent of all deportations have occurred since the mid-1990s. This exponential rise in modern-day mass deportation was enabled and facilitated by what scholars often refer to as “crimmigration” (Stumpf 2006)—the merging of some of the most punitive aspects of US criminal and immigration laws. One consequential feature of modern-day mass deportation, enabled by crimmigration, is the deputization of state and local law enforcement agencies to engage in federal immigration law enforcement. However, mass deportation is also enabled by policies that limit access to lawful pathways to the United States, including for asylum seekers and others fleeing economic, political, or social conditions.

We now describe the evolution of these crimmigration measures, beginning in the 1980s and spanning Republican and Democratic administrations. In response to illegal drug use and drug trafficking, the Ronald Reagan administration implemented the Anti-Drug Abuse Acts of 1986 (ADAA I) and 1988 (ADAA II). ADAA I laid the groundwork for local law enforcement to share information with immigration officials regarding immigrants who had been arrested or convicted of drug offenses. In turn, immigration officials could issue detainers—requests to local law enforcement to detain immigrants until immigration authorities can assume custody. ADAA II went further still, inserting into immigration law for the first time the notion of aggravated felonies, a special class of offenses defined only in US immigration law that carry harsh immigration consequences. In contrast to their name, such crimes do not have to be aggravated or felonies, and while ADAA II initially focused on drug-related crimes, the definition has grown to include “many nonviolent and seemingly minor offenses” such as theft, failing to appear in court, simple battery, and filing a false tax return (American Immigration Council 2021).

The Reagan administration also implemented the Immigration Reform and Control Act (IRCA) in 1986. While IRCA is often cited for

its amnesty provisions, resulting in the legalization of nearly three million undocumented immigrants and their family members, it also codified into law mechanisms wherein immigration officials can sanction employers suspected of employing undocumented workers. These sanctions permitted the use of worksite enforcement actions such as workplace raids. While workplace raids have historically contributed only a fraction of overall apprehensions, they invoke fear and turmoil in immigration communities, which we describe further later.

With the crimmigration foundation laid in the 1980s, the 1990s saw a vast expansion of the US deportation system. This was enabled by changes to US immigration laws under the Bill Clinton administration that dramatically expanded immigration law enforcement and collaboration between federal and local law enforcement (codified in ADAA I), expanded the categories of deportable offenses, made deportability for such offenses retroactive, limited previously existing protections from removal, and limited due process protections for noncitizens in deportation proceedings (Patler and Golash-Boza 2017). The Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act of 1996 (hereafter IIRIRA) was one of the most consequential policies. Most notably, IIRIRA added Section 287(g) to the Immigration and Nationality Act, which established Memoranda of Agreement, hereafter referred to as 287(g) agreements, authorizing immigration officials to delegate some of their apprehension and detention functions to state and local law enforcement officers, effectively converting police officers into *de facto* immigration officers (Armenta 2017). IIRIRA also made several other changes that facilitated mass deportation such as implementing the process of expedited removal, which permits immigration officials to deport individuals quickly and without an appearance before an immigration judge (American Immigration Council 2023).

By the start of the twenty-first century, the crimmigration framework was thoroughly embedded in law. The George W. Bush administration further reinforced the criminalization of immigration following the events of Septem-

ber 11, 2001, by creating the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) to oversee all immigration legal and enforcement matters, which were previously spread across the Departments of Justice, Labor, and the Treasury. Importantly, the Homeland Security Act created ICE to enforce immigration law and codified the immigration courts (the Executive Office for Immigration Review, or EOIR) under the Department of Justice. The use of 287(g) agreements and workplace raids also proliferated after the formation of DHS (see Peacock 2025, this issue). The George W. Bush administration also dramatically expanded large-scale removals by introducing Operation Streamline in 2005, wherein immigration courts can quickly prosecute and deport large numbers of undocumented migrants, often in groups of eighty or more.

Deportations accelerated during the first and second Barack Obama administrations through heavy reliance on 287(g) agreements between local police and ICE, as well as the expansion of expedited removal at the US-Mexico border. The Obama administration also introduced the Consequence Delivery System (CDS), designed as a program to deter migration at the southern border by allowing US Customs and Border Protection (CBP) to apply various consequences to migrants, depending on their previous migration history (Capps et al. 2017). Many CDS actions resulted in detention, which made it possible for families to be separated at the border, including children from their parents, wives from husbands, and so on. This became a large-scale problem during the Obama administration as family units increased from 3 percent to 14 percent of apprehensions from FY2013 to FY2014, and by FY2016, children and family groups together accounted for a third of the total (137,000 out of 409,000 cases) (Capps et al. 2017). The child separation policies that would become a hallmark of the Donald Trump administration (see Law 2025, this issue) thus had roots in the CDS program.

The Obama administration, however, also implemented changes in how deportations should be prioritized. In 2011, ICE Director John Morton articulated a new enforcement strategy directing ICE officers to consider a number of factors before acting on a removal

order, including an immigrant's ties to the United States and the severity of an immigrant's criminal convictions (Morton 2011). The Obama administration continued its focus on criminality by introducing the Secure Communities program in 2008, which fomented the massive expansion of federal-local entanglement enabled under 287(g) by allowing data-sharing between federal, state, and local law enforcement agencies. Secure Communities was so widespread that so-called sanctuary jurisdictions, in which local law enforcement officials are generally not permitted to execute the functions of DHS, proliferated in part as a response (Collingwood and Gonzalez O'Brien 2019).

By the end of the second Obama administration, Secure Communities was largely phased out, in part because of opposition and organizing from immigrant communities. However, the apparatus within DHS to implement mass deportation remained in place through 287(g) and the Priority Enforcement Program (PEP), introduced in 2014 to prioritize individuals convicted of felonies or multiple misdemeanors or with existing deportation orders (American Immigration Council 2017).

Thus, when Trump assumed office in 2017, among his very first acts as president was to re-implement 287(g) agreements and Secure Communities. In total, the first Trump administration took 1,296 actions on immigration, nearly all targeted at limiting the admission of immigrants and refugees to the United States or restricting the rights of immigrants already living here (Immigration Policy Tracking Project 2025). Most actions were issued by executive branch agencies such as DHS and EOIR, among others, or as presidential executive orders, thus bypassing the legislative process. Notably, Executive Order 13768 eliminated all priorities for immigration enforcement, explicitly making mass deportation the end goal. Further, in May 2018, Attorney General Jeff Sessions initiated the policy of family separation, whereby chil-

dren and adults in family units apprehended at the border were intentionally separated (see Law 2025, this issue).

Of the nearly 1,300 Trump-era actions on immigration, about 680 remained in place during the Joe Biden administration, which faced considerable pressure to further restrict entry as an unprecedented number of asylum seekers arrived at the southern border of the US. For example, while the Trump administration issued the March 20, 2020, order implementing the COVID-19-era policy of Title 42,² under which migrants or asylum seekers apprehended at the border were immediately returned to Mexico, the Biden administration kept this policy in place until May 2023, when the COVID-19 emergency declaration formally ended. Ultimately, Title 42 resulted in 2.8 million expulsions across the first Trump and Biden administrations (Long 2023).

The Biden administration also enacted several other immigration policies that enabled deportation, most notably affecting asylum seekers. In 2024, Biden reenforced a 2018 Executive Order disallowing any asylum claims made outside of an official port of entry. Also in 2024, President Biden issued an executive order severely restricting asylum by tethering the number of asylum seekers to a formula based on DHS records of migrant apprehensions.³ This order fundamentally changed the process by which asylum claims could be made, thus massively slowing entry of asylum seekers, creating an immense backlog of asylum seekers on the border, and likely increasing the undocumented population by limiting the grounds for legal entry (Chishti et al. 2024). After running on a platform of anti-immigrant messaging, Trump returned to the presidency in January 2025. From the first day in office, the Trump administration immediately began to implement draconian immigration enforcement actions to remove immigrants from the United States, with the highest price tag in US history: On July 4,

2. Title 42 refers to the 42 U.S.C. § 265, a section of the Public Health Service Act.

3. Under the order, if DHS encountered a daily average of more than 2,500 people between ports of entry during a seven-day period, entry of anyone without a CBP One appointment—including individuals eligible for asylum—would be denied. CBP One was a phone application implemented by the Biden administration to allow migrants to schedule asylum screenings from outside the United States.

2025, Trump signed into law H.R. 1 (referred to as the “One Big Beautiful Bill”), which allocated a staggering \$171 billion to DHS, up from \$65 billion in 2025 (American Immigration Council 2025). As of October 13, 2025, the Trump administration had taken 477 actions on immigration, nearly all geared at increasing deportations, restricting admissions, and limiting immigrants’ rights (Immigration Policy Tracking Project 2025). Perhaps most consequentially, the administration has dramatically expanded the scope of the 287(g) program to further allow state and local law enforcement agents to engage in immigration enforcement activities that channel noncitizens into the deportation pipeline. While in January 2025, at the end of the Biden administration, ICE had 135 287(g) agreements in place, as of September 11, 2025, a staggering 1,000 agreements were in place across forty-two states (Kocher 2025a).

The second Trump administration has also taken a series of actions to subject more people to deportation and make deportations easier, including by limiting admissions (through, for example, travel bans), revoking valid visas (for example, from international students and faculty and those with Temporary Protected Status), and cancelling funding for legal services for unaccompanied minor children and people with severe cognitive disorders in immigration court. The Trump administration also seeks to end birthright citizenship for any child without at least one lawful permanent resident or US citizen parent, which experts estimate “would strip 4.74 million U.S.-born children of citizenship over the next two decades, with impacted children representing more than one in every 18 (5.7%) U.S. births over that period” (Heiges-Goepfert et al. 2025, 2). The administration has also declared a national emergency on the southern border and invoked the very rarely used Alien Enemies Act of 1798 to give itself wider latitude to detain and deport individuals without due process, including 238 Venezuelans sent to El Salvador’s Center for the Confinement of Terrorism (CECOT) prison in March 2025. Finally, President Trump also signed into law the Laken Riley Act (passed by Congress under

the Biden administration), which initiates deportation proceedings for immigrants who are accused of low-level crimes like shoplifting and gives states broad authority to sue the federal government over immigration outcomes in their jurisdictions.

Taken together, these actions, if fully implemented, will almost surely result in the massive growth of the US undocumented (and thus, deportable) population, so long as economic and political conditions in sending countries remain unchanged and the US continues to rely on immigrant labor in key industries. For example, the repeal of birthright citizenship would increase the undocumented population by an additional 2.7 million by 2045 and 5.4 million by 2075 (Van Hook et al. 2025). Finally, while many of the administration’s executive orders and actions have been challenged in the courts, with federal judges issuing a series of national injunctions, the US Supreme Court has permitted the Trump administration to proceed with many of its efforts while the cases advance through the courts, and the final outcome of these proceedings may still be years away.

The specter of future enforcement actions proposed by the Trump administration remains front and center in public debate. This includes, for example, calls to deport immigrants to Libyan prisons (despite that country having a Level Four travel advisory for US citizens), punish sanctuary jurisdictions, reopen federal prisons for immigrant detention, and continue the mass apprehension and detention of immigrants, including those lawfully present in the US. Fear and outrage have spread through communities across the US following highly publicized coverage of immigrants being apprehended on the streets or pulled from their cars by masked (and often plainclothes) agents, often in front of screaming children or families (Laviates 2025; Kile 2025), and of young, US citizen children, including at least one four-year-old suffering from Stage Four cancer, being removed from the US alongside their parents (Lopez and Das 2025). These actions and threats underscore the need for a much deeper understanding of the implications of the deportation system; this is the contribution of this issue.

CONCEPTUALIZING THE DEPORTATION SYSTEM

We conceptualize deportation in broad terms, as a system with an often circular nature that encompasses premigration, within-US, and post-deportation outcomes, including the potential for remigration to the United States. In this subsection, we expand on the underpinnings of this conceptualization.

How Premigration Contexts Channel Migrants into the Deportation System

Migration to the US is driven by a complex set of structural push and pull factors, including economic and political conditions in sending and receiving countries. US immigration laws specify discrete options for legal admission to the United States and relief from removal, such as through a direct family tie, employment, or humanitarian considerations. These categories—and their corresponding visa allotments, in which no country can account for more than 7 percent of visas in any given year, irrespective of demand—often exist regardless of the interconnected political, social, economic, and environmental realities of sending countries or the United States. This leads to differential and unequal paths to legal status, thereby creating disparate exposure to the deportation system, often stratified by racialized group and class (Martínez 2022).

Contemporary mass migration to the US from Mexico provides one notorious example of the mismatch between immigration law and migration realities that leads to differential exposure to deportation. Beginning in 1942, in response to labor shortages in the agricultural industry, the US government recruited and provided temporary visas for laborers from Mexico through the Bracero program. At its height, this program recruited up to 450,000 workers per year and became a structural feature of the US and Mexican economies (Massey et al. 2002). However, the Bracero program ended abruptly at the end of 1964, followed ten months later by Congress' passage of the Hart-Cellar Act, which

created, for the first time, quotas on migration from the Western Hemisphere. Thus, with the Bracero program's termination and no similarly sized visa allocation in place, "undocumented migration was the only possible outlet" for the ongoing structural reliance on migration in Mexico and the United States (Massey et al. 2002, 41). Unsurprisingly, the population of undocumented Mexican immigrants in the United States ballooned after 1965.

To the present day, most Mexican nationals who do not have direct family ties in the United States have few options to migrate to the US legally.⁴ This reality, combined with over a century of binational economic reliance on Mexican labor in the United States, increases the likelihood of Mexican migration without authorization, thereby heightening vulnerability to the deportation system. Certain geographic areas of Mexico, namely those home to indigenous Mexicans, are even less likely to have access to visas to legally enter the United States, creating further disparities in the experiences of migrant illegality (Asad and Hwang 2018; Herrera 2016) and subsequent deportability. Despite intensive funding to boost US border security, Mexican undocumented migration is driven predominantly by economic factors; indeed, increased border enforcement has led to more (not less) undocumented migration (Massey et al. 2016), and the Mexican undocumented population has only begun shrinking since the mid-to-late 2000s in response to the US recession and to economic and demographic shifts in Mexico (Masferrer et al. 2025).

Central American migration provides another example of how US politics and policies create unequal paths to (un)documented immigration status and thus potential exposure to deportation. Large-scale migration from Central America began after 1979 following the US government's intervention in the revolution in Nicaragua, as well as its support of right-wing regimes in Guatemala, El Salvador, and Honduras. Fleeing political conflict, violence, and related economic disruptions, many mi-

4. Even individuals with family ties can often wait decades for visa processing owing to the notorious visa backlog. For example, as of August 2025, Mexican nationals who are married sons or daughters of US citizens and are being processed for a visa have been waiting since February 2001 (nearly twenty-five years); see <https://travel.state.gov/content/travel/en/legal/visa-law0/visa-bulletin/2025/visa-bulletin-for-august-2025.html>.

grants from these four countries entered the US without authorization or overstayed tourist visas. However, while the 1997 Nicaraguan Adjustment and Central American Relief Act (NACARA) allowed Nicaraguans to proactively apply for legal permanent residence, Salvadorans and Guatemalans were only authorized to apply for a suspension of deportation or cancellation of removal, that is, not legal permanent residence, and only defensively, and Hondurans were not covered at all. Consequently, Nicaraguan immigrants “disappear[ed] from the undocumented population,” while migrants from El Salvador, Guatemala, and Honduras remained undocumented or “languished in . . . the legal limbo of temporary protected status.” (Massey et al. 2014, 1032). As of 2021, around 63 percent of Salvadorans (800,000 of 1,300,000), 70 percent of Guatemalans (700,000 of 1,000,000), and 75 percent of Hondurans (525,000 of 700,000) living in the US were present without authorization, up from 55 percent, 63 percent, and 73 percent, respectively, in 2010 (Passel and Krogstad 2024; Massey et al. 2014; Moslimani et al. 2023). As the cases of Mexican and Central American migration show, the political relationship between the US and sending countries shapes migrants’ premigration circumstances and access to legal status, with significant consequences for subsequent exposure to the deportation system (see also Asad 2024; Canizales 2024).

Inequities in exposure to the deportation system, even prior to migration, are reinforced through regulations surrounding the manner of entry to the US, in which consequential distinctions exist between individuals who enter the US without inspection and those who enter the US legally and overstay visas. Under current US immigration law, to eventually legalize status, individuals who entered without inspection must leave the country and apply to be lawfully admitted, while visa overstayers do not have to leave the US because they were at one point lawfully admitted. Moreover, all applicants for lawful admission must prove that they do not meet any grounds of inadmissibility, yet one such factor is a history of unlawful presence in the United States. Furthermore, IIRIRA created automatic and nondiscretionary three- and ten-

year bars for admission based on time in unlawful status, which are triggered precisely when a person leaves and applies to come back to the United States. As such, the reentry bars almost exclusively apply to border crossers and not to visa overstayers.

Reentry bars have consequences, for example, for spouses of US citizens who are otherwise eligible for permanent residency through marriage or other family petitions but face reentry bars owing to initially entering the US without inspection (American Immigration Council 2024). In one example, Mexican national Emma Sanchez entered the United States without authorization in 2000, where she soon met and married Michael Paulsen, a US citizen and Marine veteran (Humanizing Deportation 2019, 2020). The couple had three children together and applied to adjust Emma’s status through their marriage. However, “immigration laws stipulated that applicants seeking legal status must return to their country of origin [and reenter lawfully] . . . but once an applicant who had been living in the United States without permission left the country, they were automatically barred from re-entering” (Sanchez 2016). This bar kept Emma and Michael separated for over a decade, forcing Emma to miss important milestones in her children’s lives and even keeping her from her husband during a medical emergency. Cases like Emma’s prompted the Biden administration to introduce in August 2024 the Parole in Place (PIP) program, which would have allowed eligible spouses to remain in the United States while their applications are processed, had it not been stopped by a court.

Importantly, because working-class immigrants from Mexico and Central America are much more likely to have entered the US without inspection than other undocumented people, they are disproportionately exposed to reentry bars. In this way, US immigration laws reinforce differential exposure to the deportation system among the world’s migrant population by racialized group and class. The reentry bars also prevent many people from legally returning to the United States following deportation, for example, to reunify with family (see also Vargas Valle et al. 2022; Valdivia 2025, this issue).

Within-US Consequences of the Deportation System

The previous section established the differential paths to exposure to the deportation system, which can begin even prior to migration. We now turn to the implications of the deportation system for immigrants and their communities in the United States. We begin by reviewing the demographic portrait of deported immigrants, focusing on false narratives of immigrants as criminals which are promoted by political elites and other issue entrepreneurs. We then provide a summary of the literature on the outcomes of deportation for individuals, families, and communities, in addition to the economy, US politics, and political outcomes.

The Myth of Immigrant Criminality

Political rhetoric about immigration commonly relies on false narratives of immigrant criminality (Ferris and Mohamed 2018; Albertson and Gadarian 2015; Figueroa-Caballero and Mastro 2018). Yet despite the ubiquity of such narratives, the reality is starkly different: Immigrants in general, and undocumented immigrants in particular, have lower offending rates than US citizens overall (Light 2024). Furthermore, as more immigrants move to US cities, violent crime rates decrease (Ousey and Kubrin 2009). In addition, most deported people have committed no serious criminal infraction (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2019), and deportation does not reduce violent crime rates (Hines and Peri 2019). As of August 2025, over 70 percent of immigrants detained by ICE (41,822/59,380) had no criminal record (Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse 2025). With respect to deportation, figure 2 shows the number of individuals deported between 2003 and 2024 by ICE's criminal infraction classification system. This figure makes clear that most deported individuals either have no criminal conviction or have minor (level 3) convictions.

Despite being false, immigrant criminality narratives have been pervasively reinforced by political elites. For example, in October 2020, just days before the US presidential election, President Trump issued an executive order making November 1 a "National Day of Remembrance for Americans Killed by Illegal Aliens." Such narratives are persistent and reemerged

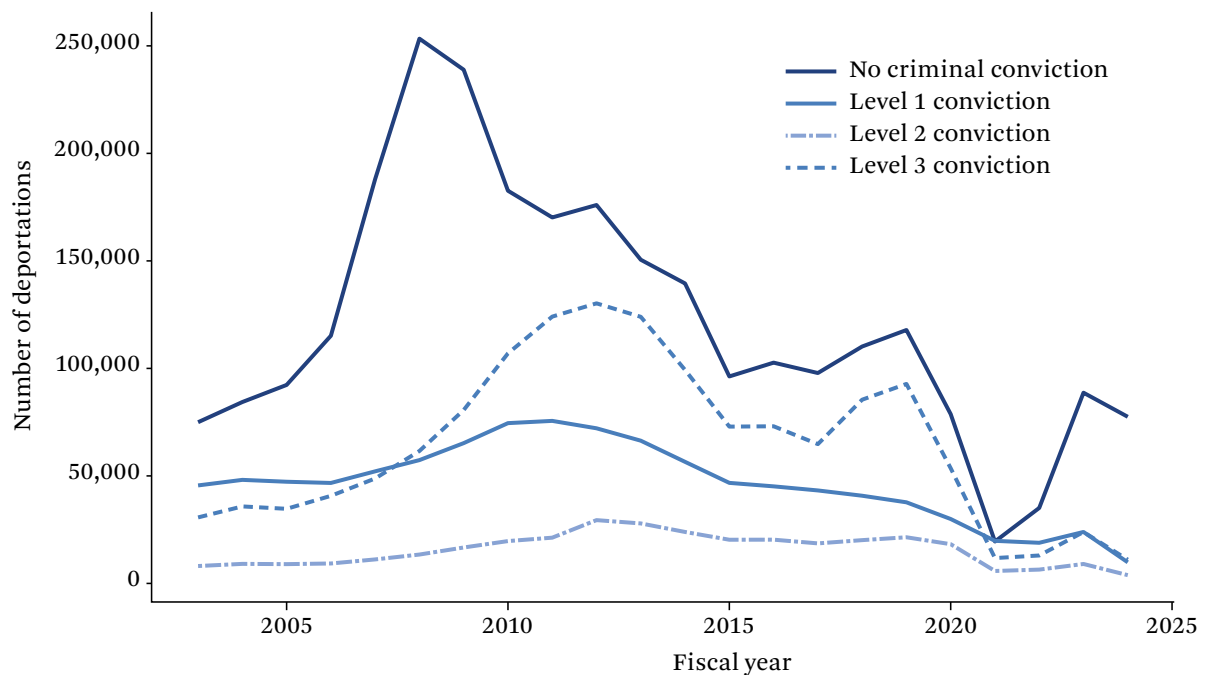
in the 2024 US presidential election campaign, with presidential candidate Trump and his running mate frequently linking violent immigrant criminality to lurid and vivid portrayals of victims while making false claims about the prevalence of violent criminality among immigrants (Brennan 2024), including false and racialized claims about Haitian immigrants in Ohio (Levien 2024), and repeatedly promising to implement "the largest deportation [program] in the history of our country" (Paquette and Brulliard 2024). After his victory in the 2024 election, the Trump administration escalated criminality narratives, using them to justify, for example, the invocation of the Alien Enemies Act to facilitate mass deportation without due process.

In spite of vast evidence against it, the narrative of immigrant criminality has induced anxiety toward, and fear of, immigrants (see also, Albertson and Gadarian 2015; Brader et al. 2008; Branton et al. 2011; Ferris and Mohamed 2018; Ramírez and Peterson 2020). Experimental studies demonstrate that when White Americans are exposed to immigrant criminality narratives, their support for punitive policies, harsher legal sentencing, and deportation significantly increases (see also, Brader et al. 2008; Figueroa-Caballero and Mastro 2018). Similarly, studies using observational data show that in geographic contexts where deportation rates are high, White Americans demonstrate increased trust in government compared to those in low-removal contexts (Rocha et al. 2015). This literature illustrates how myths about immigrant criminality, spread by political elites, can sway public opinion, thus increasing support for even more punitive deportation policies spearheaded by the very same political elites.

Consequences of the Deportation System for Individuals, Families, and Communities

The vast majority of deported people are men from Latin America and the Caribbean, leading scholars to conceptualize deportation as a gendered and racialized system that disproportionately impacts non-White families and communities in the United States (Golash-Boza and Hondagneu-Sotelo 2013; Maltby et al. 2020; Martínez 2022; Ngai 2004). The impacts

Figure 2. Most Deportations Are of Individuals with No Criminal Convictions or Minor Criminal Convictions



Source: Authors' calculation based on Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse, <https://tracreports.org/phptools/immigration/remove/>.

Note: ICE identifies three levels of criminal infractions. Level 1 convictions are the most serious, including violent crimes. Level 2 infractions are serious but less serious than level 1 convictions. Level 3 convictions are very minor infractions (for example, driving with a broken taillight or unlawful reentry into the United States).

of the deportation system extend far beyond individual deported people: Eleven to twelve million undocumented immigrants reside in the United States as of 2023. Most of them are in the labor force and share households with 6.6 million US citizens, including 5.7 million US citizen children (Warren and Kerwin 2017, 2024).

An important legal feature also characterizes US deportation policy. Unlike criminal law, immigration law is administrative in nature and therefore lacks several of the procedural safeguards that exist in the criminal legal system, such as the right to government-appointed counsel and a speedy trial. For this reason, advocates have referred to the immigration detention system as “indefinite imprisonment without trial” (Arulanantham 2022). In addition, the Supreme Court of the United States, relying on case law from the era of Chinese Exclusion, has repeatedly ruled that deportation is not a punishment, but rather an administrative process

of returning to their home countries noncitizens who are deemed inadmissible to the United States. Many observers refute the definition of deportation as non-punishment, especially given the harsh consequences of removal as experienced by the very individuals subject to the actions (Goodman 2020; Reiter and Coutin 2017; Slack 2019), the compounded vulnerability for children and families of deported people (Patler and Gonzalez 2021; Dreby 2015), and the harms to the US economy (East et al. 2023; East and Velasquez 2025).

While undocumented status creates unique vulnerability to deportation, any noncitizen can be deported if found in violation of US immigration laws. This includes lawful permanent residents (LPRs), who make up one in ten deported people each year (Immigration Policy Center 2010). Many LPRs are unaware that their status, despite its nominal permanence, does not shield them from deportation; others face linguistic, financial, or other barriers to naturaliza-

tion that would protect them from deportation. However, as noncitizens, they remain subject to grounds of inadmissibility that trigger deportation, including the retroactive penalties imposed by IIRIRA. This has been the case, for example, for thousands of refugees from Southeast Asia who were born in refugee camps and brought to the United States as young children, adjusted their status to LPR, and later had contact with the criminal legal system with little or no legal advice as to the immigration consequences of various plea bargains (Southeast Asia Resource Action Center and American University Washington College of Law Immigrant Justice Clinic 2018). Without the protections of naturalization, many such individuals end up in deportation proceedings. LPRs also tend to spend the longest periods of time detained by ICE as their removal cases proceed (Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse 2013).

As the deportation system has expanded, research on its consequences has proliferated. This body of work provides ample evidence of the deportation system's harmful direct, indirect, spillover,⁵ and intergenerational impacts on socioeconomic, political, and health and well-being outcomes (see, Amuedo-Dorantes and Lopez 2017; Barreto et al. 2009; East et al. 2023; Lopez 2019; Perreira and Pedroza 2019; Wong et al. 2020). For example, in contexts where mass removals are higher, children of immigrants experience poorer educational outcomes (Amuedo-Dorantes and Lopez 2017; Weber 2022) and US-born individuals experience decreased employment and wages (East et al. 2023). Mass deportation programs such as Secure Communities have been linked to increased incidence of adverse infant health outcomes, such as low birth weight among infants born to foreign-born Latina mothers, through mechanisms such as increased maternal stress and lack of adequate prenatal care due to chilling effects—at an estimated annual cost of nearly \$1.6 billion (Vu 2023; see also Hong et al. 2025, this issue).

Immigration law enforcement tactics like large-scale immigration raids have also been linked to deleterious outcomes in Latino com-

munities, including higher levels of enforcement stress and lower self-rated health (Lopez et al. 2017; Lopez 2019), increased risk of low birth weight among infants (Novak et al. 2017), and reduced enrollment in Head Start programs (Santillano et al. 2020). Raids are also linked to declines in student achievement, reduced educational and employment paths, increased school absences and exclusionary disciplinary actions, diagnoses of substance use disorder and depression, increased incidents of self-harm, and suicide attempts or ideation, among children of immigrants (Heinrich et al. 2022; Bennett et al. 2025, this issue; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2025, this issue).

Even the threat and possibility of deportation, or what Nicholas De Genova calls “deportability,” (2002, see also De Genova and Peutz 2010) can have profound negative impacts on health and well-being, leading to worsening health in contexts of higher deportation threat (Gemmell et al. 2019; Jones et al. 2021; Vargas and Ybarra 2017). The notion of deportability is important: Even in the current era, most immigrants do not face imminent deportation, but millions live in spaces of deportability, where the threat of deportation can undergird daily life (Asad 2024). In contrast, decreasing deportation threat—for example, through the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) program—can lead to improved health, both for directly impacted individuals and for their families (Hainmueller et al. 2017; Venkataramani et al. 2017; Patler and Pirtle 2018; Patler et al. 2021; Hamilton et al. 2021; Patler et al. 2019). In addition to its deleterious impacts to health and well-being, the deportation system also has significant negative effects on the US economy, an issue we consider next.

Consequences of the Deportation System for the US Economy

Deportation harms the US economy in several ways, despite common political arguments to the contrary. This is true historically and today. For example, the mass repatriation of Mexicans in the 1930s has been causally linked to reduced employment and occupational down-

5. Following Asad Asad and Mathew Clair (2018), we define spillover as the impacts of the deportation system on people, communities, and institutions that are not the direct targets of immigration law enforcement.

grading of US-born workers (Lee et al. 2022). Research on the more recent era of mass deportation has focused on the Secure Communities program, the staggered rollout of which allows for causal research designs to measure impact. This growing body of research shows that Secure Communities has had negative impacts on both the immigrant and US-born labor force. The Secure Communities program decreased the employment of undocumented immigrants but also decreased employment and hourly wages among US-born individuals, likely given the important, complementary roles that undocumented workers play in the US economy (East et al. 2023; Mayda and Peri 2017). Secure Communities also reduced the labor supply of college-educated US-born mothers with young children by increasing the cost of outsourcing household production to undocumented immigrants, such as caregiving and other services (East and Velásquez 2025). Secure Communities has also been linked to reductions in self-employment rates across the country and to negative impacts on the income of the self-employed, with stronger effects among White and male individuals and workers in the manufacturing and service sectors (García and Gutiérrez-Li 2023).

Deportation also harms the economy by increasing poverty and economic hardship in immigrant and US citizen communities, especially among Latinos. Secure Communities led to reduced enrollment in federal safety-net programs such as the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) and Supplemental Security Income (SSI) among Hispanic-headed citizen households, likely owing to fear of deportation of family members, rather than stigma or lack of information about benefits (Alsan and Yang 2024).

Taken together, this research shows that mass deportation programs like Secure Communities have significant negative ramifications for various sectors of the US economy. In addition, existing economic research makes clear that labor market outcomes improve in the context of reduced exposure to deportability, for example, through legalization programs (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2007; Lozano and Sorensen 2011).

Consequences of the Deportation System for Political Outcomes

Deportation and the threat of deportation also significantly impact political outcomes and attitudes. An expanding body of work examines the relationship between immigration enforcement and political attitudes and behaviors. For example, Hannah Walker and colleagues (2020) examined whether proximal contact with immigration enforcement influences protest activity and found a significant positive association between contact with immigration enforcement and participation in protest activities among White and Asian survey respondents. Among Black and Latino respondents, the willingness to participate in protests was high regardless of proximal contact. In a similar vein, Ariel White (2016) found that voter turnout rates among Latinos residing in Secure Communities locations significantly increased after exposure to the program. She argues that, with the increased threat of removal aimed at Latinos, Latino activist groups successfully mobilized Latino voters in these locations.

Other research has examined how having social ties with undocumented immigrants and deported people impacts political judgment and behavior. Walker and colleagues (2019) demonstrate that among Latinos, close ties to individuals threatened with detention or deportation have a complex impact on political behavior: In the context of detention or deportation threat of a close friend or family member, Latinos may disengage from political institutions out of fear they may expose their friend or family member (see also Patler and Gonzalez 2021). However, other forms of civic engagement, such as participating in collective action efforts like signing petitions, attending rallies, and other related efforts, significantly increase among those with close ties to threatened individuals. Marcel Roman and colleagues (2022) similarly show that ties to undocumented immigrants led to an increase in protest activities (see also Baretto et al. 2009).

More generally, higher rates of exposure to detentions and deportations are associated with a variety of political outcomes and attitudes. Elizabeth Maltby and colleagues (2020) examined the relationship between Latinos' proximity to locations experiencing large-scale deporta-

tion and “linked fate”—the belief that one’s future is dependent on the group’s future. They found that among native-born Latinos, feelings of linked fate were substantially higher for those exposed to high-level immigration enforcement, compared to those not exposed to such environments, providing evidence that threatening enforcement environments have spillover effects on individuals ostensibly shielded from enforcement actions (that is, US-born) but who have ties to co-ethnics who are directly impacted by enforcement actions. Similarly, in a survey experiment, Bradford Jones and colleagues (2021) demonstrated that exposure to explicit details of Trump’s 2016 immigration agenda significantly increased deportation anxiety among foreign-born and US citizen Latinos.

Deportation has also been linked to political trust. Using survey data from Texas, Rene Rocha and colleagues (2015) considered the differential effects of residing within and outside locations involved in the Secure Communities program. They found that among Latinos, exposure to Secure Communities and the subsequent increases in deportations led to significant decreases in trust in government as well as endorsement of political efficacy—the belief that individuals have agency in making political change. However, among White survey respondents, high deportation exposure had the opposite effect, wherein White respondents reported a significantly higher level of trust in government and political efficacy compared to Whites not exposed to Secure Communities immigration action.

Variation in immigration policies from restrictive to accommodating can also have an impact on political behavior. Angela García (2021) leveraged variation in local immigration laws in Southern California towns and cities and found that the nature of immigration policy had divergent effects on behavior. For Mexican immigrants residing in places with restrictive local immigration policies, individuals became more vigilant and informed about immigration enforcement but were less politically engaged compared to Mexican immigrants in more accommodating locations. Taken together, research on the political implications of deportation and immigration policies has wide-ranging, highly variable outcomes.

Post-Deportation Outcomes

We have briefly reviewed the extensive impacts of deportation on social, economic, and political outcomes in the United States. The question of what happens after deportation is also important—and understudied. Indeed, while the deporting country (for example, the United States) may turn its back on expelled individuals, the afterlife of mass deportation extends far beyond the deportation itself (Andrews and the Students of the Mexican Migrants Field Research Program 2023). For many families, deportation signifies permanent or long-term family separation, with particularly detrimental impacts for children who remain in the US, including harms to health, behavior, material hardship, and academic outcomes (Martinez-Donate et al. 2024).

The research on post-deportation outcomes broadly takes four paths. One body of research examines the economic, social, and political impacts of mass deportation on countries of origin. These studies, predominantly focused on deportation from the US to Mexico and El Salvador, analyze the mostly detrimental impacts of mass deportations on the economy (for example, firm behavior, wages, and employed deported people’s experiences; Anderson 2015; Bandiera et al. 2023), children’s educational opportunities (Sviatschi 2019), and violent crime rates (Rozo et al. 2020).

Another group of studies explores how states and institutional actors in countries of forced return structure the reintegration of deported individuals and their families, with policies ranging from criminalizing to ignoring to welcoming (Golash-Boza 2015; Hagan and Wassink 2020). Existing research also documents the challenging and multifaceted experiences of deported people who struggle to make ends meet and face stigma, prejudice, and discrimination in their countries of origin (Andrews and the Students of the Mexican Migrants Field Research Program 2023; Andrews and Khayar-Cámara 2020; Boehm 2016; Caldwell 2019; Dingeman 2017; Golash-Boza 2015; Hagan and Wassink 2020; Rivera Sánchez 2019; Masferrer et al. 2025). For instance, deported migrants often face high levels of precarity and stigma after deportation from the United States (Buckinx and Filindra 2015; Slack 2019; Masferrer et al. 2025).

Finally, a growing body of research focuses on questions of changing family configurations following deportation. When a family member is deported, mixed-status families must make difficult choices about whether and how to stay together, reunite in the country of origin, or return separately to the country of expulsion (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2015; Hamilton et al. 2023; Vargas Valle et al. 2022; see also Escamilla García and Cerón 2025, this issue; and Valdivia 2025, this issue). Children of deported people who leave the US with their parents—*de facto* deportees—also face social and institutional exclusion (Boehm 2016; Caldwell 2019; Dreby 2015; Hamilton et al. 2023; Hoffmann 2024; Zayas 2015; see also Hamilton et al. 2025, this issue).

While research increasingly addresses the post-deportation context, this body of research is still relatively smaller than the research focused on the pre-deportation and within-US components of the US deportation system. Even less is known about the rebooting of the deportation system among individuals who return to the US following deportation (Valdivia 2025, this issue).

THIS ISSUE

This introduction advances a conceptualization of deportation as a system spanning pre-migration, within-US, and post-deportation outcomes, which is often circular in nature. We have laid out the historic legal and political roots and contemporary consequences of US deportation policy (crimmigration), which has been a key issue across multiple presidential administrations. We then reviewed a multidisciplinary body of research on deportation with the goal of laying a foundation and setting a research agenda for the future. To that end, we now turn in greater depth to the contributions of this issue, which explores a wide range of impacts of the deportation system, including how the system functions and is perpetuated (Ian G. Peacock); the impact of US immigration enforcement on families, schooling, and social services uptake (Cora Bennett, Virginia Graves, and Benjamin Meadows; Youngjin Stephanie Hong, Marci Ybarra, and Angela S. García; J. Jacob Kirksey and Carolyn Sattin-Bajaj); political communication about immigration issues (Tina Law); the well-being of individuals who

reenter the United States following deportation (Carolina Valdivia); the impact of family composition on decisions to return to the United States following deportation (Ángel A. Escamilla García and Adriana M. Cerón; Erin R. Hamilton, Claudia Masferrer, Angelita Repetto, and Nicole Denier); and the impact of external shocks in immigrants' home countries on removals from the US (Agustina Laurito and Ashley N. Muchow). We briefly consider these contributions in the context of our conceptualization of the deportation system and discuss emergent themes in the articles.

Perpetuation and Growth of the Deportation System

As we have described, mass deportation is enabled primarily through the merging of the US immigration and criminal legal systems, including the dramatic expansion of 287(g) agreements. Ian G. Peacock analyzes the factors that led to the diffusion of 287(g) agreements across the country between 2002 and 2011. Using a difference-in-differences design with data recording county participation in public official associations (POAs), such as the National Sheriffs' Association (NSA) and the Major County Sheriffs of America (MCSA), Peacock generates three findings with tremendous importance for the current era. First, the NSA and MCSA had significant influence on counties' decisions to opt into 287(g) agreements. Second, opting in to a 287(g) agreement was a diffusion process wherein counties simply reused the language from previously opted-in counties' participation letters, thus spreading POA influence from one county to others. Third, the extent of this influence impacted the degree to which counties cooperated with ICE: Highly influenced counties increased their commitment to immigration enforcement by, among other things, devoting more jail space to ICE detainees and complying with ICE detainer requests at higher rates. Thus, this article not only documents how county involvement in 287(g) agreements occurred but also how participation proliferated across the country. Peacock's article provides important explanatory potential for the current rise of 287(g) agreements under the second Trump administration, which have also been enabled by state policies mandating par-

icipation (or penalizing abstention), including in Florida, Virginia, and Texas.

Ultimately, Congress makes US immigration policy, but the executive branch has been increasingly empowered to influence its implementation. Tina Law explores how the dynamics between a strengthened executive branch and a sharply divided Congress influence the development of deportation policy. Using a policy feedback framework, which emphasizes the mutually reinforcing relationship between policies and political institutions, Law creates an original dataset and uses computational text analysis to analyze congressional responses on Twitter to the rollout and subsequent suspension of the Trump administration's 2018 family separation policy. The findings show that members of Congress from both parties respond selectively to executive actions on deportation, particularly when policies are perceived as politically untenable or unpopular. These patterns raise important questions about the balance of power in shaping deportation policy and the broader consequences for migration governance and democratic accountability.

Pre-Migration Experiences

While most of the articles in this issue address within-US or post-deportation contexts, Agustina Laurito and Ashley N. Muchow consider an increasingly relevant question facing migration scholars with important implications for the entire deportation system: measuring the impact of climate change on migration. The authors examine the impact of natural disasters in countries of origin (for example, storms, droughts, extended periods of high temperatures, floods, and other natural disasters) on US deportation rates of citizens from those countries. Using a causal research design, Laurito and Muchow find a significant increase in removals of immigrants from countries where disasters occurred in the period following the disaster, relative to the removal rate in the period prior to the disaster. The notion of pre-migration context is relevant in the two possible mechanisms that may explain this result. The first potential mechanism suggests the occurrence of catastrophic events would increase the propensity for migrants to irregularly migrate to the US, resulting in increased deportations.

The second potential mechanism suggests that changes in the behaviors of undocumented migrants from the country of the disaster who are already residing in the United States could impact exposure to deportation. The authors do not find strong evidence that natural disasters impact the decision to irregularly migrate (mechanism 1). Instead, they demonstrate increases in labor force participation among undocumented immigrants already residing in the US who may be seeking to generate income for remittances in the wake of natural disasters, in turn making more immigrants vulnerable to apprehensions and deportations, for example, through workplace raids or audits (mechanism 2). While the article does not address the post-deportation context, it stands to reason that if more individuals are deported from the US owing to downstream impacts of country-of-origin disasters, this could trigger a return to the United States in irregular and potentially more vulnerable statuses, thus rebooting the deportation system.

Within-US Consequences

Several of the contributions to this issue explore the relationship between immigration enforcement or the threat of enforcement and a variety of outcomes. Two articles consider how immigration enforcement influences academic achievement. Cora Bennett, Virginia Graves, and Benjamin Meadows analyze the impact of ICE enforcement actions at the school-district level. The authors merge data from Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) requests containing all ICE arrests over a ten-year period (2008–2018) for five southern states (Alabama, Arkansas, Louisiana, Mississippi, and Tennessee) with Stanford Education Data Archive (SEDA) data on school achievement from every school district in those states. The analysis links immigration enforcement actions to a large and robust decrease in math and language arts achievement, suggesting that local communities experience enforcement actions as traumatic events.

J. Jacob Kirksey and Carolyn Sattin-Bajaj also consider the impacts of immigration enforcement on children's outcomes. Specifically, they document how immigration raids impact employment and education among Latinos

and English-language learners. Their article examines a 2018 ICE immigration raid at Long Trail LLC, a trailer manufacturing plant in North Texas, which resulted in 159 arrests affecting four nearby counties. Using a synthetic control design comparing pre-raid and post-raid outcomes, they find that applications to four-year higher education institutions significantly declined, college readiness scores and applications for college financial aid significantly declined, and employment rates significantly increased among legally vulnerable students following the raid. They attribute this latter change to the likely need for additional sources of income in the wake of increased deportations within the community.

While the preceding two articles address the negative downstream outcomes of the deportation system on educational outcomes, Youngjin Stephanie Hong, Marci Ybarra, and Angela S. García examine the everyday threat of a deportation on social safety net participation among families with young children. Using data from the California Health Interview Survey (CHIS) from 2008 to 2020, the authors examine the relationship between expanded deportations under the Secure Communities program and enrollment in social safety-net programs including SNAP; Medicaid; Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC); Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF); and Head Start and state preschool programs in California. They find that higher removal rates were negatively associated with children's enrollment in WIC, TANF, and Medicaid among likely undocumented mothers who had lived in the US for five years or less, relative to US-born mothers. Taken together, these three articles add to a growing literature documenting the spillover harms of immigration law enforcement on children of all ages, many of whom are US citizens, with potentially harmful ramifications for their long-term development and opportunities.

Post-Deportation Consequences

The final set of articles in this issue explores questions pertaining to post-deportation consequences and experiences, with an emphasis on the impacts of deportation on families. Ángel A. Escamilla García and Adriana M. Cerón

address an important question—the decision to return to the US after deportation—among a large and growing but vastly understudied population: Central American migrants. Relying on semi-structured interview data from Central Americans who were deported, as well as survey data from the 2014–2018 Survey of Migration in the Southern Border of Mexico (EMIF Sur), they find that deported Central Americans with existing family in the US (that is, a spouse, child[ren], or both) were significantly more likely to express intentions to return to the US compared to those without family in the US. Moreover, they demonstrate trauma and anxiety due to family separation as a potential key mechanism prompting the desire to return immediately to the US following deportation. The article underscores the powerful role of family in shaping migration decision-making, even after deportation.

While Escamilla García and Cerón explore the factors that can lead families to return to the United States even after deportation, Erin R. Hamilton, Claudia Masferrer, Angelita Repetto, and Nicole Denier consider the factors that cause the phenomenon of *de facto* deportees (family members who leave the country because another family member has been deported). While the US records individual deportations, it keeps no records of *de facto* deportees; the Mexican government has also failed to consistently measure this population. The novel analysis by Hamilton and colleagues provides the most up-to-date statistics on the number and demographic characteristics of *de facto* deportees in Mexico. Relying on analysis of Mexican census data, the authors conclude that more than eleven thousand individuals were *de facto* deportees in Mexico between 2015 and 2020, with a disproportionate number being children and women. The first of their kind, these findings underscore once again the importance of family to deported migrants, as well as the gendered nature of the US deportation system.

The final article in this issue, by Carolina Valdivia, considers post-deportation consequences in an interesting and original way. Analyzing seventy-one in-depth interviews, Valdivia zeroes in on the lives of deported individuals who subsequently reenter and reside in

the US, most frequently to reunite with family, thus rebooting the deportation system. She argues that while many immigrants in the US experience a high degree of vulnerability due to deportation threat, previously deported returnees and their families experience new and heightened levels of precarity, a condition she calls hyper-illegality. This understudied population is extremely vulnerable, given that US immigration policies are far more punitive for individuals who have previously been deported (for example, reentry after deportation is a criminal offense, not a misdemeanor). Valdivia's article documents the trauma, stress, fear, and anxieties faced by returning deported people living in states of hyper-illegality and their families. This article contributes valuable insights to extant work on the psychological impacts of deportation, which extend beyond deported individuals. It also provides a framework for understanding the vast and often circular nature of the US deportation system.

CONCLUSION

This issue considers new perspectives on the implications of the US deportation system, which we conceptualize as entailing premigration experiences, within-US consequences, and post-deportations outcomes. Each of the contributions to this issue speaks to aspects of this system, including by describing its operation and growth. While these insights reflect an advancement of our understanding of the impact and effects of deportation, considerable methodological challenges remain for all researchers interested in the US deportation system. In particular, researchers face concerning barriers to data access and transparency from DHS (Government Accountability Office 2024; Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse 2017, 2019). For example, a recent report by the Government Accountability Office (2024) found that ICE understated its detention numbers by up to tens of thousands of individuals, a trend that appears to have continued into 2025 (Kocher 2025b). The Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse has also documented "gross irregularities in recent data releases from the Executive Office for Immigration Re-

view (EOIR), the agency that oversees the US immigration court system" (Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse 2019), as well as ICE's refusal to transparently report detainer information (Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse 2017). Recently, however, the Deportation Data Project successfully resolved FOIA litigation requiring DHS to provide individual identifiers for every person in its system.⁶ This unprecedented innovation will enable researchers and other stakeholders to trace individuals' movements through the deportation system, from apprehension to detention and through the immigration courts, thereby facilitating more comprehensive analyses of the outcomes of the deportation system. However, considerably more data transparency is necessary. Furthermore, while the research we have reviewed herein provides substantial evidence of the harms of the US deportation system, additional studies of premigration and post-deportation experiences (and their linkages) will be particularly valuable. In addition, research that documents the impacts of deportation policies implemented more recently—such as those under the Biden and second Trump administrations—will be critical to understanding the vast, complex, and multifaceted impacts of the US deportation system.

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Imitate, Then Escalate: Social Influence and Its Consequences for the Subfederal Deportation System in the United States



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I examine how social influence shapes both the adoption and implementation of 287(g) agreements—federal-local contracts that deputize local law enforcement to enforce immigration law. Drawing on organizational theory, the article highlights the role of public official associations (POAs) in diffusing interest in these agreements across counties. Using data on application letters and quasi-experimental methods, the study shows that counties with stronger ties to POAs were more likely to express interest in 287(g) agreements and to imitate language used by peer jurisdictions. It then links this imitation to variation in enforcement intensity: Counties that closely copied others' applications were more likely to escalate their institutional commitment, including devoting more jail space to Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) detainees, complying with ICE detainer requests at higher rates, and becoming more central to ICE's detainee transfer network. This suggests that social influence may shape not only entry into immigration enforcement but also its long-term implementation.

Keywords: immigration federalism, immigration enforcement, social influence, escalation of commitment

Discussions of immigration enforcement in the United States bring to mind federal agencies such as US Customs and Border Protection (CBP) and Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE). Yet without state and local government cooperation, current enforcement levels could not continue. During recent administrations, for example, the majority of ICE interior arrests originated from local transfers (Capps

et al. 2018). Hundreds of local jails confine non-citizens for ICE (Ryo and Peacock 2020). In certain jurisdictions, local police officers can begin noncitizens' removal processes or recommend certain legal remedies in lieu of formal removal proceedings (American Immigration Council 2021).

Research on this phenomenon has bifurcated into two bodies of scholarship. One aims

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Peacock, Ian G. 2025. "Imitate, Then Escalate: Social Influence and Its Consequences for the Subfederal Deportation System in the United States." *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 26–48. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.02>. Thanks to Asad Asad, Ingrid Eagly, Jacob Foster, Brad Jones, Cree Jones, Caitlin Patler, Huyen Pham, Emily Ryo, Roger Waldinger, Edward Walker, and three anonymous reviewers for their feedback. Funding from the following sources supported this research: American Sociological Association; John Randolph Haynes and Dora Haynes Foundation; and University of California, Los Angeles. Direct correspondence to: Ian Peacock, at ipeacock@uchicago.edu, 1111 E. 60th Street, Chicago, IL 60637, United States.

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to explain the incidence and intensity of local government involvement, linking participation to the demographic, economic, and political features of the participating localities. The second aims to understand the consequences of such enforcement for noncitizens, their families, and the communities in which they live. This study considers the connections between these findings by asking whether motivations for participating in immigration enforcement influence the consequences of such participation.

I answer this question by examining 287(g) agreements, named after Section 287(g) of the US Immigration and Nationality Act (INA). These agreements allow the federal government to formally delegate immigration enforcement functions to local law enforcement. State and local governments apply to ICE to receive training and authorization to participate in immigration enforcement and, should ICE approve the application, sign agreements with ICE formalizing the arrangement. While a now burgeoning body of scholarship examines 287(g) agreements and the participation of police in immigration enforcement, very little of this research documents heterogeneity in the implementation of immigration enforcement or provides an explanation for such heterogeneity. This is a notable oversight given that the Trump administration has sought not only to revitalize the 287(g) program, but also to deputize a wide range of actors beyond local police, such as Drug Enforcement Agency officers (Hackman and Gurman 2025) and military personnel (Rodriguez 2025), to enforce immigration laws. Theory gives us little guidance on what might drive variation in how these actors interpret and implement immigration enforcement in this critical moment.

I address this gap by examining how the motivations that drive local participation—particularly those rooted in social influence—shape the intensity and character of immigration enforcement once agreements are in place. This study focuses on social influence as a motivation for counties' participation in immigration enforcement. It is the first to identify public official associations (POAs), such as the National Sheriffs' Association (NSA) and the Major County Sheriffs of Amer-

ica (MCSA), as central to creating interest in immigration enforcement among county governments. Using archival sources never before analyzed, including sheriff association publications, conference materials, and internal communications, I find that many counties' decisions to participate were not isolated processes driven entirely by local concerns. POAs contributed to the spread of 287(g) agreements by serving as venues wherein others, such as federal authorities or issue entrepreneurs, influence counties vis-à-vis immigration enforcement. I use regression discontinuity and text reuse methods with never-before-analyzed data to show that POA participation shaped the timing and manner in which US counties first began to show interest in 287(g) agreements.

Next, the study links this social motivation for participating in 287(g) agreements to the agreements' effects. I use difference-in-differences and regression discontinuity methods that leverage geographic and temporal variation in 287(g) agreement applications to show that counties entering 287(g) agreements with higher text reuse (a strong proxy for social influence) became more involved in immigration enforcement—even beyond the scope of 287(g) agreements—than counties with lower levels of text reuse. This includes dedicating more jail space to ICE detainees, complying with ICE detainer requests at higher rates, and becoming more central in the network of correctional facilities through which ICE shuttles noncitizens. These changes suggest that 287(g) agreements establish new organizational stakes in public offices. This potentially creates political feedback loops and further escalates commitment to immigration enforcement.

This study makes several contributions. First, it expands the literature on the diffusion of immigration enforcement policies by highlighting the role of nonpartisan professional associations—rather than partisan or ideological actors—in motivating local participation. Second, it advances understanding of the consequences of immigration enforcement by showing that variation in the intensity of implementation is shaped by the motivations underlying policy adoption. Third, it contributes to growing scholarship on sheriffs by showing

how professional networks and supralocal affiliations shape local enforcement choices and institutional commitments. Fourth, it extends the study of intergovernmental agreements by showing how participation in programs like 287(g) can generate new institutional stakes and reshape local priorities—insights that apply beyond immigration to other domains of federalism by contract.

RESEARCH ON SUBFEDERAL IMMIGRATION ENFORCEMENT

This section first reviews research providing explanations for subfederal government participation in immigration enforcement. It then reviews research on the consequences of such participation.

Explanations for Subfederal Government Participation in Immigration Enforcement

As this issue's introduction discusses, legislation in the 1980s and 1990s laid the groundwork for subfederal immigration policymaking (see Patler and Jones 2025, this issue). The Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act (IIRIRA), notably, added Section 287(g) to the INA in 1996, allowing federal immigration authorities to delegate certain enforcement functions to states and localities through agreements with local law enforcement (DHS 2010). Through these agreements, deputized local law enforcement officers may identify and process noncitizens for removal in state and local correctional facilities, during the course of their regular duties, or both (DHS 2010, 20). Amid concerns over inconsistent practices and racial profiling, the Barack Obama administration curtailed 287(g) agreements, but the Trump administration revitalized them (Rosenberg and Levinson 2017). Currently, sixty agreements remain active (ICE 2025).

The creation of programs to encourage federal-local collaboration, nonetheless, does not explain why, when, and where localities choose to participate. To address these questions, researchers have identified many predictors of engaging in immigration enforcement under 287(g) arrangements or similar policies. Here, it is worth noting that sheriffs and their offices receive no funding to run 287(g) agree-

ments but rather must independently support the agreements themselves. Thus, social motivations are likely a key explanation for entry into such arrangements. Consistent with this, studies often focus on local issues and characteristics as determinants. Scholars argue that desires to maintain social control in light of perceived racial, cultural, or other threats amid demographic changes are motivators (for example, Creek and Yoder 2012; Ryo and Peacock 2020; Walker and Leitner 2011). Similarly, local employers may see restrictive policies targeting noncitizens as a useful mechanism by which they can selectively threaten and control undocumented workers (Gomberg-Munoz and Nussbaum-Barberena 2011). Some homeowners may see them as a mechanism to curb the expansion of local low-income housing (Brettell and Nibbs 2011; Walker and Leitner 2011). Struggling economies may pursue jail contracts with ICE in exchange for per diem revenues (Ryo and Peacock 2020). Politicians facing public dissatisfaction may opportunistically blame immigrants for local problems and propose cooperation with ICE as a solution (Creek and Yoder 2012).

Other research suggests that supralocal factors channel local features to take on specific effects. Daniel Hopkins (2010) argues that national discourse shapes local responses to demographic change. Others have argued that ideological framing can determine the nature of a locality's policymaking vis-à-vis noncitizens (Chavez and Provine 2009; Steil and Vasi 2014). Beyond political discourse, scholars have claimed that supralocal institutions explain why localities participate in immigration enforcement. Karthick Ramakrishnan and Pratheepan Gulasekaram (2013) maintain that political parties, particularly the Republican Party, and issue entrepreneurs have successfully leveraged post-9/11 ethnic nationalism to catalyze localities into prioritizing the policing of noncitizens. The relationship between different levels of government within parties may also matter. Lina Newton (2012) suggests that local governments enact restrictive policies not to address local issues but rather to send a signal of vertical integration with (or resistance against) the federal government and the incumbent executive. Similarly, federal or state

public officials may promote local immigration policymaking in hopes that building pressure for action gets released when local governments adopt their own solutions. This model of steam valve federalism allows higher-level governments to avoid the pressure from lower-level governments to create blanket federal or state-level policies and, thereby, avoid fallout from potentially unpopular policies (Creek and Yoder 2012).

Strategic activism complements institutionalized politics to shape local immigration enforcement participation. Activist networks create channels to promote local involvement in immigration enforcement, such as actions by the American Legislative Exchange Council (Collingwood et al. 2019) or the Minuteman Project (Steil and Vasi 2014), or create opposition to such involvement, such as organizations affiliated with the UnidosUS (Steil and Vasi 2014). These forms of advocacy often involve framing immigration enforcement in ways that are locally resonant (Ramakrishnan and Gulasekaram 2013; Steil and Vasi 2014) and “targeting . . . jurisdictions with partisan conditions . . . ripe for enacting such regulation” (Ramakrishnan and Gulasekaram 2013, 1445).

While research on supralocal sources of influence offers many insights, one question that remains unanswered is what role, if any, organizations outside of partisan and movement politics play in the spread of subfederal forms of immigration enforcement. Answering this question is important because of the prevalence of nonpartisan organizations in the US and because such organizations may hold keys to explaining why localities that differ greatly in their sociopolitical makeup have converged on similar immigration enforcement policies. My study directly addresses this shortcoming by elaborating on public official associations and their contribution to the spread of immigration enforcement policies.

Consequences of Participation in Immigration Enforcement

Once localities begin to participate in immigration enforcement, research shows that such involvement has far-reaching consequences. As other articles in this issue highlight, local participation in immigration enforcement leads to

significant declines in the physical and mental health of noncitizens, disrupts their life decisions and economic stability, and erodes trust in local law enforcement and civic engagement (for example, see Bennett et al. 2025, this issue; Hong et al. 2025, this issue; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2025, this issue; and Patler and Jones 2025, this issue). Involvement in immigration enforcement also has unintended consequences among those charged with enforcing the law. Amada Armenta (2017) shows how officers deputized under 287(g) arrangements increasingly act as arms of the federal government rather than as independent agents and lose focus on other services that they might provide to a community. Mai Thi Nguyen and Hannah Gill (2016) likewise argue that 287(g) distorts local law enforcement priorities. Moreover, Katharine M. Donato and Leslie Ann Rodriguez (2014) find that 287(g) programs altered officer discourse about immigrants and the reasons for which officers claimed to arrest them. Research also notes how 287(g) agreements, or similar policies such as Arizona’s “show me your papers” law, can lead to increased racial profiling (Jones-Correa and Fennelly 2009; Coon 2017).

While scholarship has documented these and other consequences of localities’ involvement in immigration enforcement, little research focuses on the heterogeneity in such consequences. Given the striking nature of the trends associated with 287(g) agreements and the fact that such agreements entail federal oversight, one might expect 287(g) agreements to have uniform consequences. But Mathew Coleman’s (2012) study of neighboring North Carolina counties that had both entered into 287(g) agreements suggests otherwise. The Durham Police Department used the program as a tool for gang suppression and only checked the immigration status of those arrested for felony offenses. The Wake County Sheriff’s Office, on the other hand, used the program as grounds to begin screening all immigrants, regardless of criminal history. The effects of the policies in the two neighboring counties diverged considerably. Wake County deported several thousand people during the same period that Durham County only deported several dozen individuals. Likewise, in a study

of a federal-local program similar to 287(g) agreements, Daniel E. Chand and William D. Schreckhise (2015) find that partisan politics notably predicted the number of deportations by county. These findings suggest that identical policies can produce heterogeneous outcomes and be mediated by social dynamics.

Understanding the conditions under which the implementation of similar policies diverges, therefore, provides a clear area to extend research. This is especially the case given the decentralized nature of the US law enforcement system (Lowatcharin and Stallmann 2017) and the potential for the loose coupling between policies, formal structure, and the implementation of policies in organizations (Weick 1976). This study contributes to a greater understanding of heterogeneity in the effects of subfederal immigration enforcement by connecting the effects of 287(g) agreements back to the process by which interest in such agreements spread. This study is the first to raise the question of how motivations at the time of adoption might influence the implementation of 287(g) agreements.

AN ORGANIZATIONAL THEORY FOR THE SPREAD AND EFFECTS OF IMMIGRATION ENFORCEMENT

To develop a theory of nonpartisan, supra-institutional determinants of 287(g) adoption, I draw on the insight from organizational scholarship arguing that policies gaining social acceptance are key to understanding their spread. As Beth A. Simmons and colleagues (2007) discuss, social acceptance occurs in at least three ways relevant to this study. First, organizations draw inferences about the appropriateness of policies based on their socio-cultural relationship with other organizations. This process of policy gaining acceptance relies on actors looking to others and often implicitly theorizing about what types of organizations should adopt what kinds of policies (Simmons et al. 2007). Thus, to determine whether some course of action is acceptable, decision-makers may look to those with whom they are structurally equivalent (Burt 1987, Elkins et al. 2006), psychologically proximate (Waltman 1980), or otherwise connected (Davis 1991, Sikkink 1993).

A consideration that arises from this point is the importance of organizations having awareness of precisely which other organizations are relevant in the first place. David Strang and John Meyer (1993, 491) argue that cultural categories are important for this purpose, insofar as they provide a “cognitive map [that] identifies reference groups that bound social comparison processes.” Categorization draws the boundaries of “the organizational field,” wherein potential policy adopters come to conceive of themselves as fundamentally similar (DiMaggio and Powell 1983; Strang and Meyer 1993).

Second, organizations look to exemplars in deciding whether to adopt policies. Organizations often play follow-the-leader by mimicking organizations that appear more successful (Haveman 1993). As outside observers, it becomes difficult to untangle the causal roots of another organization’s success. Followers may, accordingly, copy anything they assume contributes to desired outcomes, even if it means mimicking other organizations ritually and erroneously (Bennett 1991; Walker 1969).

Third, rather than looking to peer or leader organizations, organizations may also get information about the acceptability of policies based on information from field-specific experts and authorities. Experts theorize the effects of a policy and, in doing so, provide reasons for others to adopt it (Simmons et al. 2007). Pamela Tolbert and Lynne Zucker (1996, 183) argue that theorization involves two major tasks: identifying a general organizational failing for which a new policy or practice is a solution, and justifying the new solution. Scholars often point to the role of epistemic communities, which are networks of experts and professionals who define relevant issues and interests among actors in a policy arena (Haas 1992), in theorizing policy solutions and associated norms that lead to different organizations converging on similar solutions (DiMaggio and Powell 1983). Of course, organizations may use expert theorization as post hoc justifications rather than as motivations for policy decisions (Briscoe and Murphy 2012). In either case, expert theorization provides decision makers with a resource.

These points provide perspective for under-

standing how policies gain acceptance and diffuse among local governments. They highlight three mechanisms central to the spread of policies like 287(g) agreements: first, localities adopt policies by socially comparing themselves to similar or connected jurisdictions; second, localities imitate those they perceive as successful exemplars, sometimes even without clear evidence of effectiveness; and third, policy adoption is influenced by external experts who provide justifications and rationales that legitimize certain policy choices. The key implication for immigration enforcement is that local decisions about participating in programs like 287(g) may be driven significantly by these forms of social influence rather than solely by local needs or ideological motivations. Thus, the diffusion of immigration enforcement policies can occur broadly and rapidly—even across politically and demographically diverse localities—through structured organizational relationships, imitation of peers, and the theorizing activities of recognized experts or authorities.

Once policies have spread, the question remains of what effect they will have. Because the primary interest of this study is how law enforcement officers alter their behavior as a consequence of participating in immigration enforcement, I focus on consequences pertaining to law enforcement activity. The behavioral change of interest to this study is the escalation of commitment to immigration enforcement. While no study has explicitly considered this type of escalation as an outcome of localities participating in immigration enforcement, part of the variation in escalation will connect back to motives for adoption, including social motives. Consistent with this, research suggests that organizational and environmental factors moderate the strength of coupling between policy and implementation (Bromley and Powell 2012). Two relevant insights of this research are that the internalization of external influences can create tight coupling of focal policy and practices, even at the cost of disrupting other core organizational goals (Sauder and Espeland 2009), and that “motivations and skills that exist at adoption” create the contours for policy implementation insofar as such conditions “provide a form of imprinting that

shapes subsequent . . . performance” (Weber et al. 2009, 1325).

Klaus Weber and colleagues (2009) provide a noteworthy example of these points in their study of the diffusion of national stock exchanges. They argue that those countries that created stock exchanges in response to coercive pressure from the International Monetary Fund and World Bank were more likely to ceremonially adopt stock exchanges, since such countries’ internal motivation and capacity for adoption had considerable limits. Countries that created stock exchanges as an act of social emulation, on the other hand, tended to have more material adoption, given higher levels of internal motivation and the possibilities of learning through observation of prior adopters. The extensiveness of implementation, accordingly, was a function of motives for policy adoption. Considering these insights, we might expect those localities that entered 287(g) agreements because of social influence to show the greatest escalation of commitment to immigration enforcement.

In short, this section develops the linkage between the spread of immigration enforcement policies and their subsequent implementation. Specifically, localities’ motivations at the point of policy adoption, particularly those driven by social influences such as peer imitation, exemplars, and expert theorization, have implications beyond mere diffusion. These initial motivations may imprint on organizations, shaping how intensively and durably they commit to enforcing immigration policies. Thus, localities influenced by professional peer networks and perceived policy legitimacy may not only adopt immigration enforcement practices more readily but also enforce them more vigorously and consistently. This insight provides the basis for the empirical analysis that follows, in which I examine whether social motivations behind adopting 287(g) agreements are associated with measurable differences in outcomes.

THE EMPIRICAL CASE: 287(G) AGREEMENTS AND SHERIFFS’ ASSOCIATIONS

This section develops the empirical case by identifying the institutional mechanisms through which influence operates, motivating

the research design, defining key measures, outlining the empirical strategy, and presenting results that test the theory's observable implications.

Public Official Associations and the Spread of Subfederal Immigration Enforcement

The diffusion mechanisms outlined in the previous section—social comparison, mimicry of exemplars, and expert theorization—operate through concrete organizational settings. In the case of 287(g) agreements, public official associations (POAs) like the NSA and the MCSA structured the environment in which sheriffs encountered these influences. This subsection draws on archival sources to show how these associations shaped the field of immigration enforcement: identifying relevant peers, circulating policy models, and staging encounters with purported experts.¹ By examining the informational materials, events, and interpersonal connections fostered by these POAs, I show how they contributed to the spread of interest in 287(g) agreements and framed immigration enforcement as a professional norm. These patterns motivate the quantitative research design that follows, which tests whether counties exposed to POA influence were more likely to adopt 287(g) agreements and escalate their involvement in federal enforcement efforts.

For some context, POAs are national organizations whose primary membership consists of public officials and “whose purpose includes advancement of the general public interest [and] the special interests of the members” (Plant and Arnold 1993, 212). The organizational form of the POA originated in the first half of the twentieth century. POAs came in response to Progressive Era concerns about corruption and incompetence of local public offices and found a second purpose when public officials needed to effectively coordinate in response to

policies of the New Deal Era that shifted ideals of intergovernmental relations from layer-cake forms of federalism, with neatly delineated authority corresponding to different levels of government, to marble-cake federalism, wherein different levels of governments have interlaced responsibilities (Plant and Arnold 1993; Wright 1990).

The activities of POAs grew to reflect these concerns. POAs allowed for the establishment of general professional standards, sharing best practices and strategies, interfacing with higher levels of government, business leaders, researchers, and other experts, and providing opportunities for professional coordination nationwide (Hertel-Fernandez 2019; Plant et al. 2010; Teaforde 2002). Participation in the associations signaled a commitment to modern ideals of professionalism, expertise, efficiency, and “scientific management” (Teaforde 2002, 6). The locus of assembly was, consequently, not to be ideological but instead professional. POAs, even more recently formed ones, continue to boast commitments to expertise and professionalism over ideology today.

POAs' networks and resources also, importantly, situate them well to contribute to the acceptance of new practices and policies. POAs draw boundaries around specific sets of public officials such that POA members come to see other POA members as a relevant reference group for comparison and learning (Shipan and Volden 2012). POAs facilitate the display of exemplars by circulating publications and providing workshops to learn about policies of other public officials (Plant and Arnold 1993). POAs also link public officials to experts who can provide rationales to legitimize policies (Teaforde 2002).

For a concrete example, let us consider the NSA. The association draws the boundaries around a specific set of actors whom sheriffs come to see as members of the same field,

1. This section draws on an original review of primary sources, including back issues of *Sheriff* magazine, NSA and MCSA conference programs, press releases, IRS Form 990 filings, and other organizational documents from 2000 to 2012. I also examined contemporaneous news coverage and ICE communications to reconstruct how 287(g) agreements were presented, discussed, and disseminated within POA networks. These sources provide insight into the informational environment that shaped sheriffs' perceptions of immigration enforcement and the role of professional peer networks in policy diffusion.

namely, other sheriffs. Thus, rather than looking to other heads of law enforcement agencies, such as police chiefs or directors of federal agencies, or to other county officials—such as supervisors or managers—NSA conferences, publications, and other proceedings help sheriffs to see each other as the relevant reference group to whom they look for cues and make comparisons. NSA activities reinforce the conception of sheriffs' offices as fundamentally similar and relevant to each other.

Furthermore, the NSA creates ample opportunity for social learning and mimicry of exemplars. The NSA publishes the bimonthly *Sheriff* magazine, recurring reports, brochures, and other materials that allow sheriffs to stay abreast of policies and practices implemented by other sheriffs. A 2007 issue of *Sheriff*, for example, was entirely dedicated to the topic of immigration enforcement. In this issue, Jim Pendergraph (2007)—the sheriff of Mecklenburg County, North Carolina—penned an essay titled “What the Section 287(g) Program Can Do for Your Community,” wherein he described the implementation of a 287(g) agreement in his county and touted the agreement's alleged benefits. The NSA also hosts multiple national conferences on a yearly basis. Sheriff Pendergraph, for example, mentioned learning about 287(g) agreements from another sheriff at one such NSA conference in 2005 (Caldwell et al. 2009). Besides allowing for peer-to-peer networking, such conferences also feature a wide range of seminars, workshops, exhibit rooms, committee meetings, and other events. In 2007, for example, the NSA held a conference wherein the association's immigration subcommittee led a discussion about issues related to immigration enforcement, joined by sheriffs from across the country (McKain and McKain 2007b). As part of that conference, the NSA hosted a workshop called “The Cost of Crime: Dealing with Illegal Immigration” (NSA 2007). Later conferences offered workshops explicitly on 287(g) agreements.

The NSA also creates opportunities for sheriffs to get information about the acceptability of different immigration enforcement policies from actors who are ostensibly field-specific authorities and experts. Following the 9/11 attacks, for example, Robert Mueller (2002), then head of the Federal Bureau of Investigation, gave an NSA keynote highlighting areas of improvement for coordination between local and federal authorities for homeland security purposes. This was a similar theme—often with an explicit discussion of immigration enforcement—emphasized by subsequent NSA conference keynote speakers coming from the worlds of law enforcement, politics, and academia.² Interaction with such actors could extend beyond giving keynotes at NSA conferences. For example, John Clark (2006), the first deputy assistant secretary for ICE, offered an NSA seminar on immigration issues affecting sheriffs and opportunities for cooperation with ICE.

While many of the keynote speakers were figures whom one might reasonably classify as experts, it is not clear what criteria the NSA applied to allow outsider participation in workshops and seminars. Investigative reporting has noted how nativist organizations such as the Federation for American Immigration Reform and the Center for Immigration Studies (CIS) made concerted efforts, starting during the George W. Bush administration, to steer the NSA and its members toward participating in immigration enforcement (Vazquez 2017). At one NSA conference, for example, a CIS representative touted the benefits of 287(g) agreements using a report based on selective statistics and misleading interpretations of academic research (Vaughn 2012a).

In short, the preceding discussion demonstrates the potential of POAs to play an active role in shaping sheriffs' perceptions of immigration enforcement. As highlighted, the NSA certainly showed this potential through reference-group definition, policy exemplar promotion, and expert theorization. These

2. For example, subsequent speakers included: former US Attorney General Alberto Gonzalez (“Attorney General Gonzales” 2005); US Senator Joseph Biden (“Biden” 2005); former Department of Homeland Security Director Janet Napolitano (NSA 2009); former ICE Director John Morton (“National Sheriffs' Association 70th” 2010); and criminology professor Simon Perry, who specializes in homeland security and policing (Peluso 2013).

mechanisms offer clear implications for empirical measurement: if POAs significantly influenced sheriffs, then counties with stronger POA ties should display observable patterns consistent with social influence, specifically, higher initial interest and greater imitation in their decisions to enter immigration enforcement. Likewise, consistent with the second aspect of the theory developed earlier, those counties that enter into immigration enforcement responding to social influence may ultimately exhibit a more intense policy implementation. The statistical analysis developed in the following sections explicitly tests these predictions.

Contextualizing the Statistical Analysis

I focus on the spread of 287(g) agreements among counties between 2002 and 2011.³ The study of 287(g) agreements, compared to other policies, offers advantages for empirical and theoretical reasons. To enter a 287(g) agreement, all law enforcement agencies must first express interest and apply to participate in an agreement with ICE. This leaves a paper trail subject to public records requests, while other local policies regarding noncitizens tend to be informal and left to law enforcement discretion (Decker et al. 2009). Localities' stated rationales for entering such agreements are part of the paper trail too, something that existing research has yet to examine. The relative uniformity of 287(g) agreements in terms of aim and scope also makes them more comparable across different locations and therefore easier to identify as imitable. Moreover, 287(g) agreements enter localities into direct enforcement of immigration laws, whereas other policies put localities in more intermediary or ad hoc positions (Armenta and Alvarez 2017). Lastly, a major advantage of studying 287(g) agreements is that two quasi-natural experiments and never-before-analyzed data

involving the agreements, as later discussed, allow for clearer pictures of the causes and effects of local participation in immigration enforcement.

For studying 287(g) agreements, a focus on counties also offers clear advantages. Counties comprised the vast majority (82 percent) of the law enforcement agencies participating in 287(g) agreements during this study's time period. Sheriffs' offices generally operate larger and longer-term jails than city police, and ICE-locality cooperation is more likely to occur in jails than on patrol (Armenta and Alvarez 2017). And, compared to police departments, sheriffs' offices have a higher likelihood of participating in immigration enforcement and reporting that federal officials have shaped their decisions to participate in immigration enforcement (Provine et al. 2016).

To understand the spread of 287(g) agreements, I focus on two sheriff-related POAs.⁴ The first is the NSA. The major advantage of studying the NSA is that the association acted as an arena within which sheriffs and other actors explicitly discussed 287(g) agreements on many occasions through various mediums, as discussed earlier. Indeed, accounts from sheriffs themselves include reports of directly copying 287(g) application materials from other sheriffs following discussion of 287(g) agreements at the NSA conference (see, for example, Pendergraph 2007). And while the NSA—as an organization in an official capacity—did eventually lobby federal authorities for continuance of the 287(g) program and promote participation in the program, such actions took place after the time period of interest to this study (see, for example, NSA 2011, Vaughn 2012b). This timing is important because it provides conceptual clarity regarding the process by which the NSA might have influenced interest in immigration enforcement before 2012, insofar as the timing rules out potential top-down

3. I limit years studied to 2002–2011 for theoretical and empirical reasons. First, this range of years covers the early institutionalization period of 287(g) agreements, before the Obama administration began a phaseout of many agreements in 2012 (Kolker 2021). Federal funding for the 287(g) program also saw a notable decline shortly after this period (Kolker 2021). Moreover, in 2011, the POAs that I study eventually endorsed 287(g) agreements, which makes untangling the processes by which participation in POAs influenced county decision-making more difficult.

4. These POAs are in no way representative of all or most POAs. This article's aim is not to generalize to all POAs.

or coercive influences that the NSA's official backing of a policy could have on policy adoption during this period.⁵

The second POA on which I focus is the MCSA. The MCSA deserves attention for two main reasons. First, like the NSA, the MCSA served as an important venue where information about 287(g) agreements spread. During the time of interest to my study, MCSA annual conferences took place during and as part of NSA conferences. MCSA attendees, thus, were likely exposed to many of the same sources of influence. Moreover, between 2005 and 2008, Jim Pendergraph was an MCSA executive officer (MCSA 2005; "Sheriff Carona" 2007). Pendergraph's status as an MCSA officer is important because he was a notable proponent of 287(g) agreements. Beyond encouraging 287(g) agreements at conferences informally (McKain and McKain 2007a) and formally (Pendergraph 2007), Pendergraph frequently contacted other MCSA members and provided delegation tours—so many tours, in fact, that deputies complained of not having adequate time for regular work—to demonstrate the implementation of the 287(g) program (Loller 2006). In 2008, Pendergraph became the head of ICE's Office of State and Local Coordination, in which capacity he continued meeting with NSA leadership and MCSA members and promoted participation in 287(g) agreements (Capps et al. 2011; Peters 2008).

Another reason the MCSA deserves this study's attention is its membership criterion. MCSA membership has been historically determined by county population, with membership consisting of all sheriffs who represent counties or parishes with a population of 500,000 or more (MCSA 2022). This cutoff allows for me to employ a regression discontinuity design (RDD) to understand if participation in the MCSA influenced the timing and manner in which counties began to express interest in 287(g) agreements.

Data Used for Statistical Analysis

Online appendix table 1 details the variables used for analysis.⁶ This section provides an overview of the main outcome and explanatory variables.

Outcome Variables

Expressed Interest in a 287(g) Agreement indicates whether a county submitted a formal letter to ICE applying for participation in the 287(g) program in a given year. I construct this measure using public records and Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) responses from ICE and county sheriff departments. Within the framework of policy diffusion, this action marks a county's transition from observer to adopter and signals a willingness to participate in federal-local immigration enforcement.

Interest Letter Imitation captures the extent to which a county's first letter to ICE replicates language from earlier letters submitted by other counties. For each county, I compare its initial letter to all previously submitted letters and assign the highest observed similarity score using the Jaccard coefficient. This score measures social imitation insofar as it reflects the degree to which sheriffs borrow rhetorical frames or justifications from peer jurisdictions. Field reports confirm that sheriffs often shared or copied application letters following professional association meetings (for example, Pendergraph 2007). Prior studies use similar methods to trace diffusion and peer influence through text reuse (for example, Bail 2012; Gilaridi et al. 2021). Because the distribution of maximum similarity scores is highly bimodal, I also create a binary indicator for *High Imitation*, which equals one if the similarity score exceeds the trough between modes.

Transitioning to outcomes of 287(g) agreements that I consider, *Percent of County Jail Population Held for ICE* measures the share of individuals in a county's jail population held on behalf of ICE in a given year. This outcome re-

5. During other periods, this may be a well-founded concern because the NSA is one of the four parent associations of the Commission on Accreditation for Law Enforcement Agencies, which accredits law enforcement agencies. The NSA often coordinates with federal authorities in deciding on the allocation of grants and the provision of training, technical assistance, and other services (Bowman 2001). These aspects of the NSA may make certain sheriffs more likely to implement NSA-backed policies.

6. The online appendix can be found at <https://www.rsfjournal.org/content/11/4/26/tab-supplemental>.

flects the degree of operational alignment between county jails and federal immigration enforcement. *Compliance with Detainer Request* records whether a county honored ICE's request to hold a noncitizen beyond their scheduled release date to facilitate a potential transfer into ICE custody. The unit of analysis is the individual detainer request. This measure captures local cooperation with federal enforcement efforts at the case level. *Incoming Transfers of ICE Detainees* counts the number of noncitizens ICE reported transferring into a county jail on a given day. This measure captures the flow of detainees into local facilities and reflects the county's integration into federal enforcement logistics. It is worth reemphasizing that 287(g) agreement with ICE in no way obligates counties to engage in these other activities. Thus, positive changes in these outcomes all reflect an escalation of commitment to immigration enforcement beyond 287(g) agreements.

Key Explanatory Variables

NSA Leadership equals one if a county's sheriff served in a leadership position within the NSA during a given year. Because most sheriffs hold general NSA membership, I focus on leadership roles, which involve regular attendance at association meetings and exposure to organizational messaging.

MCSA Membership identifies whether a county belonged to the MCSA in a given year. The MCSA restricts membership to sheriffs from counties with populations above 500,000. *287(g) Active* indicates whether a county held an active 287(g) agreement during a given year. This binary variable distinguishes formal adopters from applicants and provides the primary treatment variable in analyses of downstream effects.

Empirical Strategy for Statistical Analysis

This study analyzes both the spread and consequences of 287(g) agreements. The first part of the analysis investigates when counties expressed interest in joining the 287(g) program. I code a county as expressing interest in a given year if it officially submitted a letter of application to ICE. I estimate a discrete-time event history model using county-year as the unit of

analysis. This model includes county fixed effects, year fixed effects, and a set of time-varying controls. The key explanatory variables indicate whether a county's sheriff held a leadership role in the NSA or was a member of the MCSA. This approach assumes that, conditional on the included covariates and fixed effects, unobserved shocks do not systematically affect the hazard of submitting an application.

To more credibly estimate the effect of MCSA membership, I use an RDD that exploits the association's membership rule, which restricted eligibility to counties with populations of 500,000 or more. I center the running variable (county population) at the threshold and estimate local linear regressions using triangular kernel weights. To ensure that estimates are not sensitive to bandwidth choice, I fit models using multiple symmetric bandwidths: 100,000, 125,000, 150,000, and 175,000. These bandwidths reflect a balance between theoretical relevance and empirical precision. This design assumes that counties near the threshold are similar in both observed and unobserved characteristics and that no other policy or institutional change occurs at that same population cutoff. I assess these assumptions by testing for discontinuities in the density of the running variable (using a McCrary test), checking covariate balance across the threshold, and conducting placebo tests at alternative cutoffs. The diagnostics provide no evidence of manipulation or imbalance near the threshold.

I then analyze whether counties that applied to the program imitated the language of prior applicants. To do this, I construct a dataset that pairs each county's first letter of interest with every letter submitted by other counties prior to its own. Each observation in this dataset corresponds to a county-letter pair. I use Jaccard similarity scores for each pair and assign to each county the highest similarity score across all comparisons. This maximum score captures the degree to which a county's application reused language from earlier submissions. Because the distribution of maximum similarity scores is highly bimodal, I define a binary indicator for *High Imitation*, which equals one if the county's score falls above the valley between the two modes. This classification reflects a

clear split between counties that engaged in substantial language reuse and those that did not. I use both pooled regressions and RDDs (centered at the 500,000 population threshold) to estimate whether MCSA-eligible counties were more likely to submit highly imitative letters. I also test results' robustness to alternative similarity measures.

The second part of the analysis estimates the consequences of entering into a formal 287(g) agreement. Between 2005 and 2012, 168 counties submitted applications to ICE, but fewer than half ultimately entered the program. Some counties withdrew their applications, others were denied, and some remained in pending status. This application process allows me to compare treated counties—those that signed agreements—to counties that applied but never participated. I use a stacked difference-in-differences design that aligns counties by the year of adoption and compares outcomes in the four years before and five years after entry. Counties that never entered but applied serve as the control group. This approach assumes that, absent treatment, treated and untreated counties would have followed similar trends in outcomes. I examine pretreatment trends to evaluate the plausibility of this assumption.

To test whether counties' motivations shaped the effects of participation, I interact the High Imitation indicator with event-time indicators in the stacked design. This interaction estimates whether counties that closely mimicked earlier letters experienced different enforcement outcomes. I estimate these models for three outcomes: Percent of County Jail Population Held for ICE, Compliance with Detainer Requests, and Incoming Transfers of ICE Detainees. For the jail population outcome, I use county-year panel data and include time-varying covariates and fixed effects. For the detainer and transfer outcomes, I use datasets with individual detainer requests and county-day observations, respectively. I estimate saturated fixed effects models that include county-by-year interactions to absorb all time-varying county-level factors. For the detainer compliance outcome, I also include person-level fixed effects to control for time-invariant characteristics of each noncitizen.

I address the assumptions specific to each

analysis in greater detail in online appendix table 1, where I also report robustness checks and sensitivity analyses.

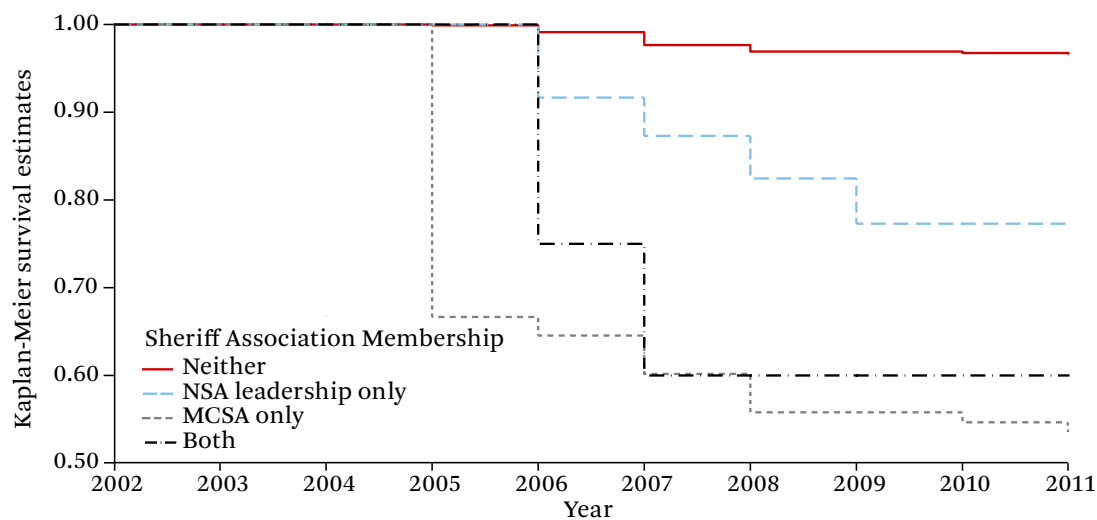
Results of Statistical Analysis

Figure 1 plots the hazard of counties expressing interest in 287(g) agreements by NSA leadership and MCSA membership status over time. It shows that counties with sheriffs in NSA leadership expressed interest in 287(g) agreements at much higher rates between the years 2002 and 2011. Similarly, it documents a higher rate of interest among MCSA members, with a notable jump in interest in 287(g) agreements among MCSA members starting in 2005.

Rows (A) and (B) of table 1 display estimates from various discrete-time models predicting time to expressed interest in 287(g) agreements. For ease of interpretation, I present coefficients as changes in predicted probabilities. Thus, during the period of interest, the first model shows that NSA leadership was associated with a 2.5-percentage-point increase in the probability of expressing interest in a 287(g) agreement while holding constant control variables. MCSA membership was associated with a 7-percentage-point increase in the same probability. The next models, using an RDD framework, show that MCSA membership was associated with between a 4- and 12-percentage-point increase in the probability of expressing in 287(g) agreements, depending on the size of the bandwidths around the 500,000-inhabitant cutoff for MCSA membership.

Figure 2 plots measures of *Interest Letter Imitation* by county population. It shows that *Interest Letter Imitation* values tend to be higher on average among those counties with populations greater than 500,000 residents than those below 500,000 residents, which suggests that MCSA membership could have an effect on tendencies to reuse text from previously submitted letters. Rows (C) and (D) of table 1 present evidence consistent with figure 2, namely that when comparing letters of interest submitted to ICE with all those letters of interest previously submitted, those letters submitted by members of NSA leadership and the MCSA have significantly higher levels of text reuse compared to nonmembers. The RDD models

Figure 1. Hazard of Expressed Interest in 287(g) Agreement by NSA Leadership and MCSA Membership, 2002–2011



Source: Author's calculations.

Note: Kaplan-Meier survival curves show the proportion of counties that had not yet expressed interest in a 287(g) agreement between 2002 and 2011, stratified by sheriff association affiliation. For example, by 2007, approximately 40 percent of counties whose sheriffs were members of both NSA and MCSA leadership had submitted a letter of interest.

Table 1. Models Estimating Effect of NSA and MCSA Membership on Time to Expressing Interest in 287(g) Agreements and Interest Letter Imitation, by Sample and Bandwidth

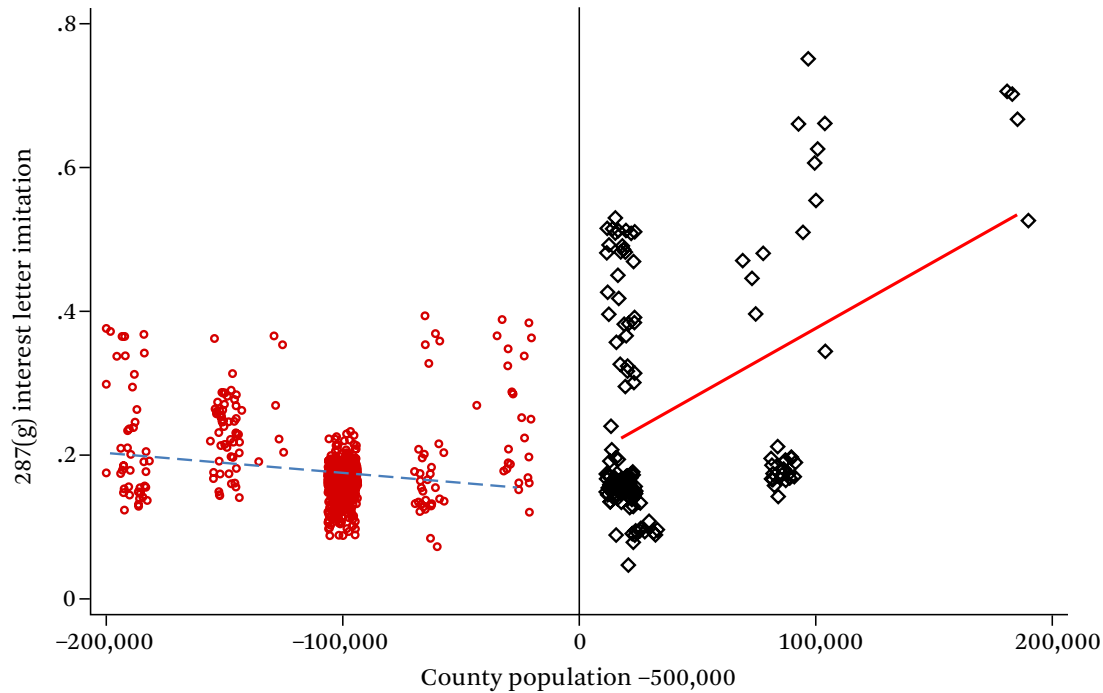
	All Obs. (1)	RDD, BW = 100k (2)	RDD, BW = 150k (3)	RDD, BW = 200k (4)
(A) Effect of NSA leadership on time to expressing interest in 287(g) agreement	0.025***			
(B) Effect of MCSA membership on time to expressing interest in 287(g) agreement	0.070***	0.122**	0.048*	0.043*
(C) Effect of NSA leadership on 287(g) interest letter imitation	0.279*			
(D) Effect of MCSA membership on 287(g) interest letter imitation	0.187*	0.419***	0.576***	0.470***

Source: Author's calculations.

Note: RDD = regression discontinuity design. BW = bandwidth. Units of analysis = rows (A) and (B): county years; rows (C) and (D): letter of interest pairs. Controls = county fixed effects; county population; unemployment rate; percent Hispanic; violent crime rate; percent Republican; neighboring counties with 287(g) agreements; state has 287(g) agreements. *Interest Letter Imitation* is a continuous measure of maximum textual similarity between a county's first letter and all previously submitted letters. For rows (A) and (B), coefficients represent average marginal effects from discrete-time hazard models, interpreted as percentage point changes in the predicted probability of submitting a 287(g) letter in a given year. For rows (C) and (D), coefficients represent changes in similarity scores. Columns 2–4 report RDD estimates using bandwidths of $\pm 100,000$, $\pm 150,000$, and $\pm 200,000$ around the 500,000-population cutoff for MCSA eligibility. Each estimate comes from a local linear regression with triangular kernel weights. Standard errors clustered at the county level.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Figure 2. 287(g) Interest Letter Imitation by County Population



Source: Author's calculations.

Note: 287(g) Interest Letter Imitation is computed using Jaccard similarity scores between a county's first letter of interest and previously submitted letters. The x-axis shows county population, centered at the MCSA eligibility threshold of 500,000; values above zero indicate counties above the threshold, and values below zero indicate counties below it. The diagonal lines display local linear regressions fitted on either side of the cutoff using triangular kernel weights.

in table 2 also provide similar evidence across various bandwidth ranges.

Row (A) of table 2 presents estimates of the effect of 287(g) agreement adoption on the percent of the county jail population held for ICE, disaggregated by counties' levels of *Interest Letter Imitation*. Among counties classified as high imitators, 287(g) adoption is associated with a statistically significant increase of 0.088 percentage points in the share of the jail population held for ICE. In contrast, counties with low levels of imitation show a small and statistically insignificant decline (-0.040). The difference in effects across the two groups is 0.129 percentage points ($p < 0.05$), indicating that the estimated impact of 287(g) participation varies by the level of textual similarity in counties' initial letters of interest. Figure 3 illustrates this divergence over time, with relatively flat trends among low-imitation counties and post-adoption increases concentrated among high-imitation counties.

Row (B) of table 2 reports the estimated effect of 287(g) agreement adoption on the probability that a county complies with an ICE detainer request. Among counties classified as high imitators, adoption is associated with a statistically significant increase in compliance of 0.121 percentage points. In contrast, counties with low levels of imitation show a small and statistically insignificant decrease in compliance (-0.110). The difference between the two groups is 0.231 percentage points ($p < 0.01$), indicating that the estimated effect of 287(g) participation on detainer compliance differs by counties' levels of *Interest Letter Imitation*. Figure 4 provides event-study estimates that parallel this finding, with compliance rates remaining flat or declining slightly in low-imitation counties but trending upward after adoption in high-imitation counties.

Row (C) of table 2 presents estimates of the effect of 287(g) agreement adoption on the number of ICE detainees transferred into county

Table 2. Models Estimating Effect of 287(g) Agreement on Percent of County Jail Population Held for ICE, Compliance with Detainer Requests, and Incoming Transfers of ICE Detainees, by Level of Interest Letter Imitation

	Population = Low Interest Letter Imitation (1)	Population = High Interest Letter Imitation (2)	Difference (columns 2–1)
(A) 287(g) effect on percent of jail population held for ICE	–0.040	0.088*	0.129*
(B) 287(g) effect on compliance with detainer request	–0.110	0.121**	0.231**
(C) 287(g) effect on incoming transfers of ICE detainees	0.289	0.353*	0.064*

Source: Author's calculations.

Note: Units of analysis = row (A): county-year; row (B): detainer requests; row (C): county-day. Controls = row (A): county fixed effects, year fixed effects, county population, unemployment rate, percent Hispanic, violent crime rate, percent Republican, state has 287(g), neighboring county has 287(g); row (B): noncitizen fixed effects, year fixed effects, county fixed effects, interaction between year and county fixed effects; row (C): year fixed effects, county fixed effects, interaction between year and county fixed effects. Coefficients represent the effect of adopting a 287(g) agreement on each outcome, estimated using a stacked difference-in-differences design comparing outcomes four years before and five years after adoption. Counties are classified as high vs. low *Interest Letter Imitation* based on a binary measure derived from the bimodal distribution of textual similarity scores. Column 3 reports the difference in treatment effects across the two groups, based on interaction terms between 287(g) treatment and the *High Imitation* indicator. The counterfactual group includes counties that submitted a 287(g) application but withdrew, were denied, or remained pending.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

jails. Among high-imitation counties, adoption is associated with a statistically significant increase of 0.353 detainees per county-day. Low-imitation counties show a smaller and not statistically significant increase of 0.289. The difference between the two groups is 0.064 ($p < .05$), which suggests a modest but statistically significant divergence in transfer activity following adoption. Figure 5 shows a similar pattern over time, with transfers remaining more stable in low-imitation counties and rising steadily after adoption in high-imitation counties.

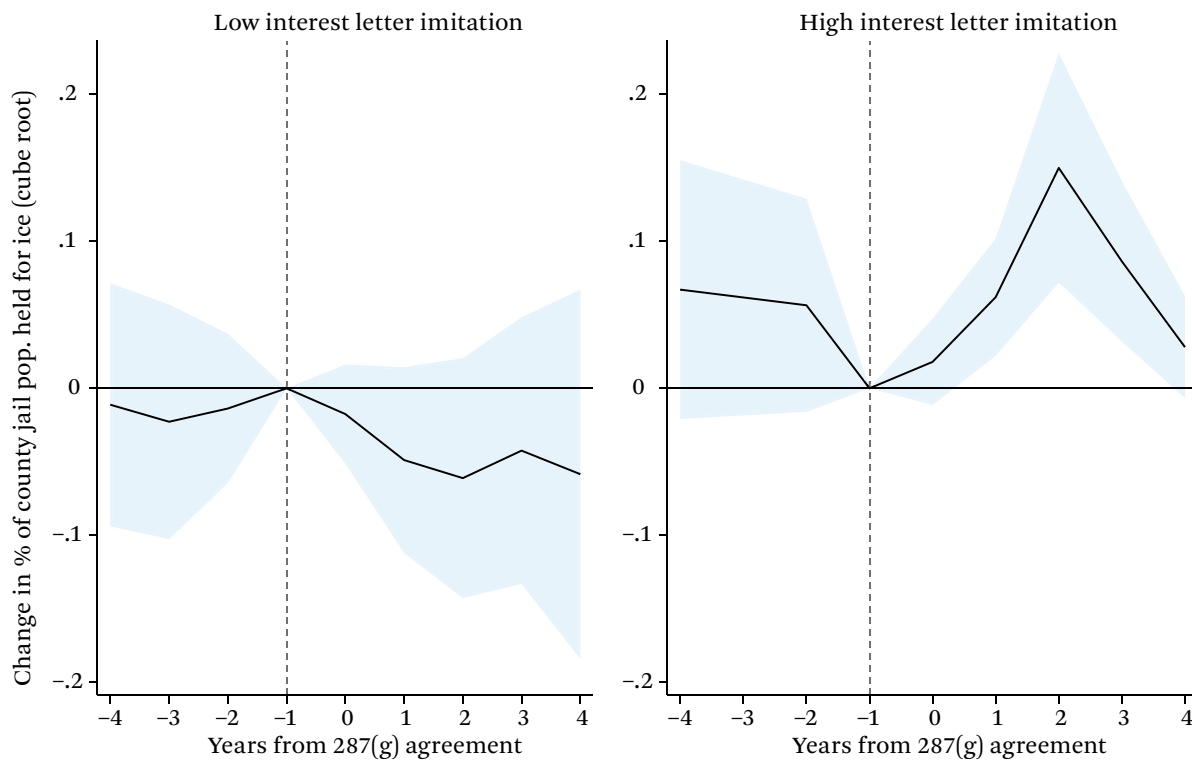
CONCLUSION

Using a range of data sources and methodological approaches, the analysis points to two general findings. Concerning the spread of 287(g) agreements, county participation in POAs—specifically the NSA and the MCSA—predicted (1) significantly higher rates of expressing

interest in 287(g) agreements and (2) significantly higher levels of copying language used by other counties in application letters for 287(g) agreements. This suggests that many counties' decisions to participate in immigration enforcement were subject to social influence experienced because of their affiliation with a POA.

On 287(g) agreements' consequences, I find their outcomes interact with the aforementioned social influence. Following the enactment of 287(g) agreements, counties that had imitated the application materials from other 287(g) applicants at higher levels significantly diverged from counties with lower levels of imitation in application materials in terms of their tendency to escalate the commitment of existing law-enforcement resources to immigration enforcement. Indeed, the scale of immigration enforcement significantly expanded in the former counties insofar as they dedi-

Figure 3. Effect of 287(g) Agreement on Percent of County Jail Population Held for ICE (Cube Root) by 287(g) Interest Letter Imitation



Source: Author's calculations.

Note: Lines show event-time coefficients from stacked difference-in-differences models centered on the year a county adopted a 287(g) agreement. The outcome variable is the cube root of the percent of the county jail population held for ICE, transformed to reduce skewness. Shaded areas indicate 95 percent confidence intervals. The omitted category is the year immediately prior to adoption ($t = -1$). Panels compare counties classified as high vs. low in *Interest Letter Imitation*, based on Jaccard similarity scores between each county's first letter and previously submitted letters.

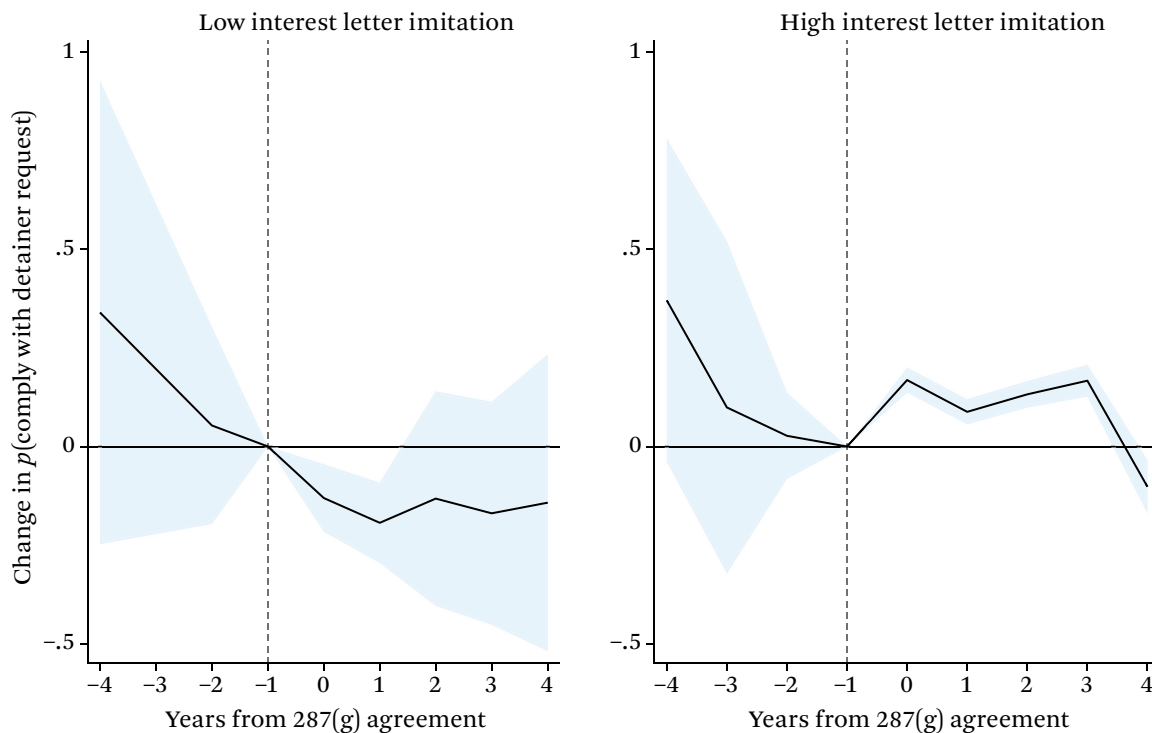
cated a larger share of jail space for confining noncitizens for ICE, complied with ICE detainer requests at higher rates, and became more central in the network of correctional facilities through which ICE shuttles noncitizens.

Here, it may be worth noting this study's limitations. For one, this study only considers one type of social influence—peer imitation among public officials—as measured through text reuse in application letters for 287(g) agreements. This approach captures a narrow but observable channel of influence: rhetorical mimicry following participation in professional associations. But it is likely that other forms of social influence, like shared consultants or legal counsel, also play a role in shaping both the decision to participate and the intensity of policy implementation. Moreover, it is possible that something other than social

influence led to higher levels of *Interest Letter Imitation* and higher levels of the aforementioned outcomes independently. But it seems unlikely that anything other than social influence—in some form—led to pairs of counties submitting letters that contain large sections of identical text—including typographical errors. Moreover, while it is possible that unobserved variables could explain selection into social influence that would affect *Interest Letter Imitation* and the aforementioned outcomes, my attempts to detect indicia of selection have revealed no clear trends. That said, while I have taken efforts to reduce potential sources of bias through careful design and robustness checks, the estimates should not be interpreted as identifying causal effects with certainty.

Notwithstanding these limits, these findings offer insights for several bodies of scholar-

Figure 4. Effect of 287(g) Agreement on $P(\text{Comply with Detainer Request})$ by 287(g) Interest Letter Imitation



Source: Author's calculations.

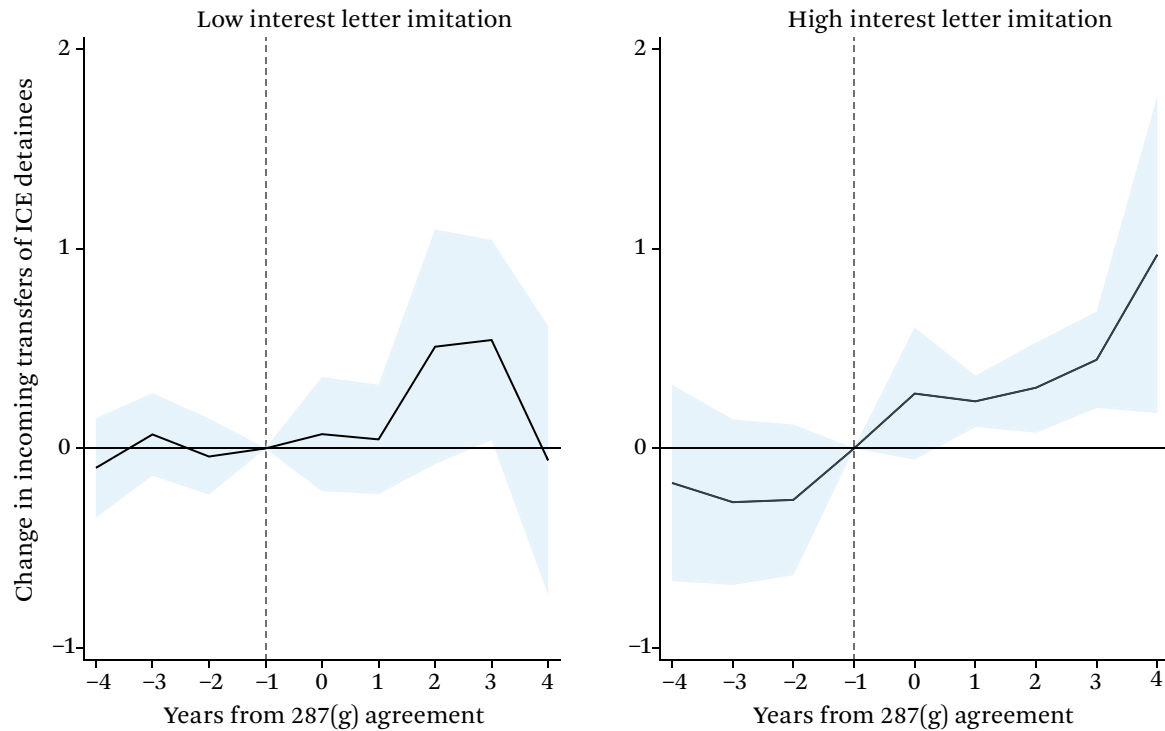
Note: Lines show event-time coefficients from stacked difference-in-differences models centered on the year a county adopted a 287(g) agreement. The outcome variable is the probability that a county complies with an ICE detainer request. Shaded areas represent 95 percent confidence intervals. The omitted category is the year immediately prior to adoption ($t = -1$). Panels compare counties classified as high vs. low in *Interest Letter Imitation*, based on Jaccard similarity scores between each county's first letter and previously submitted letters.

ship. First, while research on the spread of subfederal immigration enforcement has pointed to supralocal influences contributing to this spread (see, for example, Steil and Vasi 2014), such research has largely highlighted influences that are explicitly partisan or political in nature. My archival analysis of POA materials—including NSA and MCSA conference proceedings, publications, and correspondence—and my statistical analysis illustrate the importance of previously overlooked, nonpartisan professional associations as nonpartisan sources of such influence. Given the prevalence of nonpartisan organizations and the fact that organizational research has argued that “the character of American federalism encourage[s] . . . [an] association-driven diffusion” of policy often by associations working outside of existing partisan allegiances and power (Clemens 1997,

98), this is an important area for research on subfederal immigration enforcement to develop.

Second, this study builds on existing research looking at the consequences of immigration enforcement. Prior studies have shown that new federal immigration policies lead to increased commitment of resources by federal authorities (Andreas 2000), subfederal immigration policies can fuel public hostility toward immigrants (Flores 2017), and subfederal law enforcement officers adjust their behavior when involved in immigration enforcement (Armenta 2017; Donato and Rodriguez 2014). My research expands on these by showing how motivations for entering into immigration enforcement help explain variation in the subsequent escalation of commitment to immigration enforcement.

Figure 5. Effect of 287(g) Agreement on Incoming Transfers of ICE Detainees



Source: Author's calculations.

Note: Lines show event-time coefficients from stacked difference-in-differences models centered on the year a county adopted a 287(g) agreement. The outcome variable is the number of ICE detainees transferred into a county jail on a given day. Shaded areas represent 95 percent confidence intervals. The omitted category is the year immediately prior to adoption ($t = -1$). Panels compare counties classified as high vs. low in *Interest Letter Imitation*, based on Jaccard similarity scores between each county's first letter and previously submitted letters.

Third, this study contributes to a growing body of scholarship examining the political and institutional power of sheriffs in contemporary law enforcement. Recent work highlights the unique autonomy sheriffs possess as elected officials and their ability to shape local criminal justice and immigration policy with minimal oversight (Farris and Holman 2024; Pishko 2024). My findings show that sheriffs do not make enforcement decisions in isolation but often in response to signals and incentives generated by supralocal professional networks. In particular, I argue that POAs serve as influential sites of policy diffusion, where sheriffs encounter federal officials, model policies, and peer endorsements that encourage participation in immigration enforcement. These organizational settings help explain not only which sheriffs pursue programs like 287(g), but also

may have further downstream effects on how much institutional capacity sheriffs ultimately dedicate to federal enforcement efforts. By linking the social and institutional motivations for entering immigration enforcement to concrete implementation outcomes, this study shows how sheriffs' professional affiliations can shape the scope and intensity of their cooperation with federal immigration authorities.

These findings also hold implications for ongoing discussions on 287(g) agreements and immigration federalism. Now that President Trump has returned to office and begun revitalizing the 287(g) program, the findings of this study carry renewed policy relevance. Dozens of agreements remain active, and recent signals from the Trump administration suggest expanded efforts to enlist local law enforce-

ment in federal immigration efforts. To the extent that jurisdictions adopt these agreements in response to social influence—rather than through independent policy evaluation—they may commit resources to enforcement in ways that persist beyond the agreements themselves. This has implications not only for enforcement levels but also for broader immigration policymaking. As Pratheepan Gulasekaram and S. Karthick Ramakrishnan (2013) argue, when subfederal governments take on a larger role in immigration enforcement, they may generate political feedback loops that constrain future federal legislative action by normalizing local control. The dynamics identified in this study may also extend beyond 287(g) agreements. States like Texas have recently initiated unilateral enforcement efforts (Barragán and Svitek 2022), and model legislation promoted by interest groups may further diffuse similar policies across jurisdictions (Hertel-Fernandez 2019). Future research can examine whether these newer enforcement regimes—often rooted in partisan dynamics—generate similar institutional commitments and policy effects or whether their consequences differ depending on the motivations and contexts of adoption.

Finally, this study also holds implications for understanding an increasingly important but understudied legal device: the intergovernmental agreement. While only a minority of all counties at any given time participate in 287(g) agreements, it has become far more common for state and local governments to enter into agreements with federal immigration authorities to participate in immigration enforcement in other ways—such as using their correctional facilities to confine noncitizens in ICE custody (Ryo and Peacock 2020). Bridget Fahey (2020) identifies the type of arrangement that exists in a 287(g) agreement as an example of federalism by contract, wherein multiple governments coauthor contracts that function like regulations or statutes. Federal authorities' access to state driver's license databases to conduct facial recognition searches, military transfers of equipment to local police, or Medicaid's operationalization are all achieved through similar agreements. Many such agreements remain secret (Fahey 2020). While much of the scholarly

work that can improve government policy relating to intergovernmental agreements centers around doctrinal questions—of which rules apply or which courts govern, for example—my study contributes to an empirical understanding of such agreements. I show that sociological and organizational processes shape the performance of such agreements in ways that may fundamentally alter participants' priorities and resource allocation. Thus, beyond 287(g) agreements in particular, this study offers a glimpse into the power of intergovernmental contracts to establish new stakes and interests in local governments. These empirical considerations should inform discussions of the costs and benefits of intergovernmental agreements in the context of immigration enforcement and other areas.

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Unpacking the Politics of the US Deportation System



TINA LAW 

There is a growing multidisciplinary effort to understand the political causes and consequences of the US deportation system amid rapidly changing policies and significant data limitations. I contribute to this timely work by considering how interactions between an increasingly empowered executive branch and a politically polarized Congress shape deportation policymaking. I apply a policy feedback approach, a theoretical lens that analyzes policies and politics as co-constitutive, and construct a novel dataset to computationally analyze how Congressmembers publicly responded on Twitter to the Trump administration's implementation and suspension of the family separation policy in 2018, during which migrant parents were prosecuted and detained separately from their children. Findings suggest that Republican and Democratic Congressmembers are unlikely to respond to executive assertions of power on deportation, even when policies are highly unpopular among the public. This raises concerns about shared governance on deportation policy and its implications for migration and democracy.

Keywords: family separation, deportation, policy feedback, political polarization, social media, text analysis

Empirically and systematically studying the growing deportation system in the US is a pressing priority for social scientists. However, this is often a difficult endeavor because of rapidly changing deportation and immigration policies and significant data limitations. Despite these challenges, research on the deportation system is flourishing. For example, a growing body of research examines the politics of

the deportation system, namely how deportation policy shapes experiences of citizenship and non-citizenship (Asad 2023; Rocha et al. 2015; Valdivia 2025, this issue) and the process of deportation policy agenda-setting (Flores 2018; Hopkins 2010; Jones and Martin 2017).

I contribute to this burgeoning and timely multidisciplinary effort to understand the political causes and consequences of the US de-

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Law, Tina. 2025. "Unpacking the Politics of the US Deportation System." *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 49–75. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.03>. Thank you to Em Bello-Pardo for his engagement with this research project, including help with data collection and analysis. Thanks also to the issue editors, fellow contributors, and anonymous reviewers for helpful comments on earlier drafts. This research was supported in part by a collaborative research seed grant from the Summer Institutes in Computational Social Science, Russell Sage Foundation (regranted from grant number G-6821, ROR: <https://ror.org/02yh9se80>), and Alfred P. Sloan Foundation. Direct correspondence to: Tina Law, at law@ucdavis.edu, University of California, Davis, Social Sciences and Humanities, Department of Sociology, One Shields Drive, Room 1298, Davis, CA 95616, United States.

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portation system by applying a policy feedback approach to consider how interactions between an increasingly empowered executive branch and a politically polarized Congress shape contemporary deportation policy. A policy feedback approach offers a theoretical lens to analyze policies and politics as co-constitutive (Mettler and Soss 2004; Pierson 1993; Skocpol 1992) and has been used to study policy domains such as social welfare policy (Campbell 2003; Hacker 2002; Mettler 2005). This approach can also be used to study the politics of deportation policymaking.

I examine how Congressmembers publicly reacted on Twitter (now known as X) to the Trump administration's implementation and suspension of the family separation policy in 2018, which authorized federal authorities to prosecute migrants and separately detain parents and children while they awaited criminal proceedings and deportation. I construct a novel dataset of approximately 830,000 tweets generated by members of the 115th US Congress during their term (2017–2019) and analyze these data using computational text analysis methods and a quasi-experimental design. I find that, irrespective of party affiliation, there was no change in Congressmembers' likelihood of issuing an online public statement about deportation and immigration after the implementation of the family separation policy. However, Congressmembers were less likely to issue online public statements about deportation and immigration after the policy was suspended. I also find that when Congressmembers discussed deportation and immigration during the family separation policy, there was no measurable change in politically polarizing rhetoric, as measured by use of moralizing language, though their tweets about deportation and immigration were highly moralized compared to their tweets on other topics throughout their entire two-year term. The findings confirm that legislators behave as strategic communicators on online social media platforms, as with more traditional mediums of political communication. More important, the findings suggest that, far from serving as a check on executive overreach, Congressmembers are unlikely to respond to executive assertions of power on deportation policy, even

when policies are highly unpopular among the public. This raises concerns about shared governance on deportation policy and its potential implications for migration and democracy.

THE DEPORTATION SYSTEM AND POLICY FEEDBACK

Over the past four decades, social scientists have advanced understanding of the policy feedback process, or how “public policies are not merely products of politics but also shape the political arena and the possibilities for further policymaking” (Campbell 2012, 334). Policy feedback research differs from studies of political process, which focus on ascertaining how policies are produced (that is, policy as a dependent variable), and from policy analysis, which focuses on evaluating the outcomes of policies (that is, policy as an independent variable) (Mettler and SoRelle 2014; Mettler and Soss 2004; Pierson 1993). Instead, this multidisciplinary research engages public policies as living institutions that are not only continuously shaped by, but also actively define, the polity (that is, policy as independent and dependent variables) (Campbell 2012; Mettler and SoRelle 2014; Pierson 1993).

Within the context of the United States, research on policy feedback has primarily examined the role of political elites, interest groups, and the public in the development and implementation of social welfare policies, such as social security, health care, and Aid to Families with Dependent Children, and, in turn, how these policies affect the political behavior of these actors (Campbell 2003; Hacker 2002; Mettler 2005; Pierson 1994; Skocpol 1992; Soss and Schram 2007). In addition to comprehensively identifying the diverse individuals and organizations involved in social welfare policymaking (for example, elected legislators, caseworkers, labor unions, businesses) and tracing their interactions, this research has helped to explain the evolution of social welfare policy over time and to elucidate the obstacles to and possibilities for change (for reviews, see Campbell 2012; Mettler and SoRelle 2014; Mettler and Soss 2004). Specifically, Suzanne Mettler and Mallory SoRelle (2014) identify four important findings from policy feedback research on American social welfare policy: Policies define

citizenship or inclusion in the polity; there is a reciprocal relationship between policies and governance; policies produce interest groups whose advocacy enables policies to persist; and the process of defining and mobilizing support for a policy agenda is dynamic and continual. Taken together, this research provides a useful mapping of social welfare policy that connects and galvanizes researchers and practitioners who seek to improve not just social welfare policy but also the very process that generates and governs these policies.

A policy feedback approach may be similarly useful for organizing and supporting burgeoning research on deportation policymaking. The contemporary deportation system in the US is composed of a vast and growing array of immigration and criminal laws and procedures, developed and implemented by diverse actors at the federal and local levels—all of which collectively define and stratify the experiences of migrants to the US, including their initial journey, their navigation of daily life once they arrive, and their removal (and remigration) if and when they are deported (see Patler and Jones 2025, this issue). The deportation policies that are produced also often fail to produce intended effects and even backfire (Massey et al. 2002, 2014, 2016; Rocha et al. 2014). Given the scale and complexity of the deportation system, a policy feedback approach, with its emphasis on mapping diverse actors and elucidating dynamic processes, may provide an especially helpful theoretical framework for studying deportation policymaking.

There is growing research that examines the politics of the deportation system. This research, which is varied in foci, data, and methods, and which has parallels to policy feedback research on social welfare policy, can generally be organized into two analytic streams: research that analyzes how deportation policy shapes experiences of citizenship and non-citizenship, and research that analyzes the process of deportation policy agenda-setting. Studies from the first analytic stream elaborate the quotidian and extraordinary ways in which deportation policies define citizenship and non-citizenship and the resulting implications for migrants and others living in the US. For ex-

ample, Asad L. Asad (2023) illustrates how the deportation system and its growing surveillance apparatus require citizen and noncitizen Latino migrants to regularly navigate forms of institutional inclusion that vary in benefits and coercion while Carolina Valdivia (2025, this issue) highlights the particularly precarious plight of previously deported undocumented migrants who have returned to the US and their efforts to navigate conditions of what she refers to as hyper-illegality. In a complementary line of research, Rene R. Rocha and colleagues (2015) show that the effects of immigration enforcement on civic inclusion are not limited to migrants but also affect native-born citizens, such that local immigration enforcement can decrease political trust among native-born Latinos while increasing political trust among non-Hispanic Whites. Additional studies show that deportation policies can activate feelings of linked fate among native-born Latinos (Maltby et al. 2020) and incentivize their withdrawal from electoral politics while simultaneously mobilizing them to engage in collective action (Walker et al. 2019).

Meanwhile, studies from the second analytic stream clarify the process of setting and mobilizing support for a deportation policy agenda, particularly how political elites and the mass public interact on issues about migration. Several studies show that political elites are instrumental in mobilizing public support for deportation and other types of restrictionist policies because they can legitimize views already held by some members of the public and provide compelling framings of target populations, social problems, and policy solutions (Newton 2008; Wallace and Zepeda-Millán 2020; Roe 1989; Schneider and Ingram 1993; see also Edelman 1974). Yet, this research also shows that there are important limitations to political elites' influence. Namely, the effectiveness of elite cues is typically conditioned by political partisanship and local context (Hopkins 2010; Jones and Martin 2017), and any effects are usually short-lived, given that public attitudes about migration tend to remain relatively fixed (Flores 2014, 2017, 2018).

I contribute to this growing research on the politics of the deportation system by applying a policy feedback approach to consider how in-

teractions between the two political branches of the US government—the executive branch and Congress—may shape contemporary deportation policy. As I elaborate in this article, interactions between the executive branch and Congress are important when it comes to understanding the development and implementation of deportation policy because these two branches possess unique governing power on issues of immigration, and because current trends pose serious challenges for shared governance and effective policymaking. My focus on how the executive branch and Congress interact on deportation policymaking also complements burgeoning research that examines the role of judicial decision-making in the deportation system (Asad 2019; Blasingame et al. 2024; Kocher 2019; Law 2010).

In the US, the executive branch and Congress assume primary responsibilities on immigration policy. In general, the plenary power doctrine provides Congress with “unfettered discretion to set forth immigration rules absent direct constitutional restraints” and case-law has largely extended this judicial deference to the executive branch on matters of immigration (Koh 2020, 956). Legal scholars observe that this judicial deference has enabled the executive branch to exert much more influence on deportation compared to other policy domains. Because many constitutional protections ensuring checks and balances and judicial oversight and review do not apply in immigration law, the executive branch, which includes the president, appointed advisers, and fifteen executive departments and their associated federal agencies, have uniquely wide latitude for shaping deportation policy (Cox and Rodríguez 2009; Koh 2020; Legomsky 1984). Tools that the executive branch can wield include policymaking (for example, issuing executive orders) and administrative decision-making regarding organization, staffing, and operations of executive departments and federal agencies such as the Department of Homeland Security (DHS), Customs and Border Protection (CBP), and Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) (Chen 2017; Kagan 2001; Koh 2020). Despite the executive branch’s unusual policymaking power as it relates to deportation, Congress nevertheless retains dis-

tinct powers for enacting deportation policies and checking executive overreach, including the ability to change immigration laws, set agency budgets, initiate oversight and investigations, and, most important for this study, publicly justify or criticize actions (Koh 2020).

However, two distinct yet reinforcing trends currently challenge this balance of governing power between the executive branch and Congress on deportation policy. First, the executive branch’s power in shaping deportation policy has increased in recent years as the deportation system has grown and executive administrations—both Republican and Democratic—have been increasingly willing to exercise such power (Donato and Amuedo-Dorantes 2020; Koh 2020). Second, as executive administrations have exercised more power on deportation policy in recent years, Congress has grown more politically polarized, rendering Congressmembers with fewer incentives to check executive overreach and uphold effective governance—especially when it means having to act against their party’s interests (Fennelly et al. 2015; Hacker and Pierson 2019; Layman et al. 2006). These two trends are not unrelated; for example, legal scholars observe that the uptick in executive policymaking on deportation stems in part from executive administrations increasingly viewing legislative reform on immigration as being politically infeasible (Cox and Rodríguez 2009; Koh 2020; see also Donato and Amuedo-Dorantes 2020). Taken together, these two trends significantly distort the current deportation policymaking process and pose broader concerns about policy stability and coherence, shared governance, and democratic responsiveness (Chen 2017; Cox and Rodríguez 2015; Koh 2020).

As such, the current context calls for social scientists who are concerned about deportation policy to closely examine interactions between the executive branch and Congress, particularly when and how Congress responds to executive assertions of power. Toward this end, I apply the policy feedback approach to examine the reactions of the 115th US Congress to the Trump administration’s separation of migrant families at the southern border in 2018. In the next section, I discuss this empirical case, including the opportunities and chal-

lenges it presents for addressing data limitations that have long hindered research on the deportation system.

CONGRESS AND THE 2018 FAMILY SEPARATION POLICY

On May 7, 2018, the US Department of Justice (DOJ) announced the implementation of the Trump administration's family separation policy (Sessions 2018a; Dickerson 2022; see also Alcaraz et al. 2024). The announcement authorized federal authorities to prosecute migrants attempting to cross the southern border and to separately detain parents and children in CBP facilities while they awaited criminal proceedings and deportation. The Trump administration's separation of migrant families was part of a broader zero tolerance approach to border security (Sessions 2018b; Trump 2018a), which originates from the George W. Bush administration's response to the 9/11 attacks and relies on the use of criminal prosecution to deter unauthorized entry by migrants at the southern border (Dickerson 2022; Patler and Jones 2025, this issue). Although previous executive administrations—both Republican and Democratic—have considered separating families to deter migration, the practice was not adopted as part of a federal approach to immigration and deportation until 2018 (Dickerson 2022). The family separation policy, which affected 3,924 children between January 20, 2017, and January 20, 2021, based on estimates from the DHS (2023) faced swift and strong public disapproval (Arango and Cockrel 2018; Everett and Caygle 2018; YouGov 2018), and was quickly suspended by President Trump through an executive order issued on June 20, 2018 (Trump 2018b).¹

I argue that the Trump administration's separation of migrant families in 2018 serves as a useful empirical case for examining when and how Congress responds to executive assertions of power on deportation policy, particularly during a period of heightened political polarization. There are three main reasons. First, the

separation of migrant families exemplifies both an assertion of executive power over deportation policymaking and the limitations of that power. That is, it illustrates the extraordinary political power over deportation that is increasingly consolidated in the executive branch, but also demonstrates the heavy political liabilities that executive administrations incur when wielding this power (Cox and Rodríguez 2009; Koh 2020). This dynamic example of executive power in practice is useful for empirical purposes, as social science research on deportation has typically examined static instances of executive power. Second, the short time frame in which the separation of migrant families was authorized and then subsequently halted by the Trump administration—forty-five days in total—provides a unique window for observing how deportation policy immediately affects governance. Specifically, the separation of migrant families can provide insights into political learning, or how policies shape the political attitudes and behaviors of elected legislators, which has been challenging for policy feedback researchers to empirically observe (Mettler and SoRelle 2014; Pierson 1993). Third, given that “feedback research has focused on historical periods in which partisan cleavages were far less prominent than they are today,” this empirical case can test existing knowledge about policy feedback and provide updates for the current era of elite political polarization (Hacker and Pierson 2019, 13).

In this article, I focus on empirically elaborating one type of readily observable policy feedback during the Trump administration's separation of migrant families in 2018: how Congressmembers publicly responded on Twitter to the implementation and suspension of the family separation policy. This approach has some analytical advantages. Namely, this approach leverages new and relatively accessible digital data to advance knowledge about the deportation system, which social scientists have traditionally studied using survey, interview, and administrative data that are more

1. Although it is difficult to definitively ascertain the number of migrant families who were affected by the 2018 family separation policy due to significant data limitations, a separate report (Dickerson 2018) concludes with a similar figure, estimating that a minimum of 4,335 migrant children were separated from their parents during the Trump administration as of June 18, 2018.

difficult to obtain. Indeed, researchers are increasingly turning to digital data to study immigration and deportation by, for example, analyzing social media data to examine attitudes about immigration among political elites and the public (Flores 2017; Mendelsohn et al. 2021) and using Google Trends data to measure public awareness of deportation threat (Alsan and Yang 2024; Johnson et al. 2024).

However, an important limitation of this approach is that I am unable to determine Congressmembers' motives for their behavior—for example, whether specific actions taken by the Trump administration caused them to issue a public statement on Twitter. As such, I am unable to make any causal inferences. Another limitation is that although tweeting is an increasingly important form of political behavior among Congressmembers (Barberá et al. 2019; Golbeck et al. 2010; Hemphill et al. 2013), tweeting does not constitute policymaking, and I am unable to make any inferences about Congressmembers' legislative activity based solely on their tweets. Nevertheless, analyzing Congressmembers' public statements during this time frame can provide much-needed empirical insights about congressional political behavior during executive assertions of power on deportation, which can be further elaborated by future research that examines more empirical cases.

Should we expect Congressmembers to publicly react to executive assertions of power on deportation policy, and if so, how might we expect them to react? Extensive and long-standing research in political communication demonstrates that Congressmembers are strategic communicators focused on reelection (Fenno Jr. 1978; Grimmer 2013; Mayhew 1974). Increasingly, Congressmembers rely on social media platforms such as Twitter to engage in strategic communication. A growing number of studies show that Congressmembers use social media to share their work with their constituencies and engage in credit-taking, as well as to gauge the sentiment of their constituents and the broader public to inform the positions they take and the policy priorities they set (Barberá et al. 2019; Box-Steffensmeier and Moses 2021; Golbeck et al. 2010; Hemphill et al. 2013; Lee et al. 2025). In contemporary American pol-

itics, then, online engagement is an increasingly prevalent type of congressional political behavior.

A growing body of research on political polarization and social media also shows that political elites, such as Congressmembers, increasingly engage in politically polarizing discourse that reinforces in-group solidarity and out-group antipathy along party lines (Hacker and Pierson 2019; Layman et al. 2006), and that this tendency is further amplified on social media (Rafail et al. 2024; Cinelli et al. 2021; see also Barberá et al. 2020). A recent study finds that since the 1970s, political elites have used more politically polarizing rhetoric over time to discuss the topic of immigration (Card et al. 2022). A hallmark of politically polarizing rhetoric in contemporary American politics is the use of moralizing language, or language that frames political arguments using moral values that emphasize cooperation (that is, other-regarding behavior) and therefore casts opponents as not only uncooperative but also immoral (Jung and Clifford 2025). Studies show that elite political discourse is increasingly moralized, in part because moralizing language is highly effective in mobilizing co-partisans and attacking members of other parties (Clifford et al. 2015; Jung 2023; Wang and Inbar 2021, 2022). Moralizing language serves as a particularly effective tool for Congressmembers when they need to act expeditiously during moments of political tumult to either justify their party's political actions or criticize those of the opposite party.

Given that previous research finds that Congressmembers tend to behave as strategic communicators and increasingly rely on politically polarizing rhetoric based on moralizing language to pursue political goals, I hypothesize that Congressmembers—both Republicans and Democrats—increased their discussion of deportation and immigration on Twitter immediately following the Trump administration's implementation of the family separation policy, albeit for different reasons. Republicans who supported the policy, or at least viewed it as a political victory, likely sought to publicly align themselves with the administration and the policy, whereas Democrats who opposed the policy, or at least viewed it as a political li-

ability, likely sought to publicly criticize the administration and the policy. I also hypothesize that Congressmembers across party lines increased their discussion of deportation and immigration on Twitter immediately following the suspension of the policy. Here, Republicans likely sought to justify the administration's actions in order to avoid the appearance of suffering a political loss, whereas Democrats likely sought to highlight their opposing party's apparent political misstep. With both events, Congressmembers' use of moralizing language in their tweets about deportation and immigration serves as a gauge of political polarization during this time frame. I hypothesize that Congressmembers were more politically polarized, and used more moralizing language after each executive action on the family separation policy, as they likely viewed the widely publicized actions as moments of political tumult in which they needed to quickly mobilize their party.

DATA AND METHODS

To examine Congressmembers' public statements on Twitter during the Trump administration's implementation and suspension of the family separation policy, I constructed a novel dataset from Twitter and analyzed these data using computational text analysis methods and a quasi-experimental research design. The analysis consisted of four main tasks: constructing a tweet corpus, identifying tweets about deportation and immigration, coding tweets for moralizing language, and measuring trends in congressional tweeting behavior immediately after the start and end of the family separation policy.

The 115th US Congress Tweet Corpus

I constructed a dataset, or corpus, of tweets generated by members of the 115th US Congress during their term, which began on January 3, 2017, and ended on January 3, 2019. This corpus consists of approximately 830,000 tweets. Table 1 summarizes this corpus, describing the Congressmembers and their

tweets. All except eight Congressmembers had a Twitter account, which provides further evidence that social media is an important tool for Congressmembers in contemporary American politics (Barberà et al. 2019; Golbeck et al. 2010; Hemphill et al. 2013). In terms of tweets, slightly more than half (58 percent) were written by Democratic Congressmembers, who tended to tweet more on average compared to Republican Congressmembers (approximately 1,884 tweets per Democrat versus 1,104 tweets per Republican).² The tweets were also overwhelmingly generated by Congressmembers who are incumbents (87 percent) and males (75 percent), though this is largely consistent with their overrepresentation in Congress more generally. Appendix A provides additional information about this corpus, including detailed information on how I constructed this corpus.

I also preprocessed the text in this corpus. Because previous research shows that preprocessing decisions, and the order in which they are implemented, can have important downstream implications for text analysis (Denny and Spirling 2018; Grimmer et al. 2022), I describe my preprocessing steps here. I first implemented a set of steps to make the tweet text machine-readable: For example, I set all text to lowercase; removed URLs, emojis, and punctuation; replaced the ampersand symbol with the word "and"; and removed white spaces around text. Notably, I retained hashtags to bolster my ability to identify immigration-related tweets, though I was unable to analyze the hashtags themselves in later analyses because hashtags are not recognized as everyday language and therefore not included in common computational text analysis tools. I then worked to identify tweets written in English since the text analysis tools I use perform best with English language text. I used the *textcat* package in R (Hornik et al. 2013a, 2024b), which supports n-gram-based language categorization, to detect tweets written in English and Spanish. Approximately 98 percent of tweets were detected as containing English. I

2. Members of other parties (Independent and Libertarian) tweeted quite prolifically given their small numbers in Congress; the average number of tweets for members of other parties during this time period was approximately 2,076.

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics of 115th US Congress Tweet Corpus

	<i>N</i>	Prop
Members		
Total	561	—
Party		
Republican	305	0.54
Democrat	251	0.44
Other	5	0.01
Chamber		
Senate	115	0.20
House of Representatives	440	0.78
Delegates	6	0.01
Incumbency status		
Incumbent	487	0.87
First year	74	0.13
Gender		
Male	448	0.80
Female	113	0.20
Twitter participation		
Has account	553	0.99
Has active account	548	0.98
Tweets		
Total	830,158	—
Total English-language tweets	820,267	—
Party		
Republican	337,002	0.41
Democrat	472,884	0.58
Other	10,381	0.01
Incumbency status		
Incumbent	710,754	0.87
First year	109,513	0.13
Gender		
Male	615,983	0.75
Female	204,284	0.25

Source: Author's calculations.

removed non-English tweets, resulting in a slightly smaller corpus that still retains representation of all members of the 115th Congress who had active Twitter accounts during this term.

The preprocessed corpus contains 820,267 tweets from 548 members of the 115th Congress. For the text analyses, I further removed certain words from tweets to focus the analyses. For example, I removed numbers, stop-words, or frequently occurring words that are not substantively meaningful (for example, *I*,

this, *that*), and extremely rare words that appear less than ten times in the entire corpus and may therefore introduce misleading signals in the analyses. I also performed procedures to tokenize text, or split tweets into individual words, so that they could be readily measured using computational text analysis tools.

Identifying Deportation and Immigration-Related Tweets

To measure trends in Congressmembers' discussion of deportation and immigration on

Twitter during the family separation policy, it is necessary to identify tweets in the corpus that mention these topics. Given the size and heterogeneity of the corpus, I used computational text analysis methods to identify relevant tweets. I completed a preliminary analysis to compare a simple dictionary-based approach and Structural Topic Modeling (Roberts et al. 2013, 2014). I found that the dictionary-based approach was more appropriate for identifying deportation- and immigration-related tweets for this corpus because these tweets occur relatively infrequently and do not cluster in a single topic about immigration but instead appear across diverse topics. As such, I proceeded with a dictionary-based approach to identify relevant tweets. I compiled a dictionary of words and phrases related to deportation and immigration by drawing on previous research on American public opinion on immigration (Levy and Wright 2020; Wright and Levy 2019) and immigration discourse on Twitter (Rowe et al. 2021; Stocking et al. 2018), as well as feedback from fellow contributors to this issue. This deportation and immigration dictionary, which consists of fifty-six words and phrases, is available for use in future research and provided in appendix B.

Coding Tweets for Moralizing Language

Trends in Congressmembers' use of moralizing language on Twitter during the family separation policy can serve as a gauge of political polarization. To examine this, I coded deportation- and immigration-related tweets, as well as tweets about other topics, using the extended Moral Foundations Dictionary (eMFD) (Hopp et al. 2020), which is based on Moral Foundations Theory (Haidt and Graham 2007; Graham et al. 2009). This social psychological theory posits that there are five main moral values: care, fairness, loyalty, authority, and sanctity. Care and fairness emphasize individual rights and welfare and tend to be associated with political liberalism, with care centered on concerns about nurture and protection and fairness centered on concerns about reciprocity and justice (Graham et al. 2009). Loyalty, authority, and sanctity emphasize group cohesion and tend to be associated with political conservatism, with loyalty focused on fulfilling

obligations, authority focused on respecting hierarchical roles, and sanctity focused on maintaining cultural boundaries (Graham et al. 2009). Each value can be expressed in positive or negative terms. In political discourse about deportation, for example, care can be positively invoked to emphasize the need for compassion for migrants or negatively invoked to emphasize the need to protect citizens from potential harm posed by migrants. Although there are many other value systems, research shows that the Moral Foundations may be most relevant for identifying moralizing language, especially in American political discourse, because these values tend to be most moralized among Americans (Jung and Clifford 2025).

The eMFD is a validated tool that quantifies the presence and valence of the five moral values in everyday text. The eMFD consists of a set of 3,270 words, in which each word has a defined level of association with each of the moral values—that is, the probability that the word, when used, is associated with a particular value on a scale of 0 (no association) to 1 (perfect association)—and a defined sentiment of association with a particular moral value on a scale of -1 (most negative) to 1 (most positive). For example, the words *betrayal* and *loyalty* are both strongly associated with the value of loyalty (level = 0.48 and 0.47, respectively). However, *betrayal* has a negative sentiment (-0.41) while *loyalty* has a positive sentiment (0.55).

I used the eMFD to code all deportation- and immigration-related tweets, as well as tweets about other topics, for moralizing language. For each tweet, I determined whether any of the words appeared in the eMFD. I then measured each tweet's level and sentiment of association with the five moral values—care, fairness, loyalty, authority, and sanctity—as the mean of all words in the tweet that appeared in the eMFD. Overall, 98.45 percent of all tweets in the corpus contained at least one word from the eMFD. Within a given tweet, an average of 56.23 percent of words appeared in the eMFD (SD = 17.21 percent). In table 2, I provide examples of two deportation- and immigration-related tweets that were strongly associated with each of the five moral foundations: one with overall positive sentiment and one with overall negative sentiment.

Table 2. Examples of Tweets Highly Associated with the Five Moral Foundations

Moral Foundation	Sentiment Type	Tweet Text	Level	Sentiment
Authority	Positive	Dreamers are Americans. They're not pawns, they're not aliens. They +embrace+ the best of America.	0.29	0.33
	Negative	So you're "pro ~immigrant~ " by wanting to ~kill~ a pre-born immigrant child ? Self-refute much?	0.3	-0.34
Care	Positive	We must show @realDonaldTrump that US doesn't have to sacrifice our +compassion+ & conscience for our ~security~ . #NoBan	0.25	0.38
	Negative	Acquitting the ~illegal~ ~immigrant~ who ~shot~ and ~killed~ #KateSteinle of ~murder~ , involuntary manslaughter, and ~assault~ is unconscionable. 1/3	0.29	-0.59
Fairness	Positive	.@NJToday: Congress asks Obama to +protect+ Dreamers	0.27	0.33
	Negative	Thx, @RepAdamSmith, @RepJayapal for sponsoring bill to defund the NW ~Detention~ Ctr. No profit from ~immigrant~ bondage!	0.26	-0.24
Loyalty	Positive	Congratulations @RepEspaillat for your +commitment+ to +protecting+ ~immigrant~ ~rights~ !	0.22	0.22
	Negative	POTUS's anti- ~immigrant~ plans are ~cruel~ and un-American.	0.18	-0.49
Sanctity	Positive	+Celebrating+ the ~border~ , Texas and America at the Charreada at UTRGV in #Brownsville.	0.22	0.33
	Negative	My #ProtectDreamers bill ~shields~ DREAMers' ~data~ from being used by Trump Admin to ~deport~ them. #WithDreamers	0.22	-0.25

Source: Author's calculations.

Note: Words associated with the foundation are boldface. Words with positive sentiment are bracketed with the + symbol, and words with negative sentiment are bracketed with the ~ symbol.

Measuring Trends in Congressional Tweeting Behavior

To measure trends in Congressmembers' tweeting behavior during the family separation policy, I used interrupted time series (ITS) analysis. ITS analysis is appropriate for this study because I am evaluating a complex intervention, defined as a set of time points of interest that are interrelated and occur closely in time (the implementation and suspension of the family separation policy), rather than a single

intervention occurring at one point in time. Compared to other quasi-experimental approaches such as regression discontinuity in time designs (Hausman and Rapson 2018), ITS analysis provides greater flexibility for addressing the challenges associated with evaluating complex interventions (Bernal et al. 2017, 2018). ITS has also previously been used in studies examining Twitter behavior (Jaidka et al. 2019; Endres et al. 2021).

I observed congressional tweeting behavior

between April 1, 2018, and August 1, 2018, which covers approximately one month before the Trump administration implemented the family separation policy (May 7, 2018) and one month after the administration suspended the policy through executive order (June 20, 2018). I used this relatively short time frame because political discourse on Twitter transpires rapidly and therefore it was likely that Congressmembers responded quickly to the family separation policy on Twitter if they responded at all. The unit of analysis is at the tweet-level and observed on a weekly basis. Congressmembers generated 159,787 tweets during this period, which make up 19 percent of all tweets in the corpus. Of these tweets, 12,580 tweets were identified as discussing deportation and immigration.³ I measured two dimensions of congressional tweeting behavior during this time frame, which serve as my dependent variables: the proportion of weekly tweets that were about deportation and immigration, and the average proportion of moralizing language or eMFD words in weekly tweets about deportation and immigration. I used generalized least squares (GLS) models to account for potential temporal trends in the data. I estimated separate models for each dependent variable, with both time points of interest included in all models. I also estimated separate models by party to examine partisan differences (six models in total). Formally, the models can be expressed as follows:

$$\text{TweetDimension} = B_0 + B_1T + B_2X_t + B_3TX_t$$

where B_0 is the baseline level of the outcome (either the proportion of weekly tweets that were about deportation and immigration or the average proportion of eMFD words in weekly tweets about deportation and immigration), B_1 is the change in outcome associated with a time-unit increase, B_2 is the change in the level of the outcome following the intervention (either the start or end of the family separation policy), B_3 is the difference between the pre-intervention and post-intervention slopes of the outcome, T is the number of weeks elapsed since the start of the study, and X_t is a

dummy variable indicating intervention status at time t .

RESULTS

Tweets About Deportation and Immigration by the 115th US Congress

In general, members of the 115th US Congress discussed deportation and immigration relatively infrequently on Twitter during their term between 2017 and 2019. Using a dictionary-based approach, I identified 42,716 tweets about deportation and immigration, which constitute approximately 5 percent of all tweets in the corpus. Given that immigration was a top policy priority for the Trump administration, as evidenced by the many presidential orders on immigration enforcement that were issued (Donato and Amuedo-Dorantes 2020; Immigration Policy Tracking Project 2025; Waslin 2020), it is striking that Congressmembers rarely discussed deportation and immigration on Twitter, especially since the president's party held majorities in both chambers of Congress and Republican Congressmembers therefore could have leveraged this advantage to advance the administration's immigration policy agenda.

When deportation and immigration were discussed on Twitter, Democrats were considerably more likely to tweet about these topics compared to Republicans, generating three-fourths of all deportation- and immigration-related tweets ($n = 32,207$) in the corpus, despite constituting less than half of all members in Congress. The average number of deportation- and immigration-related tweets for Democrats was about 128 tweets, compared to 33 tweets on average for Republicans. This sizable partisan disparity in tweeting was driven by a small number of highly active Democrats, some of whom, such as Representative Pramila Jaypal and Representative Joaquin Castro, often appeared in traditional news media as outspoken critics of the Trump administration during this period. Table 3 describes the top five Congressmembers from each party who tweeted about deportation and immigration and provides ex-

3. I also removed a small number of Congressmember tweets about deportation and immigration ($n = 66$) to ensure that the data for the models did not contain any missing values.

Table 3. Top Five Congressmembers Tweeting About Deportation and Immigration, 2017–2019

Congressmember	Number of Tweets	Years in Office	Example of Tweet with <i>Border</i>
Democrats			
Rep. Luis Gutierrez (Illinois-4)	809	24	This is a country that should value our children. Instead, @realdonaldtrump is holding kids in cages and tent cities at the border . He has chosen to take this democracy to its very bottom. He must end the family separation crisis he created NOW. #FamiliesBelongTogether
Rep. Pramila Jayapal (Washington-7)	797	0	No border wall. Or detention beds. Or any of the other items on Trump's hateful checklist. Period.
Rep. Joaquin Castro (Texas-20)	653	4	We need to stop catering to politicians' self-delusion. We have more border patrol agents, ICE agents, detention centers than ever before with less migration than in years past. We became the most powerful, prosperous nation on earth without a wall. #TrumpShutDown
Rep. Adriano Espaillat (New York-13)	633	0	Americans don't want a border wall. We need a modern day solution to address immigration and the growing #humanitarian crisis at the border. @cnn @NewDay
Rep. Lucille Roybal-Allard (California-40)	574	24	A # Border Wall won't solve our #immigration challenges. We need comprehensive immigration reform that protects American & our values.
Republicans			
Rep. Andy Biggs (Arizona-5)	318	0	We need a wall, and we need it now. That's why I'm continuing to encourage @POTUS @realDonaldTrump to hold firm until his request for increased border wall funding is secured. This is a national security issue, and one that Congressional Democrats should not take lightly.
Rep. Paul Gosar (Arizona-9)	292	6	Americans want a secure border . Americans want a wall. It's time for open border Democrats to stop blocking the wishes of the American people. #BuildTheWall
Rep. Louie Gohmert (Texas-1)	243	12	It is outrageous that we have allowed criminals to take over areas along our southern border on United States federal land.
Sen. John Cornyn (Texas)	195	15	My Senate bill just passed requires U.S. Customs and Border Protection to report to Congress with an operational analysis of the country's air, land, and sea ports of entry, including threats posed by groups and individuals seeking to enter the U.S. unlawfully at ports of entry
Sen. Martha McSally (Arizona)	177	2	Border security is national security. I applaud the Arizona National Guardsmen and women who are deployed to the southern border . I will continue to make sure they have the resources they need to further carry out this mission.

Source: Author's calculations.

amples of their tweets using the word *border*. As might be expected, Republicans typically invoked *border* to voice support for the Trump administration's policies, whereas Democrats used the same word to criticize these policies.

Democratic and Republican Congressmembers also tended to use different words to discuss deportation and immigration on Twitter. Appendix table C.1 shows the most distinctive words and hashtags in deportation- and immigration-related tweets among Democrats and Republicans, which are measured using term frequency-inverse document frequency (TF-IDF) values. TF-IDF is a natural language processing measure that quantifies how important a word is to a corpus of text by taking into account the frequency with which a word appears in a document—in this case, a tweet—and the overall corpus (see Grimmer et al. 2022; Jurafsky and Martin 2024). As the table shows, there was no overlap in distinctive words and hashtags in deportation- and immigration-related tweets between Democrats and Republicans. Whereas Democratic discourse on deportation and immigration on Twitter was defined by words and hashtags such as #keepfamiestogether, #standwithdreamers, and #refugeeswelcome, Republican discourse on these topics was defined by words and hashtags such as #securetheborder, *native*, and #fairimmigration. This indicates strong linguistic polarization among Democrats and Republicans in discourse about deportation and immigration and underscores the importance of using a well-defined dictionary developed by domain experts to appropriately analyze this distinct type of discourse.

In addition, Congressmembers' tweets about deportation and immigration contained more moralizing language on average compared to their tweets about other topics. I calculated the mean level and sentiment of each of the five moral values in each Congressmember's tweets on these topics and their tweets about other topics, and then conducted paired *t*-tests on each of these ten variables. Table 4 shows that there are significant and strong effects of tweet topic, such that tweets about immigration were strongly and negatively associated with each of the five moral values. This finding is consistent with previous research

showing that political elites increasingly use politically polarizing rhetoric involving moralizing language to advance goals on immigration (Card et al. 2022; Simonsen and Bonikowski 2022), and further attests to generally high levels of political polarization in Congress during this time period.

Trends in Congressional Tweeting Behavior During the Family Separation Policy

Although deportation and immigration were relatively rare topics of discussion on Twitter for members of the 115th Congress during their two-year term, they were frequently discussed during the forty-five days in which the Trump administration implemented and suspended its family separation policy. Figure 1 shows the weekly number of deportation- and immigration-related tweets by Republican and Democratic Congressmembers between April 1 and August 1, 2018, with the first vertical line indicating the implementation of the family separation policy (May 7) and the second vertical line indicating the suspension of the policy (June 20). The figure reveals an acute spike in deportation- and immigration-related tweets between the start and end of the family separation policy for Congressmembers of both parties, with the weekly number of relevant tweets for each party increasing rapidly for several weeks post-implementation and then finally decreasing about a week before President Trump issued an executive order to halt family separations. Although Democrats generally tweeted more about deportation and immigration during the study period, trendlines are remarkably parallel for Democrats and Republicans. This suggests that during the family separation policy, Congressmembers made more public statements on Twitter about deportation and immigration than usual.

Results from the GLS models provided in table 5 help to clarify these trends. There is no evidence of an association between Congressmembers' proportion of weekly tweets that discuss deportation and immigration and the start of the family separation policy. However, there is evidence that Congressmembers were less likely to tweet about deportation and immigration after the end of the policy (coefficient = -0.14 , p -value = 0.04).

Table 4. Level and Sentiment of the Five Moral Foundations in Immigration and Non-Immigration Tweets

	Immigration Tweets		Non-Immigration Tweets		Statistical Comparison of Immigration and Non-Immigration Tweets	
	Level	Sentiment	Level	Sentiment	Level	Sentiment
Authority	0.11 (0.03)	-0.04 (0.11)	0.1 (0.03)	0.02 (0.15)	$t(531) = 29.55$ $p < .0001$ $d = 1.28$	$t(531) = -31.6$ $p < .0001$ $d = -1.37$
Care	0.12 (0.03)	-0.07 (0.12)	0.11 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.15)	$t(531) = 21.54$ $p < .0001$ $d = 0.93$	$t(531) = -28.03$ $p < .0001$ $d = -1.22$
Fairness	0.12 (0.03)	-0.04 (0.11)	0.11 (0.03)	0.02 (0.14)	$t(531) = 22.79$ $p < .0001$ $d = 0.99$	$t(531) = -31.03$ $p < .0001$ $d = -1.35$
Loyalty	0.11 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.11)	0.1 (0.02)	0.04 (0.13)	$t(531) = 14.25$ $p < .0001$ $d = 0.62$	$t(531) = -29.12$ $p < .0001$ $d = -1.26$
Sanctity	0.09 (0.02)	-0.05 (0.11)	0.08 (0.03)	0.00 (0.14)	$t(531) = 23.42$ $p < .0001$ $d = 1.02$	$t(531) = -22.03$ $p < .0001$ $d = -0.95$

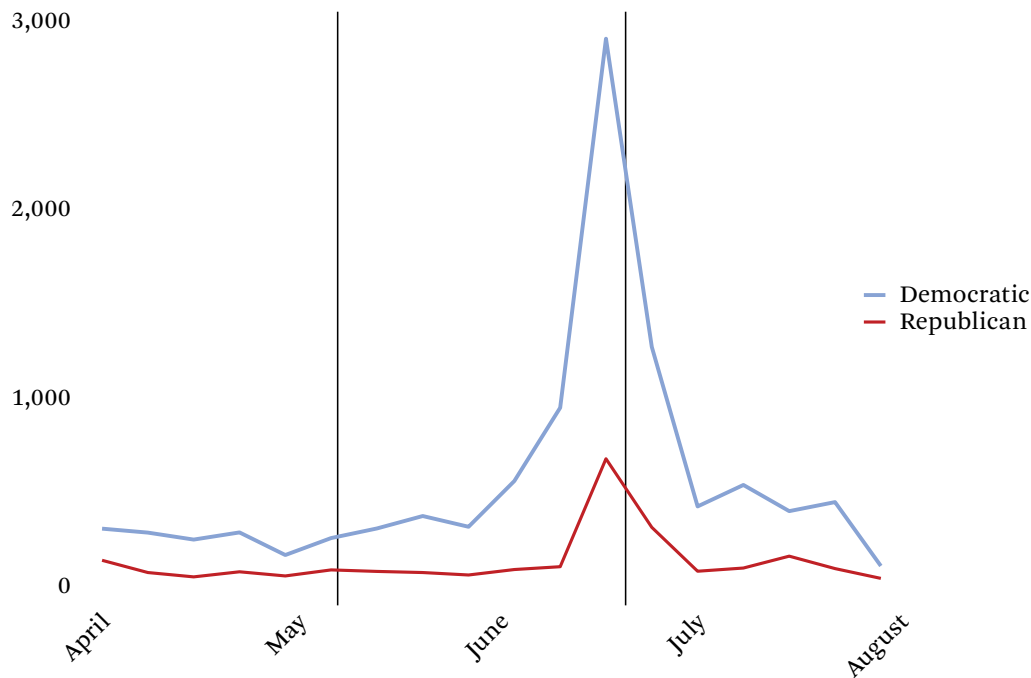
Source: Author's calculations.

Note: Standard deviations shown in parentheses.

In the party-specific models, there is evidence of a post-suspension decrease in relevant tweets for Democrats only (coefficient = -0.18, p -value = 0.02). These findings run counter to my hypotheses that Congressmembers—both Republicans and Democrats—would be politically motivated to increase their discussion of deportation and immigration on Twitter following the implementation and suspension of the family separation policy. The lack of a post-implementation increase in relevant tweets for both parties suggests that there may be a potential lag between executive assertions of power on deportation and congressional responses, particularly when Congressmembers view an action as politically unviable and unpopular, irrespective of their own partisan considerations. The significant post-suspension decrease in relevant tweets among Democrats is somewhat surprising, as it suggests that Congressmembers may be more apt to move on from, rather than capitalize on, executive missteps in deportation policymaking when they

are not the party in power, especially when they view the policy as being unpopular. Indeed, the family separation policy was not only widely publicized but also met with immediate and strong public disapproval (Arango and Cockrel 2018; Everett and Caygle 2018; YouGov 2018). Congressmembers, regardless of their party affiliation, may have therefore sought to distance themselves from this highly unpopular executive action—even after the action was suspended.

I also hypothesized that Congressmembers likely viewed the executive actions on the family separation policy as generating political tumult and increased their use of moralizing language during this time frame to mobilize their own party and attack the opposing party. There is preliminary evidence partially supporting this hypothesis based on a basic quantification of Congressmembers' use of moralizing language in deportation- and immigration-related tweets. During the family separation policy, Democratic tweets on deportation and immi-

Figure 1. Weekly Number of Deportation- and Immigration-Related Tweets by Democratic and Republican Congressmembers, April 1 to August 1, 2018

Source: Author's compilation.

Note: The first vertical line indicates the implementation of the Trump administration's family separation policy (May 7, 2018), and the second vertical line indicates the suspension of the policy (June 20, 2018).

Table 5. Generalized Least Squares Models Predicting Weekly Proportion of Tweets About Deportation and Immigration Among Congressmembers, April 1 to August 1, 2018

	All		Republicans		Democrats	
	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)
Start date	0.043 (0.064)		0.013 (0.035)		0.055 (0.080)	
End date		-0.139** (0.061)		-0.054 (0.036)		-0.183*** (0.071)
Week	0.00004 (0.001)	0.002* (0.001)	0.0001 (0.0005)	0.001* (0.0005)	0.00003 (0.001)	0.002* (0.001)
Constant	-0.623 (15.165)	-29.194* (16.262)	-2.043 (7.962)	-14.267* (8.492)	-0.511 (19.094)	-37.190* (19.949)
Observations	18	18	18	18	18	18
Log likelihood	26.344	28.291	35.595	36.407	22.979	25.531
Akaike Inf. Crit.	-40.688	-46.582	-59.190	-60.813	-33.958	-41.062
Bayesian Inf. Crit.	-35.346	-42.130	-53.848	-55.471	-28.616	-36.610

Source: Author's calculations.

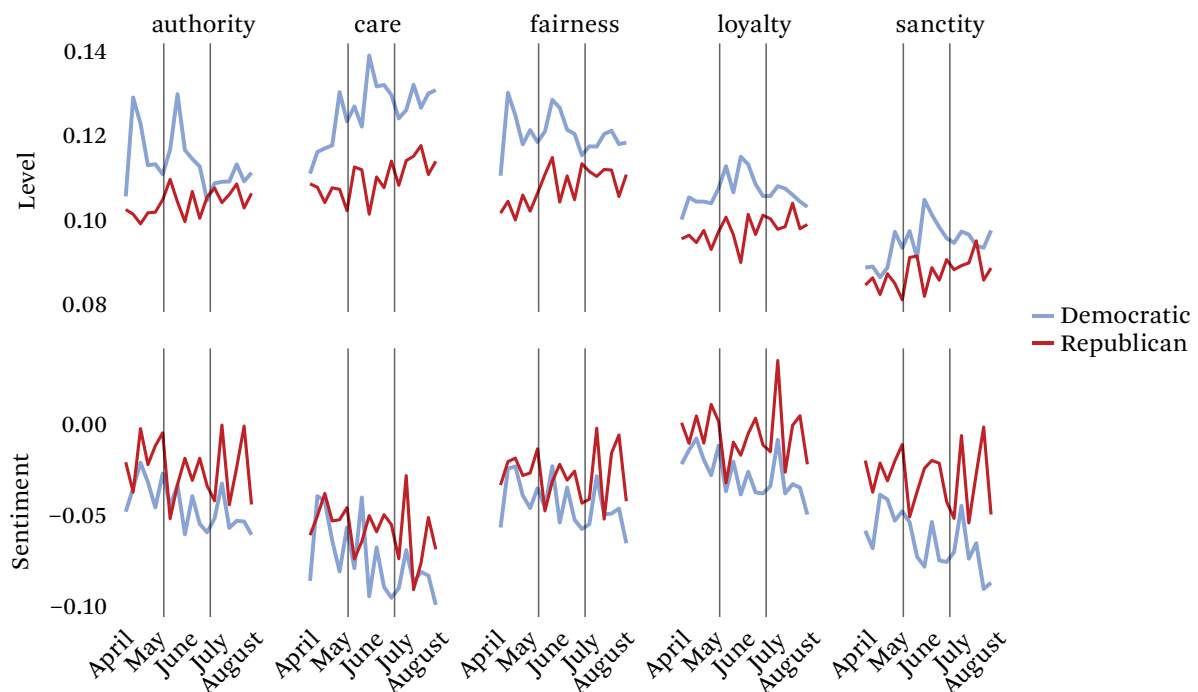
* $p < .1$; ** $p < .05$; *** $p < .01$

gration used more moralizing language and more negative sentiment, while Republican tweets actually used less moralizing language. Figure 2 shows the average level and sentiment of the five moral values—care, fairness, loyalty, authority, and sanctity—in Congressmembers' weekly tweets on deportation and immigration during the study period, with the first vertical line indicating the implementation of the family separation policy (May 7) and the second vertical line indicating the suspension of the policy (June 20). The top half of the figure, corresponding to level of association with moral values, shows that compared to Republicans, Democrats generally used more moralizing language when tweeting about immigration and deportation during the study period. However, during the family separation policy, the parties diverged in their use of moralizing language, with Democrats referring more to care, fairness, authority, and sanctity in their tweets and Republicans referring less to these same values

in their tweets. Interestingly, Democrats used not only individualizing values that are typically associated with political liberalism (care and fairness) during the family separation policy, but also binding values that are typically associated with political conservatism (authority and sanctity).

The second half of figure 2, corresponding to sentiment of association with moral values, shows that Congressmembers from both parties expressed the five values with negative sentiment (for example, care as protection from harm instead of compassion) during the study period. However, during the family separation policy, Democratic tweets were somewhat more negative, perhaps because Democrats sought to mobilize their party in a reactive manner (for example, highlighting the harms they believed the policy was inflicting). Republican tweets, on the other hand, remained relatively unchanged in terms of sentiment during the family separation policy, though there were more

Figure 2. Average Weekly Level and Sentiment of the Five Moral Foundations in Deportation- and Immigration-Related Tweets by Democratic and Republican Congressmembers, April 1 to August 1, 2018



Source: Author's compilation.

Note: The first vertical line indicates the implementation of the Trump administration's family separation policy (May 7, 2018) and the second vertical line indicates the suspension of the policy (June 20, 2018).

Table 6. Generalized Least Squares Models Predicting Average Proportion of Moralized Words in Weekly Tweets About Deportation and Immigration Among Congressmembers, April 1 to August 1, 2018

	All		Republicans		Democrats	
	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)
Start date	-0.007 (0.009)		-0.009 (0.012)		0.002 (0.009)	
End date		-0.008 (0.008)		-0.002 (0.012)		-0.012 (0.008)
Week	0.0002 (0.0001)	0.0002* (0.0001)	0.0005*** (0.0002)	0.0004** (0.0002)	-0.00001 (0.0001)	0.0001 (0.0001)
Constant	-2.334 (2.023)	-2.619 (1.913)	-8.105*** (2.663)	-6.709** (2.767)	0.804 (2.083)	-1.888 (1.732)
Observations	18	18	18	18	18	18
Log likelihood	56.692	56.888	45.146	44.795	55.207	56.397
Akaike Inf. Crit.	-103.384	-103.775	-78.292	-77.590	-98.414	-100.794
Bayesian Inf. Crit.	-98.932	-99.324	-72.950	-72.248	-93.072	-95.452

Source: Author's calculations.

* $p < .1$; ** $p < .05$; *** $p < .01$

positive expressions of loyalty after the end of the policy.

Results from the GLS models in table 6 temper these preliminary findings. In the general and party-specific models, there was no evidence of an association between Congressmembers' proportion of weekly deportation- and immigration-related tweets that use moralizing language and either the start or end of the family separation policy. This lack of an association runs counter to my hypothesis that Congressmembers from both parties would immediately and noticeably increase their use of moralizing language in order to mobilize their own party to respond to the political tumult generated by the executive actions on migrant families. However, it is quite possible that no change was detected in Congressmembers' use of moralizing language immediately after the implementation and suspension of the family separation policy because, as previously discussed, their tweets about deportation and immigration were already highly moralized relative to their tweets about other topics (see table 4).

Results from an additional set of models potentially suggest an unexpected way that Congressmembers may use moralizing language

during moments of political tumult involving deportation policy. Table 7 presents results from GLS models estimating the association between Congressmembers' use of moralizing language in weekly tweets that are not about deportation and immigration and the start and end of the family separation policy. There is some evidence that immediately after the implementation of the policy, Congressmembers were more likely to use moralizing language in tweets about topics unrelated to deportation and immigration (coefficient = 0.01, p -value = 0.08). The party-specific models provide some evidence of a post-implementation increase in moralizing language in Democratic tweets about other topics (coefficient = 0.01, p -value = 0.08). For example, many Democrats used moralizing language in the week after the start of the family separation policy to criticize the 2018 Farm Bill, which at the time proposed new work requirements for Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program recipients. These results potentially suggest that during periods of political upheaval generated by specific executive actions on deportation, Congressmembers may not necessarily increase their use of moralizing language about the topic at hand, but instead draw on moralizing language to discuss

Table 7. Generalized Least Squares Models Predicting Average Proportion of Moralized Words in Weekly Tweets About Other Topics Among Congressmembers, April 1 to August 1, 2018

	All		Republicans		Democrats	
	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)	(1)	(2)
Start date	0.012* (0.007)		0.012 (0.008)		0.013* (0.007)	
End date		-0.006 (0.009)		-0.014 (0.010)		-0.005 (0.008)
Week	-0.00005 (0.0001)	0.0002 (0.0001)	-0.00003 (0.0001)	0.0003* (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	0.0001 (0.0001)
Constant	1.405 (1.501)	-2.139 (2.006)	1.142 (1.891)	-3.900* (2.304)	1.649 (1.618)	-1.802 (1.880)
Observations	18	18	18	18	18	18
Log likelihood	64.175	61.737	62.114	60.540	62.269	60.709
Akaike Inf. Crit.	-116.350	-113.474	-112.228	-111.079	-112.538	-109.417
Bayesian Inf. Crit.	-111.008	-109.022	-106.886	-106.628	-107.195	-104.075

Source: Author's calculations.

* $p < .1$; ** $p < .05$; *** $p < .01$

other issues as a way to mobilize their party more generally, especially when their party is not in power. However, these results, which suggest an apparent spillover of moralizing discourse from deportation and immigration to other issues during politically tumultuous moments, are quite tentative and should be examined more closely in future work.

Role of Retweets

The trends I identified in congressional tweeting behavior during the family separation policy may be misleading if this behavior was systematically different by political party. Namely, it is possible that Republicans tweeted less about deportation and immigration during this time frame and instead relied on retweeting President Trump at the time, who frequently tweeted about immigration in this period. I examined retweets and found little evidence supporting this. Table C.2 shows that there was no partisan difference in likelihood of retweeting in general nor on the specific topic of deportation and immigration. In fact, Democrats were somewhat more likely to make use of retweets when discussing immigration (0.23 of all tweets) compared to other topics (0.21). Table C.3 also shows that President Trump was not

the most frequently retweeted account by Republicans on the topic of deportation and immigration, as might be expected; the top retweeted accounts among Republicans were @FoxNews and @HouseHomeland (account at the time for the DHS). Together, this suggests that it is unlikely that the trends I observed in congressional tweeting behavior during the family separation policy were driven by Republicans' greater reliance on retweeting the executive.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

In this study, I examined how Congressmembers publicly responded on Twitter to the Trump administration's family separation policy in 2018. I applied a policy feedback approach (Mettler and Soss 2004; Pierson 1993; Skocpol 1992) and constructed a novel dataset of tweets to computationally analyze Congressmembers' public statements on Twitter immediately following the implementation and suspension of the family separation policy. My analysis shows that there was no change in Congressmembers' likelihood to issue online public statements about deportation and immigration after the implementation of the widely publicized and highly unpopular policy,

though they were less likely to make such statements after the policy was suspended. When Congressmembers publicly discussed deportation and immigration during the family separation policy, there was no measurable change in their rhetoric in terms of moralizing language, though their tweets on deportation and immigration were highly moralized compared to their tweets on other topics throughout their two-year term. It seems that during the family separation policy, Congressmembers from both parties generally did not exercise their ability to check executive overreach and instead chose to distance themselves from a policy they viewed as politically unviable and unpopular.

These findings provide helpful and timely insights into how an increasingly empowered executive branch and a politically polarized Congress interact to shape contemporary deportation policy. In the US, statutory frameworks call for shared governance on deportation policy between Congress and the executive branch, which is distinct from how other policy areas are typically governed (Cox and Rodríguez 2009; Koh 2020). As executive power on deportation has expanded over time, it has become increasingly incumbent for Congress to check executive overreach (Donato and Amuedo-Dorantes 2020; Koh 2020). The findings in this study cast doubt on the ability of Congress to fulfill this role. That Congressmembers are unwilling to respond to executive assertions of power on deportation when their party is in power may not be surprising, given that elite political polarization decreases incentives for Congressmembers to act against their own party (Hacker and Pierson 2019). That is, it is not surprising that Republicans did not publicly respond in a measurable way to the Trump administration's family separation policy. However, it is surprising to observe this same behavior among Democrats, who we would expect, based on the literature on elite political polarization, to have strong political incentives to criticize these executive actions. Although a small number of Democrats vocally criticized and even engaged in protest against the family separation policy (Arango and Cockrel 2018), the study shows that the vast majority of Democrats were not more likely to publicly

discuss deportation and immigration on Twitter after the start of the policy and were even less likely to discuss these topics after the end of the policy. These findings are especially concerning, given that these executive actions were widely publicized and highly unpopular (Everett and Caygle 2018; YouGov 2018), which would seemingly compel, or at least allow, Congressmembers—of either party—to respond. This study reveals that when the executive branch asserts power on deportation, Congressmembers may be just as likely to avoid responding as they are to justify or criticize these actions, which has the effect of allowing the boundaries of executive power to expand even as specific actions—such as the family separation policy—may succeed or fail.

This study has limitations. Namely, while I analyzed when and what Congressmembers posted on Twitter, I am unable to determine why they posted—for example, whether they were motivated to post in response to specific actions taken by the Trump administration and public outcry. Additional data on Congressmembers' interactions with the Trump administration and the public during this time may help to test causal links. This is an important limitation of this study, which reflects general limitations of observational data and long-standing data and methodological challenges that hamper policy feedback research (Campbell 2012; Pierson 1993). I am also unable to rule out the possibility that Congressmembers' tweeting behavior was influenced by other deportation- and immigration-related events that occurred during the same period, though I attempted to mitigate this by defining a short study period.

Future research should continue to elaborate the relationship between deportation policy and governance by broadening analysis to include more individuals and organizations who assume important roles in federal deportation policymaking alongside the president, Congress, and the judiciary. For example, more research is needed to understand federal agencies and their internal and external dynamics with regard to deportation policy (Chen 2017; Cox and Rodríguez 2015; Rocha et al. 2014). These include federal agencies with obvious

purview over deportation policy, such as the DHS, CBP, and ICE, but may also include agencies that appear less directly relevant, such as the Department of the Treasury and the Department of Commerce (including the US Census Bureau). Relatedly, there is also a need for more research on the individuals and organizations that constitute what Ian G. Peacock (2025, this issue) calls the “subfederal deportation system.” For example, sheriffs often exercise considerable discretion in enforcing deportation policy at the county level, and understanding when and why they exercise discretion can surface new and useful insights (Peacock 2025, this issue; Pedroza 2019). In addition, there is ample opportunity to understand the role of nongovernmental interest groups in deportation policymaking and how these groups collaborate and compete to wield influence on deportation policy over time (Wong 2006). As the deportation system expands and evolves, it will be necessary for social scientists to broaden their efforts to analyze more actors and actions, while also connecting these efforts into a unified account of this increasingly pervasive and consequential system.

The first months of the second Trump administration indicate that executive action on deportation, which has increased steadily over the past several executive administrations, is likely to accelerate and expand (Congressional Research Service 2025). This development, paired with continued elite political polarization, will likely make interventions by Congress simultaneously more necessary and more difficult. Moving forward, social science scholarship will be crucial for tracking and explaining the increasingly tight coupling of deportation policy and governance in the US and its implications for migration and democracy.

APPENDIX A. DEVELOPMENT OF THE 115TH US CONGRESS TWEET CORPUS

I constructed a dataset of all tweets generated by the 115th US Congress by compiling and linking data across three sources. First, I collected data on the members of the 115th Congress, which commenced on January 3, 2017, and ended on January 3, 2019, from the official congressional website (<https://congress.gov>). For this Congress, there were a total of 561 members, consisting of 115 Senators, 440 Representatives, and 6 nonvoting delegates. Notably, there was considerable turnover, due in part to this term commencing shortly after the 2016 election, with 42 members serving only part of this term. This Congress was also distinct in that both the Senate and House of Representatives had Republican majorities. I used this data source to identify members as well as to construct several member-level covariates, namely party, incumbency status, and gender.

To collect Twitter handles, or account names, for this Congress, I obtained a list of Congressman handles used in a previous study (Schwemmer et al. 2020), and manually added and updated handles for Congressmembers who had missing or outdated handles in this list, preferring verified to unverified accounts. Of the 561 members of the 115th Congress, I was able to identify Twitter accounts for 553 members. The eight members without Twitter accounts likely either did not have accounts or deleted them by the time I began this study.⁴

Finally, I collected tweets generated by members of the 115th Congress via the Twitter Application Programming Interface (API) with the *rtweet* package in R (Kearney 2018). Using the Twitter API, I collected the 3,200 most recent tweets associated with each identified Congressman handle.⁵ The nature of the API pulls made it so that I was only able to col-

4. The eight members include Madeleine Bordallo (Democrat, Delegate for Guam), Jason Chaffetz (Republican, Representative for Utah District 3), Trent Franks (Republican, Representative for Arizona District 8), Tim Murphy (Republican, Representative for Pennsylvania District 18), Collin Peterson (Democrat, Representative for Minnesota District 7), Mike Pompeo (Republican, Representative for Kansas District 4), Tom Price (Republican, Representative for Georgia District 6), and Jeff Sessions (Republican, Senator for Alabama).

5. At the time of this study, 3,200 was the maximum number of tweets that could be collected from a single account, as set by the Twitter API.

lect tweets that were present on that date, meaning that I may be missing tweets that were created but deleted before that date, which is an acknowledged limitation of this dataset. I collected tweets for 520 Congressmembers shortly after the end of the 115th congressional term on January 11, 2019. Twelve Congressmembers who were not reelected had already deleted their accounts by this date; for these Congressmembers, I relied on tweets collected earlier, on October 26, 2018. I collected tweets for 21 additional Congressmembers on February 19, 2019, March 14, 2019, and March 15, 2019. I was ultimately able to collect 830,158 tweets for 548 members of the 115th Congress, with 5 members having no tweets generated

during this term despite having accounts.⁶ For each Congressmember, I retained tweets generated during the time they served as part of the 115th Congress (whether for a full or partial term).

The 115th US Congress Tweet Corpus I have assembled for this study is a novel and useful dataset, given its comprehensive coverage of social media activity among Congressmembers for the entirety of a congressional session, as well as its overlap with the first two years of the first Trump administration. These types of social media datasets are becoming rare, as platforms such as Twitter (now known as X) increasingly restrict research access to platform data.

APPENDIX B. DEPORTATION AND IMMIGRATION DICTIONARY

The following is a list of words and terms I used to identify tweets discussing deportation and immigration in the 115th US Congress Tweet Corpus.

alien	deported	illegal immigrant	non-citizen
aliens	deportation	illegal immigrants	permanent resident
amnesty	dhs	illegal worker	refugee
anchor baby	dreamers	immigrant	refugees
asylum	#FamilySeparation	immigrants	sanctuary city
asylum seeker	family separation	immigration	sanctuary cities
border	#FamiliesBelongTogether	involuntary separation	separation crisis
borders	forcible separation	#KeepFamiliesTogether	southern border
border patrol	forcibly separating	#KidsinCages	temporary protected status
build the wall	green card	migrant	travel ban
caravan	green cards	migrants	unaccompanied minor
child migrant	guest worker	migration	undocumented
citizenship	illegals	muslim ban	visa
criminal alien		noncitizen	
daca			
deport			

6. These five members include Rob Bishop (Republican, Representative for Utah District 1), Evan Jenkins (Republican, Representative for West Virginia District 3), Brenda Jones (Democrat, Representative for Michigan District 13), Jon Kyl (Republican, Senator for Arizona), and Mick Mulvaney (Republican, Representative for South Carolina District 5).

APPENDIX C: ADDITIONAL TABLES

Table C.1. Most Distinctive Words and Hashtags in Deportation- and Immigration-Related Tweets Identified with TF-IDF Values

Party	Top Twenty Words and Hashtags
Democrats	#borderbiz, #standwithdreamers, aliens, #toimmigrantswithlove, #istandwithimmigrants, advocates, #nobannowall, #refugeeswelcome, #worldrefugeeday, happening, agree, statement, donate, antiimmigrant, #keepingfamieliestogether, #immigrantsrights, #keepfamieliestogether, noon, jesus, #dreamersdeserveavote
Republicans	fly, #citizenshipmatters, policy, #securetheborder, congratulations, box, alienated, native, hit, seeks, base, incredible, analysis, #crossborder, muslim, #fairimmigration, spring, final, nafta, smart

Source: Author's calculations.

Table C.2. Tweets and Retweets by Party and Topic

Party	All Tweets		Deportation- and Immigration-Related Tweets Only	
	Original Tweets	Retweets	Original Tweets	Retweets
Republican	261,935 (0.78)	75,067 (0.22)	8,075 (0.78)	2,220 (0.22)
Democrat	371,907 (0.79)	100,977 (0.21)	24,923 (0.77)	7,284 (0.23)
Other	8,403 (0.81)	1,978 (0.19)	166 (0.78)	48 (0.22)

Source: Author's calculations.

Note: Counts shown with proportion of tweets per party in parentheses.

Table C.3. Top Five Twitter Accounts Retweeted by 115th Congress on Topic of Deportation and Immigration

Party	Top Five Twitter Accounts
Democrats	1. @HispanicCaucus (530) 2. @LeaderHoyer (104) 3. @HomelandDems (91) 4. @HouseDemocrats (82) 5. @SpeakerPelosi (74)
Republicans	1. @FoxNews (112) 2. @HouseHomeland (112) 3. @realDonaldTrump (101) 4. @JudiciaryGOP (84) 5. @FoxBusiness (58)

Source: Author's calculations.

Note: Counts shown in parentheses.

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Climate of Exclusion: Spillover Effects of Home-Country Natural Disasters on Immigrant Removals from the United States



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Deportations of immigrants from the United States have grown substantially over the past two decades. While existing research has examined how changes to US laws and policies have contributed to this increase, less attention has been given to how conditions in immigrants' countries of origin shape deportation patterns. This article investigates how an important external shock—home-country natural disasters—influences immigrant removals from the US. We combine annual data on removals by country with information on natural disasters to estimate difference-in-differences models that exploit exogenous variation in the timing and magnitude of natural disasters across countries. Our results show that immigrant removals increased, on average, by 29 percent after salient natural disasters. When we explore mechanisms, we find little evidence that home-country natural disasters increase irregular migration, but we do find that non-citizen and likely undocumented immigrants increase their labor force participation and employment following these shocks. This finding suggests that natural disasters in immigrants' countries of origin may influence the economic behavior of immigrants, putting them at greater risk of detection by immigration enforcement authorities.

Keywords: climate change, natural disasters, immigration, removals, deportation

Deportations of immigrants from the United States have grown substantially over the past two decades. Immigrant removals more than doubled in the first decade of the twenty-first century, from slightly more than 185,000 in 2000 to nearly 432,000 by 2013.¹ While total removals declined in subsequent years, they remained much higher than in the early 2000s.

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Laurito, Agustina, and Ashley N. Muchow. 2025. "Climate of Exclusion: Spillover Effects of Home-Country Natural Disasters on Immigrant Removals from the United States." *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 78–101. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.04>. We thank participants of the Russell Sage Foundation conference "The Deportation System and Its Aftermath," the editors of this issue, and three anonymous reviewers for their insightful comments and feedback. Direct correspondence to: Agustina Laurito, at malaurit@uic.edu, 400 South Peoria Street, Room 2118 (MC 278), Chicago, IL 60607, United States. Ashley N. Muchow, at muchow2@uic.edu, 1007 West Harrison Street, Room 4014B BSB (MC 141), Chicago, IL 60607, United States.

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1. Authors' calculations using data on removals from the *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics* using years 2000–2019 (<https://ohss.dhs.gov/topics/immigration/yearbook>). For additional details on the patterns of deportation

As Caitlin Patler and Bradford Jones (2025, this issue) describe in detail, this increase in removals is due, in part, to the growing immigration enforcement apparatus in the US that has leveraged local criminal justice systems to identify, apprehend, and remove noncitizens from the US. Research has examined how immigration enforcement policies, laws, and regulations have contributed to the rise in removals in the post-migration US context—focusing on the role that national, state, and local forces play in shaping deportation patterns (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2019; Armenta 2017) and their effect on immigrant outcomes (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman 2022; Amuedo-Dorantes and Arenas-Arroyo 2019; Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2020; Bellows 2019; East et al. 2023).² Less attention has been paid to the influence of country-of-origin conditions and premigration contexts on removal dynamics, and the little research that has investigated these forces has yet to consider how they influence deportation vulnerabilities of immigrants already present in the US. Thus, to gain a full picture of the forces that shape deportation patterns in the US, we consider the influence of premigration conditions and origin-country contexts on the probability of apprehension and removal.

Natural disasters in immigrants' countries of origin represent a critical, though often overlooked, premigration and post-migration factor that may shape deportation dynamics in the US. On the one hand, natural disasters may increase migration from affected countries to the US (Berlemann and Steinhardt 2017; Ibáñez et al. 2021). If this migration occurs through unauthorized channels, it could lead to a rise in removals by increasing the number of individuals who are legally subject to deportation. On the other hand, natural disasters may also influence the behaviors of immigrants already residing in the US in ways that increase their visibility to immigration enforcement and their risk of deportation. For example, if immigrants need to send financial support to disaster-

affected relatives, they may enter the labor force, become employed, or take on additional work. They may also make more frequent visits to locations to wire money, potentially increasing their chances of contact with law enforcement.

This article expands our understanding of deportation dynamics by estimating the effect of home-country natural disasters on immigrant removals from the US. This question is domestically and internationally salient, as natural disasters are expected to increase in frequency and magnitude in the coming years amid a changing climate (Van Aalst 2006). Specifically, we seek to answer two research questions. First, do international natural disasters increase immigrant removals in the US? Second, what are some possible mechanisms that may explain any observed increases in removals following these disasters? To answer these questions, we employ a quasi-experimental research design that exploits exogenous variation in the timing and magnitude of natural disasters across the globe from 2000 to 2019.

To preview our results, we find that salient international disasters increase immigrant removals by 29 percent. This change represents a clear break from prior trends. While we find no evidence that irregular migration grew following these shocks, we do observe increases in the labor force participation and employment of noncitizens and likely undocumented immigrants that range from 20 to 24 percent, as well as increases in remittances. These results suggest that, after salient home-country natural disasters, immigrants from disaster-affected countries living in the US alter their behaviors in ways that increase their vulnerability to detection and subsequent deportation by immigration enforcement authorities.

DETERMINANTS OF IMMIGRANT REMOVALS

The surge in deportations from the US over the last three decades has prompted scholars to

over time, see Caitlin Patler and Bradford Jones (2025, this issue). We use the terms *deportations* and *removals* interchangeably, though we note that *removals* is the official term used by the US government to describe involuntary expulsions from the country.

2. See also Bennett et al. (2025, this issue); Hong et al. (2025, this issue); Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj (2025, this issue).

take stock of the underlying reasons behind this growth. Escalations in removals have coincided both with the expansion of the immigration enforcement apparatus and policy changes that broadened the grounds for deportation and curtailed legal immigration pathways (Moinester 2024). A series of legal and policy actions—particularly laws passed between 1986 and 1996—expanded the criminal grounds for deporting noncitizens (Hausman 2021; Miller 2003; Stumpf 2006). These legal changes also increased immigration enforcement spending and facilitated local involvement in the enforcement of federal immigration law—laying the groundwork for today’s “formidable immigration enforcement machinery” (Meissner et al. 2013). National security concerns following the terrorist attacks of 9/11 fueled additional spending, with expenditures nearly tripling from \$9.2 billion in 2003 to \$26 billion by 2021 (American Immigration Council 2021). This expansion was accompanied by increased state and local involvement in identifying, apprehending, and detaining deportable noncitizens through programs such as Section 287(g) and Secure Communities (Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse 2020, 2024).³ The result was a dramatic increase in deportations, driven not only by policy and institutional growth but also by a broadening set of circumstances under which individuals could be targeted for removal.

Various frameworks have been employed to understand how deportation risk is distributed across immigrant populations, highlighting the significance of factors such as interior immigration enforcement, exposure to the criminal justice system, time in the US, and employment. The initiation of deportation proceedings requires that deportable noncitizens be identified and ultimately apprehended and detained by federal immigration authorities (Moinester 2024). Justifications for immigrant deportation typically hinge on a lack of legal status or criminal history (Hausman 2021; Moinester 2024). But not all undocumented immigrants face deportation, nor are all noncitizens convicted of deportable crimes removed from the country.

Noncitizens with criminal records—especially those convicted of aggravated felonies—are more likely to be targeted for removal (Hausman 2021). Yet even those with low-level convictions or no criminal history may be apprehended and removed, especially under expansive enforcement policies or when lacking legal status (Grimsley and Vásquez 2024). Recent undocumented arrivals may also face increased odds of deportation, especially when apprehended at the border, as was the case during the Biden administration (Muzaffar and Bush-Joseph 2024).

Labor dynamics also play a role in channeling migrant inflows and shaping deportation patterns. In 2007, rates of joblessness among the working class skyrocketed amid the economic turmoil of the Great Recession (Groshen and Holzer 2021). With construction and building sectors contracting during the real estate bust, crucial outlets for Latino immigrant male labor waned. These contractions may have heightened the expendability of immigrant labor and increased deportation risk (De Genova 2002). Indeed, prior work evaluating trends over this period has linked unemployment to increased rates of Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) apprehension (Joyner 2018).

At a more microlevel, employment and labor force participation can influence immigrant exposure to deportation. Working at a site targeted by a federal workplace raid or encountering local law enforcement while commuting to and from work can increase an individual’s risk of deportation. In most US states, undocumented immigrants are ineligible for state-issued identification cards or driver’s licenses (Urban Institute 2021). Because driving without a license is an arrestable offense, the act of driving for many undocumented immigrants can increase the odds of police apprehension. Under programs like 287(g) and Secure Communities, arrests can easily trigger deportation proceedings if a noncitizen lacks documentation or has committed a deportable offense (Armenta 2017).

While research has documented how noncitizens alter their behavior to reduce visibility

3. For additional details on related laws, policies, and programs, see Caitlin Patler and Bradford Jones (2025, this issue).

and limit exposure to the expanding immigration enforcement apparatus (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman 2022; Asad 2023; East et al. 2023; Wong and Shklyan 2024), immigrants—regardless of documentation status—also engage in selective avoidance (Asad 2023). Thus, life in the US requires immigrants to navigate a tension between avoiding situations that could lead to detection and deportation, and engaging with institutions—such as schools, workplaces, or hospitals—that increase their visibility as they settle in the US and meet social responsibilities (Asad 2023). Thus, if the immigrant experience consists of a balance between engagement and avoidance, we ask in this article whether home-country natural disasters influence this dynamic in ways that increase immigrant vulnerability to deportation.

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

Given these internal enforcement dynamics, we identify two key pathways through which natural disasters may increase removals of immigrants from affected countries. As depicted in figure 1, home country natural disasters could influence removals through two main mechanisms. First, they may motivate unauthorized migration to the US from disaster-affected countries. Second, they could alter the behavior of immigrants from those countries living in

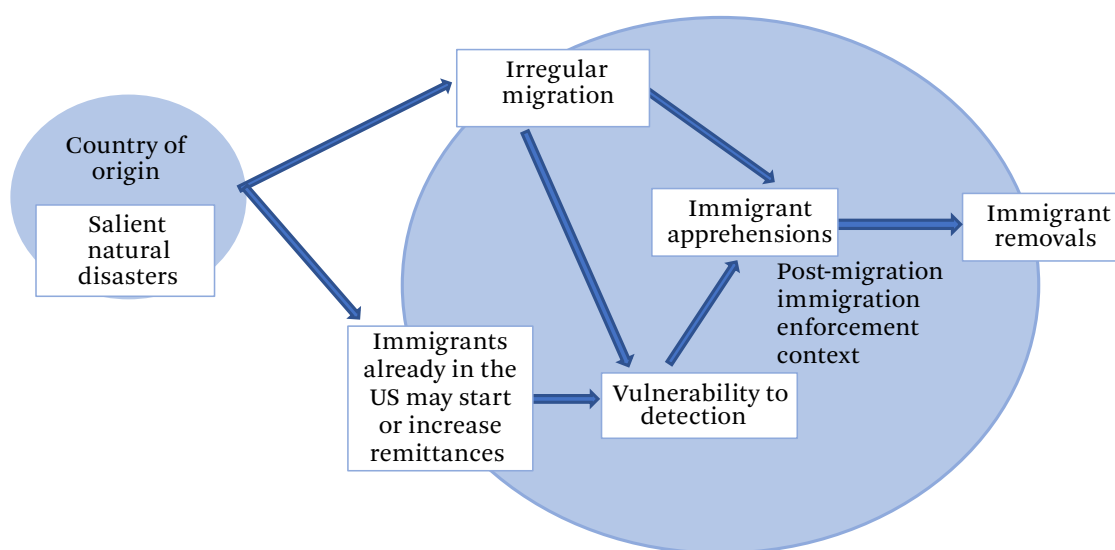
the US in ways that increase their vulnerability to detection and deportation.

Natural Disasters and International Migration

Growing scholarly attention to the link between natural disasters and migration has been spurred by concerns about the increased frequency and severity of these events in a changing climate (Van Aalst 2006). While estimates vary, some suggest that in the next thirty years as many as two hundred million people could be affected by climate-related displacement (Kaczan and Orgill-Meyer 2020; Newland 2011). Climate-related shocks may directly induce internal and international migration through their effects on agricultural output. They may also indirectly prompt migration by increasing wage gaps between and within countries, making migration from less to more developed countries more attractive (Berlemann and Steinhardt 2017).

Prior research has documented these shifts, highlighting that climate and natural disasters may have a larger impact on migration in agriculture-dependent economies (Berlemann and Steinhardt 2017; Ibáñez et al. 2021; Kaczan and Orgill-Meyer 2020; Newland 2011). For example, existing research has shown that changes in rainfall and temperature increase migration from Mexico to the US (Berlemann

Figure 1. Conceptual Framework: Effect of Home-Country Natural Disasters on Immigrant Removals



Source: Authors' compilation.

and Steinhardt 2017). Similarly, Ana Maria Ibáñez and colleagues (2021) find that extreme temperature changes also increase international migration, likely to the US, from agricultural-dependent households in El Salvador. Taken together, this body of research supports the notion that migration to the US may increase after international natural disasters and extreme weather events. Focusing specifically on hurricanes, Parag Mahajan and Dean Yang (2020) find that the share of immigrants from hurricane-affected countries entering the US increased following these events. Their article also finds increases in regular migration that benefited from preexisting networks within the US, for example, through direct sponsorship. This focus on regular migration, however, does not preclude the possibility that natural disasters may also encourage undocumented migration.

Understanding whether and to what extent international natural disasters increase regular or irregular migration is important because prevailing premigration conditions create inequities that may facilitate or hinder regular migration (Patler and Jones 2025, this issue), and a migrant's status affects their probability of removal from the US. In other words, if natural disasters increase unauthorized migration, we might observe an increase in removals after these salient shocks because of the higher number of deportable immigrants entering the US. While policies such as Temporary Protected Status (TPS) protect some unauthorized immigrants from deportation, TPS designation tends to occur in the wake of large-scale natural disasters that generate widespread attention and international response (for example, the Haiti earthquake of 2010). TPS designation is much less likely when countries experience multiple smaller-scale disasters that cumulatively produce substantial human and economic costs. While such disasters are less likely to garner widespread attention and a policy response, they may still increase international migration through the direct and indirect channels outlined above. Thus, after salient home-country natural disasters, we may observe an inflow of undocumented immigrants

arriving in the US that increases removals following these shocks.

Migrant Transnationalism and Increased Vulnerability to Detection

Periods of acute need in immigrants' home countries may activate transnational obligations in ways that increase the exposure of immigrants in the US to immigration enforcement. A large body of work has shown that immigrants maintain home-country connections (Akay et al. 2017; Orozco and Burgess 2011; Portes et al. 1999; Soehl and Waldinger 2010; Waldinger 2013, 2015). For example, many immigrants maintain regular communication with family and friends in their home countries and visit if they are able to travel. Importantly, immigrants are key players in a system of transnational social protection (Boccagni 2017; Levitt et al. 2017) because they contribute financially to their home countries directly through regular remittances, and indirectly by aiding hometown associations engaged in philanthropic and local development projects such as building schools or other infrastructure (Chen 2021; Orozco and Burgess 2011; Smyth 2017). In 2019, remittances accounted for roughly 5 percent of a country's gross domestic product (GDP), on average, with substantial variation across countries and regions.⁴ Research has also shown that after natural disasters, remittances and other forms of assistance to home countries increase (Bragg et al. 2018; Chen 2021; Mohapatra et al. 2012; Orozco and Garcia-Zanello 2009; Rehman and Kalra 2006; Smyth 2017). Further, countries with higher shares of immigrants benefit more from these remittance flows (Mohapatra et al. 2012). In El Salvador, for example, households that had access to remittances were better able to cope with extreme temperature shocks and less likely to migrate as a result (Ibáñez et al. 2021).

To send this assistance, immigrants in the US may adjust or change their behaviors in ways that increase their vulnerability to detection by immigration authorities and the likelihood of removal. While research exploring these dynamics is limited, survey evidence from Haitian immigrants in the US has found

4. Authors' calculation using World Bank development indicators: remittances received as a percent of GDP.

that many started or increased their remittances following the 2010 earthquake that devastated the country (Orozco and Burgess 2011). As a result, immigrants may make more frequent trips to locations where remittances are sent, increasing their chances of detection during these visits. Some immigrants may draw from their savings to provide such assistance (Orozco and Burgess 2011), but for the most economically vulnerable, working more or finding a job may be the primary way in which they obtain the financial resources to start or increase economic assistance to their home country. These behavioral changes may increase immigrants' vulnerability to removal if they become more publicly visible. This may be especially relevant for undocumented and non-citizen immigrants, who may be working in industries more likely to be targeted by federal workplace raids (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman 2022). For example, engaging in additional work may increase the probability of immigrants being stopped by authorities while traveling to and from job sites, or of being present during an ICE raid. It is possible that after salient home-country natural disasters, immigrants are more willing to put themselves at risk of detection and apprehension to maintain or increase financial assistance to their disaster-affected country. If this is the case, we might see that after salient home-country natural disasters, noncitizens, including undocumented immigrants, work more to send remittances to their home countries, thus increasing their vulnerability to deportation.

DATA

We draw on data from multiple sources to construct a country-by-year panel dataset to carry out our analyses. We collect data on the number of removals per year by country of nationality from the Department of Homeland Security. These data are publicly available in the *Year-*

book of Immigration Statistics, which is published every year and can be downloaded from the Office of Homeland Security Statistics.⁵

We use data on international natural disasters by country and year from the Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT): The International Disaster Database, maintained by the Centre for Research on the Epidemiology of Disasters (CRED). These data are also publicly available and have worldwide coverage. The EM-DAT dataset includes a record of all disasters that meet at least one of the following conditions: produce at least ten deaths; affect one hundred or more people; involve a declaration of emergency; or involve a call for international assistance. The data include both natural and technological disasters and have been widely used to study the social and economic consequences of disasters (Datar et al. 2013; Kahn 2005; Laurito 2022; Toya and Skidmore 2007). We restrict our focus to natural disasters and exclude technological events for two primary reasons. First, natural disasters account for the majority of disasters and are the largest in magnitude. Second, natural disasters are more policy-relevant in the context of climate change, as many of these disasters are predicted to increase in frequency and magnitude (Van Aalst 2006).⁶

Using these data, we calculate the share of people affected or killed by natural disasters by country each year. People affected include those who need medical attention because of physical or emotional injuries, those whose home are damaged or lost, and those who need food or other forms of assistance. People killed include those who lose their lives or are missing and presumed dead.⁷ We create a measure of disaster magnitude by adding the total number of people affected or killed by any natural disaster in a given country and year. We divide this sum by the country's population in the prior year. Similar cumulative measures have been used in prior research (Austin and McKin-

5. We focus on removals, which do not include voluntary departures.

6. Online appendix figure A.1 shows the distribution of natural disasters by type during the sample period. The most common disasters are floods and storms, which account for 64 percent of all disasters during the 2000–2019 period. The online appendix can be found at <https://www.rsfsjournal.org/content/11/4/78/tab-supplemental>.

7. For additional details see the EM-DAT documentation: <https://doc.emdat.be/docs/>.

ney 2016; Laurito 2022). We prefer to use this cumulative measure because, while a few large-scale disasters occurred during our study period (for example, the Indian Ocean tsunami in 2004, the Haiti earthquake in 2010), most countries tended to experience small- to medium-scale disasters that, when added together over a year, affected a large share of the country's population. Because these disasters tended to attract less international attention and aid (Strömberg 2007), they may have motivated out-migration or been more likely to increase the need for immigrants abroad to send remittances. We match the share of people affected or killed by natural disasters lagged one year to the immigrant removals data. We use a one-year lag to allow time for immigrants to respond to these home-country shocks.

We supplement these data with a series of control variables capturing home-country characteristics as well as features of the immigrant population in the US. We gathered yearly data on the TPS of each country from the US Department of Justice. We obtained each country's unemployment rate using World Bank development indicators, and each country's disaster vulnerability and readiness index from the University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative. These indexes are composed of a series of indicators that reflect a country's ability to take disaster adaptation and coping actions (readiness) and the probability that a country will be negatively affected by disasters (vulnerability) (University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative 2023). Readiness includes three dimensions: political, economic, and social. Vulnerability also includes three dimensions:

exposure, sensitivity, and adaptive capacity (University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative 2023).⁸ We use the version of the indexes that adjusts for country GDP given its influence on vulnerability and readiness, though results are not sensitive to this choice.

We rely on the American Community Survey (ACS) Public Use Microdata (Ruggles et al. 2023), which we aggregate to calculate the number of immigrants aged eighteen to sixty-five in the US from each country that are male, have a high school degree or less, are noncitizens, and are likely undocumented.⁹ We also use the ACS to identify likely undocumented immigrants from each country who are recent arrivals, which we define as having been in the US for less than three years. We use these data to estimate the number of noncitizens and likely undocumented immigrants in the labor force and employed, and to calculate their average number of weekly hours worked. We impute missing data using linear interpolation for the country unemployment rate and the variables constructed using the individual-level ACS, as not all countries are represented every year in these data.

We also collect information on immigrant remittances for each country to use in supplemental analyses. We gathered data from the World Bank on two variables: personal remittances as a percent of a country's GDP and personal transfers from nonresident household members in US dollars (logged).¹⁰ While these data are not restricted to remittances and transfers from the US, they should still convey whether patterns of financial assistance respond to salient home-country natural disasters.

8. More details on these indexes and their component indicators can be found in the full technical report (University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative 2023).

9. We follow the approach used by George J. Borjas and Hugh Cassidy (2019) to determine likely undocumented status. Foreign-born respondents with none of the aforementioned traits were considered undocumented: arrived in the US before 1980; are a US citizen; receive Social Security benefits or Supplemental Security Income; are a veteran or currently in the Armed Forces; work in the government sector; were born in Cuba; work in an occupation that requires licensing (such as physicians, registered nurses, lawyers); or have a spouse that is a legal immigrant or citizen.

10. Personal remittances include both personal transfers from nonresident household members and compensation of employees working in a country where they do not reside, as well as compensation of resident employees who work for nonresident employers. For additional details, see World Bank development indicators documentation: <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/BX.TRF.PWKR.DT.GD.ZS>.

EMPIRICAL STRATEGY

We employ a difference-in-differences approach leveraging exogenous variation in the timing and magnitude of international natural disasters to estimate their impact on total removals. We assume that only salient natural disasters will produce a response through the mechanisms previously discussed and outlined in figure 1. Thus, following prior research (Laurito 2022), we consider a country to have experienced salient natural disasters (to be treated) if, over the course of the prior year, natural disasters affected or killed more than 1 percent of the home country population.¹¹ We use this cutoff for theoretical and practical reasons. Theoretically, disasters covered by this threshold are large enough to be meaningful for a country. According to World Bank data, in 2019—the last year of our sample—average population growth around the world was 1.06 percent.¹² Thus, for roughly 40 percent of the countries in our sample, our chosen cutoff is equivalent to more than a year of population growth.¹³ Practically, this threshold results in a similar number of observations for treated and untreated groups. We experiment with higher cutoffs to check the sensitivity of our results to the choice of disaster magnitude threshold and use a lower cutoff to confirm that only disasters

deemed cumulatively salient produce a response.¹⁴

As is customary in difference-in-differences designs, once a country is exposed to salient natural disasters, it remains treated for the remainder of the study period. Specifically, we compare the change in immigrant removals before and after a country was first exposed to salient natural disasters with the change in removals of immigrants from countries that never experienced disasters of that magnitude. Provided that treated and untreated units follow parallel trends prior to the disaster, the difference in this change should yield an unbiased estimate of the effect of salient natural disasters on removals.¹⁵ This baseline specification takes the following form:

$$(1) \log(TotRemoved)_{it} = \alpha_i + \beta Disaster_{it-1} + X'_i\theta + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it},$$

where the outcome consists of the logged total number of removals of immigrants from country i in year t .¹⁶ Our key independent variable, *Disaster*, equals one starting when a country first experienced natural disasters that cumulatively affected or killed more than 1 percent of the population, and remains one for the rest of the sample period. The *Disaster* indicator is

11. This roughly equates to the share of people affected or killed being in the 85th percentile of the overall distribution. Note that in subsequent analyses, we estimated the sensitivity of our results to this threshold by re-estimating our analyses using 5 percent and 10 percent threshold.

12. Authors' calculation using World Bank development indicators: Population growth (annual %): <https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SP.POP.GROW>.

13. Average population growth in our sample from 2000 to 2019 is 1.31 percent. About 40 percent of countries in our sample had negative population growth or population growth ranging from 0 to 1 percent.

14. Note that our measure is at the country level and does not account for regional variations within countries in the probability of natural disasters or migration flows into the US. If immigrants in the US come from regions that were not affected by natural disasters, they may be less likely to respond to these events through the hypothesized mechanisms. This source of measurement error should bias our estimates toward zero.

15. Some countries are likely to experience other salient natural disasters after this first exposure. To address concerns that our treatment definition may not fully capture multiple exposures, we conduct a supplemental analysis evaluating their impact on removals and review the results later in the article.

16. We do not transform the removal variable before logging to preserve zeros. We do so because there are very few observations with zero removals in a given year (thirty observations) and dropping these observations as a result of the log transformation should not alter our conclusions. That said, we conducted additional analyses to check this assumption. Specifically, we added a value of one to the removal counts before logging them. As expected, our results do not change. These tables are available from the authors.

always zero for countries that never experienced salient natural disasters. This variable is lagged one year to permit time for immigrants to respond. The model also includes a vector of baseline country characteristics (X_i), which includes TPS designation, readiness and vulnerability scores, home-country unemployment, the logged number of male immigrants in the US aged eighteen to sixty-five, and the logged number of immigrants in the US aged eighteen to sixty-five with a high school degree or lower.¹⁷ We also include year fixed effects (δ) and country fixed effects (α). Year fixed effects should account for factors that affected all countries in a given year, while country fixed effects account for time-invariant, country-specific factors such as their proximity to the US. Our coefficient of interest is β , which captures the effect of salient home-country natural disasters on total removals and, again, it should be an unbiased estimate under the parallel trends assumption.

Indeed, an important underlying assumption of our empirical approach is that, prior to the occurrence of salient natural disasters, removals of immigrants from affected countries did not differ systematically from those of countries never exposed to such disasters. A violation of this parallel trends assumption would suggest that factors other than salient home-country natural disasters are driving the observed differences in removal patterns between treated and untreated countries. To test the plausibility of this assumption, we estimate event studies of the following form:

$$(2) \log(TotRemoved)_{it} = \alpha_i + \sum_{k=-10}^{k=10} \beta_k Disaster_{it-1} + X_i' \theta + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{it}.$$

Equation (2) includes a series of dummy variables that capture the number of years before and after a country first experienced salient natural disasters. If immigrant removals are affected by these shocks, we should see an in-

crease in removals following the salient natural disasters and no change before. Observing that removals were increasing in the pre-period would suggest that factors other than home-country natural disasters are driving our results. The rest of the equation is as before.

We estimate all regressions using the estimator developed by Brantly Callaway and Pedro Sant'Anna (2021) instead of using a traditional two-way fixed effects model and present aggregated average treatment effect on the treated (ATT) estimates for the pre- and post-disaster periods in all tables. As a growing body of research has shown, two-way fixed effects models can bias the estimated coefficient in the presence of differential treatment timing as they use both good and bad comparisons, with bad comparisons consisting of units that have already been treated and no longer serve as good counterfactuals (Callaway and Sant'Anna 2021; Goodman-Bacon 2021; Roth et al. 2023; Sun and Abraham 2021). In the present empirical set up, this estimator is preferable as it allows us to account for potential bias owing to the fact that countries were exposed to salient natural disasters at different points in time. Further, the Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator also relies on baseline covariates for estimation. This is important as many relevant control variables in our model are likely affected by salient natural disasters and would not be appropriate to include as controls in a traditional two-way fixed effects regression. We restrict our analyses to a window of ten years before and after salient natural disasters to allow time for a delayed response while ensuring that more distal time periods, which are more likely to be affected by factors unrelated to natural disasters, are not driving our results.¹⁸ We dropped thirty-eight countries that experienced salient natural disasters in 2000 and thus were considered treated for the full period. The Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator relies on a balanced panel for estimation in which, for each treatment cohort, only observations with balanced pairs be-

17. Results are robust to removing the age restriction for these last two variables.

18. We test the sensitivity of our results to this choice and find that our results are robust when restricting our time frame to five, six, seven, eight, and nine years before and after salient natural disasters.

tween each pre-period year and the post-period years are used for identification.

To explore the possible mechanisms that might explain changes in removals after salient natural disasters, we estimate equations (1) and (2) for the following outcomes: logged likely undocumented immigrants present in the US for less than three years; logged noncitizen and likely undocumented immigrants in the labor force; logged noncitizen and likely undocumented immigrants who are employed; and noncitizen and likely undocumented immigrants' average weekly hours worked. These analyses will shed light on whether changes in removals following salient natural disasters are driven by increases in irregular migration or increased vulnerability to detection as immigrants engage in additional or new employment.

RESULTS

We begin by descriptively documenting the geographic distribution of immigrant removals as well as natural disaster exposure across the countries in our sample in figure 2. As seen in panel A, immigrants from across the globe are subject to removal from the US, but countries across the Americas are overrepresented among those deported during our study period. This is particularly true for Mexico, Brazil, Canada, Venezuela, Bolivia, Peru, Ecuador, and Colombia; countries in Central America such as Guatemala, El Salvador, and Honduras; and countries in the Caribbean. India and China also include substantial numbers of removals, while most European and African countries have the lowest numbers.

In panel B, we see that while countries around the world experienced natural disasters that affected at least 1 percent of the country's population over the sample period, countries in South America, the Caribbean, Central America, Africa, and South and East Asia expe-

rienced the largest disasters. Taken together, this figure shows that there is substantial geographic variation in both removals and cumulative disaster magnitude.

Table 1 provides descriptive statistics for our sample of countries at baseline. Overall, only 6 percent of countries had TPS in 2000, but that number was higher among countries that experienced salient natural disasters over the study period (9 percent). As expected, countries that have experienced salient natural disasters have lower readiness and higher vulnerability scores. We also see that there are more male immigrants aged eighteen to sixty-five in the US from disaster-affected countries than from non-affected countries, as well as more immigrants with a high school degree or less. A look at the regional distribution shows that 30 percent of countries in our sample are in Europe and Central Asia, 25 percent are in Africa, 18 percent in Latin America and the Caribbean, and 13 percent are in East Asia. This distribution changes when we focus on countries that have experienced salient natural disasters. Countries in Latin America, the Caribbean, and Africa are overrepresented among this group, while countries in Europe and Central Asia are more than half of the countries that did not experience these salient shocks.

EFFECT OF HOME-COUNTRY NATURAL DISASTERS ON IMMIGRANT REMOVALS

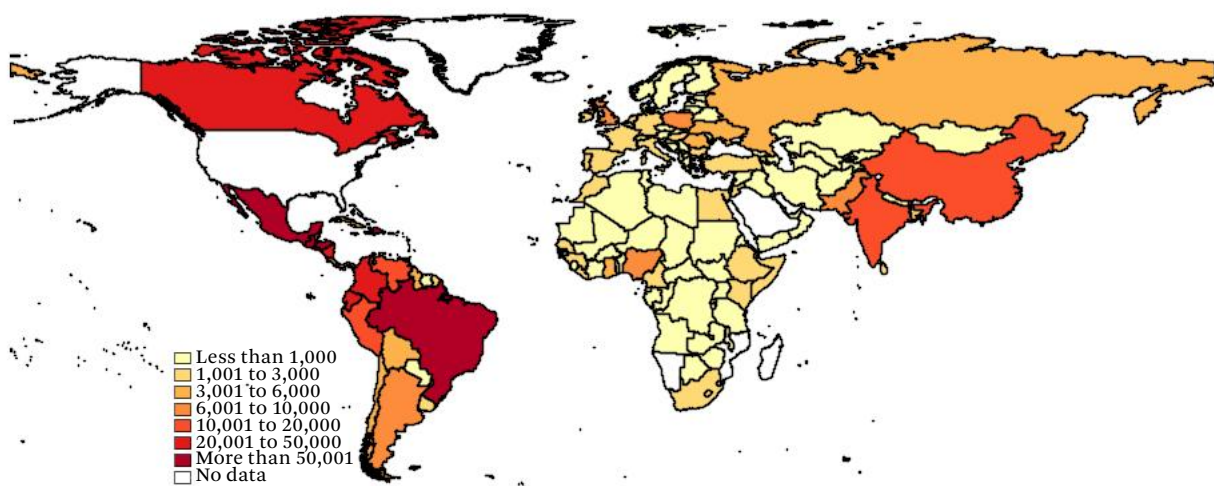
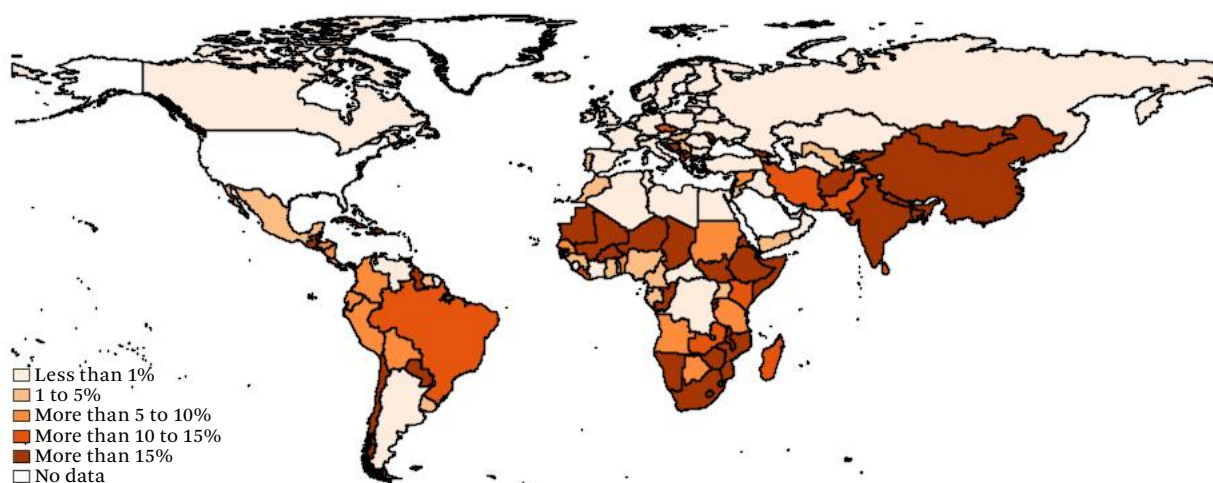
Table 2 presents results from our difference-in-differences analyses examining the impact of salient home-country natural disasters on immigrant removals. On average, salient home-country natural disasters increase immigrant removals by 29 percent in the years following their occurrence (column 1).¹⁹ This estimate is similar in models that include home country and US immigrant population baseline controls (column 2).²⁰ This increase marks a clear

19. Because the outcome is logged, we exponentiate all coefficients to interpret their magnitude as a percent change, as follows: $100 \times (e^{\beta} - 1)$.

20. Because some countries have missing data for the controls, the sample size in column 2 is reduced. Additional analyses show that any differences in the point estimates between columns 1 and 2 are not caused by compositional changes in the sample resulting from adding controls. Analyses are available from the authors.

Figure 2. Total Immigrant Removals and Maximum Natural Disaster Magnitude by Country

Panel A. Total Removals, 2000–2019

Panel B. Maximum Natural Disaster Magnitude, 2000–2019
(Percent of Population Affected or Killed)

Source: Authors' compilation based on *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics* (US Department of Homeland Security, n.d.) and Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT): The International Disaster Database (<https://doc.emdat.be/docs/>).

Note: Total removals reflect the sum of all removals from 2000 to 2019. Disaster magnitude captures the percent of the country's population that was affected or killed by natural disasters. The map reflects the maximum magnitude experienced by a country from 2000 to 2019.

departure from the removal patterns witnessed prior to the occurrence of salient natural disasters, as seen in the pre-period estimates reported in this table.

Event study results shown in figure 3 confirm these findings. Specifically, we see a clear increase in removals shortly following salient

home-country natural disasters. These estimates range from 31 to 47 percent. Importantly, we do not observe statistically significant changes in the period before salient natural disasters, suggesting that our results are not merely continuations of prior trends driven by unobserved or unaccounted-for factors.²¹

21. We estimate the pre-period coefficients using the long difference from base period $T - 1$, which is the best approximation of the standard event study regression and is most appropriate for visual inspection of pre-trends (Callaway and Sant'Anna 2021).

Table 1. Mean Sample Characteristics at Baseline

	All	Salient Natural Disasters	No Salient Natural Disasters
Panel A. Country and immigrant characteristics			
TPS	0.06 (0.24)	0.08 (0.27)	0.02 (0.16)
Country readiness score	0.01 (0.08)	-0.01 (0.06)	0.04 (0.12)
Country vulnerability score	-0.02 (0.08)	0.00 (0.07)	-0.06 (0.07)
Country unemployment rate	8.52 (5.88)	8.10 (5.84)	9.45 (5.92)
Male immigrants 18–65 years old in US	88,795.20 (392,388.00)	111,906.80 (471,668.70)	38,626.05 (57,815.56)
Immigrants with high school or less in US 18–65 years old	112,136.90 (619,651.70)	147,284.60 (746,510.10)	35,840.68 (59,769.48)
Panel B. Country region			
East Asia and Pacific	0.12 (0.33)	0.16 (0.37)	0.05 (0.22)
Europe and Central Asia	0.32 (0.47)	0.17 (0.38)	0.63 (0.49)
Latin America and Caribbean	0.21 (0.41)	0.27 (0.45)	0.07 (0.26)
Middle East and North Africa	0.08 (0.27)	0.04 (0.21)	0.15 (0.36)
North America	0.01 (0.09)	0.00 (0.00)	0.02 (0.16)
South Asia	0.05 (0.21)	0.07 (0.25)	0.00 (0.00)
Sub-Saharan Africa	0.22 (0.42)	0.29 (0.46)	0.07 (0.26)
Observations	130	89	41

Source: Authors' compilation based on the *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics* (US Department of Homeland Security, n.d.), Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT): The International Disaster Database (<https://doc.emdat.be/docs/>), ACS (Ruggles et al. 2023), World Bank development indicators (<https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators>), and the University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative 2023.

Note: Sample is restricted to countries with non-missing removals and non-missing data at baseline (year 2000). Disaster readiness and vulnerability are GDP adjusted; unadjusted values range from 35 to 44 for readiness and from 39 to 49 for vulnerability. Countries with salient natural disasters are those that experienced natural disasters that cumulatively affected or killed more than 1 percent of the population in the prior year. Standard deviations are shown in parentheses.

Table 2. Effect of Home-Country Natural Disasters on Immigrant Removals

DV: Log (total removals)	(1)	(2)
Panel A. Main results: 1 percent threshold		
Pre-disaster	-0.034 (0.085)	-0.003 (0.135)
Post-disaster	0.258** (0.084)	0.255* (0.123)
Observations	2,135	1,793
Panel B. Robustness check: 5 percent threshold		
Pre-disaster	0.093 (0.091)	0.179 (0.102)
Post-disaster	0.214* (0.091)	0.263* (0.116)
Observations	2,567	2,110
Panel C. Robustness check: 10 percent threshold		
Pre-disaster	0.022 (0.103)	0.023 (0.118)
Post-disaster	0.236* (0.098)	0.271* (0.129)
Observations	2,727	2,271
Country and immigrant demographic controls	No	Yes
Country fixed effects	Yes	Yes
Year fixed effects	Yes	Yes

Source: Authors' compilation based on the *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics* (US Department of Homeland Security, n.d.), Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT): The International Disaster Database (<https://doc.emdat.be/docs/>), ACS (Ruggles et al. 2023), World Bank development indicators (<https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators>), and the University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative 2023.

Note: Table shows aggregated ATTs obtained with the Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator predicting log total immigrant removals using alternative cutoffs to define salient natural disasters. All models include the following baseline country and immigrant demographic controls: TPS, home country readiness score, home country disaster vulnerability score, US immigrant male population aged 18 to 65 (logged), US immigrant population aged 18 to 65 with a high school degree or less (logged), and the home country unemployment rate. Models also include country and year fixed effects. Always-treated units are omitted from the analyses. Mean number of removals at baseline (year 2000) is 1,441.

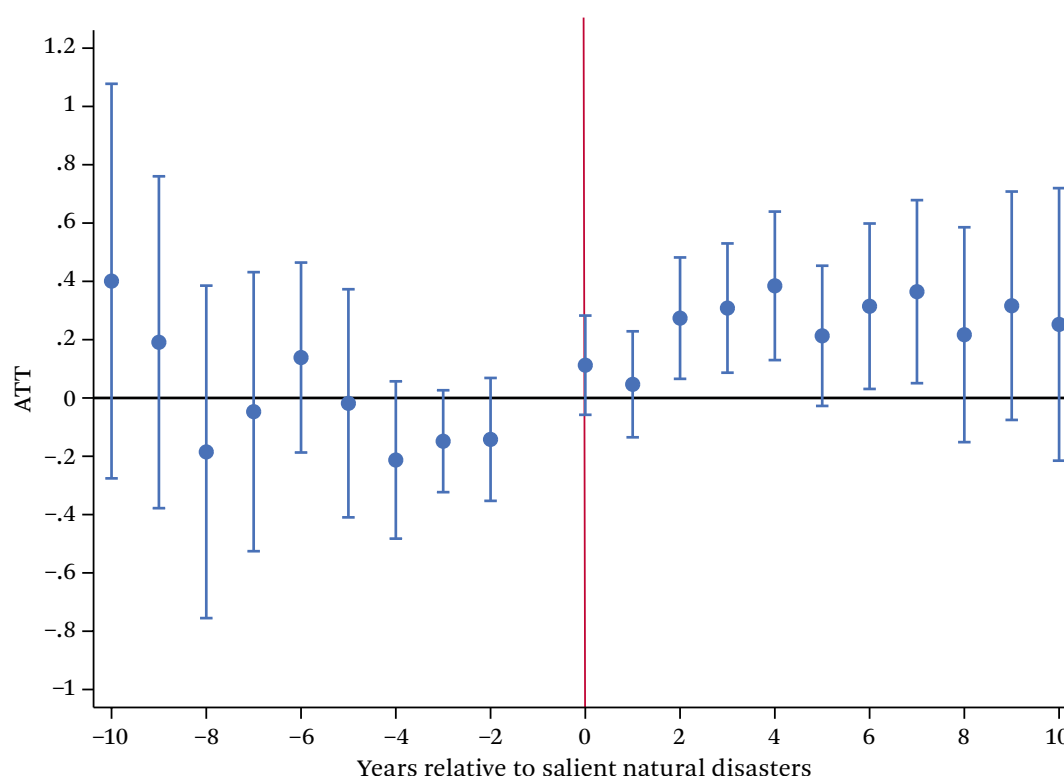
Standard errors in parentheses (clustered by country)

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

We check the sensitivity of our findings to our choice of treatment cutoff by reestimating these models using two alternative cutoffs: natural disasters in which the share of people af-

ected or killed was more than 5 percent and more than 10 percent of the home country population. As seen in panels B and C of table 2, our results are robust to these modifications,

Figure 3. Event Study Estimates Predicting the Effect of Home-Country Natural Disasters on Immigrant Removals



Source: Authors' compilation based on the *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics* (US Department of Homeland Security, n.d.), Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT): The International Disaster Database (<https://doc.emdat.be/docs/>), ACS (Ruggles et al. 2023), World Bank development indicators (<https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators>), and the University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative 2023.

Note: Figure shows results from event studies estimated using the Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator. The model includes baseline controls: TPS, disaster readiness, disaster vulnerability, US male immigrant population aged 18 to 65 (logged), US immigrant population aged 18 to 65 with a high school degree or less (logged), and the country unemployment rate. Models also include country and year fixed effects. Salient natural disasters are defined as those in which more than 1 percent of the population was affected or killed by natural disasters over the prior year. The outcome is total immigrant removals (logged). Always-treated units are omitted from the analyses.

with point estimates showing increases in removals following salient home-country natural disasters ranging from 24 to 31 percent.²²

To further assess the sensitivity of our main results to our choice of estimation strategy, we reestimated our models using the estimator developed by Liyang Sun and Sarah Abraham

(2021) for dynamic difference-in-differences. The results, presented in online appendix table A.2, align with our main findings. After salient home-country natural disasters that affected or killed more than 1 percent of the home country population over the course of the prior year, we see a 20 to 22 percent increase in immigrant

²² We also performed a falsification test using a cutoff lower than 1 percent (75th percentile instead of roughly the 85th represented by our 1 percent cutoff). There should be no change following disasters below this threshold since this threshold includes disasters that are not deemed salient and, therefore, unlikely to produce a change through the hypothesized mechanisms. As seen in online appendix table A.1, we find no evidence that disasters of this magnitude affect removal patterns.

removals, which also constitutes a clear break from prior trends (table A.2, panel A) and in event study estimates plotted in online appendix figure A.2.²³ These results are robust to other disaster magnitude thresholds as well, ranging from 18 to 30 percent (online appendix tables A.2, panels B and C).

A concern with including more distal time periods is that factors other than natural disasters might be more influential and have an outsized impact on removals. To ensure our results are not sensitive to our ten-year time window, we reestimate our preferred model specification while restricting the time frame to five, six, seven, eight, and nine years before and after salient natural disasters.²⁴ Our results, shown in online appendix table A.3, are not affected by these changes. Specifically, salient home-country natural disasters increase immigrant removals between 25 percent (five-year window) to 29 percent (nine-year window).²⁵

The analyses discussed up to this point examine the impact of a country's first exposure to salient natural disasters that, in the course of a year, affected or killed more than 1 percent of a country's population. Our empirical approach does not differentiate countries that experienced subsequent natural disasters above

the 1 percent threshold from those that did not. In our sample, roughly 35 percent of countries were never exposed to disasters at this threshold, about 13 percent were exposed in only one year, and approximately 11 percent were exposed in only two years. This leaves a little over a third of countries in the sample exposed to salient natural disasters for more than two years. To test whether these additional exposures matter, we conducted a supplemental analysis stratifying the sample by whether the first exposure was the only one or not. As seen in online appendix table A.4, we find little evidence that additional exposures have a differential effect. Removals increased by 40 percent in countries exposed to salient natural disasters over only one year and by 28 percent in countries exposed for two or more years. However, a test for equality of coefficients revealed these estimates to be not statistically different from one another.²⁶

EXPLORING MECHANISMS

A secondary objective of this article is to explore plausible mechanisms driving the increases in immigrant removals following salient home-country natural disasters.²⁷ In table 3, we begin by examining whether these disasters increased the number of recent likely un-

23. We also estimated a two-way fixed effects regression using the most parsimonious specification shown in column 1 of table 2. Using time-varying controls in this case would not be appropriate, as many of our control variables are simultaneously affected by salient natural disasters. Results from this specification show an increase in removals of 22 percent, and event studies reveal that there were no prior differences in removals before salient natural disasters (online appendix figure A.3). These results further suggest that our findings are not driven by the choice of estimator.

24. As an additional sensitivity check, we estimated these results without control variables finding that our conclusion remains unchanged. In these regressions, average effects range from 24 percent to 29 percent. Results are available from the authors.

25. Considering that most immigrant removals affect immigrants from Mexico and Central America, we reestimated our regression removing removals from Mexico, Honduras, El Salvador, Guatemala, and Nicaragua from the sample. Our results remain unchanged, suggesting the estimated removal patterns are not driven by these countries. Results are available from the authors.

26. We performed this test following Raymond Paternoster and colleagues (1998), which yielded: $Z = 0.479$ ($p > .10$). These analyses are also robust when using the Sun and Abraham estimator, which yields an increase in removals of 15 percent among the sample exposed to salient natural disasters only once and 20 percent among the sample exposed for two or more years.

27. In a set of supplementary analyses, we estimated the effect of salient home-country natural disasters on immigrant apprehensions. If immigrant apprehensions are a necessary precursor to removal, we should observe an increase in this outcome following these home-country shocks. If we do not see this increase, it could cast

Table 3. Exploring Mechanisms: Migration and Employment

	Recent Likely Undocumented Immigrants (1)	Noncitizen Immigrants		
		Labor Force Participation (2)	Employed (3)	Hours Worked (4)
Pre-disaster	0.092 (0.107)	-0.059 (0.057)	-0.066 (0.062)	0.210 (0.449)
Post-disaster	-0.018 (0.145)	0.183* (0.083)	0.183* (0.086)	-0.938 (0.690)
Mean outcomes (baseline)	25,323.30	69,800.32	63,969.68	39.99
Observations	1,896	1,909	1,909	1,909

Source: Authors' compilation based on the *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics* (US Department of Homeland Security, n.d.), Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT): The International Disaster Database (<https://doc.emdat.be/docs/>), ACS (Ruggles et al. 2023), World Bank development indicators (<https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators>), and the University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative 2023.

Note: Table shows aggregate ATTs using the Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator. All models include the following baseline country and immigrant demographic controls: TPS, home country readiness score, home country disaster vulnerability score, US immigrant male population aged 18 to 65, US (logged), immigrant population aged 18 to 65 with a high school degree or less (logged), and the home country unemployment rate. Models also include country and year fixed effects. Always-treated units are omitted from the analyses. Salient natural disasters are defined as those in which more than 1 percent of the home country population was affected or killed in the prior year. Baseline is the year 2000.

Standard errors in parentheses (clustered by country)

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$

documented immigrants (column 1). We do not find evidence that undocumented migration increases after salient home-country natural disasters.

Yet another channel through which salient natural disasters may increase the number of apprehensions and subsequent removals is if immigrants from disaster-affected countries in the US alter their work behavior so that they can send financial assistance to their home country. If immigrants work more in response to natural disasters, they may be more vulnerable to detection by immigration authorities and subsequent deportation as they become more publicly visible. Columns 2 through 4 explore whether salient home-country natural disasters increase the labor force participation,

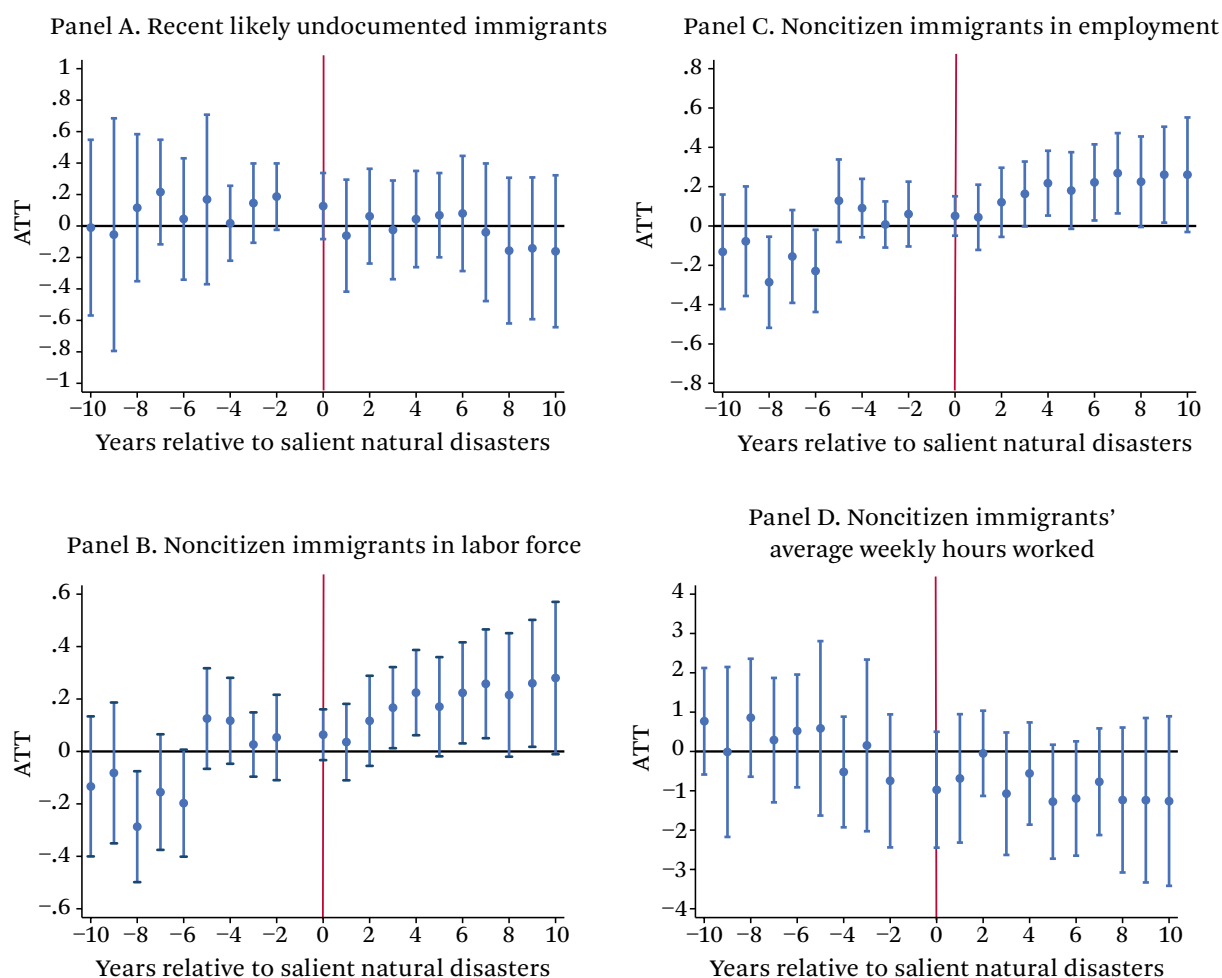
employment, and hours worked of noncitizen immigrants. Overall, we see that noncitizen immigrants increase their labor force participation and employment following salient home-country natural disasters by 20 percent. We find no evidence that salient natural disasters positively affect the average number of hours noncitizens work per week, which could suggest that most immigrants are already working full time.²⁸

As before, we use event studies to inspect whether the estimates reported in table 3 are not attributable to preexisting or otherwise unaccounted for factors. The results presented in figure 4 confirm our findings. Panel A shows no change in recent likely undocumented immigrant arrivals. Although panel D shows no

doubt on whether our proposed mechanisms are driving changes in removal patterns. Our results reveal that apprehensions increased by 40 percent following salient home-country natural disasters (online appendix figure A.4).

28. Based on our analyses of ACS data, noncitizen immigrants work an average of thirty-nine hours per week.

Figure 4. Event Study Estimates Predicting the Effect of Home-Country Natural Disasters on Likely Undocumented Immigrant Arrivals and Noncitizen Labor Market Outcomes



Source: Authors' compilation based on the *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics* (US Department of Homeland security, n.d.), Emergency Events Database (EM-DAT): The International Disaster Database (<https://doc.emdat.be/docs/>), ACS (Ruggles et al. 2023), World Bank development indicators (<https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators>), and the University of Notre Dame Global Adaptation Initiative 2023.

Note: Figure shows results from event studies estimated using the Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator. The model includes baseline controls: TPS, disaster readiness, disaster vulnerability, US male immigrant population aged 18 to 65 (logged), US immigrant population aged 18 to 65 with a high school degree or less (logged), and the country unemployment rate. Models also include country and year fixed effects. Salient natural disasters are defined as those in which more than 1 percent of the population was affected or killed by natural disasters over the prior year. The outcome is total immigrant removals (logged). Always-treated units are omitted from the analyses.

change in noncitizen average weekly hours worked, panels B and C reveal that the increases in labor force participation and employment shown in table 3 emerged shortly after salient natural disasters.

We reach similar conclusions to those presented in columns 2 through 4 of table 3 when we restrict our focus to likely undocumented

immigrants, which we identify following the approach by George J. Borjas and Hugh Cassidy (2019), instead of all noncitizen immigrants. As seen in online appendix table A.5 and online appendix figure A.5, we find that salient home-country natural disasters increase likely undocumented immigrants' labor force participation and employment by 23 and 24 percent, respec-

tively, which represents a break from prior trends. Interestingly, these analyses show a statistically significant decline of approximately 1.4 weekly hours worked. This change is small and represents a 3.6 percent decline relative to the mean.

Altogether, our results indicate that increases in removals following salient natural disasters are not driven by the presence of more deportable immigrants in the US, as the number of recent undocumented immigrants did not increase. Our findings, then, suggest that immigrants already present in the US alter their behaviors in ways that may make them more vulnerable to detection and deportation after these home-country shocks.

One concern with these labor market analyses is the potential influence of unobserved factors in immigrants' US state of residence that could affect labor force participation and employment outcomes. For example, local natural disasters may affect employment patterns—as seen among immigrants working in the reconstruction and recovery process following Hurricane Katrina (Donato et al. 2007; Fussell 2009a, 2009b)—an effect that may be more likely among those working in sectors sensitive to fluctuations in the economy and immigration enforcement (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman 2022; East et al. 2023). To address these concerns, we reestimated our models using individual-level ACS data. We augmented our baseline specification by including state-by-year fixed effects, which capture state-specific time shocks, and industry-by-year fixed effects, which adjust for industry-specific time shocks. This last set of fixed effects is important given that immigrants tend to be overrepresented in particular industries and occupations for various systemic reasons (Laurito et al. 2024; Tesfai and Thomas 2020). We also include a richer set

of individual-level variables and migration-year fixed effects.²⁹ The results, presented in online appendix table A.6, largely support our main conclusions. We do not see an increase in the labor force participation of noncitizen immigrants (column 1, panel A), but we observe a 1 percent increase in employment following salient home-country natural disasters (column 2, panel A). While pre-period estimates are negative, they are statistically different from zero, suggesting that employment was declining prior to these home-country shocks. We also observe a small increase in the number of hours worked, which is about 0.6 percent relative to the mean. Taken together, these additional analyses provide evidence that noncitizen immigrants alter their labor market outcomes in response to home-country shocks. In the case of undocumented immigrants (panel B), we do not find statistically significant changes, but all post-disaster estimates are positive.

Lastly, to better understand the rationale behind these increases in labor force participation and employment, we also examine whether remittance flows have similarly increased following salient home-country natural disasters. Within a framework of transnational social protection (Boccagni 2017; Levitt et al. 2017), assistance from remittances may constitute an important element for both disaster recovery as well as preparedness for future disasters. Online appendix table A.7 and online appendix figure A.6 show results from these analyses.³⁰ Aggregate post-treatment estimates show positive but statistically insignificant increases in remittances and personal transfers. Yet in online appendix figure A.5, we observe statistically significant increases in remittances and personal transfers after salient natural disasters and, most importantly, a clear

29. In addition to country fixed effects, we include the following controls: male, number of children, Hispanic, Black, Asian, other race or ethnicity, age in years, an indicator for presence in the US for less than ten years, married, speaks only English, does not speak English or has limited English proficiency, high school or less, some college, migrated before age twelve, as well as baseline controls for home-country readiness, vulnerability, and unemployment. Note that because of its added flexibility for cross-sectional analyses and different fixed effects, we use the Sun and Abraham estimator for these individual-level analyses.

30. In these specifications, we control for country-level characteristics, as well as year and country fixed effects. We exclude controls specific to US immigrant populations because the remittance data are not limited to transfers originating from the US.

break in prior trends. While suggestive, these results provide support for our hypothesized mechanism that immigrants respond to these salient shocks by engaging in behavior that would allow them to start or increase remittances. This behavior may increase immigrants' probability of apprehension and subsequent deportation as they become more publicly visible.

CONCLUSION AND DISCUSSION

This article examines how country of origin contexts shape patterns of immigrant removals during a period of intensified immigration enforcement in the US. We focus our attention on the influence of salient natural disasters, which are expected to increase in frequency and magnitude because of climate change (Van Aalst 2006). Our analysis finds that natural disasters affecting more than 1 percent of the home-country population increase immigrant removals from the US by 29 percent. This result comes from employing a difference-in-differences strategy that exploits exogenous variation in the timing and magnitude of natural disasters across the world. Our findings are robust to alternative disaster magnitude thresholds, difference-in-differences estimators, time windows around these salient shocks, and adjustments for various home-country characteristics and attributes of immigrants living in the US. In terms of magnitude, our results seem plausible, suggesting an increase of 418 additional removals per year based on the baseline mean. This is roughly equivalent to one additional day of removals at baseline.

Our investigation into the channels through which salient home-country natural disasters increase immigrant removals points to behavioral changes among immigrants already residing in the US—rather than increases in irregular migration—as the primary driver of these effects. We found no evidence that these disasters increase the number of recent arrivals of likely undocumented immigrants.

We observe large increases in the labor force participation and employment of non-citizen and likely undocumented immigrants after salient home-country natural disasters. These effects ranged from a 20 percent increase for noncitizen immigrants to roughly

24 percent among likely undocumented immigrants. We also find that remittances and personal transfers increase after salient natural disasters, suggesting that observed changes in labor market outcomes might be the result of immigrants' decisions to start or increase financial assistance to their home countries. The changes we observe in employment outcomes may expose immigrants who are vulnerable to deportation to heightened risk of detection and subsequent removal by immigration authorities. Previous research has highlighted that even minor interactions, such as a routine traffic stop, can initiate deportation proceedings for those lacking legal status or noncitizens who have committed one of the myriad offenses that trigger deportation (Armenta 2017). Although we cannot definitively prove a link between employment and increased encounters with law enforcement, our findings suggest that participation in the labor force may elevate immigrants' visibility and exposure to the extensive immigration enforcement system in the US. Indeed, prior work has shown that likely undocumented immigrants negatively adjust their labor market outcomes in response to heightened immigration enforcement, likely in an attempt to avoid deportation (Amuedo-Dorantes and Antman 2022). When faced with the need to send remittances or assistance to their disaster-affected countries, immigrants—many of whom may be economically vulnerable—may not take these precautions. Further research examining the connection between employment and deportation risk would be a valuable addition to the limited body of existing literature exploring the factors contributing to immigrants' vulnerability to deportation and its interaction with home-country shocks. Additionally, starting or sending more frequent remittances may also increase the vulnerability of immigrants to detection and apprehension if they make more frequent trips to money transfer locations in the US, where they can be detected by immigration enforcement authorities. Again, while we do not have data linking increased remittance activity and immigration enforcement encounters, we believe isolating this mechanism would be a fruitful area for future research further linking immigrants' behav-

iors, home-country shocks, and deportation risks.

Our study is not without its limitations. First, we rely on publicly available, aggregated, country-level data, which means we are unable to explore how local enforcement conditions influence or moderate the effect of home-country natural disasters on removals. It could be the case that less welcoming immigration climates put immigrants at greater risk of detection by immigration authorities following natural disasters. Understanding the interactions between home-country shocks and the local context where immigrants live in the US would be an important area for future research.

Second, our data do not allow us to explore more direct pathways that might explain the observed increases in removals, such as whether immigrants residing in areas with more immigration enforcement activity are more likely to be removed following these home-country shocks. Understanding whether, and to what extent, immigrants are more likely to be detected by law enforcement, to be transferred to federal immigration authorities, and to receive less favorable rulings in immigration court after home-country natural disasters is an important line of future research.

Third, our country-level analysis may mask nuanced responses to local conditions in immigrants' home countries or prevailing conditions in US residential areas. Our lack of information on localities of origin may bias our estimates toward zero, as immigrants may be more likely to respond to natural disasters that affect their hometowns but not alter their behavior otherwise. Further, because our analyses capture national shifts in employment and removals, we are unable to assess how local US conditions affect observed patterns. These conditions could push estimates upward or downward. For example, if local natural disasters increase demand for workers for reconstruction, employment estimates may be driven upward. Conversely, local recessions could drive these estimates downward. In the case of removals, local variation in immigration climate and enforcement could have similar opposing effects.

Fourth, while we did not find evidence that salient home-country natural disasters in-

crease irregular migration to the US, our ability to fully assess this relationship is limited by several factors. Our analyses do not rule out potential heterogeneity in this effect because of a country's proximity or difficulty of migration to the US. Unfortunately, our sample size of countries is not large enough to confidently estimate models stratified by region. In addition, our study combines all natural disasters within a country over a one-year period. To the extent that some types of disasters are more likely to generate out-migration, our analyses may also hide this heterogeneity. Future research should examine how different types of natural disasters affect premigration conditions and influence the likelihood of undocumented migration. Moreover, the ACS data we use to estimate recent migration do not include undocumented arrivals who are detained at the border and turned away. Thus, it is likely that our measure underestimates recent undocumented arrivals, providing an incomplete picture of the effect of natural disasters on this type of out-migration.

Despite these limitations, this article provides compelling evidence that home-country natural disasters constitute important pre- and post-migration contexts that alter deportation patterns in the US. Our findings show that the influence of migrants' home countries persists even after they leave. Immigrants live transnational lives and are key players in transnational networks providing social assistance for disaster recovery and reconstruction, which may explain why home-country conditions influence immigrants' behaviors and, ultimately, their risk of apprehension and removal post-migration.

This article sheds light on the important, yet often overlooked, transnational dimension of disaster vulnerability. Research on disaster vulnerability has shown that immigrants in the US are less likely to prepare for natural disasters, more likely to suffer negative consequences from these events, and less likely to benefit from post-disaster reconstruction and recovery (Méndez et al. 2020; Tierney 2019). Yet, this work has largely ignored how disasters in immigrants' home countries affect their vulnerability and experiences in the US. This article expands our understanding of disaster vulner-

ability by showing that home-country natural disasters can have tangible impacts on the lives of immigrants living in the US. As our results reveal, immigrant lives happen in both the US and in their home countries. Therefore, to fully understand the consequences of the deportation system in the US, we must take into account the local and transnational lives of immigrants and how these dynamics interact with each other.

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ICE at the Door, Tests on the Floor: Student Achievement and Local Immigration Enforcement



CORA BENNETT, VIRGINIA GRAVES, AND BENJAMIN MEADOWS

Federal immigration statutes are enforced by Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE). However, ICE enforcement does not occur in a vacuum; it has a well-documented legacy of spillovers. Understanding the actual behaviors of immigration enforcement is exceedingly difficult owing to opaque or unavailable data. In this article, we are able to match the level of local immigration enforcement in local areas to school-district-level elementary and middle school achievement scores. Specifically, we merge ten years of individual-arrest ICE records from the New Orleans district field office obtained from a Freedom of Information Act request to district-level achievement scores to understand how immigration enforcement affects the human capital of children. We find that overall responses to enforcement as measured by district-level achievement scores are sharp and large, with achievement scores dropping anywhere between 0.27 and 0.52 of a standard deviation.

Keywords: immigration, economics of education, economics of immigration, immigration enforcement

In recent years, the documented effects of immigration enforcement on vulnerable populations have increased tremendously. For example, Secure Communities, a Department of Homeland enforcement program, directly reduced Hispanic citizen participation in Federal safety net programs (Alsan and Yang 2024) and both citizen and noncitizen labor hours (East et al. 2023). Opposing policies that reduce immigration enforcement have been shown to potentially increase an immigrant's willingness to report crime (Jacome 2022). Within the United States, scarce resources must be devoted toward immigration enforcement, and therefore, the efficacy and spillovers of those resources should be justly scrutinized, as documented by Caitlin Patler and Bradford Jones (2025, this issue). The tremendous scale at which enforcement has grown in the past twenty years makes this a highly pertinent question. Yet, most studies that document the actions of immigrants and immigration en-

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forcement either use rough proxies to identify the immigration status of an individual, such as race, or use broad immigration policy changes, such as the county-wide Secure Communities program. While using these broad individual characteristics or changes in immigration policy offers insight into how immigration policies affect individuals, it narrows the precision of research on such a significant topic.

In this study, we use GPS-coded or landmark-location, individual arrest, Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) data. This data focuses on non-border apprehensions, which is a growing segment of ICE activity. With this data, we can gain a better understanding of the effect of ICE enforcement on the achievement scores of US schoolchildren because, rather than assessing the rollout of a policy geared to increase immigration enforcement, we assess the enforcement itself. When an immigration enforcement policy is rolled out, it could differ by its level of enforcement across treated areas, have delays in implementation, or have heterogeneous effects based on the treatment population. By using apprehension data, we are better able to identify the specific treatment that was implemented by these immigration enforcement policies.

We match this ICE arrest data to school-district-level achievement data from the Stanford Education Data Archive (SEDA). This affords us the ability to estimate the effect of local ICE enforcement on student achievement, measured at the school-district level. The arrest data specify the type, location, and date of each ICE arrest, which also affords a level of heterogeneity in analysis. We estimate a difference-in-differences model, following Brantly Callaway and Pedro H. C. Sant'Anna (2021), to compare the Hispanic-White test score gap between school districts with high levels of immigration enforcement activity and those without.

Two key sources of variation allow us to identify the effects. First, our outcome variable captures the difference between Hispanic and White students within a school district. We chose to focus on the Hispanic-White test score gap, as there is extensive literature on the racialized consequences of immigration enforcement (Flores and Schachter 2018; Asad

and Clair 2018). Thus, not only are undocumented Hispanic students going to be affected by the shocks to their community caused by ICE apprehensions at higher rates than their White peers, but additionally, both undocumented and documented students might be directly affected if someone in their family is apprehended. Regardless, as Frank D. Bean and colleagues (2015) examine—legal status is a central axis of inequality for Hispanic Americans, and our study highlights one of these areas.

Our second source of variation is the differing levels of ICE enforcement across school districts. Although this variation may appear endogenous—since school districts with higher proportions of Hispanic families, regardless of immigration status, are likely to have a greater number of enforcement events—we do not believe it affects our outcome variable, which is the difference between Hispanic and White test scores.

The findings indicate that ICE enforcement within a school district significantly impacts Hispanic children's test scores, particularly when enforcement is substantial (right-tail events) and occurs directly in communities. Specifically, such enforcement actions increased the White-Hispanic test score gap by between 0.27 and 0.52 of a standard deviation in math and between 0.28 and 0.52 of a standard deviation in reading language arts.

This analysis also reveals a statistically precise negative effect on student performance on standardized test scores when there is large-scale ICE enforcement. An unintended consequence of immigration enforcement policies in the US is their effect on young, school-age children. Other literature by Benjamin Meadows (2021) points to the fact that these negative effects are not held by immigrants alone—young US citizens are affected as well.

We contribute to the broader literature on the unintended effects of immigration enforcement, and more specifically, the effects on children. In general, children of immigrants are worse off across many dimensions with more intense immigration enforcement. After increases in immigration enforcement, children live in an increased level of poverty (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2018) and can have blunted early

childhood development (Gonzalez and Patler 2021).

Literature has developed around the effects of increased immigration enforcement on young children's educational achievement and attendance. J. Jacob Kirksey and Carolyn Sattin-Bajaj (2021) find that California children's academic performance was hindered by local immigration enforcement. Additionally, Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj (2025, this issue) show that an ICE raid on Load Trail LLC in 2018 not only decreased four-year college enrollment among Hispanic and English-learner students (a common proxy for students lacking documentation) but also increased high school employment in those populations, likely stemming from students choosing to enter the workforce rather than four-year colleges. Laura Bellows (2019) also finds that activation of Secure Communities decreased achievement scores in Hispanic and Black students. Finally, while Thomas Dee and Mark Murphy (2018) document large disenrollments among Hispanic students in the face of Section 287(g) partnerships, Benjamin Meadows and Griffin Edwards (2023) find that most students in Southeastern states remained in the classroom during the brunt of harsh local immigration enforcement laws. The research presented in this article underscores the effects using more detailed data, confirming what was already understood from assessments of large-scale policies.

Biases against certain ethnicities or nationalities can translate into discriminatory practices in hiring, wage setting, and access to public services, contributing to economic inequality. These biases likely also translate to the classroom. For example, René D. Flores and Ariela Schachter (2018) demonstrate that factors such as national origin and social status cues (like occupation, education, and language fluency), as well as other characteristics or police records, influence whether someone is perceived as undocumented. Asad L. Asad and Matthew Clair (2018) expand this with the idea of racialized legal status (RLS), defining it as a seemingly race-neutral legal category that disproportionately affects racial/ethnic minorities. They argue that RLS functions as a social determinant of health, contributing to disparities

through direct effects on individuals who hold the status and indirect spillover effects on their racial/ethnic group members. Cecilia Menjívar (2021) also highlights the extensive research exploring the criminalization and racialization of immigrants through legal frameworks, media portrayals, and enforcement action. This work underscores how legal statuses, enforcement programs such as 287(g), media stereotypes, and local contexts contribute to discrimination, disparate impacts, and negative experiences for various immigrant groups, often along racial and ethnic lines. Thus, if ICE enforcement programs target majority-Hispanic communities, there are multiplicative effects expected, and these ripple out throughout the community, regardless of enforcement purposes.

We also add to the literature that looks specifically at the effects of immigration enforcement actions, not just the enforcement policies. Catalina Amuedo-Dorantes and Francisca M. Antman (2022) find that ICE deportations reduce labor force participation in likely undocumented workers. Conversely, Daniel Corral (2021) finds that sanctuary policies may have an insulating effect on these typically deleterious consequences. At the same time, the interaction of natural disasters and visibility and detection by ICE has been investigated by Agustina Laurito and Ashley N. Muchow (2025, this issue), who show increased labor force participation in the face of home-country natural disasters, leading to greater detection by ICE.

Also, local policing practices and perceptions of legal status further complicate the education of immigrant communities. Joscha Legewie and Jeffrey Fagan (2019) demonstrate that aggressive policing tactics can negatively impact the educational outcomes of minority youth, potentially limiting their future economic opportunities. This is reinforced by Legewie and colleagues (2022), who find that increased police presence around college campuses can reduce the academic performance of undocumented male students. Using student data from the City University of New York, they observe particularly sharp effects in Black and South Asian men who face heightened surveillance, demonstrating significant consequences

of local policing for undocumented individuals. The intersection of legal status and local law enforcement creates significant barriers to human capital development for this population, as our article reinstates.

DATA

To understand the effect of local immigration enforcement upon local student populations, we merge two unique data sets. First, we use ICE apprehension data from the New Orleans field office. Second, we merge this into the SEDA data archive, which includes the universe of student achievement scores.

Enforcement Data

To measure the effects of immigration enforcement on children's human capital accumulation, it is important to focus on ICE's on-the-ground activity. Specifically, we focus here on apprehensions by ICE. Typically, deportations are the most-reported and displayed events from ICE, yet they also represent the last link in a lengthy chain of administrative events (arrests, court dates, transfers to other facilities, final orders, and so on) (Moinester 2024). Alternatively, ICE apprehensions represent the genesis of that administrative cascade of events, and thus may still be highly influential in communities. There are several different types of ICE apprehensions, but in general, one can define an ICE apprehension as the point in time when a person is transferred to ICE custody, whether by jail transfer or in-person arrests. The data for daily ICE enforcement operations come from a Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) request we filed with ICE. These data are the records of every individual apprehended by ICE's Enforcement and Removal Operations (ERO) from 2008 to 2018. Each data point is an arrest at the individual level from the New Orleans field office, which covers Louisiana, Arkansas, Mississippi, Tennessee, and Alabama. Thus, our research and results are pinned to the Southeastern context. Each observation includes the individual's country of origin, apprehension location, arrest method, arrest program, and date. Arrest program typifies the program used to apprehend the individual under ERO, which can be the Criminal Alien Program (CAP), Section 287(g) of the Immigration

and Nationality Act, or a targeted apprehension program that includes the arrest methods Non-Custodial Arrests and Located Arrests. Arrest method is defined as the type of apprehension ICE executes within the aforementioned programs and includes specific indicators such as local, state, or federal arrests under CAP.

In addition to location, we are able to isolate different types of operations undertaken by ICE.

In our data, there are five common arrest methods outlined by ICE: Federal Criminal Alien Program, Local Criminal Alien Program, State Criminal Alien Program, Located Arrests, and Non-Custodial Arrests. For instance, ICE can detain or request to detain undocumented individuals arrested by other agencies for non-immigration offenses (drunk driving, theft, and so on) under CAP. The majority of the arrests in our data are these types of detainees, in which custody is transferred from the specific authority to ICE. Specifically, these are coded as CAP Local (78 percent), CAP State (3 percent), and CAP Federal (7.8 percent). For the remainder of the article, all CAP programs are treated as one.

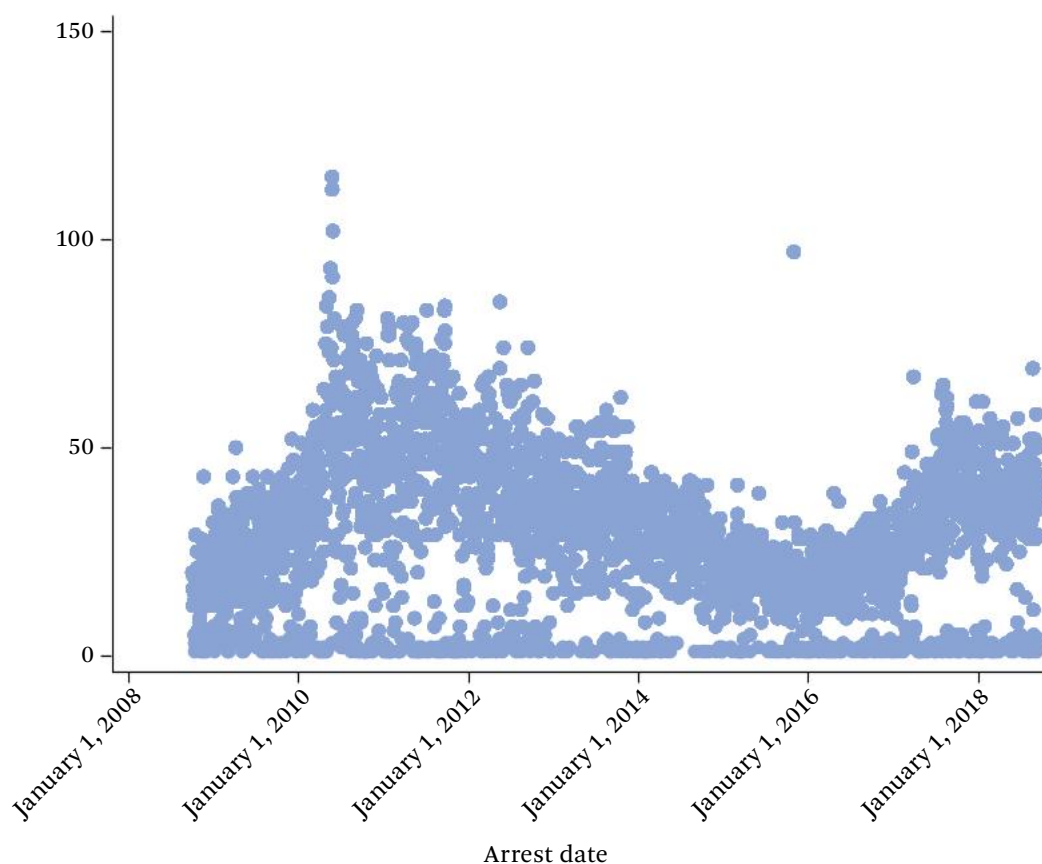
The other arrest types are more direct apprehensions, with Located Arrests (4.6 percent), Non-Custodial Arrests (2 percent), and 287(g) arrests (1 percent). While these types of arrests are smaller in number, they are important to include as they codify the moments when ICE removes an individual from the public specifically for immigration violations. Located Arrests are where an individual is directly located and arrested by ICE. Since Located and Non-Custodial Arrests occur more visibly than jail transfers, it stands to reason that these arrest types could translate into larger community reactions, which may affect the well-being of students. It follows that the estimates of interest in our model rely on Located and Non-Custodial apprehensions rather than the total of ICE activity. Lastly, 287(g) arrests stem from the section of the Immigration and Nationality Act that authorizes local and state enforcement officials to perform immigration enforcement operations (Peacock 2025, this issue). In our data, these arrests typically occur only in the counties or districts that signed agreements with ICE to do so.

Overall, these ICE records obtained through FOIA create a picture of enforcement levels and totals on any given day in this study area. We display the yearly arrest totals for all types of ICE enforcement in figures 2–6. The general shape of ICE enforcement activities in figure 1—with peaks in the early 2010s and again in 2016–2018—matches different executive branch’s administrative priorities.

To merge this data with SEDA achievement outcomes, we leverage the shapefiles for each school district provided by SEDA—placing the GPS coordinates from the ICE data within the school districts. From there, we aggregate the number of arrests within our time period, which corresponds to the academic school year. When we aggregate all arrest types across all years, we see that the majority of the arrests occur in the largest cities—and therefore school districts—within the states: Fayetteville, Arkan-

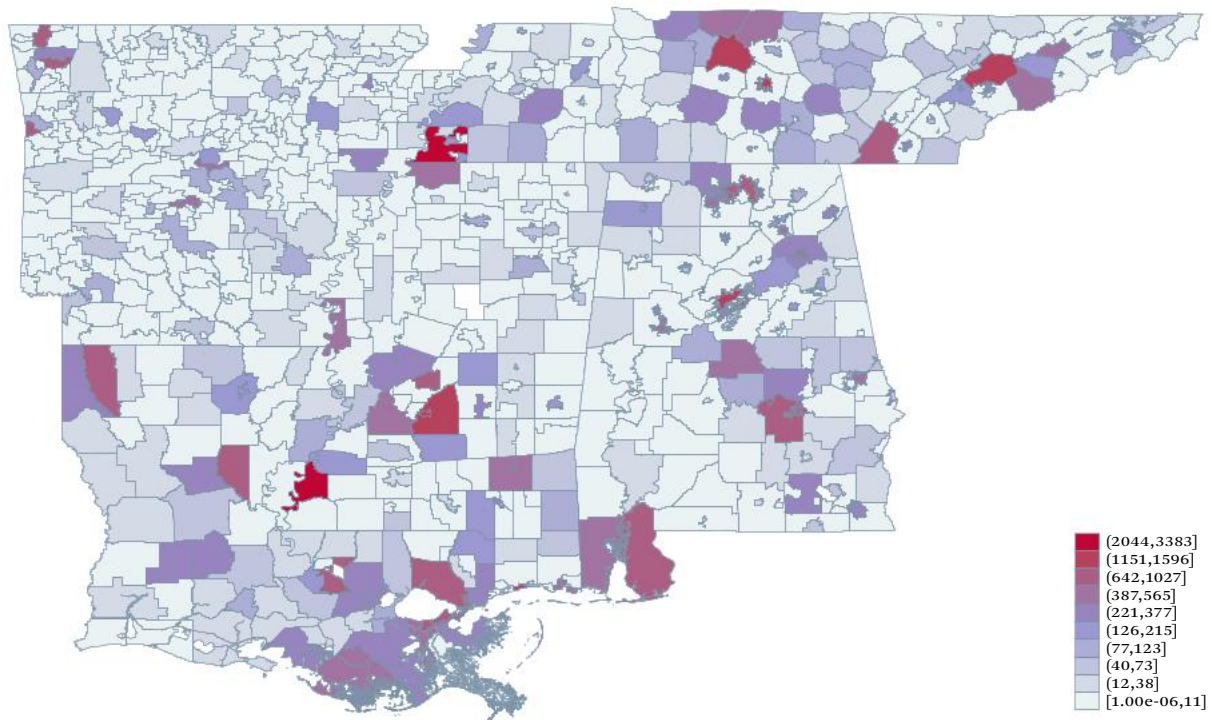
sas; Nashville, and Knoxville, Tennessee; Jackson, Mississippi; Birmingham, Alabama; and New Orleans, Louisiana (figures 2, A.1, and A.2). Additionally, figure 2 shows that port areas, such as New Orleans, Louisiana, and Mobile, Alabama, see increased enforcement numbers. When we aggregate only Located Arrests (arrests where ICE directly arrests an individual), we see a different pattern (figure 5). Further, when we incorporate Non-Custodial Arrests with Located Arrests areas such as Memphis, Tennessee; coastal Louisiana; and northern Alabama all show prominent numbers of these arrest types. As previously mentioned, 287(g) arrests only occur in a few areas due to agreements struck between ICE and local municipalities or counties (Fayetteville, Arkansas; Nashville and Knoxville, Tennessee; and Baton Rouge, Louisiana), as seen in figure 3. Lastly, in figure 4, CAP (jail transfer) arrests are highly

Figure 1. Total ICE Apprehension, by Day

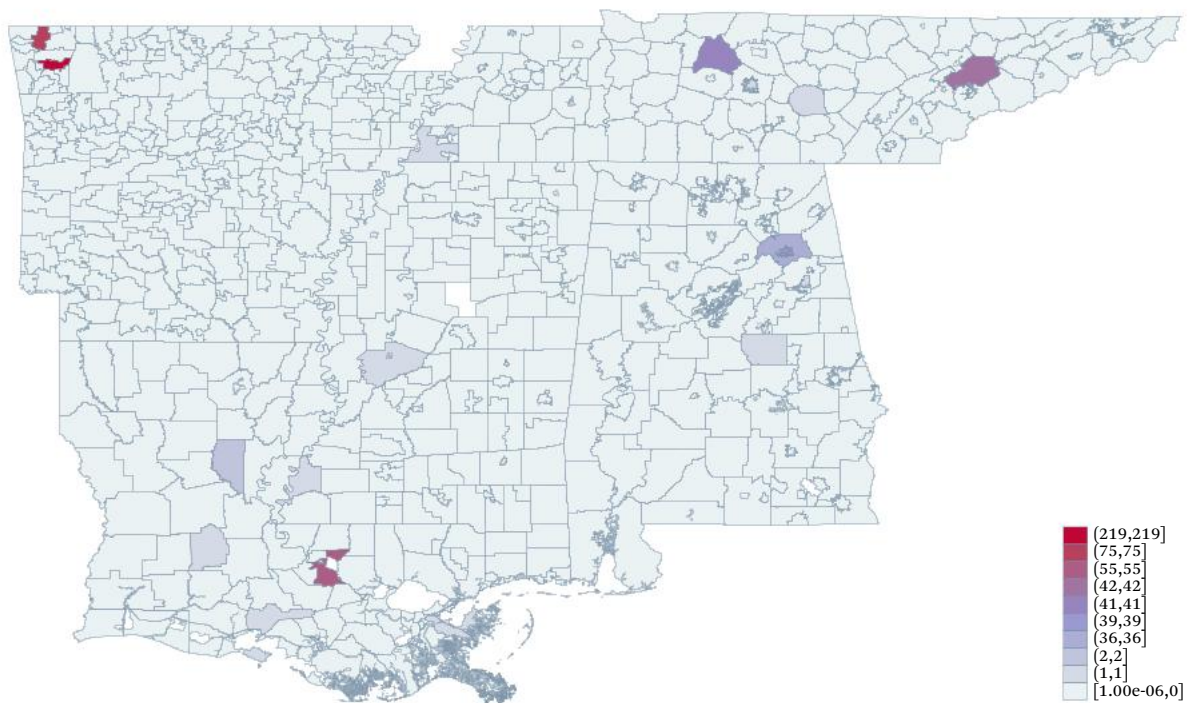


Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Note: The total number of ICE apprehensions across all arrest types is aggregated by day and plotted for the entire panel.

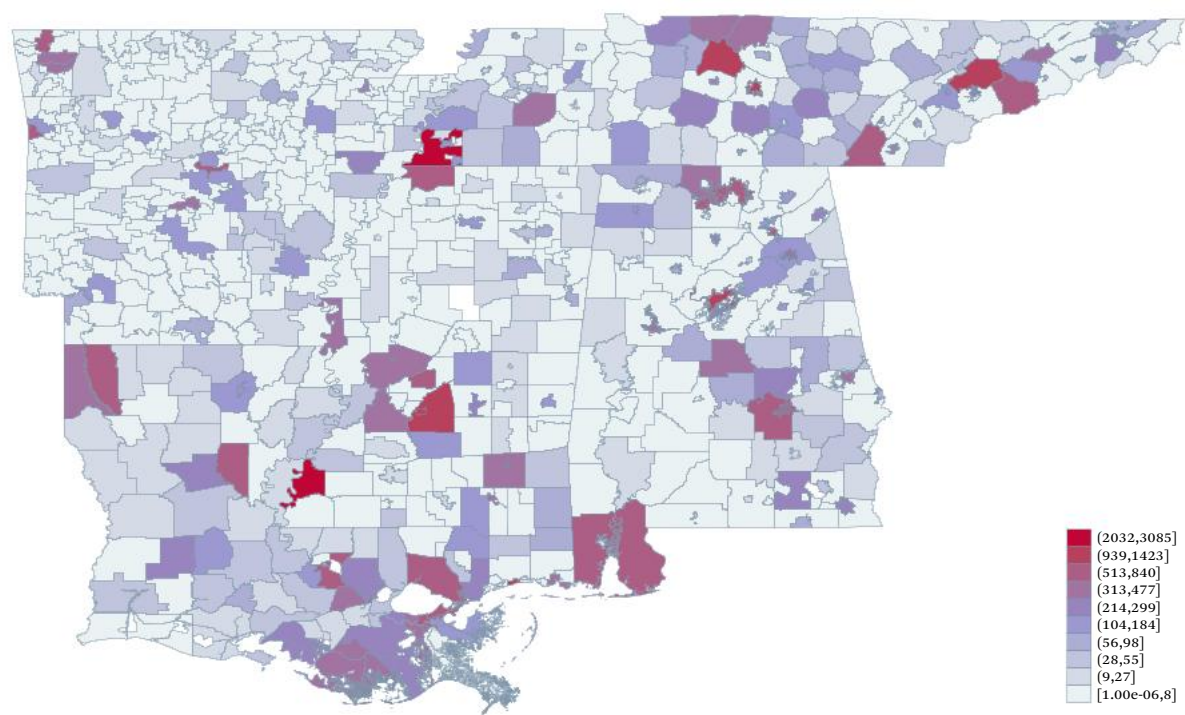
Figure 2. All ICE Arrests, 2008–2018, in Southeastern School Districts

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Figure 3. All Section 287(g) ICE Arrests, 2008–2018, in Southeastern School Districts

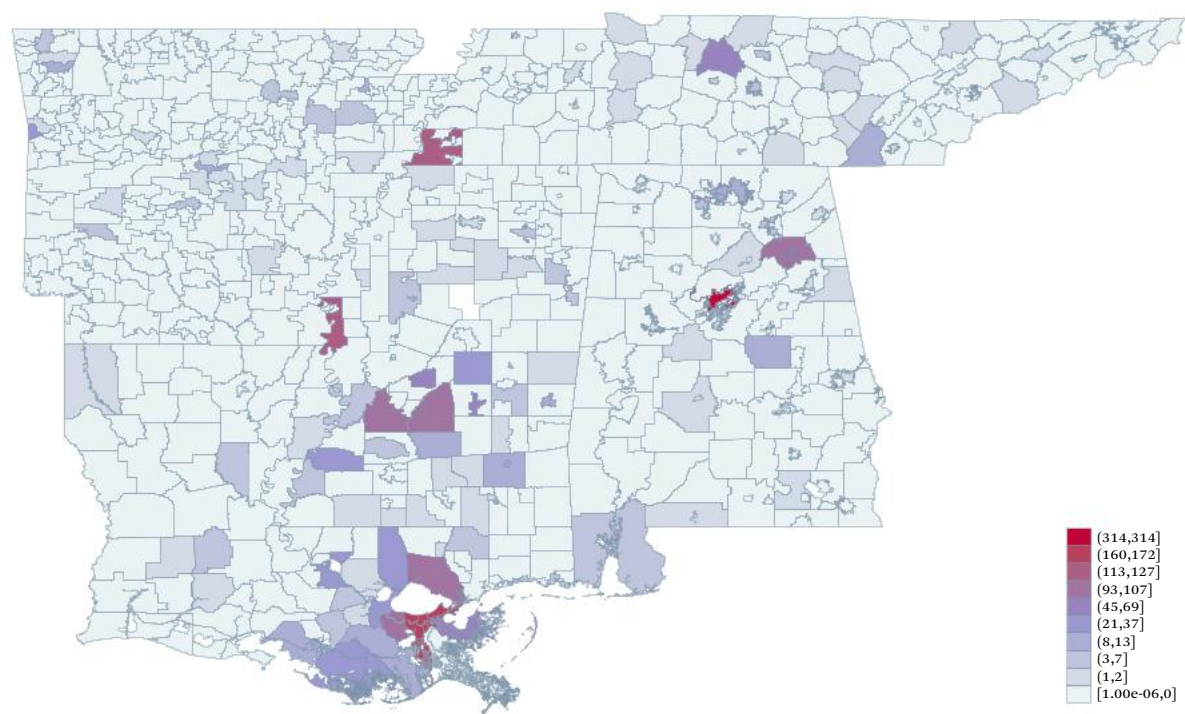
Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Figure 4. All CAP Arrests, 2008–2018, in Southeastern School Districts

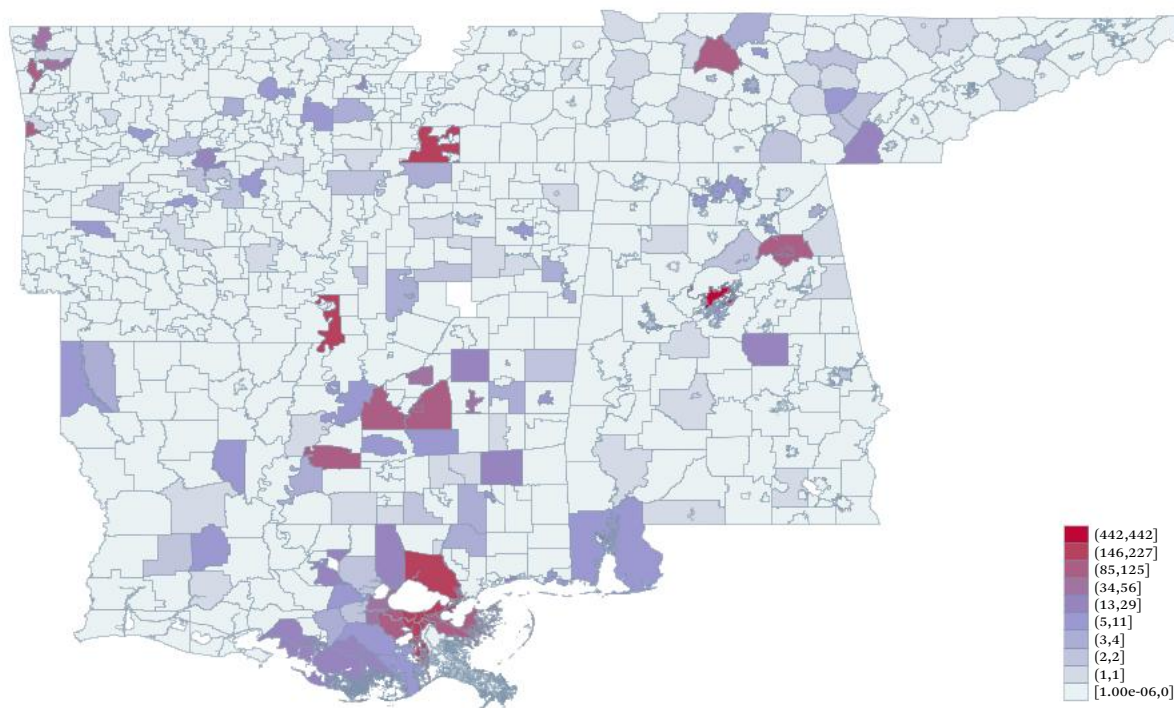


Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Figure 5. All Located ICE Arrests, 2008–2018, in Southeastern School Districts



Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Figure 6. All Located and Non-Custodial ICE Arrests, 2008–2018, in Southeastern School Districts

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

variable across geographies, which partially reflects the holding jails of ICE (Mississippi and Louisiana) as well as the inherent randomness of transferring individuals in and out of custody.

Education Data

To assess student test scores, we use the nationwide standardized test score database from SEDA (Fahle et al. 2021). A large literature has grown from these data in not only education (Bellows 2019; Chin et al. 2020; Reardon et al. 2019; Welsh and Swain 2020; Rossin-Slater et al. 2020) but also economics (Abott et al. 2020; Baum-Snow et al. 2019; Bergman et al. 2019; Park et al. 2021). We specifically use SEDA Version 4.1 with estimates spanning from the 2008–2009 to 2017–2018 academic years. For efficiency, we simplify 2008–2009, for example, to academic year 2009 for the remainder of the article. The SEDA data leverages test score data required by the No Child Left Behind Act, which was then reported to the National Center for Education Statistics. SEDA is a uniquely comprehensive dataset that aggregates approximately 430 million standardized test scores from the 2009 through 2018 academic years. The dataset places state-administered assess-

ments onto a unified national scale, facilitating consistent comparisons of educational opportunity across states, counties, school districts, and individual schools (Fahle et al. 2021). Rather than being sampled, it is population-level, encompassing nearly all US public school students. This allows for a direct, census-like description of student achievement nationwide.

From SEDA, we extract standardized test scores for grades 3 through 8 across all US school districts. The data include subgroup estimates disaggregated by student race, ethnicity, and economic disadvantage status. Our analyses incorporate scores from both mathematics and reading language arts (RLA) assessments. All achievement metrics are standardized and reported in terms of standard deviations relative to the national distribution of student-level test scores.

This makes SEDA data particularly appealing given that it is normalized to a common scale, allowing test scores at each grade, subject, and ethnic group to be compared across county and state lines (Fahle et al. 2021). In addition to average achievement levels, we also incorporate district-level achievement gaps reported by SEDA, where available. These gaps

quantify the difference in academic performance between specified student groups and serve as key indicators of educational inequality. Because our ICE data precede our SEDA data by one year, we limit our analysis to academic years 2009–2018, focusing on grades 3 through 8. Our reported estimates reflect the effect size; or explicitly, a one unit increase in average achievement is as if a school district’s average Hispanic student scored one standard deviation higher than the national grade reference achievement score (Bennett 2020). For context, David E. Frisvold (2015) estimated a positive 0.09 SD increase in test scores following the adoption of universal school lunches, while Eunsik Chang and Maria Padilla-Romo (2023) estimated a 0.11 SD test score drop for students who were exposed to violent crimes near their schools.

ANALYTIC STRATEGY AND RESULTS

To assess the impact of ICE enforcement on schoolchildren, we leverage the depth of the SEDA database to estimate the difference in the achievement gap between White and Hispanic students, across districts that receive high levels of ICE enforcement compared to those that do not (table 1). This affords an extra layer of robustness as compared to a classic difference-in-differences methodology, which might empirically fit where students who receive treatment are differenced out from those who do not before and after the event. Characteristics endogenous to the student population will likely be captured in our within-district estimates, specifically anything affecting all students in the district. This is accounted for not only in the district-level fixed effect but also in

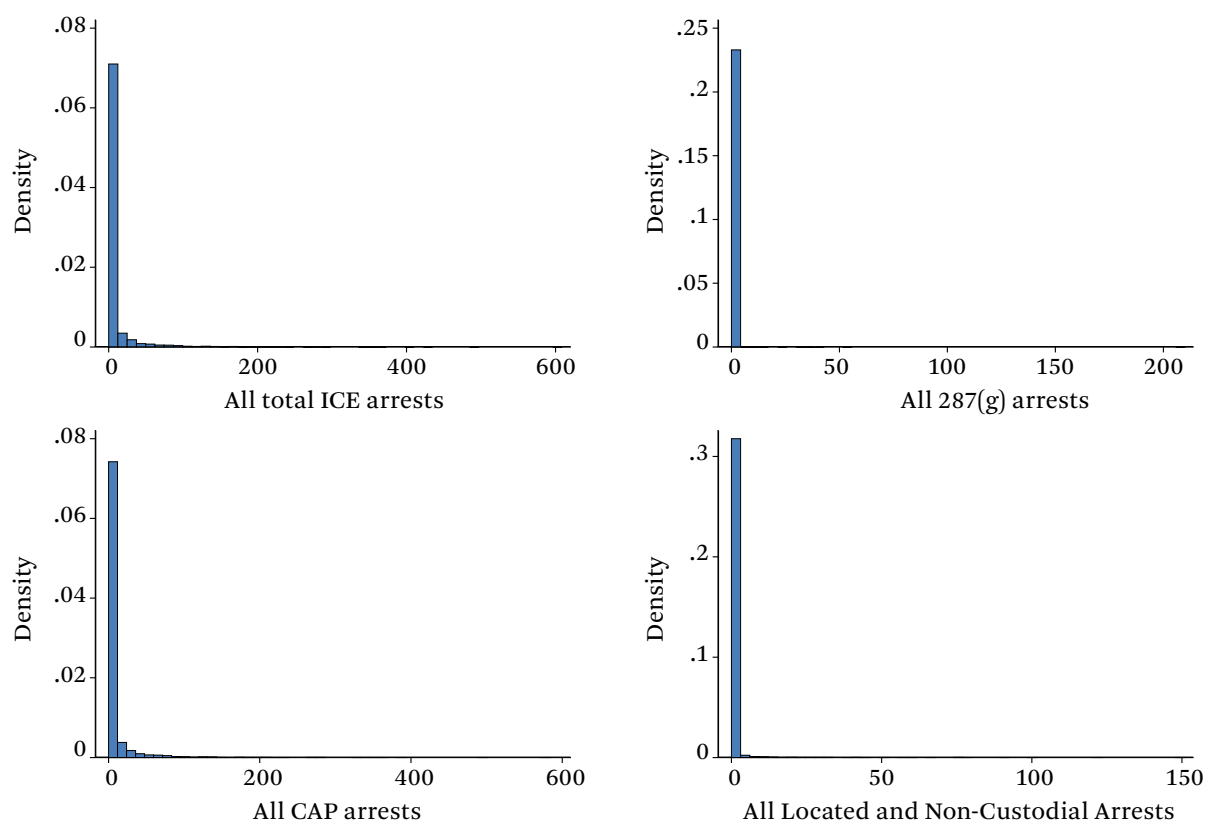
the fact that we estimate the gap between White and Hispanic students in the same district. For example, enforcement is endogenous to the makeup of the local community. ICE enforcement events rarely occur in predominately non-Hispanic school districts. Because our outcome variable captures the differences between white and Hispanic students within a school district, it should control for unobserved heterogeneity between school districts. We choose to look at White students as a control cohort because White students typically are unaffected by ICE enforcement (Meadows 2021; Bellows 2019) making them a good control group. Explicitly, we model a difference-in-differences model per Brantly Callaway and Pedro H. C. Sant’Anna (2021), but also leverage a key feature of the SEDA dataset—the White-Hispanic test score gap. While enforcement is endogenous to the makeup of the local community, as ICE enforcement events rarely occur in predominately White school districts, our outcome variable captures the differences between the target population and others within a school district.

This outcome variable is advantageous, as it allows us to compare the difference in test scores of Hispanic students to White students within the same school district against the difference in test scores of Hispanic and White students in school districts that never receive ICE enforcement after an ICE enforcement event. This pseudo-triple-difference allows us to account for unobserved differences between school districts (including geographic sorting of families), unobserved differences between White and Hispanic students, and any temporal or other cross-boundary events that could confound our analysis.

Table 1. Summary Statistics—Achievement Scores

	Math Achievement Scores			RLA Achievement Scores		
	N	Mean	SD	N	Mean	SD
All students	40470	-.2493579	.3782498	41247	-.1717547	.342783
White	34747	-.0455919	.3399081	35864	.0395518	.3095359
Hispanic	7967	-.3169334	.3130288	7797	-.3163735	.2983609
Black	23200	-.6157642	.3082515	23862	-.522243	.2765474
Female	36281	-.1964859	.3675684	37355	-.0084557	.3460839

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Figure 7. Density of ICE Enforcement Events Within School Districts

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

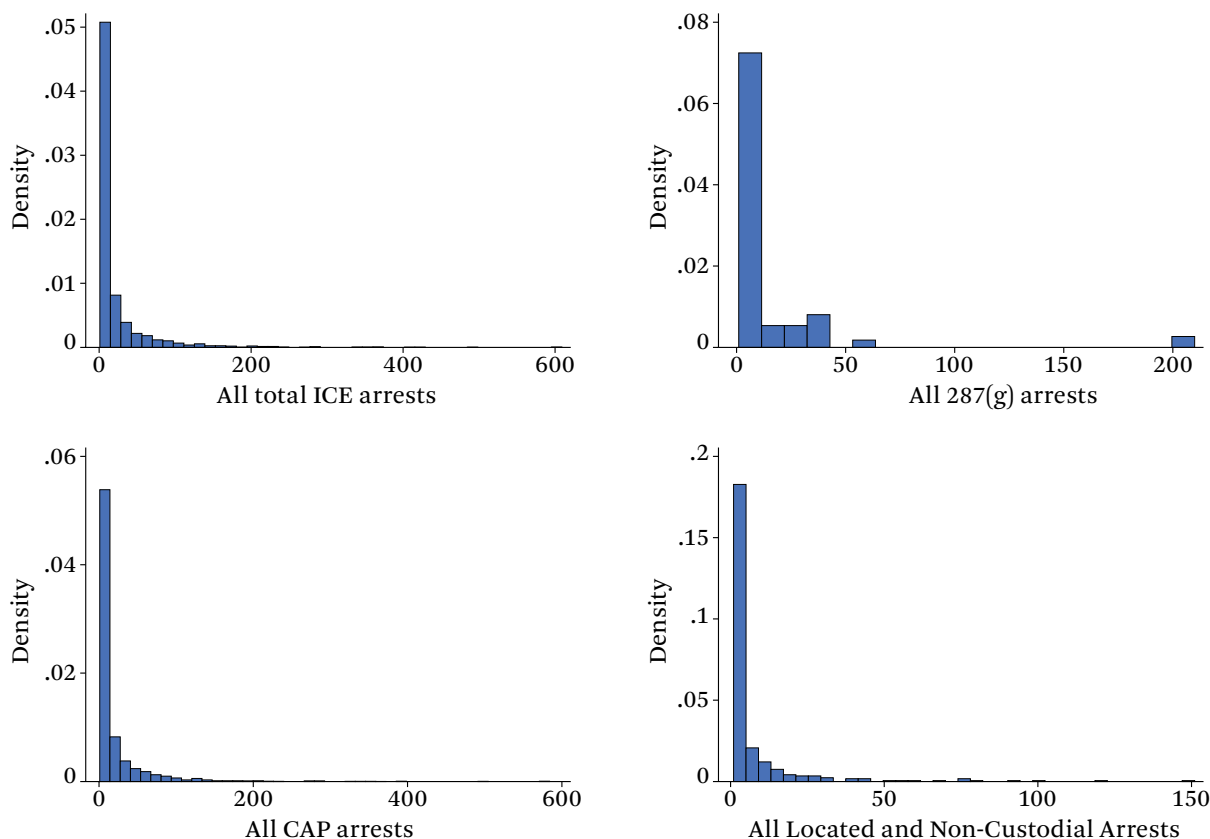
As previously mentioned, ICE enforcement covers most geographies in our dataset, but at minimal levels. For instance, 64 percent of school districts never have an ICE enforcement event within a school year. Figure 7 reveals this gap—the most common ICE enforcement event is none at all. A large portion of events are small scale, with between one and three arrests total across a decade, which might not factor prominently into students’ annual test scores. Instead, high-profile events might affect students the most. To this end, we focus on right-tail events. Figures 7 and 8 show the density of immigration events at the school district level. Depending on the arrest type, the discrete number of arrest events in the right tail might change—meaning, a statistical cut point related to a percentage or standard deviation would lead to an unbalanced treatment

scheme.¹ So for clarity and simplicity, we run multiple, separate regressions, selecting only one type of ICE enforcement at a time and coding the ten arrest events with the highest number of apprehensions as treatment.² School district-year observations within the largest ten arrest events are in our treatment group. All other school district-year observations are in the control group.

Given the staggered timing of the ICE events across our panel, combined with the need to control for unobserved heterogeneity across school districts, we estimate the two-way estimator proposed by Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) to account for the well-established issue of “forbidden” comparisons and negative weighting. Specifically, we use the formulation from Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) that estimates long gaps, using $t-1$ as the base period,

1. Alternatively, we could select cut points based on the shape of the enforcement histograms, but this would lead to differing quantities of treatment dates for each enforcement type, since a histogram cut point would leave us with 287(g) arrests receiving one treatment date and CAP arrests receiving eight.

2. A tabulated list of these events can be found in the appendix tables A.1–A.8.

Figure 8. Density of Non-Zero ICE Enforcement Events Within School Districts

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

likening the estimand—the effect the model aims to measure—to a standard difference-in-differences setup. Explicitly, we estimate a difference-in-difference model using Callaway and Sant’Anna (2021) by

$$(1) \quad Y_{igt} = \eta_i + \eta_t + \beta \times ICE_i \times POST_t,$$

where Y is the respective test score gap between White and Hispanic students (reading or math) in i , the individual school district; g , the grade level; and t , the school year. Fixed effects η_i and η_t , help control for spatial and temporal unobserved heterogeneity. ICE is an indicator variable that represents those school districts that receive one of the top ten ICE enforcement events, and $POST$ indicates the years that follow said event. Whereas there has been a statistical reckoning with difference-in-differences models, we address these concerns in two ways. We use the Callaway and Sant’Anna estimator to estimate a pseudo-triple difference by comparing the gap between White and Hispanic students within the same district to the gap in un-

treated districts. This approach helps explain some confounding, unobserved heterogeneity, as discussed by Andreas Olden and Jarle Møen (2022).

Tables 2 and 3 report the estimates of high ICE enforcement events, as denoted by the ICE variable, on the math and RLA achievement, respectively, differences between Hispanic and White students, relative to the difference of those students who did not have an ICE enforcement event in their school district. All aggregated ICE arrests increase the gap between White and Hispanic test scores by 0.12 and 0.067 of a standard deviation for math and RLA, respectively, although RLA is not precisely estimated. CAP and 287(g) arrests are both imprecisely estimated. Located Arrests widen the gap between White and Hispanic students by 0.105 and 0.10 of a standard deviation in both math and RLA, respectively. Table 4 reports the summary statistics by treatment level.

Given the possibility of multiple treatments (see appendix tables A.1–A.8), we assess the effect of a dosage style treatment by comparing

Table 2. Achievement Gap, Math, White-Hispanic

	All Total ICE Arrests	All CAP Local Arrests	All 287(g) Arrests	All Located Arrests
<i>POST x ICE</i>	0.118* (0.0510)	0.0760 (0.0413)	-0.0126 (0.0451)	0.105** (0.0343)
Observations	26,816	26,673	26,973	27,011

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table 3. Achievement Gap, RLA, White-Hispanic

	All Total ICE Arrests	All CAP Local Arrests	All 287(g) Arrests	All Located Arrests
<i>POST x ICE</i>	0.0668 (0.0395)	0.0514 (0.0317)	0.0620 (0.0325)	0.100* (0.0393)
Observations	26,318	25,867	26,852	26,657

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .00$

Table 4. Demographic and Summary Statistics by Treatment

	ICE Enforcement Area		
	No	Yes	All
RLA scores, White students	0.0390683	0.243052	0.0400834
RLA scores, Hispanic students	-0.3142646	-.4383601	-0.3164618
RLA White-Hispanic gap estimate	0.3413656	0.575192	0.3425821
Math scores, White students	-0.0458852	0.1209481	-0.0450476
Math scores, Hispanic students	-0.31501	-0.4178571	-0.3169729
Math White-Hispanic gap estimate	0.2741023	0.4739589	0.2752574
Poverty rate	0.190836	0.1904757	0.1908344
% Hispanic	0.0504732	0.095711	0.0506789
% economically disadvantaged	0.6601144	0.6294719	0.659972
Unemployment rate	0.0879265	0.0870962	0.0879227

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

districts that received multiple large-scale ICE enforcement events in the panel, as compared to those that did not. Explicitly, we drop the districts that were treated once and compare the estimates from the multiply treated districts to the control (which still remains never treated) and use the same estimation strategy as before. In appendix tables A.5 and A.6, we see that the estimates are more muted and im-

precisely estimated, meaning that the multiply treated districts are not driving our results.

DISCUSSION

In this article, we matched ICE enforcement data (GPS or landmark-location data) to the school district level—specifically, to achievement data—to understand the effect immigration enforcement has on schoolchildren. We

find tightly estimated and strongly negative test score drops among the Located Arrests and Non-Custodial Arrests categories of ICE enforcement. While these precise estimates are informative, they are unsurprising. Given what researchers have established about traumatic events (Shany 2016; Chang and Padilla-Romo 2023), the fact that test scores drop when ICE executes a large-scale operation within the school district might be expected. However, contextualizing how traumatic this event might be is additionally important.

Here, we rely on Matthew A. Kraft's (2020) proposed guidelines and effect size benchmarks to better understand our results. These guidelines help set expectations about the effect sizes and place them into context, given the research design. To develop them, Kraft evaluated almost two thousand effect sizes from 747 randomized controlled trials (RCTs) and proposed new benchmarks for education research: Less than 0.05 is small, between 0.05 and 0.20 is medium, and greater than 0.20 is large. While we do not study a positive education intervention, these benchmarks are appropriate since we use standardized achievement scores as our outcome. We can situate the results presented here, while negative, against these positive benchmarks.

To put our results in context with other similar studies, it is important to analyze the results in light of the features of our specific research design. The magnitude of the effect sizes we present is affected by what outcome we used and when it was measured.

One could describe the annual, district-level achievement scores we used as sticky—or difficult to change—especially in large districts, where treated students might make up a small minority. Given this, the medium-sized effect we estimate on the gap between White and Hispanic students is quite considerable. One might think that documented Hispanic students would respond to immigration enforcement in a milder way than undocumented students. However, our outcome data only identified Hispanic students, which might

have minimized the true effects. In addition, one would expect the effect size to be larger in our situation if we could measure the effects of a standardized test taken immediately in the wake of an immigration enforcement incident, as done in Eunsik Chang and Maria Padilla-Romo's (2023) study. We imagine the salience of any existing trauma could affect student performance much more than in our annual sample.³

In addition, the treatment and control samples selected play a role in the size and interpretation of the result. We used data aggregated at the district level, relying on large numbers of enforcement incidents to identify treatment. Some school districts are large enough to have multiple schools, some of which might not have been affected by an isolated immigration-related apprehension. If areas within a treated observation acted like a control observation, we would expect, again, a larger treatment effect. Being able to aggregate the data at the classroom level or gain access to individual-level data would have better isolated the treatment.

Given all this discussion of effect sizes and Kraft's (2020) updated benchmarks, we consider our results a medium-sized, lower-bound estimate of the potential educational achievement effects of a large-scale immigration enforcement incident. The realized effects could be much greater than our model was able to detect.

We propose two mechanisms that could be causing the increase in the White-Hispanic achievement gap, both of which have a direct effect on children's performance on standardized test scores. First, Located Arrests could be creating pockets of absenteeism among Hispanic students not identified in the aggregate data. Second, these events could be placing undue amounts of stress on children with undocumented family members. Even if students are not missing school, the atmosphere outside the classroom could make learning difficult, impeding success on the standardized tests, as detailed thoroughly in Frank D. Bean and col-

3. The SEDA data is undated within an academic year. Because states administer standardized tests at different points in the year, we cannot precisely align enforcement events with the timing of test administration.

leagues' (2015) work. Both absenteeism and stress could result from an actual Located Arrest, but they could also be the result of the threat of increased enforcement. While the threat of increased activity is nearly impossible to measure, it is likely present in our control districts. If control districts are substantially affected by this threat in the same way as treated districts, the result we find might be moderated.

It is important to note that this article documents learning losses rather than improvements. Therefore, these contextualizations are likely to be conservative in nature. For instance, David E. Frisvold (2015) estimates a positive 0.09 standard deviation increase in test scores following the adoption of universal school lunches. Our estimate of Located Ar-

rest events on Hispanic student test scores is 65 percent of that estimate. Additionally, Eun-sik Chang and Maria Padilla-Romo (2023) estimated a 0.11 standard deviation test score drop for students who were exposed to violent crimes near their schools. Thus, a rough comparison of effect sizes shows an ICE enforcement event is half as detrimental as having a violent crime near the school. So, while our estimates are expected on the policy scale, they are nonetheless consequential by comparison. Research by Benjamin Meadows (2021) shows that undocumented and documented students share the burden of immigration enforcement legislation, suggesting that the human capital losses in this study are likely distributed between citizens and non-citizens alike.

APPENDIX. ICE ENFORCEMENT LEVELS, DISTRICT ACHIEVEMENT, AND EVENT STUDY RESULTS

Table A.1. List of Districts with the Highest Enforcement

	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014–2018	Total
Birmingham City					×	×
Davidson County				×		×
Natchez-Adams School District					×	×
Rankin County School District		×				×
Shelby County	×	×	×	×	×	×

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Table A.2. List of Districts with the Highest Enforcement: CAP Local

	2010	2011	2012	2013	2014	2015	Total
Davidson County					×	×	×
Gulfport School District	×						×
Knox County		×					×
Murfreesboro			×				×
Rankin County School District		×					×
Shelby County		×	×	×	×		×

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Table A.3. List of Districts with the Highest Level of Section 287(g) Enforcement

	2013	2014	2018	Total
Bentonville School District		x	x	xx
Davidson County	x			x x
East Baton Rouge Parish		x x		x x
Etowah County	x	x		x x
Fayetteville School District		x	x	x x
Gadsen City		x	x	x x
Knox County		x		x

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Table A.4. List of Districts with the Highest Level of Located Enforcement

	2009	2010	2011	2012	2014	2016	2017	2018	Total
Birmingham City					x		x	x	x x x
Davidson County		x							x
Etowah County		x							x
Jefferson Parish	x x		x x	x x					x x x x x
Orleans Parish					x				x
Rankin County School District				x					x
Shelby County		x						x	x x

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Table A.5. Achievement Scores for Districts Receiving Multiple Enforcement Events (Math)

	All Total ICE Arrests	All CAP Local Arrests	All 287(g) Arrests	All Located Arrests
<i>POST × ICE</i>	-0.0221 (0.0277)	-0.00752 (0.0294)	-0.0134 (0.0509)	-0.0176 (0.0394)
Observations	21,247	21,478	26,190	20,669

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table A.6. Achievement Scores for Districts Receiving Multiple Enforcement Events (RLA)

	All Total ICE Arrests	All CAP Local Arrest	All 287(g) Arrests	All Located Arrests
<i>POST × ICE</i>	-0.0197 (0.0180)	-0.0447 (0.0288)	0.0780* (0.0385)	-0.00325 (0.0327)
Observations	20,770	21,035	25,867	20,291

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table A.7. White-Hispanic Achievement Gap in Math, Any ICE Enforcement

	All Total ICE Arrests	All CAP Local Arrests	All 287(g) Arrests	All Located Arrests
$POST \times ICE$	0.0185 (0.0210)	0.0197 (0.0208)	0.0608 (0.0317)	0.0426 (0.0241)
Observations	18,568	18,937	26,399	23,910

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

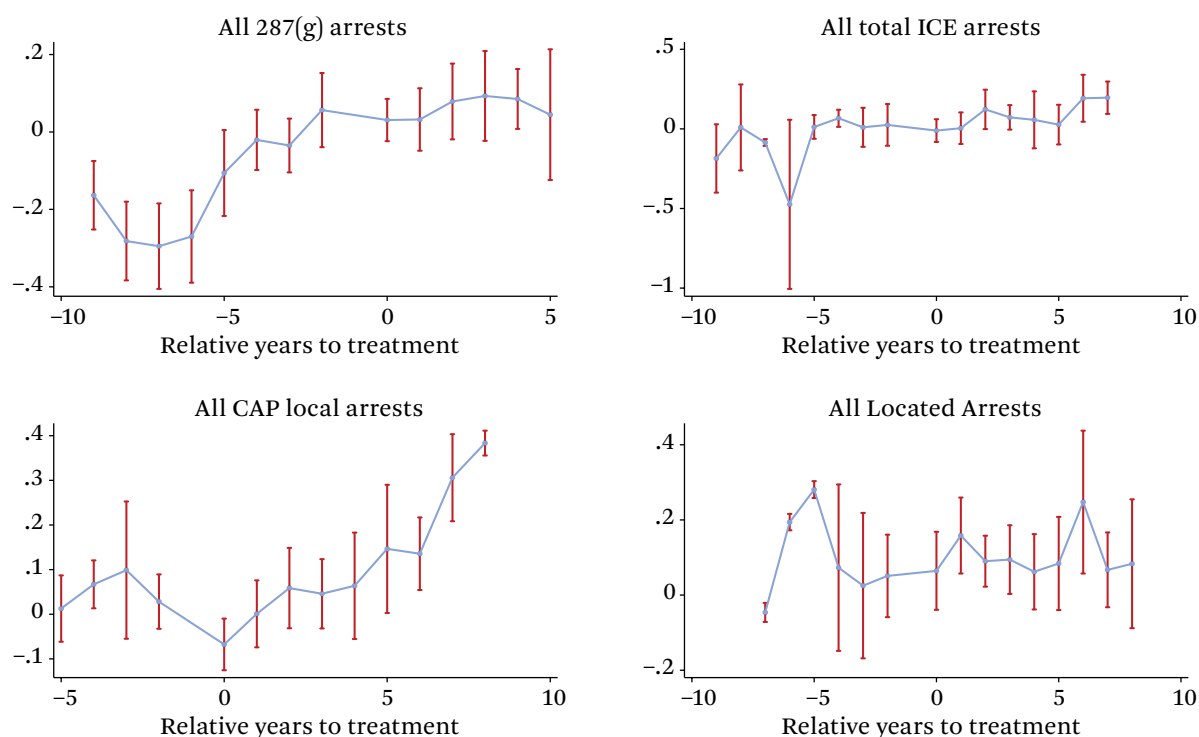
Table A.8. White-Hispanic Achievement Gap in RLA, Any ICE Enforcement

	All Total ICE Arrests	All CAP Local Arrests	All 287(g) Arrests	All Located Arrests
$POST \times ICE$	0.00678 (0.0203)	0.00666 (0.0202)	0.0574 (0.0331)	0.0317 (0.0251)
Observations	17,500	17,703	25,987	23,239

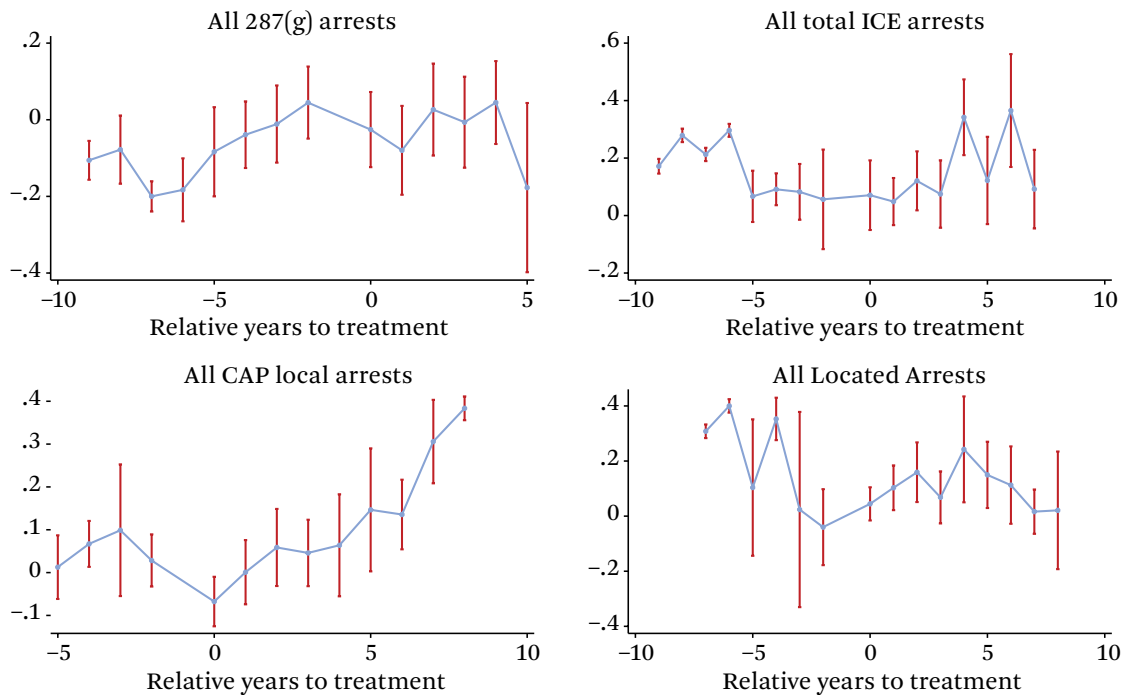
Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Note: Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Figure A.1. Event Study for Each Type of ICE Enforcement, RLA

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

Figure A.2. Event Study for Each Type of ICE Enforcement, Math

Source: Merged ICE x SEDA datafile.

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Future, Interrupted: Examining the Impact of a Large Worksite Enforcement Operation on Students' Educational and Workforce Pathways



J. JACOB KIRKSEY AND CAROLYN SATTIN-BAJAJ

This study investigates the impact of the 2018 immigration raid at Load Trail LLC, a trailer manufacturing company in Sumner, Texas. It analyzes the raid's severe and enduring effects on the postsecondary pathways of students in the surrounding areas. Situated within the broader discourse on legal vulnerability, this research highlights how exposure to immigration enforcement operations and pervasive anti-immigrant sentiments contributes to diminished educational opportunities. Using robust longitudinal data from Texas, the findings indicate pronounced declines in four-year college enrollment and shifts toward employment during high school, particularly among Latinx and English-learner students. These results delineate the extensive collateral consequences of immigration enforcement on community members not directly targeted by the raid. By documenting the raid's deleterious effects on both immediate educational engagement and longer-term career prospects, this article calls for targeted policy measures designed to buffer the negative impacts and support the resilience and upward mobility of affected student populations.

Keywords: immigration enforcement, postsecondary pathways, Latinx students, English learners, Texas, longitudinal data

There is abundant evidence about the large- and long-lasting detrimental effects for children and young adults associated with living in a state of legal vulnerability—whether it be due to their own undocumented status or that of their family members (Amuedo-Dorantes and Lopez 2015, 2017; Brabeck and Xu 2010; Velarde

Pierce et al. 2021). Increasingly, scholars, educators, and policymakers have been interested in the relationship between legal vulnerability and students' academic performance, postsecondary aspirations, enrollment, and persistence, given the strong link between postsecondary credentials and a host of life-course

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Kirksey, J. Jacob, and Carolyn Sattin-Bajaj. 2025. "Future, Interrupted: Examining the Impact of a Large Worksite Enforcement Operation on Students' Educational and Workforce Pathways." *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 123–41. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.06>. Direct correspondence to: J. Jacob Kirksey, at Jacob.Kirksey@ttu.edu, College of Education, Texas Tech University, 3002 18th Street, Lubbock, TX 79409, United States. Carolyn Sattin-Bajaj, at carolynsattin-bajaj@ucsb.edu, Gevirtz Graduate School of Education, University of California, Santa Barbara, CA 93106, United States.

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outcomes (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2023; Amuedo-Dorantes and Lopez 2017; Bellows 2019; Bjorklund 2018; Enriquez 2017; Enriquez et al. 2021; García et al. 2022; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2021, 2023; Kreisberg and Hsin 2021; Patler 2018; Terriquez 2014; Carnevale et al. 2021; Daugherty 2022; Zajacova and Lawrence 2021). This research has largely sought to measure the impacts of undocumented status overall on post-secondary pathways, participation, and outcomes, with specific attention paid to the impact of Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) eligibility on educational decisions. There is much less emphasis on examining the consequences of exposure to immigration enforcement for school-age children, specifically how enforcement activities resulting in individual or mass deportations impact school and other outcomes (Hamilton, Patler, and Langer 2021; Hamilton, Patler, and Savinar 2021; Hsin and Ortega 2018; Kuka et al. 2020).

Interior enforcement and the fear of deportation are salient parts of millions of undocumented immigrants' and their families' lives, only exacerbated by the current administration's aggressive and indiscriminate approach to dealing with all aspects of immigration policy and enforcement (Chishti and Bush-Joseph 2025). Understanding how legal vulnerability in general and the effects of enforcement episodes in particular influence students in the short and long term is thus an issue of ongoing importance (Dreby and Macias 2023). Furthermore, with the latest federal court ruling deeming the DACA program unlawful, no first-time DACA applications are being accepted, and only individuals who were DACA recipients as of July 16, 2021, or whose DACA has lapsed for less than a year can continue to apply for DACA renewals (National Immigration Law Center 2023). Consequently, the college-going calculus for undocumented students has changed. Knowing how students' postsecondary opportunities and pathways may be affected by immigration enforcement therefore represents a critical focal point in a larger research agenda dedicated to studying the consequences of the powerful deportation system shaping the lives of millions of people—US citizens and noncitizen immigrants alike. These indicators pro-

vide a clear, observable set of outcomes that can shed light on the sequelae stemming from immigration enforcement actions and the deportation that frequently ensues (Patler and Jones 2025, this issue).

Large-scale workforce employment operations (LWEO) are one example of a discrete enforcement episode whose effects can be measured empirically. Knowledge of the aftermath of raids and deportation events is critical so that public officials, social institutions, service providers, and society at large can be prepared to respond with appropriate and adequate resources and supports to minimize the damage that these destructive acts of community violence cause for individuals, families, and entire communities (Barajas-Gonzalez et al. 2018, 2021). This includes financial and housing instability, health and social-emotional distress, and immediate- and longer-term educational, professional, and economic consequences (Capps et al. 2007; Chaudry et al. 2010; Collins et al. 2022; Heinrich et al. 2023; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2023; Kirksey et al. 2020; Lopez et al. 2017, 2022).

Despite increased attention to the experiences of undocumented immigrants and their children in recent years, important questions remain about the direct relationship between enforcement activities and students' postsecondary pathways. We focus on educational outcomes because they represent a critical factor influencing individuals' long-term financial, social, and physical well-being (Carnevale et al. 2021; Daugherty 2022; Zajacova and Lawrence 2021; see also Bennett et al. 2025, this issue). Moreover, tracking students' educational pathways in the aftermath of a large-scale raid allows us to capture the spillover effects of such events for people within the community who may themselves not be at risk of deportation; as such, the broad reach of the federal deportation machine can be more fully estimated.

In this article, we leverage data from Texas to examine the impacts of one LWEO, the 2018 immigration raid at Load Trail LLC, on students' educational and career trajectories in nearby school districts. Workplace raids warrant careful scrutiny given their power to influence a large number of individuals' lives while simultaneously transforming entire communi-

ties with a single act. These are shocking events that people may experience as violent traumas that can produce both immediate- and long-term harm for the direct targets, their family members, and the broader areas where they live (Capps et al. 2007; Chaudry et al. 2010; Collins et al. 2022; Heinrich et al. 2023; Lopez 2019; Lopez et al. 2017, 2022; Novak et al. 2017). Empirically, the sudden nature of these events results in an exogenous source of variation to identify causal effects of a specific immigration enforcement action on students' educational trajectories. In this article we answer the following research questions: What is the effect of exposure to a large worksite enforcement operation on enrollment rates at two- and four-year colleges? What are the high school outcomes—such as indicators of college readiness, working during high school, and applications for financial aid—that help explain the effects on postsecondary outcomes? We also ask whether these effects differ based on students' race-ethnicity background or English learner status?

CURRENT STUDY: LARGE-SCALE WORKPLACE ENFORCEMENT OPERATION IN SUMNER, TEXAS

On August 28, 2018, 159 people were arrested on the grounds of Load Trail LLC, a trailer manufacturing plant in the North Texas town of Sumner when over 300 Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) agents entered the facility and held individuals suspected of living and working in the United States without legal authorization (Lundstrom 2018). This raid occurred roughly three weeks into the start of the new school year; it was the sixth and largest workplace raid conducted in the calendar year. Leveraging publicly available data from the Texas Education Agency and the Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board, we examine post-raid high school-to-postsecondary outcomes for students in the four surrounding counties: Fannin, Grayson, Lamar, and Hunt. By disaggregating results to separately analyze the outcomes of students who are more likely to be directly affected by immigration enforcement activity—those classified as Latinx, English learners, or both—and those of their non-Latinx, non-English learner peers, our study

continues in the tradition of work informed by Joanna Dreby's (2012) concept of a pyramid of immigration enforcement effects. This concept attempts to measure the full scope of immigration enforcement consequences for a wider population and to track the heterogeneous impacts of such events across different subgroups (Heinrich et al. 2023; Kirksey 2023; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2021, 2023; Bellows 2019).

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK: HOW ENFORCEMENT EPISODES INTERACT WITH LEGAL VULNERABILITY

Our analysis of the ways that an LWEO affected students' educational engagement, decision-making, and postsecondary pathways is shaped by prior work measuring the extensive and manifold consequences associated with living in a state of legal vulnerability (Brabeck and Xu 2010; Cebulko and Silver 2016; Velarde Pierce et al. 2021). We draw on scholarship elaborating the multiple, distinct dimensions of legal vulnerability and apply this concept to understand aggregate group outcomes after an enforcement event. This is a shift from the extant literature that has focused on examining individual-level outcomes associated with diverse aspects of legal vulnerability but has not explored direct responses to specific enforcement episodes like an LWEO, specifically in terms of the implications of exposure to immigration enforcement activity for postsecondary educational enrollment and workforce participation.

We hypothesize that the interaction between legal vulnerability and an extreme enforcement episode like the Sumner LWEO operates via multiple, mutually reinforcing channels to produce significant impacts on students' postsecondary trajectories. Specifically, we attempt to isolate some of the mechanisms through which students' postsecondary pathways and decisions are affected. This involves exploring changes to college readiness, working during high school, and applications for financial aid. Significantly, the availability of such educational indicators allows us to ground the bellicose deportation system in a concrete manifestation—that is, an LWEO—and link it to tangible, measurable outcomes.

The notion of legal vulnerability has emerged as an analytic tool to better comprehend immigrants' and their family members' experiences and behaviors. In existing work, scholars have conceptualized legal vulnerability as an individual state of being, measuring its impacts at an individual level as well as identifying those dimensions of legal vulnerability that may affect an individual's life, opportunities, and outcomes. This includes examining how another person's legal vulnerability (for example, that of a parent) may affect a separate individual, such as their child (Brabeck and Xu, 2010; Velarde Pierce et al. 2021).

In the present study, we are interested in exploring how legal vulnerability may function as a collective experience manifesting through behaviors and outcomes measurable at a community level, particularly in response to an acute enforcement episode like an LWEO. In other words, we examine how living in communities and attending schools affected by an act of community violence in the form of a workplace raid can be detected in aggregate outcomes—in this case, postsecondary enrollment and workforce participation measured at the county level. (Barajas-Gonzales et al. 2018, 2021; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2023). By considering legal vulnerability as a community-level phenomenon and one that extends to individuals who themselves may not be undocumented or at risk of deportation, we can explore its impacts overall while also being attentive to variation in the intensity of impacts by particular student characteristics such as race-ethnicity, language background, and grade level. Moreover, we focus on the interaction between students' legal vulnerability and one discrete event, an LWEO, to elucidate the forms, scale, and scope of repercussions of this dimension of the deportation machine for students and school communities.

Immigration Enforcement as Acts of Community Violence

Scholars have argued that anti-immigrant rhetoric, policies, and actions, including immigration enforcement, should be considered acts of community violence, and they have shown empirically how exposure to such forces can be detrimental to people's physical health, mental

health, development, and well-being (Barajas-Gonzalez et al. 2018, 2021; Kirksey 2024; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2023). We continue in this line of work by analyzing the consequences of a specific, identifiable act of community violence as evidenced by postsecondary educational indicators and workforce participation data measured at the county level among students most likely to be exposed to an LWEO and its aftermath.

In our conceptualization of legal vulnerability as a collective state shared among members living in the same community, vulnerability may result from multiple forces. First, there may be frequent, active, and extreme immigration enforcement activity that produces ongoing fear, stress, and instability (Watson 2014; Vargas and Pirog 2016; Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2018; Hong et al. 2025, this issue). Relatedly, undocumented people may live in or near the community, which in turn increases the risk of enforcement activity and heightens the direct harm resulting from detentions and deportations via removals, including family separations, sudden financial instability, housing insecurity, and trauma (Chaudry et al. 2010; Lopez et al. 2022). Next, community members may experience the spillover effects of fear and volatility associated with undocumented status and the threat or enactment of immigration enforcement, including what has been called multigenerational punishment (Enriquez 2015). In this study, we use student data from school districts in Fannin, Grayson, Lamar, and Hunt counties precisely because the dramatic increase in the number of deportation orders filed in immigration courts in these counties in the month after the Load Trail raid reflects a high likelihood of legal vulnerability on these three grounds. In other words, we hypothesize that students attending school in these counties would be more likely than otherwise similar students elsewhere in the state to have been exposed to immigration enforcement activity and to know someone directly or indirectly affected by the August 2018 raid.

Even without enforcement activity, living in a restrictive, anti-immigrant environment could be a final source of legal vulnerability operating at a community level and producing tangible restrictions on people. It could affect

the functioning of a community via policies, practices, or climate that limit a sense of freedom, safety, decision-making, and behaviors (Amuedo-Dorantes and Lopez 2015, 2017; Pottochnick et al. 2017; Dee and Murphy 2020). In the present study, we focus exclusively on the first form of legal vulnerability—that is, exposure to immigration enforcement events or episodes—and isolate the particular effects on students' educational choices, behaviors, and outcomes. In what follows, we review the research on how contact with immigration enforcement activity is associated with two main factors that can contribute to students' post-secondary pathways and decision-making: students' academic engagement, performance, and college enrollment, and students' economic precarity and how it influences employment and educational decisions.

Exposure to Immigration Enforcement Activity

Exposure to immigration enforcement activity—be it via an arrest, detention, or deportation of oneself, a loved one, or a member of one's local community—constitutes a form of legal vulnerability that has been shown to affect students' academic performance, engagement, and educational decisions in a number of significant ways. Absenteeism is one of the primary indicators that scholars have tracked following enforcement episodes, finding that student absenteeism rates tend to increase in schools located in areas with more frequent and proximate ICE activity, especially immediately following such events (Kirksey 2024; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2023; Heinrich et al. 2023). Students' English language arts (ELA) and math test scores also suffer when immigration enforcement actions occur, and school enrollment patterns for Latinx students can be sensitive to immigration enforcement (Kirksey 2023; Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2023; Bellows 2019). Research has shown that student mobility increases concomitant with enforcement activity and declines in Head Start and school enrollment among Latinx students are associated with increased ICE arrests (Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2023; Bucheli et al. 2021; Hong et al. 2025, this issue; Santillano et al. 2020). Less is known, however, about how students' (and

families') behaviors and choices related to investing in higher education may be impacted by enforcement events, such as fulfilling college entrance requirements, applying for financial aid, and enrolling in four-year versus two-year colleges.

Immigration enforcement can also produce immediate, extreme, and long-term economic devastation for families. Researchers have documented the extent to which lost income due to detention and deportation of key earners produces dramatic changes in families' financial stability (Capps et al. 2007; Chaudry et al. 2010; Dreby 2012; Lopez et al. 2022). Randolph Capps and colleagues (2016) estimated that families had lost anywhere from 40 to 90 percent of their income within six months of a parent's immigration-related arrest, detention, or deportation. Another analysis using US Census Bureau data showed that household income falls up to 45 percent when a family member is deported (Preston 2020). Finally, William D. Lopez and colleagues (2022) and others found evidence of heightened food, housing, and financial insecurity in the immediate weeks and months following ICE raids, with lasting, irreversible consequences that persisted over time (Capps et al. 2007; Chaudry et al. 2010).

The mental and physical health effects associated with exposure to immigration enforcement episodes have been well documented, with large-scale events like an LWEO producing complex and sustained sequelae for individuals and broader communities. Research tracking the effects of a raid of a meat-processing plant in Postville, Iowa, in 2008 found that infants born to Latina mothers in the thirty-seven-week period after the raid had a nearly 25 percent higher risk of preterm low birth weights compared to the prior year (Novak et al. 2017). Another study showed higher self-reported stress and lower self-rated health scores for Latinx survey respondents living in a Michigan county where a warehouse raid took place (Lopez et al. 2017). Lastly, Carolyn Heinrich and colleagues (2023) found increased diagnoses of depression, substance use disorder, and higher incidence of self-harm, suicide attempts, and sexual abuse among children in Tennessee after a 2018 LWEO in Morristown.

Taken together, studies of the aftermath of immigration enforcement episodes paint a clear picture of severe and often lingering damage wrought by these incidents that strike at the heart of communities. This growing body of evidence elucidates the precise ways that enforcement penetrates school buildings and classrooms, via impacts on student attendance, health and well-being, and performance on exams. Yet, large gaps remain in empirical understandings of how exposure to immigration enforcement activities shapes students' educational trajectories—in particular, their pathways to and through college. Using robust, longitudinal data from Texas students, our analysis focuses on identifying the effects of an LWEO on key postsecondary outcomes, such as direct enrollment and degree completion, while also exploring potential mechanisms underlying these impacts. This work advances knowledge of the ways that young people experience and react to an act of community violence in the form of an LWEO via their postsecondary choices and actions. We draw attention to the enduring consequences that immigration enforcement can produce for students' educational opportunities and outcomes—consequences that may have long-range implications for personal, professional, and financial success at the individual level and for community well-being overall.

METHOD

We analyzed data obtained from the Texas Education Agency, the Texas Higher Education Coordinating Board (THECB), and the Texas Workforce Commission. THECB data are supplemented with postsecondary information from the National Student Clearinghouse to track students who attended college out of state. Our sample includes students in grades nine through twelve during the academic years spanning from 2013–2014 to 2021–2023, allowing for a comparison between five high school cohorts graduating before the LWEO and five cohorts graduating afterward. We aggregate data on students across Texas counties, constituting $N = 2,540$ county-by-year observations.

To pinpoint students potentially impacted by the LWEO, we analyze data from the Trans-

actional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC) at Syracuse University, which tracks immigration enforcement actions across the US (TRAC, n.d.). TRAC data suggests that deportations from the LWEO were concentrated in four North Texas counties: Fannin, Grayson, Lamar, and Hunt. These counties were identified based on a significant increase in deportation filings that occurred in August 2018, as highlighted in table 1. The marked increase in filings during that month was clearly distinct compared to both prior and subsequent periods, indicating a concentrated surge of immigration enforcement activity during the LWEO period. The decision to focus on this region was driven by both the magnitude of enforcement activity and the counties' geographic proximity, as they form a contiguous region where the concentrated impact of the LWEO was most likely to be felt. Our analysis focused on outcomes for all students in the affected counties as well as subsamples of Latinx students and students designated as English learners, as prior research has shown these subgroups tend to experience disproportionate impacts of immigration enforcement.

Constructing a Comparable Control Group

After identifying the sample of students from the affected counties, we sought to construct a control group that would provide a comparison to measure the potential impact of the LWEO on student outcomes. This control group needed to represent what the affected counties might have looked like in the absence of the LWEO, accounting for preexisting trends in student demographics and educational outcomes. To achieve this, we employed an optimization algorithm that allowed us to select a group of non-affected counties, referred to as donor counties in our analysis, using the synthetic control method (SCM), whose characteristics closely mirrored those of the affected counties prior to the LWEO. The SCM employs an optimization algorithm to assign weights to donor counties based on their similarity to the affected counties in terms of key pre-intervention characteristics, such as student demographic composition, economic conditions, and outcomes, including prior trends in postsecondary enrollment, college readiness, and high school

Table 1. New Deportation Proceedings Processed Through Immigration Courts in 2018
(Texas Counties)

	June	July	August	September	October
Counties near Load Trail, LLC					
Fannin	3	1	31	2	1
Grayson	7	12	36	2	4
Lamar	1	1	51	0	1
Hunt	6	3	31	2	6
Other surrounding counties					
Cooke	2	1	2	6	2
Collin	67	80	47	65	77
Rockwall	4	1	6	1	6
Delta	0	0	0	0	0
Hopkins	0	2	0	0	7
Rains	0	0	0	0	0

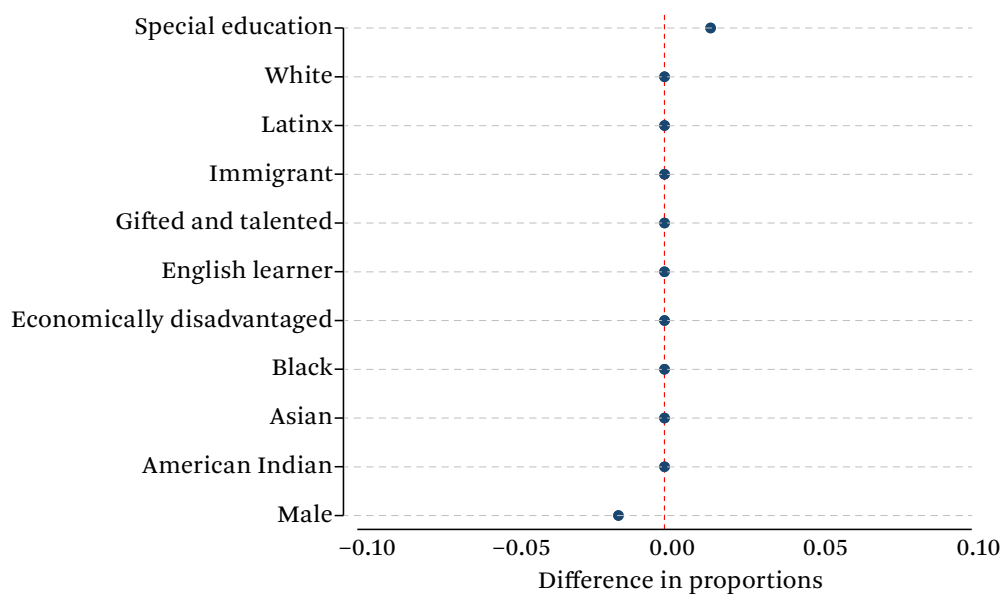
Source: TRAC Immigration, n.d.

employment rates. The algorithm assigned greater weights to counties that exhibited pre-LWEO trends most similar to those of the affected counties, combining them into a synthetic group that closely matches the affected counties on observable characteristics.

Figure 1 presents differences in demographic characteristics of students enrolled in school districts located in counties affected by the LWEO prior to the raid compared to those

in the constructed synthetic control group. All differences in demographic characteristics between the LWEO and donor counties are at or near zero. From the sample of students in the affected counties, we also constructed distinct subsamples for Latinx and English-learner students to examine whether the LWEO had disproportionate impacts on particular populations. Within the overall affected-county sample, 1 percent of students were Asian, 9 per-

Figure 1. Differences Between LWEO Counties and Synthetic Control Group



Source: Authors' calculations.

Note: Points to the right of the center line indicate higher values in LWEO counties.

cent were Black, 22 percent were White Latinx, and 61 percent were White non-Latinx. During the 2018–2019 school year, 78 percent of these students were considered economically disadvantaged, 11 percent participated in a gifted and talented program, 1 percent were identified as immigrant students, 15 percent were current English learners, and 21 percent received special education services.

Key Variables

Our study centers on two sets of outcomes. The first set of outcomes deals with the postsecondary trajectories, specifically analyzing direct enrollment in two-year and four-year colleges. We define direct enrollment as the enrollment of students in a postsecondary institution within one year following their high school graduation. This measure provides insights into the immediate educational progression of students and serves as a gauge for the broader educational aspirations and accessibility of higher education opportunities in the wake of the LWEO.

The second set of outcomes addresses several critical high school indicators that precede and likely influence postsecondary education decisions. These include assessing whether students met the college readiness standards for four-year institutions as defined by the THECB. Additionally, we evaluate completion rates of either the Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) or the Texas Application for State Financial Aid (TAFSA) applications for financial aid to attend college. We also explore the likelihood of students working during their high school years, a factor that can significantly influence academic performance and the ability to engage in extracurricular activities that enhance college applications.

Appendix table A.1 presents the mean differences in outcomes for students in LWEO counties before and after the LWEO in 2019. The four-year college direct enrollment rate increased from 3.24 percent to 4.56 percent. Conversely, four-year college readiness dropped from 4.42 percent pre-LWEO to 3.22 percent post-LWEO. FAFSA and TAFSA application rates decreased from 57.84 percent to 46.06 percent. The proportion of students working during high school showed a minor decline, though this difference was not statistically significant.

Lastly, two-year college direct enrollment experienced a small decrease, but this change was also not statistically significant. While these descriptive results show mixed trends in student outcomes following the LWEO, these findings do not account for broader time trends and confounding factors that might influence these outcomes.

We incorporate a rich set of covariates to account for factors that may influence the outcomes of interest. The covariates included a broad set of demographic information aggregated to the county level, providing a detailed snapshot of the student population within each county. This includes the percentage of students from various racial and ethnic backgrounds, the sex of the students, economic disadvantage status, English learner status, and the percentage of students receiving special education services. These covariates account for a wide range of observable characteristics that could confound estimates in identifying the effects of the LWEO on students' educational trajectories.

Empirical Strategy

In our preferred analysis of the impact of the LWEO on educational outcomes, we adopt the SCM to construct a comparable counterfactual scenario representing what would have transpired had the raid not occurred. This approach is particularly apt for assessing events like the LWEO that affect a relatively small number of observational units—counties, in this case—where a constructed counterfactual can provide insight into what outcomes would have occurred in the absence of the intervention. The SCM technique leverages observed characteristics aggregated across multiple counties over time to create a synthetic control group that closely mirrors the attributes of the four affected counties (Abadie et al. 2010). Through SCM, we generated a synthetic control group for each model employed, incorporating covariates and lagged measures of outcomes in three of the preceding academic years (2013–2014, 2015–2016, and 2017–2018). The construction of the synthetic control uses an optimization algorithm to determine the appropriate weights for potential control units, which consist of other counties not impacted by the LWEO. By

optimizing the selection of these weights, the synthetic control group was designed to closely mirror the pre-intervention characteristics of the LWEO-affected counties. This methodological approach allowed us to create a credible baseline against which we could measure the actual impacts of the LWEO, providing a clear view of the intervention's effects on student educational trajectories. Figure 1 illustrates the similarity between the synthetic control group and the four affected counties, showing negligible differences across observable characteristics. This consistency was observed across all models employed in this study. Our analysis uses SCM models to examine outcomes for all students, as well as subsamples of Latinx and English-learner students, aligning with previous research highlighting variations in the effects of immigration enforcement across different student populations (Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2021, 2023).

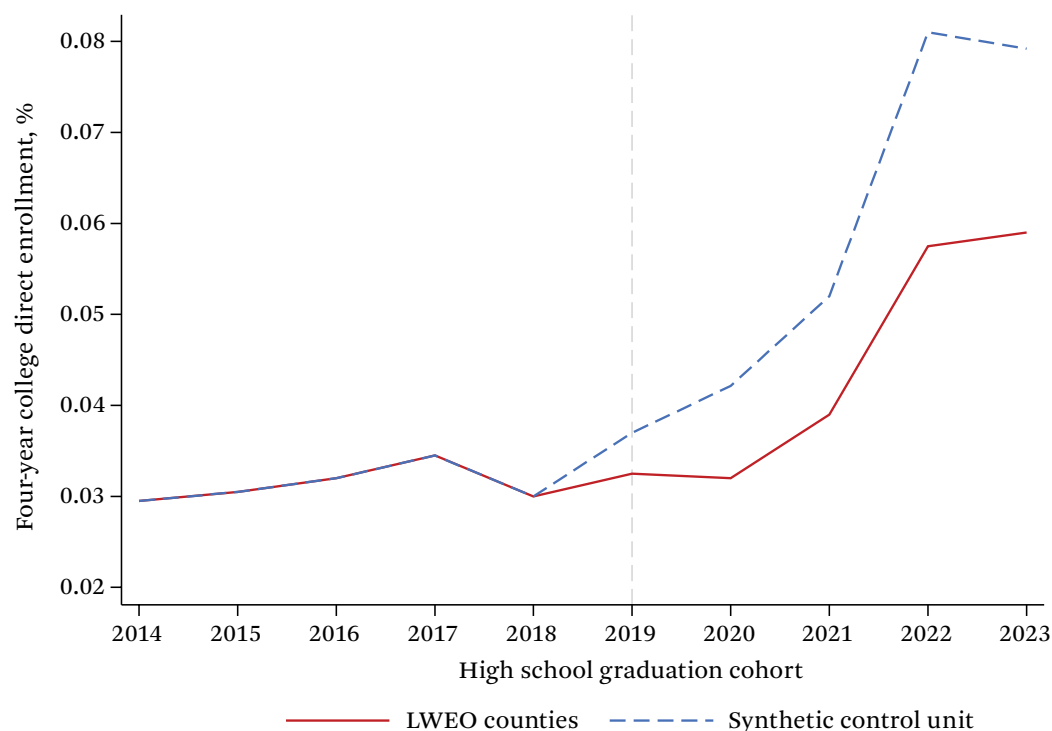
RESULTS

Our main study results are depicted through figures 2 to 6. Each graph contrasts observed trends in student outcomes before and after

the LWEO, represented by solid lines, against those of a synthetic control group, depicted by dashed lines. This control group models the expected outcomes had the LWEO not occurred, serving as a counterfactual to assess the real impact of the enforcement operation. A vertical line within each graph delineates the 2018–2019 school year, the first school year when students would possibly be affected by the LWEO.

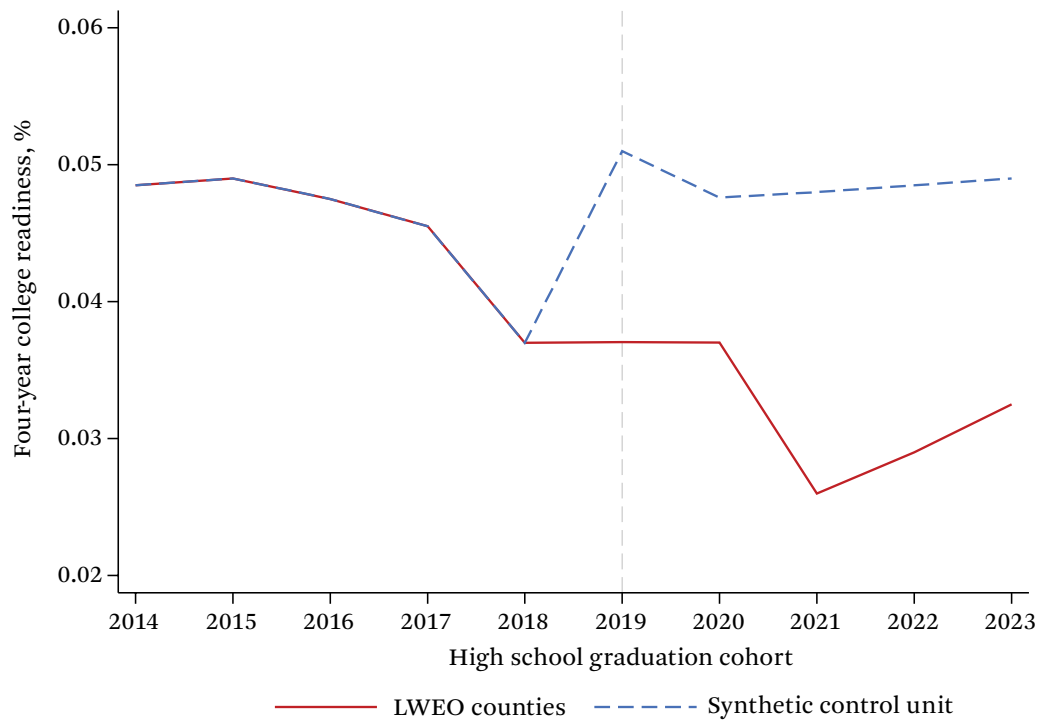
In figure 2, the data reveal a marked decline in the rate of direct enrollment to four-year colleges in the counties affected by the LWEO post-2018. This downturn is sharply contrasted by an upward trend within the synthetic control group, suggesting a disruption in students' college-bound trajectories. While we present clear evidence of the decline in direct enrollment in four-year colleges, our analyses did not yield evidence of a decline in enrollment in two-year colleges. While the overall trends indicate a significant disruption in college enrollment across LWEO-affected counties, the impact is notably more severe among Latinx and English-learner students. These students, already facing various systemic barriers to higher

Figure 2. LWEO Effect on Four-Year College Direct Enrollment Rate



Source: Authors' calculations.

Note: The dashed vertical line indicates the year of the LWEO (2019).

Figure 3. LWEO Effect on Four-Year College Readiness

Source: Authors' calculations.

Note: The dashed vertical line indicates the year of the LWEO (2019).

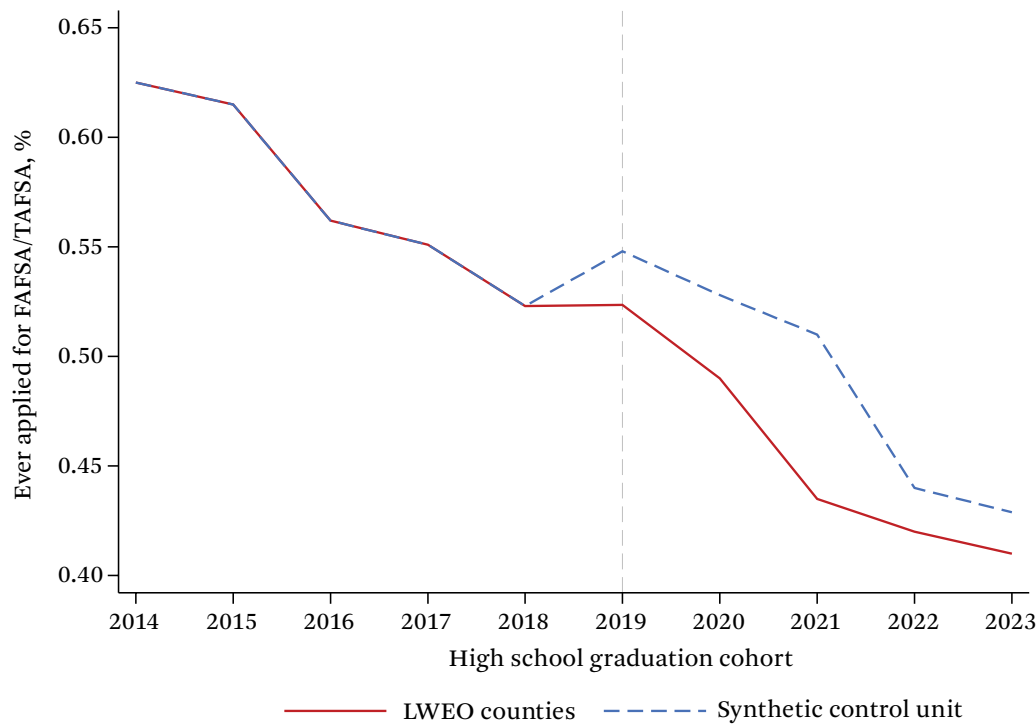
education, appear to have been disproportionately affected by the LWEO with respect to four-year college direct enrollment.

Figure 3 shows a noticeable reduction in college readiness, as measured by a decline in the percentage of students achieving high scores on readiness indicators and completing advanced academic coursework after the LWEO. The affected counties exhibited a sustained decrease, diverging notably from the stable or improving trend observed in the synthetic control group. This could imply that the stress and disruption caused by the LWEO may have diverted student focus away from academic achievements, adversely affecting their preparation for college. The reduction in college readiness, particularly pronounced in the achievement of high school course completion based on readiness indicators, underscores a significant educational setback that was even starker among Latinx and English-learner populations.

Figure 4 illustrates a large decline in applications for financial aid, including FAFSA and TAFSA, starting in 2019. This sharp drop reflects either increased financial uncertainty or decreased intent to pursue higher education

among students in LWEO-affected areas. The decline in financial aid applications could also be indicative of broader economic impacts on families affected by the LWEO, possibly resulting in reduced financial resources and increased economic responsibilities for students. The decline in FAFSA and TAFSA applications is particularly concerning for Latinx and English-learner students, who often come from backgrounds where financial aid is crucial for accessing higher education. The drop in applications from these groups could reflect an amplified sense of vulnerability about revealing their family's immigration status or a fatalistic view toward their educational prospects in a heightened enforcement environment. This reduction highlights a critical barrier to education for Latinx and English-learner students, potentially leading to lower college enrollment and completion rates, thus perpetuating cycles of poverty and limited economic mobility.

Figure 5 shows an increase in the likelihood of students working during high school in the affected counties. This rise contrasts with the steady or declining trend in the synthetic control, suggesting that economic pressures or

Figure 4. LWEO Effect on FAFSA and TAFSA Application Rates

Source: Authors' calculations.

Note: The dashed vertical line indicates the year of the LWEO (2019).

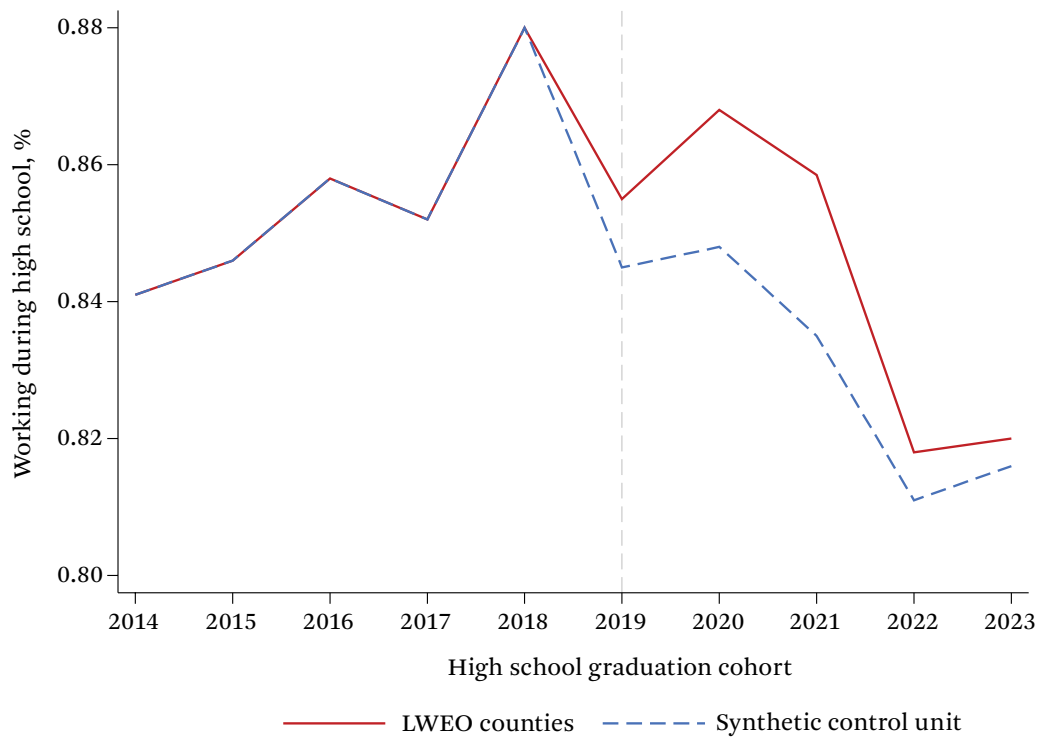
shifts in priorities might be driving more students into the workforce earlier. This increase in employment among high school students might not only reflect economic necessity but also a shift in long-term educational and career aspirations, influenced by the uncertainties brought about by the LWEO. The increased likelihood of working during high school, though significant across the board, was particularly impactful for Latinx and English-learner students. For many in these communities, working while in school is often a necessity rather than a choice, and the pressures of the LWEO may have forced more students into the workforce earlier than anticipated. This shift not only affects their immediate academic performance by limiting study time and increasing stress but also has long-term effects by potentially curtailing their aspirations for higher education.

Notably, we found mixed results in students' direct enrollment in two-year colleges. As shown in figure 6, while the synthetic control group modeled trends in enrollment rates prior to the raid, the trends following the LWEO are not consistent. These null results suggest a nu-

anced impact of the LWEO on different aspects of students' academic and professional lives. This absence of impact could suggest that two-year institutions may serve as a more resilient educational pathway amidst community disruptions caused by immigration enforcement. These colleges have lower barriers to entry, and they often provide more flexible, accessible, and financially feasible options for students, particularly those facing increased economic and social instability. The stability in enrollment rates at these institutions, despite the LWEO, underscores their role as critical educational resources in communities affected by enforcement actions.

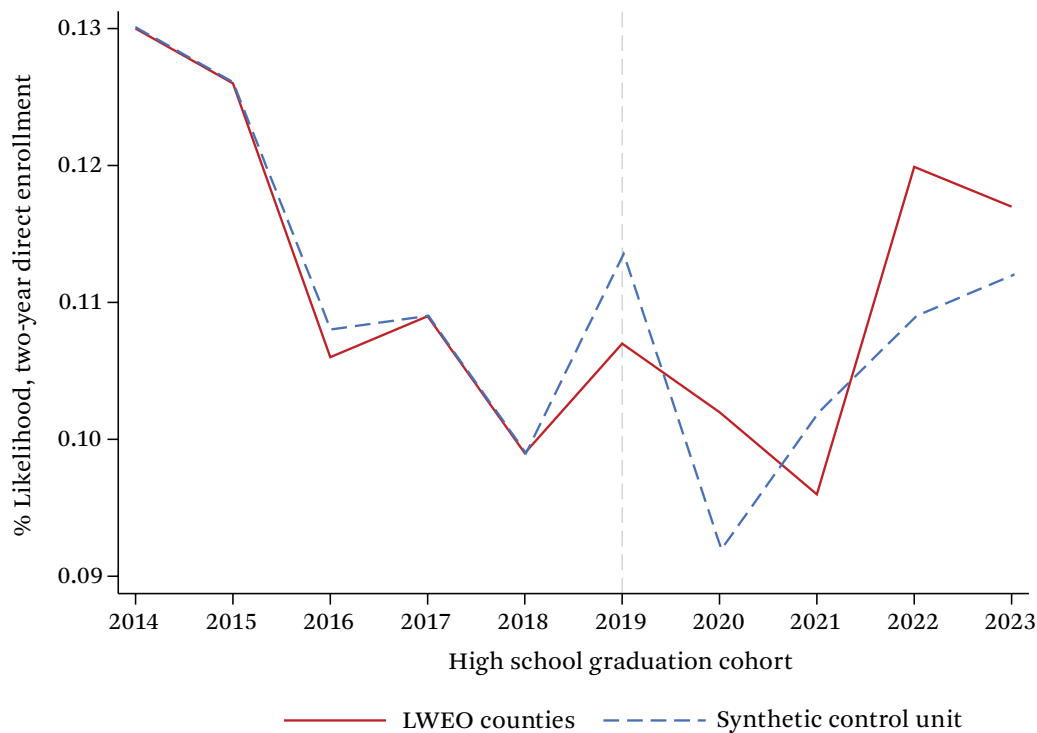
Tests of Robustness

In both appendix table A.1 and figure 2, we observe increases in four-year direct enrollment rates for the LWEO counties post-raid. While the SCM results suggest that the LWEO had a net negative effect—since the increase in LWEO counties' enrollment rates is not as large as that of the donor counties—there remains a concern that the effect we observe from the raid is confounded by other unobserved fac-

Figure 5. LWEO Effect on Likelihood of Working During High School

Source: Authors' calculations.

Note: The dashed vertical line indicates the year of the LWEO (2019).

Figure 6. LWEO Effect on Two-Year College Direct Enrollment Rate

Source: Authors' calculations.

Note: The dashed vertical line indicates the year of the LWEO (2019).

tors. To address this, we implement a placebo test (Abadie et al. 2010). The placebo test helps determine whether the observed effect is unique to the LWEO counties by applying the SCM to a set of pseudo-treated counties, none of which were exposed to the LWEO. This robustness check simulates the LWEO in the donor counties to check for spurious effects due to preexisting trends in those counties, which ensures effects attributed to the LWEO are not merely coincidental. Appendix figure A.1 displays the results from the placebo test of LWEO's impact on four-year direct enrollment rates. The bold line represents the four-year direct enrollment rate for the LWEO counties, and the lighter lines represent individual placebo counties within the donor pool. The placebo test results show that the observed increase in four-year direct enrollment rates for the LWEO counties post-raid is notably smaller than most of the placebo effects. While some fluctuation is observed in the placebo counties, the LWEO counties demonstrate a clear difference in enrollment rates post-raid, suggesting that the impact seen in the LWEO counties is unlikely to be driven by random variation. Additionally, we conducted another placebo test by shifting the intervention start year to one year prior to the actual LWEO, treating it as the baseline. This did not result in statistically significant changes. Lastly, we employed a leave-one-out sensitivity analysis, sequentially removing donor counties with large weights (> 0.1) to ensure that no individual county disproportionately influenced the synthetic control. While this slightly affected the estimated magnitude of the LWEO's impact, the divergence between the affected counties and the synthetic control group remained consistent across outcomes and analyses.

Another potential concern with our analysis is that the observed negative effects of the LWEO immigration raid on student outcomes could be confounded by disruptions associated with the COVID-19 pandemic, which began shortly after the LWEO event. While we cannot rule out possible confounding effects attributable to the pandemic, we conducted additional analyses using a difference-in-differences framework, comparing our original estimates (based on the full cohort range, 2014–2023) with

estimates derived from a narrower analytic window tightly centered around the LWEO event year (± 2 years: 2017–2021). Our results remain robust under this narrower window. For example, when examining declines in enrollment in four-year colleges, these models produce similar, statistically significant declines in college enrollment of roughly 1 percentage point. Moreover, our baseline synthetic control analysis indicates that enrollment gaps persist and notably widen to approximately 2 percentage points in subsequent cohorts, strongly suggesting that the negative enrollment impacts we attribute to the LWEO event extend beyond, and are distinct from, pandemic-related disruptions alone.

DISCUSSION

Our work builds on our current understanding of how legal vulnerability intersects with immigration enforcement by highlighting outcomes tied to postsecondary pathways that are impacted by an extreme enforcement episode—the Load Trail workplace raid. Although our data limit our ability to directly test specific underlying mechanisms, our prior research (Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2023) provides clear empirical support for how these mechanisms likely operate. In that study, we found significant declines in school attendance and student achievement following the same immigration enforcement event examined here, outcomes consistent with the pathways hypothesized in the current analysis. Thus, our present findings align closely with these previously documented mechanisms, underscoring how immigration enforcement negatively shapes students' educational trajectories. By conceiving of the LWEO as a community-wide shock whose effects can be observed at aggregate levels, we extend conceptualizations of legal vulnerability beyond an individual state of being.

Our findings highlight the profound disruption that immigration enforcement episodes like the Load Trail LWEO, and the large number of detentions and deportations that ensue, can produce for students' educational trajectories. The marked decline in direct enrollment in four-year colleges for Latinx and English-learner students attending school in the four counties nearest the plant demonstrates the

link between legal vulnerability—in this case, exposure to immigration enforcement activity—and educational opportunities and decisions that can be measured at the aggregate level. Relatedly, the lower rate of four-year college readiness among students in affected schools shows an additional consequence and potentially helps explain the depressed four-year college enrollment pattern among this subgroup. In contrast to the decline in four-year direct enrollment, we do not find any changes in direct enrollment rates for two-year colleges. This suggests that while the LWEO influences certain postsecondary educational decisions, its impact does not uniformly extend to all forms of higher education—especially those that may be perceived as lower cost, easily accessible, and more compatible with full- or part-time work (Hsin and Ortega 2018).

Without data on students' or their families' immigration status, we can only confidently point to exposure as the dimension of legal vulnerability that these affected students experience. At the same time, the fact that the negative effects on students' academic performance and pathways were concentrated among the Latinx and English-learner students, with no evidence of effects for White students in the affected schools, indicates the possibility of multiple forms of vulnerability and more intense consequences for students who may be more likely to live in immigrant families or with undocumented family members. Thus, our findings signal the importance of knowing more about the sources and degree of individual- and group-level legal vulnerability to determine the most appropriate, effective, and tailored responses. Our findings also highlight potential economic consequences associated with students' exposure to the LWEO, and these results demonstrate the interconnectedness of economic and educational decisions, especially for legally vulnerable people. We observe an increase in the percentage of students undertaking work during their high school years, which we understand as a possible shift in household priorities following a sudden loss of earnings due to detention or deportation—a shift in which students begin prioritizing economic contributions over educational pursuits.

Our study contributes to the growing body

of research on the profound and often detrimental effects of immigration enforcement on communities and, more specifically, on the educational and economic opportunities of legally vulnerable students in affected areas. While we are limited in our ability to determine which sources of legal vulnerability beyond exposure to an enforcement episode or act of community violence are present among the affected student population, we find convincing evidence that students who are more likely to have immigrant origins or live with immigrant family members (as measured by racial-ethnic background and English-learner designation) suffer meaningful consequences in terms of educational engagement and postsecondary opportunities. Furthermore, our results demonstrate the lasting and wide reach of these consequences, spreading to a large swath of the student population and persisting across multiple years. These educational outcomes represent one tangible set of indicators that reflect the vast and wide-ranging spillover effects produced by the current deportation system; similarly troubling patterns may be observed in housing data, earnings and employment, and indicators of mental and physical health and well-being among the legally vulnerable residents of communities that have experienced such acts of violence.

The findings of our study into some of the short- and medium-term educational disruptions caused by an LWEO underscore the need for empirical evidence that captures the diverse range of consequences associated with immigration enforcement and their impacts over time for individuals and communities. Furthermore, by centering community-level legal vulnerability as the primary unit of analysis, we show the value of attending to group-level outcomes while simultaneously capturing internal heterogeneity to understand variation in experience and response to community violence. This study represents a first step in understanding how exposure to immigration enforcement activity as one source of legal vulnerability may shape students' educational behaviors, aspirations, and decision-making over their life course. It also highlights the importance of considering such episodes as potentially powerful predictors or explanatory fac-

tors of individuals' and groups' earnings, career trajectories, upward mobility, and overall well-being.

The absence of findings on two-year enrollment should inform targeted interventions. Policymakers and educators should consider these results as indicative of potential areas of resilience that warrant further investigation. Strengthening the supports that maintain stable enrollment rates, even in the face of disruptive events like LWEOs, is an important consideration. These null findings emphasize the importance of nuanced approaches to policymaking and educational practice that recognize the varied impacts of immigration enforcement. They highlight the need for continued research to dissect the conditions under which educational outcomes are shielded from, or susceptible to, the consequences of immigration enforcement.

Limitations and Further Research

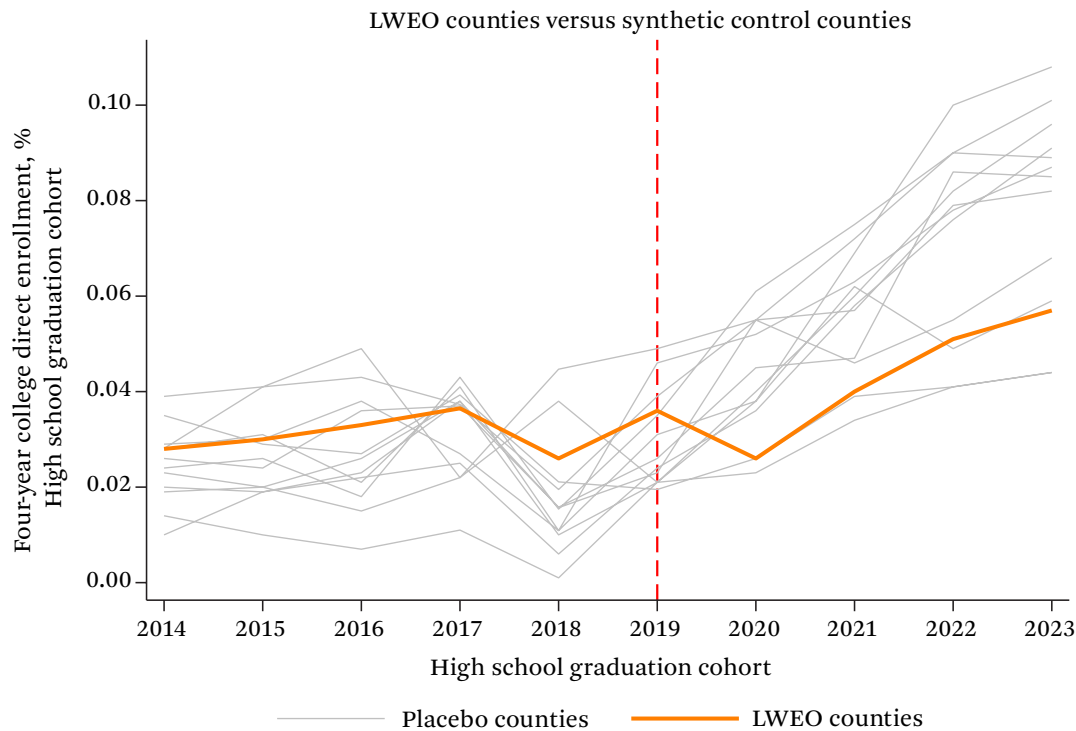
While the LWEO appears to correspond to a measurable negative influence on students' postsecondary outcomes, we acknowledge several limitations of our study. Foremost among these is the potential confounding role of the COVID-19 pandemic, which coincided with our post-raid observational period. The pandemic created unprecedented disruptions to schooling through shifts to remote learning, widespread school closures, and substantial changes in education policies and programs. These disruptions disproportionately affected economically disadvantaged communities, and it is plausible that pandemic-related impacts on school policies, resource allocation, and family circumstances may have compounded or interacted with the effects of the LWEO. Many students and families experienced significant instability during this period, potentially further diminishing their capacity to engage with college preparation, readiness, and enrollment processes. Although our inclusion of data

through 2023 extends the observational window beyond the peak of pandemic disruptions, we cannot fully disentangle the observed LWEO effects from broader systemic educational disruptions that arose during the COVID-19 period.

Another limitation concerns our reliance on administrative, district-reported data, which does not allow us to identify specific students or families directly affected by the raid or their precise sources of legal vulnerability. Without individual-level data on immigration status or personal experiences of the raid, our findings necessarily reflect broader community-level impacts rather than direct causal effects at the individual level. Furthermore, while we employed rigorous methods—such as the synthetic control method and short-window difference-in-differences analyses—to mitigate potential confounding factors, these approaches depend heavily on the assumption that our control groups accurately reflect the counterfactual scenario in the absence of the LWEO.

Future studies should also explore explicitly the interactions between immigration enforcement and public health crises to better disentangle these overlapping effects. Moreover, longitudinal analyses that track students over extended periods may capture delayed impacts not observable in shorter-term, immediate post-raid studies. Qualitative investigations could further enrich our understanding by illuminating student experiences and institutional practices that promote resilience in the face of legal vulnerabilities. Lastly, the absence of observed effects in certain domains, such as two-year college enrollment, underscores the importance of continuing research into conditions and contexts under which educational outcomes are either resilient or susceptible to immigration enforcement disruptions. Such insights would meaningfully inform targeted policy interventions and educational supports for legally vulnerable student populations.

APPENDIX

Figure A.1. Placebo Test for Four-Year Direct Enrollment Rates

Source: Authors' calculations.

Note: The dashed vertical line indicates the year of the LWEO (2019).

Table A.1. Mean Differences in Educational Outcomes for LWEO Counties Pre- and Post-Raid

Outcome	Pre-LWEO Mean (2014–2018), Percentage	Post-LWEO Mean (2019–2023), Percentage	Difference, Percentage Points	Significance
Four-year college direct enrollment	3.24	4.56	1.32	**
Four-year college readiness	4.42	3.22	–1.20	**
FAFSA and TAFSA application rate	57.84	46.06	–11.78	***
Working during high school	85.60	84.60	–1.00	*
Two-year college direct enrollment	11.56	10.96	–0.60	*

Source: Authors' calculations.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

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Settlement Duration Matters: Deportation Threat and Safety Net Participation Among Mixed-Status Families



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Studies link intensified immigration enforcement to reduced safety net participation among mixed-status families, but less is known about how this varies by settlement duration. Bridging research on immigrant settlement and system avoidance, we theorize that the impacts are strongest among immigrants with shorter US residency. To test this, we analyze whether exposure to deportation threat, measured as removals under Secure Communities per one thousand noncitizens, is associated with safety net use among citizen children of likely undocumented Latinas in California, using a two-way fixed effects regression. We find that increased removal rates are negatively related to the child's participation in the Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children; Medicaid; and Temporary Assistance for Needy Families among mothers with less than five years of residency, but not among those with longer durations, relative to US-born mothers. These findings suggest that deportation threat may be especially burdensome for recent arrivals.

Keywords: deportation threat, secure communities, safety net, mixed-status families, settlement, recent arrivals

Unauthorized legal status severely constrains undocumented immigrants' access to critical resources and long-term well-being. Lacking legal status limits employment opportunities, suppresses wages, reduces access to the social safety net, and increases vulnerability to labor exploitation (Gonzales 2011; Gleeson 2010). These material disadvantages extend to chil-

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Hong, Youngjin Stephanie, Marci Ybarra, and Angela S. García. 2025. "Settlement Duration Matters: Deportation Threat and Safety Net Participation Among Mixed-Status Families." *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 142–74. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.07>. This study was partially funded by the Center for the Study of Race, Politics, and Culture Funding at the University of Chicago. The first author currently receives support as a postdoctoral trainee from the National Institutes of Health under Ruth L. Kirschstein National Research Service Award (T32HD049302) from the National Institute of Child Health and Human Development. The content is solely the responsibility of the authors and does not necessarily represent the official views of the Eunice Kennedy Shriver National Institute of Child Health and Human Development or the National Institutes of Health. Direct correspondence to: Youngjin Stephanie Hong, at hong249@wisc.edu, 610 Walnut Street, Madison, WI 53726, United States; Marci Ybarra, at ybarra@wisc.edu, 1006 Shasta Drive, Madison, WI, 53704, United States; Angela S. García, at agarcia@uchicago.edu, 969 E. 60th Street, Chicago IL 60637, United States.

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dren, including US citizens, by reducing household income and discouraging public benefit use due to fear of detection or deportation (Yoshikawa 2011). Moreover, children's well-being can also be impacted, including academic achievement and educational and workforce outcomes (see Bennett et al. 2025 and Kirksey and Sattin-Bajaj 2025, both this issue).

Despite undocumented immigrants' exclusion from most federal safety net programs, their US-born children are eligible. However, intensified immigration enforcement in the post-Welfare Reform era has been linked to reduced safety net participation among eligible children. For example, after the 2008 implementation of Secure Communities (SC), an interior immigration enforcement program that automated data-sharing between local law enforcement and federal immigration authorities, scholars documented a surge in non-citizen removals as well as reduced safety net enrollment among immigrant families, including children (Kohli et al. 2011; Fortuny and Chaudry 2011; Bernstein et al. 2019). As such, legal vulnerability contributes not only to marginalization of undocumented immigrants but also to intergenerational disadvantage.

Low enrollment in safety net programs among children in mixed-immigration status households is especially concerning given these families' comparatively higher poverty rates and exposure to additional risks, such as workplace raids and anti-immigrant subnational laws, that negatively affect immigrant maternal and infant health (Torche and Sirois 2019; Novak et al. 2017). Moreover, participation in food assistance, public health insurance, and public early childhood education programs is associated with improved children's health and development and academic outcomes (East 2020; Hong and Henly 2020; Lee et al. 2021). Hence, reduced safety net enrollment among US citizen children with undocumented parents—an estimated six million under age eighteen (American Immigration Council 2021), about three-quarters of whom live below the income threshold for program eligibility—could generate greater individual, family, and social costs in the near and long term (Capps et al. 2016).

The weight of illegality and the constraints

it brings to safety net participation, however, may be experienced unevenly depending on how long immigrants have lived in the United States. Drawing on research on immigrant settlement and system avoidance, we hypothesize that reductions in program participation under intensified immigration enforcement are most pronounced among recently arrived immigrants (Piore 1979; García 2019; Patler and Gonzalez 2021, 2023; Asad 2023). Compared to those with longer US residency, recent arrivals are likely less familiar with both safety net programs and immigration enforcement policies, and may face greater language, information, and access barriers to program participation, and thus avoid state systems (García et al. 2024; Park et al. 2024). As the US has increased interior enforcement and implemented more restrictive border policies since the 1990s, undocumented immigrants have become increasingly locked-in to the US, lengthening their settlement duration (Massey et al. 2016). Of the estimated ten to eleven million undocumented people in the US, 43 percent have lived under the conditions of illegality and deportation threat for fifteen years or more, while others have shorter durations of stay (Migration Policy Institute, n.d.). We leverage these variations in undocumented immigrants' settlement duration to understand if and how deportation threat intersects with settlement duration in its association with safety net enrollment for US citizen children, moving beyond treating settlement duration merely as a control variable.

To do so, this study examines the association between the SC program and the take-up of a broad range of safety net programs by citizen children of likely undocumented Latina mothers in California, and whether these associations vary by mothers' duration in the US. We examine five different programs, including the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP); Medicaid; Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC); Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF); and Head Start and state preschool programs. We draw on repeated cross-sectional data from the California Health Interview Survey (CHIS). CHIS is particularly suitable for the present study because it offers a detailed measure of citizenship and immigra-

tion status and has been used to assess a range of outcomes for children with likely undocumented parents (Patler et al. 2019).

With CHIS data, we examine these dynamics in California, the focus of this study, and one of the top two states of residence for undocumented immigrants, both recently arrived and long settled. Since the start of the twenty-first century, California has embraced a progressive shift toward a broad range of legal accommodations for immigrants, including one of the most generous state-level safety nets in the US for immigrants (García 2019). Indeed, it was the first state to provide subsidized healthcare to low-income undocumented people, including children, the elderly, and all adults, although the funding for undocumented adults has been recently cut (Associated Press 2025). The state has also enacted laws around language justice to promote access to government-run programs and services for immigrants with limited English proficiency (Institute for Local Government 2011). We therefore consider California a best-case scenario for safety net take-up among citizen children of undocumented parents. Nonetheless, immigrants in California, like those in all other states, remain vulnerable to federal immigration enforcement, which may dampen program participation despite the state's policies designed to support immigrants and its comparatively generous safety net.

By interacting removal rates under the SC program with mothers' immigration status in a two-way county and year fixed effects regression, this study finds suggestive evidence that SC removal rates are negatively associated with Head Start and state preschool participation of children among likely undocumented Latinas (proxied as noncitizen Latinas without lawful permanent residency [LPR] status), relative to US-born Latinas. Critically, accounting for the durations of US residency, we observe that SC removal rates are negatively related to the child's participation in WIC, TANF, and Medicaid among mothers with less than five years in the US, but not among those with longer durations, relative to US-born mothers. Among undocumented Latinas, we also find greater reductions in children's TANF and Medicaid participation rates among recently arrived

mothers than longer-settled mothers. Our findings are based on an immigrant sample residing in California, a state with an accommodating approach to undocumented residents. Hence, there may be larger reductions in program participation in more restrictive destinations (García 2019). Taken together, our findings offer a nuanced understanding of how deportation threat intersects with legal precarity and immigrant settlement to shape citizen children's access to the safety net. By highlighting the heightened vulnerability of recently arrived undocumented mothers, this study underscores the need for policies that address the uneven burdens of enforcement on immigrant families, particularly those with eligible citizen children of recently arrived parents.

BACKGROUND

In this section, we provide information on the safety net programs covered in this study, the literature review of the effect of immigration enforcement on safety net participation, how we conceptualize deportation threat, and how immigrants' settlement duration may factor into the relationship between deportation threat and program participation.

Safety Net Access and Immigrant Eligibility

The US safety net is comprised of a range of means-tested programs designed to reduce material hardship and promote the health, well-being, and stability of low-income families. These include food assistance (for example, SNAP and WIC); public health insurance (Medicaid); income support (TANF); and early care and education (ECE) services (Head Start and state preschool), in addition to others. Eligibility for these programs depends on factors including household income and immigration status. Although undocumented immigrants are categorically excluded from most federal benefits, their US citizen children are generally eligible (Fix and Passel 2002). However, access depends on parents' ability and willingness to complete applications, provide documentation, and interact with government agencies, making public program enrollment of citizen children in mixed-status families particularly sensitive to the broader immigration policy environment.

Immigration Enforcement and Program Participation

A growing body of research demonstrates how immigration enforcement shapes safety net participation among immigrant families. For instance, children with undocumented parents are less likely to enroll in SNAP, partly due to fear, misinformation, and structural barriers (Bovell-Ammon et al. 2019; Pelto et al. 2020). Nationally, SNAP participation declined between 2015 and 2019, with the sharpest drop among children of noncitizen parents in states that did not expand Medicaid, highlighting how policy environments can exacerbate disparities (Nguyen et al. 2023). State-level restrictiveness and Trump-era policies such as the Public Charge Rule have also contributed to chilling effects on SNAP participation (Bitler et al. 2021; Chaudry et al. 2021; Miller et al. 2022).

These trends are echoed in research on Medicaid. Children in mixed-status families are less likely to enroll in public health insurance when a parent is a noncitizen, especially following restrictive immigration policy shifts (Vargas 2015; Barofsky et al. 2020; Dias and Chance 2024; Guerrero et al. 2021). Although the Affordable Care Act (ACA) helped reduce some of these gaps, disparities remain (Stimpson and Wilson 2018). Similarly, studies find that the implementation of restrictive state immigration laws, federal enforcement practices, and broader immigrant climate shifts, such as those following Donald J. Trump's election, have led to reductions in Medicaid participation and health-care utilization (Twersky 2022; Watson 2014; Ettinger de Cuba et al. 2023).

Federal enforcement practices and the Public Charge Rule have also been shown to reduce WIC participation in mixed-status families (Vargas and Pirog 2016; Choi et al. 2023; Barofsky et al. 2021). ECE enrollment is also lower among immigrant families, particularly when a parent is undocumented (Mapp and Hornung 2016; Yoshikawa 2011; Vesely et al. 2021). Studies also demonstrate that immigration raids were associated with reduced Head Start enrollment among Latine children, while SC implementation reduced participation in center-based childcare (Santillano et al. 2020; Ali et al. 2024).

The case of TANF is more complex. Although undocumented immigrants are ineli-

gible, their US citizen children may receive child-only TANF benefits—that is, a smaller benefit that excludes the parent or parents (Golden and Hawkins 2011). Nationally, in 2016, child-only cases comprised 51 percent of TANF caseloads, and 25 percent of those cases involved ineligible immigrant parents (Joyce 2018). In California, 55 percent of child-only TANF cases involved ineligible immigrant parents, the highest percentage in the nation (Joyce 2018; Mauldon et al. 2012). This suggests that TANF may be more accessible to mixed-status families in California; however, participation remains vulnerable to intensified interior immigration enforcement, as Francisco Pedraza and Vanessa Zhu (2015) found heightened SC enforcement reduced TANF use even among eligible Latine citizens.

Everyday Deportation Threat

We conceptualize deportation threat as the everyday salience of immigration enforcement in the lives of immigrants and their families. More specifically, following Amy L. Johnson and colleagues (2024), we define everyday deportation threat as the federal government's routine efforts to detain and deport noncitizens, and the public's awareness of these actions. These efforts could shape the daily life of immigrants and their families, even for immigrants who have reentered the US following deportation (see Valdivia 2025, this issue), generating psychological distress and eroding trust in public institutions. For example, Pedraza and colleagues (2017) found that the greater salience of immigration issues led Latine US citizens to avoid daily-life activities, including health-care services, because of their personal proximity to undocumented immigrants. We operationalize such everyday threats through removal rates under SC, a program that infused immigration enforcement into local policing by automating immigration checks using the fingerprints of arrestees.

Settlement Duration, System Avoidance, and Safety Net Participation

Research on system avoidance and immigrant settlement offers insight into how duration in

the US shapes responses to intensified immigration enforcement. System avoidance scholars argue that individuals who have experienced state surveillance or marginalization tend to avoid record-keeping institutions such as schools, hospitals, and benefit programs (Brayne 2014; Fong 2020; Patler and Gonzalez 2021, 2023). Yet, avoidance is not a given as undocumented parents often engage selectively with the state on behalf of their citizen children (Asad 2023; García 2019).

In particular, settlement duration may moderate these dynamics, as immigrants develop more familiarity with the safety net and the risks of immigration enforcement over time. While recently arrived immigrants often lack knowledge of program rules, face language barriers, and report lower self-efficacy in navigating services (Duh-Leong et al. 2022), the cumulative knowledge may lead long-settled parents to build trusted networks, learn how to minimize exposure while accessing resources, and reframe deportation threat as part of the risks of daily life (García 2019; Piore 1979). Thus, we expect that recent arrivals may be more vulnerable to reduced safety net participation among their eligible US citizen children as they are likely less able or willing to access safety net programs.

This study contributes to the literature by addressing two research questions. First, we examine whether removal rates under the SC program are associated with safety net participation among citizen children of likely undocumented Latina mothers in absolute terms and relative to US-born Latina mothers (RQ1). Second, we assess whether these relationships vary by mothers' duration of US residence (RQ2). We employ two analytical approaches to address each question.

DATA

We use the 2009–2019 CHIS data, which is a repeated cross-sectional population-based telephone survey of California's noninstitutionalized population, as well as the largest state survey and one of the largest health sur-

veys in the country. Within each selected household, CHIS randomly selects one adult respondent for the adult survey. In households with adolescents (aged twelve to seventeen) or children (under age twelve), one adolescent or one child is randomly selected, or both, if the sampled adult is their parent or legal guardian. Thus, at most, two children under the age of eighteen are sampled in one household. The adolescent takes the teen survey directly, while the adult most knowledgeable about the sampled child completes the child survey (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016). By linking across adult, teen, and child surveys, we created a child-level dataset linked to the parent. We hereafter refer to the parent survey respondent as the "parent" for simplicity (73.4 percent of parents who responded to the adult survey are mothers). CHIS is well suited for this study because its child and teen surveys directly ask whether the child's mother is a noncitizen without LPR status. We use this status as a proxy to more accurately capture Latina mothers who are likely undocumented, compared to most other surveys that cannot disentangle LPRs from other noncitizens (Patler et al. 2019). Prior studies using CHIS have similarly classified undocumented immigrants based on respondents' immigration status (Bustamante et al. 2014; Ortega et al. 2007, 2018),¹ and prior research supports the reliability of CHIS immigration status measures (Viana et al. 2017).

Our sample consists of citizen children whose mothers are likely undocumented Latinas or US born citizen Latinas ($N = 8,184$). To capture children who are likely eligible for safety net programs, we focus on children whose parent has no college education and whose family income is under 300 percent of the Federal Poverty Level (FPL) ($N = 5,278$)—as this income range captures most variation in safety net eligibility (Schmidt et al. 2016) and a majority of program participation questions in CHIS. (WIC, SNAP, TANF were surveyed only among families with income at or under 300 percent of the FPL in most years.) We then ex-

1. Latinas make up 98 percent of noncitizen mothers without LPR status in our sample. This likely minimizes error in our measurement of undocumented status, given the evidence that the vast majority of undocumented immigrants in the US are Latine immigrants (77.1 percent in 2017; Lopez et al. 2021).

clude cases with missing values in study variables, such as program participation and mother's years lived in the US. Most of the missing data in program participation stemmed from question changes by CHIS. In 2019, CHIS began asking WIC, SNAP, and TANF questions only to families with incomes at or below 200 percent of the FPL. Consequently, families with incomes between 200 and 300 percent of the FPL in 2019 are coded as missing in those variables. As a robustness check, we examine whether findings are substantively similar when a study sample is defined by the income threshold of 200 percent of FPL and when we drop the 2019 survey year. Missingness on the US duration variable is attributable to data processing errors² in the 2015 and 2017 CHIS child data (under age twelve). To address this issue, we conduct sensitivity analyses by dropping the 2015 and 2017 data from primary models in both the first and the second research questions. We find substantively similar results in those robustness tests.³ After removing missing cases, sample sizes vary across selected programs: 2186 (WIC), 534 (Head Start), 4,924 (TANF), 4,995 (SNAP), and 5,051 (Medicaid). We have smaller sample sizes for WIC and Head Start and state preschool because only children under age six are eligible for them, while all children under age eighteen are eligible for SNAP, Medicaid, and TANF. In addition, only children who received childcare for ten or more hours a week were asked about Head Start or state preschool enrollment. Appendix table B.1 shows a breakdown of missingness in our samples.

MEASURES

We use the following measures in this study.

Program Participation

For each program, participation is coded as equal to 1 when a child is reported to have par-

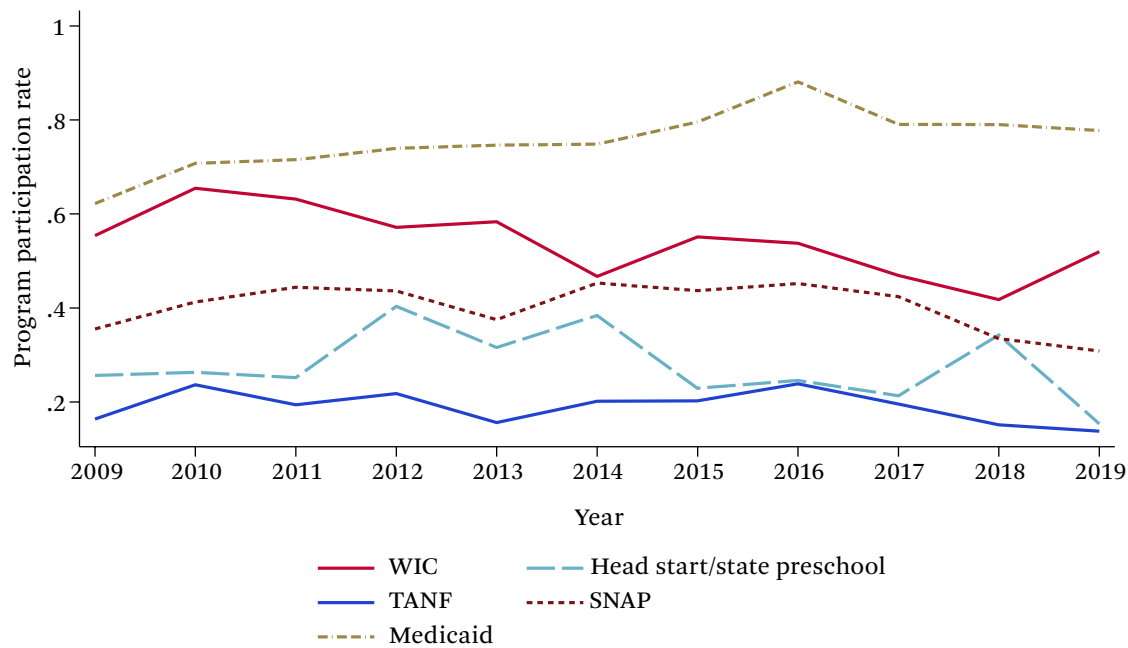
ticipated at the time of the interview (else = 0). Figure 1 illustrates 2009–2019 program participation trends in our sample of low-income, US-born citizens and likely undocumented Latinas' children. TANF and SNAP had relatively stable participation rates until 2016 when rates began to decline, although there was a slight dip in SNAP and TANF participation rates in 2013. Medicaid participation consistently increased from 2009 to 2016, followed by a decline in 2017, although it became stable afterward. WIC participation gradually declined over the years, including the periods after 2016. There was more variation in Head Start and state preschool program participation rates, which may be partly related to their smaller sample size. Taken together, although some variation exists across programs, the overall trend points to declines in program participation post-2016.

Secure Communities Removal Rates

Our treatment variable is constructed as the total number of removals under the SC program per one thousand noncitizen residents in a given county and year, an approach used in related research (Vargas and Pirog 2016). Given how it is measured, the removal rate reflects deportability and, in turn, families' exposure to deportation threat. Removal data come from TRAC (n.d.), and noncitizen population estimates are from the US Census Bureau. Removal rates are merged with the CHIS sample by survey year and county of residence. Figure 2 illustrates removal rate trends from 2009 to 2019 across California counties, with counties showing distinct patterns indicated by lines with different symbols or patterns. Changes in removal rates over time may reflect several county-level factors, such as demographic changes, proximity to the border, number of ICE officers, local attitudes toward immigration, and the size of the undocumented population. Ian Peacock

2. In 2015, some noncitizen mothers were misclassified as US-born citizens in the US duration variable, primarily in the child data ($N = 155$). In 2017, some children surveyed in the child data were not assigned valid US duration values ($N = 63$).

3. Appendix table A.1 shows that families with missing values in WIC, SNAP, TANF outcomes, or duration in the US are more likely to have income at or above 200 percent of FPL and are less likely to have children aged twelve to seventeen, compared to those who do not have missing values in those variables. This is expected, given the nature of missingness in those variables.

Figure 1. Program Participation Rates over Time in the Study Sample

Source: Authors' calculations of program participation rates from CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: CHIS weights are applied. Average participation rates are plotted for each program in the full study sample (which vary across programs).

(2025, this issue) also suggests that social influence contributes to counties' decisions to participate in immigration enforcement. In our model specification, we leverage temporal variations in removal rates within counties, coming from both the activation of SC and changes in enforcement intensity.

Mother's Immigration Status

The treated group (those impacted by removal rates) is citizen children living in Latina mixed-status families, defined as a family in which the child's mother is a likely undocumented immigrant (proxied as a noncitizen without LPR status) and identifies as Latina or Hispanic. The comparison group is citizen children whose mothers are Latina or Hispanic US-born citizens.⁴ We use the mother's immigration status because mothers are disproportionately responsible for caregiving and children's well-being, including safety net participation (Bianchi et al. 2006; Bianchi 2011), and prior research has

also used this approach (Watson 2014; Vargas and Pirog 2016; Ybarra et al. 2017). Moreover, the father's immigration status has additional missing values ($N = 817$ in the full data), which would further limit statistical power.

Moderator

For our second research question, mother's duration in the US is our moderator. It is categorized as less than five years, five to fourteen years, and fifteen or more years.

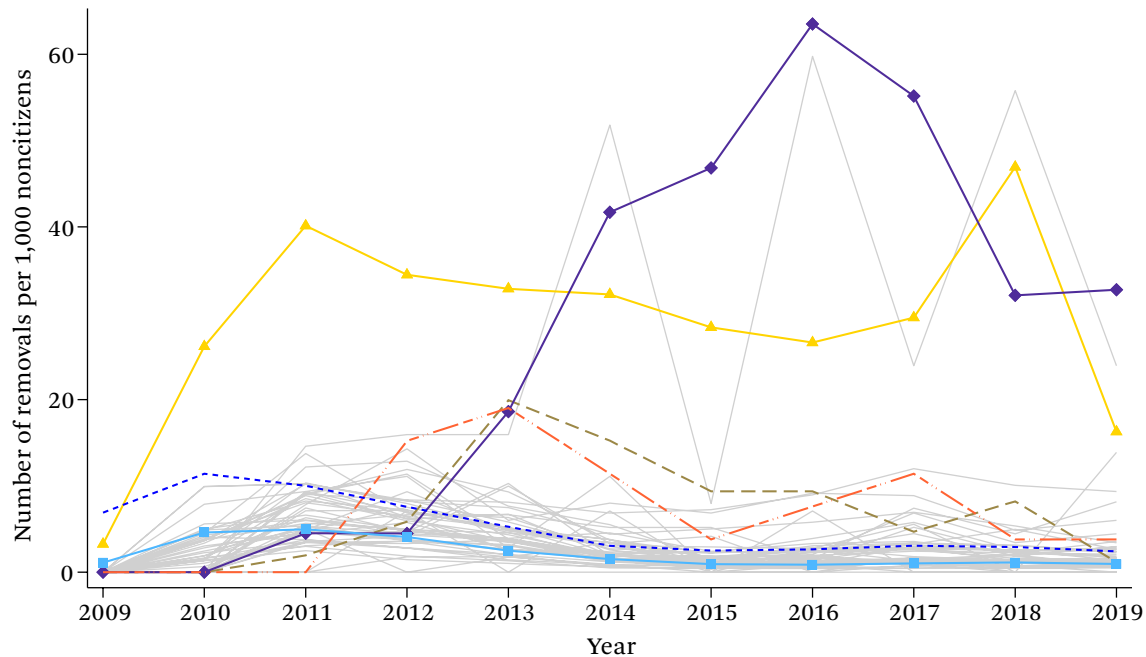
EMPIRICAL STRATEGY

To address each research question, we consider the following two analytical approaches within a two-way (county and year) fixed effects framework.

Full Analysis (Preferred Specification)

First, as our preferred specification, we conduct a full analysis that compares likely undocumented Latinas to US-born Latinas.

4. Due to relatively smaller sample sizes of naturalized citizens and lawful permanent residents in our data, this study focused on US-born citizens and likely undocumented populations. For example, there were about one hundred noncitizens with LPR status in the Head Start sample.

Figure 2. California County-Level Removal Rates over Time Under the Secure Communities Program

Source: Authors' calculations of removal rates from TRAC (n.d.) data.

Note: All California counties' removal rates are plotted in this figure. Several counties are distinguished using patterned and symbol-marked lines: Calaveras County (dash), Imperial County (triangle symbol), Lassen County (diamond symbol), LA County (squared symbol), Mariposa County (dash-dot line), and San Diego (short dash).

First Research Question

In our analysis of RQ1, we interact SC removal rates with the mother's immigration status in a county and year fixed effects regression to estimate the relationship between SC removal rates and safety net participation among eligible US citizen children with a likely undocumented Latina mother compared to those with US-born Latina mothers.⁵ This approach follows that of Tara Watson (2014), who used a similar design to examine the chilling effects of deportation threat on Medicaid participation. To implement, we use a linear probability model, which is preferable to nonlinear models when using interaction terms (Ai and Norton 2003; Mood 2010; Angrist and Pischke 2009). We analyze a model of the following form (equation 1):

$$Y_{ict} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{removals}_{ct} + \delta \text{removals}_{ct} \times \text{mixed}_i + \beta_2 \text{mixed}_i + \lambda_t + \alpha_c + \lambda_t \times \text{mixed}_i + \alpha_c \times \text{mixed}_i + \theta_{ct}' \rho + X_{it}' \gamma + \epsilon_{ict},$$

where Y_{ict} indicates the program participation status of child i in year t who lives in county c , removals_{ct} refers to removal rates in county c during year t , and mixed_i indicates that the child i 's mother is likely an undocumented Latina (= 0 if the mother of child i is a US-born Latina). The main coefficient of interest δ represents the association between a one-unit increase in removal rates (or one additional person being removed per one thousand noncitizens) and program participation among children of likely undocumented Latinas over and above the association among children of US-born Latinas. To contextualize, this one-

5. Our model is similar to a triple-difference model with a continuous treatment variable. However, it is not fully specified as a traditional triple-difference model, which would require the inclusion of county by year fixed effects. We intentionally omit these fixed effects because they would fully absorb the coefficient on removals_{ct} , the association between removal rates and program participation among US-born mothers, which is one of the primary relationships of interest in our analysis.

unit change represents approximately 20 percent of the increase in annual removal rates from the lowest to the highest levels during the study period.⁶ β_1 captures the association between removal rates and safety net participation of children of US-born Latinas. Previous studies suggest that while the effects of deportation threat may spill over onto US citizen Latinas, these effects are generally smaller than those on undocumented Latinas (Alsan and Yang 2022; Novak et al. 2017). Therefore, we expect to find these effects, if any, to be modest. Standard errors are clustered at the county level to account for common shocks within a county and serially correlated shocks over time (findings are robust when standard errors are clustered at the family level).

The model includes a set of fixed effects including year fixed effects λ_t and year by mixed-status family fixed effects $\lambda_t \times mixed_i$, which accounts for statewide annual changes in program participation among children from Latina mixed-status families. Additionally, we include county fixed effects α_c and county by mixed-status family fixed effects $\alpha_c \times mixed_i$ to control for permanent county-level differences that affect program participation among children in Latina mixed-status families. We also adjust for county unemployment rates and the implementation status of Section 287(g), captured in θ_{ct} , to account for changes in county-level economic conditions and other immigration enforcement policies over time. This set of fixed effects and county-year covariates controls for potential heterogeneity across counties and over time that could influence children's safety net participation and may covary with changes in removal rates.

We also adjust for family-level or child-level characteristics X_{it} , including the responding parent's education (less than high school, high school diploma, some college); marital status (unmarried,⁷ married, living with partner); age (eighteen to twenty-nine, thirty to thirty-nine, forty to forty-nine, fifty or older); family poverty status (0–50% FPL, 50–100% of FPL, 100–150% of FPL, 150–200% of FPL, 200%+ of FPL); num-

ber of children in the household (one, two, three or more); and children's age (zero to two years, three to five years, six to eleven years, twelve to seventeen years). Adjusting for these individual-level covariates improves the precision of our key estimate and helps balance any compositional differences between the treated and comparison groups (Olden and Møen 2022). The assumption of our model is that, after adjusting for a set of fixed effects and county and individual characteristics, there are no county-specific shocks that coincide with the SC removal rate changes and that differentially influence safety net participation for children of likely undocumented Latinas relative to US-born Latinas. We conduct tests later to examine the validity of this assumption.

Second Research Question

In our analysis of RQ2, we use equation 1 but run three separate regressions based on likely undocumented Latinas' different durations of US residency (zero to four, five to fourteen, or fifteen or more years). As before, we consider children of US-born Latinas as the comparison group. In RQ2, we focus on WIC, SNAP, TANF, and Medicaid due to the small sample size for the Head Start and state preschool outcome ($N = 534$), limiting statistical power to conduct a subgroup analysis.

Analysis for Likely Undocumented Latinas

After conducting a full analysis comparing likely undocumented Latinas to US-born Latinas, we also conduct within-group analyses for likely undocumented Latinas in both the RQ1 and RQ2.

First Research Question

For RQ1, we analyze the following specification (equation 2):

$$Y_{ict} = \beta_0 + \delta removals_{ct} + \lambda_t + \alpha_c + \theta_{ct}'\rho + X_{it}'\gamma + \epsilon_{ict}$$

where all subscripts and variables are defined similarly as above. In this specification, we additionally account for mother's duration in the

6. Across all counties, the lowest removal rate is 0.85 in 2009, and the highest removal rate is 6.21 in 2011.

7. This includes never married, separated, widowed, and divorced.

US, captured in X_{it} . The main coefficient of interest is δ , which indicates the association between removal rates and program participation of citizen children in mixed-status families. This model serves as a robustness check for the full model (equation 1) that examines relative changes by mother's immigration status, testing whether similar changes in program participation are observed among the children of undocumented Latinas themselves.

Second Research Question

In RQ2, we investigate whether undocumented Latina mothers differ from each other in their children's program participation based on duration in the US. To do so, we use equation 1, limiting the sample to undocumented Latinas and replacing *mixed_i* with mother's duration in the US, resulting in the following model specification (equation 3):

$$Y_{ict} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{removals}_{ct} + \delta \text{removals}_{ct} \times \text{USduration}_i + \beta_2 \text{USduration}_i + \lambda_t + \alpha_c + \lambda_t \times \text{USduration}_i + \alpha_c \times \text{USduration}_i + \theta_{ct}' \rho + X_{it}' \gamma + \varepsilon_{ict}$$

The coefficient of interest is δ , the interaction effect, which indicates whether the association between removal rates and children's program participation differs for undocumented Latinas with five to fourteen years and fifteen or more years, compared to those with less than five years in the US.

SAMPLE CHARACTERISTICS BY MOTHER'S IMMIGRATION STATUS

In table 1, we describe summary statistics for our study sample by mother's immigration status.⁸ Children of undocumented Latina mothers are more likely to live in poverty (below 100 percent of the FPL), compared to children of US-born citizen mothers (64 percent vs. 44 percent, respectively). Likely due to their lower income status, the program participation rate is higher for children of undocumented mothers than those of US citizen mothers across all programs except TANF (although Head Start par-

ticipation rates are statistically indistinguishable). In addition, undocumented mothers are more likely to have less than a high school education, to be married and living with a partner, to have a greater number of children, and to be in their thirties and forties. The age of the focal child also varies by mother's immigration status. Furthermore, most undocumented mothers have lived in the US for fifteen or more years (51 percent) or five to fourteen years (45 percent). Such compositional differences in demographic and economic characteristics between children of undocumented mothers and their counterparts suggest the importance of adjusting for these covariates in the model. In appendix table A.2, we also present sample characteristics by both mother's duration in the US and immigration status.

ASSOCIATION BETWEEN REMOVAL RATES AND SAFETY NET PARTICIPATION (RQ1)

Table 2 presents the association between removal rates and citizen children's safety net participation among mixed-status families, based on our preferred specification. Full results, including controls, are available in appendix table A.3. The coefficient on *Removal rate × Undocumented Latina* indicates that a marginal increase in removal rates is associated with a 7-percentage-point greater reduction in Head Start or state preschool participation among children of undocumented mothers, relative to children of US citizen mothers. This difference is equivalent to a 22 percent reduction in participation rate based on the mean of 0.32. However, while the direction of this estimate aligns with our expectation, we interpret this result with caution, given that our estimate does not meet the conventional threshold for statistical significance ($p < 0.05$). Also, in line with our expectation, we find no evidence of an association between removal rates and Head Start or state preschool program participation among US-born Latinas' children (see *Removal rate* row in table 2), providing evidence that the reduction among

8. To generate table 1, we used the sample limited to families without missing values in SNAP participation status. Appendix table A.5 presents sample characteristics of families without missing values in the Head Start and state preschool program outcome (as noted earlier, sample sizes differ by program type).

Table 1. Sample Characteristics by Mother's Immigration Status

	US-Born Citizen (55.22%) Percent / Mean (SD)	Undocumented (44.78%) Percent / Mean (SD)	Full Sample Percent / Mean (SD)	Significance
County removal rate	3.52 (3.33)	3.30 (2.63)	3.42 (3.11)	
Received WIC	55.54	69.29	61.1	***
Attended Head Start or state preschool program	30.64	31.55	30.92	
Received TANF	22.22	15.80	19.27	**
Received SNAP	36.32	45.48	40.42	**
Received Medicaid	69.13	84.99	76.23	***
Number of children in household				**
1	21.85	14.41	18.52	
2	32.1	32.35	32.21	
3+	46.05	53.24	49.27	
Focal child's age				***
0–2	24.79	15.98	20.84	
3–5	20.84	22.15	21.43	
6–11	32.22	30.68	31.53	
12–17	22.15	31.19	26.2	
Parent's marital status				***
Not married	40.79	30.16	36.03	
Married	40.15	45.88	42.72	
Living with partner	19.07	23.96	21.26	
Parent's age				***
18–29	37.71	14.6	27.36	
30–39	36.46	48.22	41.73	
40–49	17.29	30.66	23.27	
50+	8.54	6.52	7.63	
Parent's education attainment				***
Below high school	22.13	68.04	42.68	
High school degree	41.6	25.22	34.27	
Some college	36.27	6.74	23.05	
Poverty status (percent of FPL)				***
0–50	19.34	22.83	20.90	
50–100	24.46	41.18	31.95	
100–150	20.84	21.29	21.04	
150–200	16.44	10.18	13.64	
200+	18.92	4.53	12.47	
Mother's duration in the US				***
<5 years	—	4.66	2.08	
5–14 years	—	44.68	20.00	
15+ years	—	50.67	22.69	
Born in the US	100	—	55.23	
County implemented 287(g)	31.61	35.04	33.15	
County unemployment rate	8.65 (3.21)	8.60 (3.27)	8.63 (3.26)	
<i>N</i>	2,409	2,586	4,995	

Source: Authors' calculations of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: This table is generated among respondents who have non-missing values in SNAP outcome ($N = 4,995$). Thus, in this table, the sample size is 4,995 for all variables except for WIC ($N = 2,190$), Head Start/state preschool ($N = 526$), and TANF ($N = 4,925$) receipt status, as there are additional missing cases in other outcomes. Significance column shows the statistical significance of differences between US-born citizens and undocumented mothers.

+ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table 2. Full Analysis: Association Between Removal Rates and Safety Net Participation (RQ1)

	WIC	Head Start	TANF	SNAP	Medicaid
Removal rate	0.02 ⁺ (0.01)	0.02 (0.02)	−0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	−0.00 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented Latina	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.07 ⁺ (0.04)	0.00 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
Mean of outcome in treated group	0.69	0.32	0.16	0.45	0.85
<i>N</i>	2,186	534	4,924	4,995	5,051

Source: Authors' calculations of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: CHIS weights are applied. Only the key coefficients are presented, but all models control for parent's education attainment, marital status, age, household poverty status, number of children in the household, child age, county unemployment rate, 287(g) implementation status, year fixed effects, year by mixed-status family fixed effects, county fixed effects, and county by mixed-status family fixed effects.

⁺ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

mixed-status families was not likely influenced by broader factors that discourage involvement in Head Start or state preschool. Regarding other programs, we did not observe significant reductions in participation among children of likely undocumented Latinas relative to those of US-born Latinas (see *Removal rate* × *Undocumented Latina*), nor among the children of US-born Latinas (see *Removal rate*), except in the case of WIC, where we unexpectedly find a small but marginally significant positive association.

Subsequently, we conducted the within-group analysis for likely undocumented Latinas, controlling for mothers' durations in the US (equation 2); table 3 illustrates the findings.

Results are similar to what we find in table 2—a one-unit increase in SC removal rates is marginally significantly ($p < 0.1$) associated with a reduction in Head Start or state preschool program participation among children of likely undocumented Latinas by 7 percentage points. In addition, we continue to find null relationships between SC removal rates and participation in other programs among undocumented Latinas' children.

THE ROLE OF MOTHER'S DURATION IN THE US (RQ2)

Next, based on our preferred specification, we ran separate regressions for each subgroup of undocumented Latinas based on their duration

Table 3. Association Between Removal Rates and Safety Net Participation Among Likely Undocumented Latinas (RQ1)

	WIC	Head Start	TANF	SNAP	Medicaid
Removal rate	0.00 (0.01)	−0.07 ⁺ (0.04)	−0.01 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
<i>N</i>	1,106	181	2,585	2,585	2,590

Source: Authors' calculations of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: CHIS weights are applied. Only the key coefficients are presented, but all models control for mother's duration in the US, parent's education attainment, marital status, age, household poverty status, number of children in the household, child age, county unemployment rate, 287(g) implementation status, year fixed effects, and county fixed effects.

⁺ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

in the US (less than five years, five to fourteen years, and fifteen or more years), comparing each group to children of US-born Latinas. As reflected in table 4, we found evidence that there are greater reductions in citizen children's program participation when likely undocumented mothers lived in the US for less than five years. In panel 1, the coefficient on *Removal rate* $\times$ *Undocumented Latina* shows that a one-unit increase in removal rates led to an 8-percentage-point decrease (a 12 percent reduction based on the mean) in WIC participation among children of undocumented mothers with less than five years relative to US-born Latinas. On the other hand, for those with longer durations, there were no reductions in children's WIC enrollment compared to US-born mothers. Similarly, as indicated in panel 2 and panel 4, a marginal increase in removal rates differentially reduced children's TANF and Medicaid participation among mothers with less than five years in the US relative to US-born mothers by 4 percentage points (a 40 percent reduction based on the mean) and 6 percentage points (a 7 percent reduction based on the mean), respectively. In contrast, such decreases were not observed among mothers with longer durations in the US.⁹ Also, though the patterns are somewhat similar, we do not observe statistically significant greater reductions in SNAP participation among mothers with less than five years in the US compared to US-born mothers.

To better illustrate our findings, we plotted predicted participation rates at different removal rates by the mother's immigration status and durations in the US, using the regression coefficients for each program presented in table 4 (see figure 3). For brevity, we only present graphs for the subgroup model of mothers with less than five years, which corresponds to regression coefficients shown in column 1. Figure

3 shows that predicted participation rates decrease—as removal rates increase—for children of recently arrived likely undocumented Latinas, relative to children of US-born Latinas. It is notable that, at heightened removal rates, children's WIC and Medicaid participation rates among recently arrived Latinas drop below the participation rates among children of US-born Latinas, though the confidence intervals for those estimates overlap. Taken together, these subgroup analyses provide evidence that longer settlement durations may serve as a protective factor in children's safety net participation.

Next, we present within-group analysis (equation 3) to investigate whether undocumented Latina mothers differ from each other in children's program participation based on US settlement durations. Table 5 indicates that a marginal increase in SC removal rates is negatively associated with children's TANF and Medicaid participation among likely undocumented Latina mothers with less than five years in the US by 6 percentage points and 5 percentage points, respectively. See the coefficient on the *Removal rate* row in table 5. On the other hand, the coefficients on *Removal rate* $\times$ *5–14 years* and *Removal rate* $\times$ *15+ years* show that longer-settled Latina mothers are not subject to such reductions in children's TANF and Medicaid participation, as these coefficients nearly or completely offset the negative coefficient on *Removal rate*. Similarly, figure 4, which displays predicted participation rates at varying removal rates by mothers' duration in the US based on the estimates shown in table 5, illustrates that children of mothers with zero to four years in the US seem to be most vulnerable to increases in removal rates in TANF and Medicaid participation. In contrast, for WIC and SNAP participation, we do not observe significant differences in partici-

9. We unexpectedly observe a marginally significant positive coefficient of 0.03 on *Removal rate* $\times$ *Undocumented Latina* in column 3, panel 4 of table 4, indicating that removal rates increase Medicaid participation of children among likely undocumented mothers with fifteen or more years in the US compared to US-born mothers. Although the underlying reason is unclear, one possible explanation is that higher removal rates may prompt long-settled undocumented women to apply for Medicaid to offset income losses. This may occur because fathers, who are more likely to be employed, could be disproportionately affected by higher removal rates. However, the magnitude is small, representing only 3.6 percent of the mean of the fifteen or more years group.

Table 4. Full Analysis: The Role of Mother's Duration in the US in the Association Between Removal Rates and Safety Net Participation (RQ2)

	<5 Years (Versus US-Born)	5–14 Years (Versus US-Born)	15+ Years (Versus US-Born)
Panel 1. WIC participation			
Removal rate	0.02 (0.01)	0.02 ⁺ (0.01)	0.02 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented	−0.08* (0.04)	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.05 (0.03)
Latina			
Mean of outcome among the treated	0.66	0.73	0.62
N	1,144	1,788	1,403
Panel 2. TANF participation			
Removal rate	−0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented	−0.04* (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	−0.00 (0.02)
Latina			
Mean of outcome among the treated	0.10	0.16	0.16
N	2,439	3,554	3,603
Panel 3. SNAP participation			
Removal rate	0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented	−0.03 (0.02)	−0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.02)
Latina			
Mean of outcome among the treated	0.27	0.49	0.44
N	2,511	3,625	3,675
Panel 4. Medicaid participation			
Removal rate	−0.00 (0.01)	−0.00 (0.01)	−0.00 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented	−0.06*** (0.01)	0.01 (0.02)	0.03 ⁺ (0.02)
Latina			
Mean of outcome among the treated	0.81	0.87	0.84
N	2,562	3,677	3,730

Source: Authors' calculations of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Notes: CHIS weights are applied. Each column in each panel indicates a different subgroup model. Only key coefficients of interests are displayed, but all models control for parent's education attainment, marital status, age, household poverty status, number of children in the household, child age, county unemployment rate, 287(g) implementation status, year fixed effects, year by mixed-status family fixed effects, county fixed effects, and county by mixed-status family fixed effects.

⁺ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

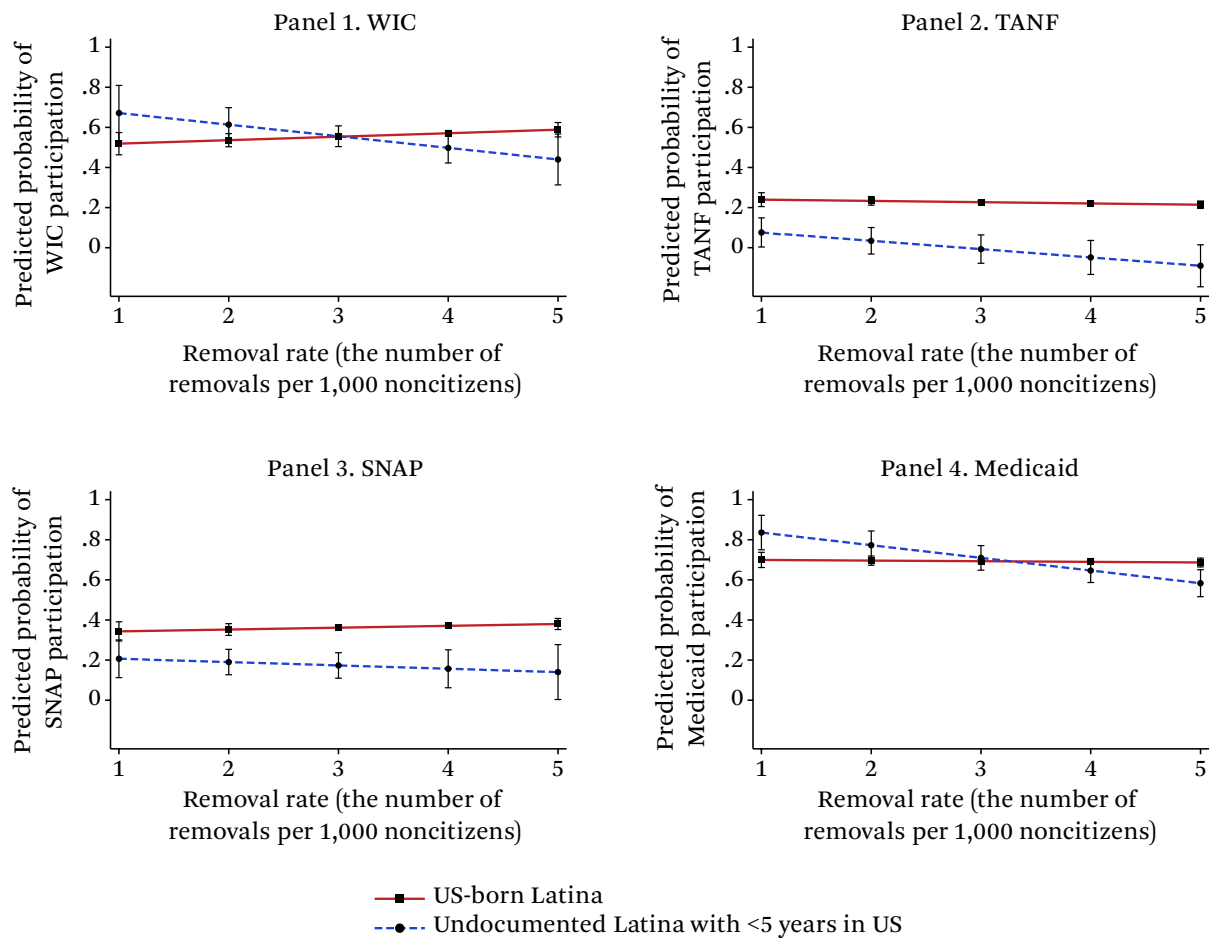
pation rates based on mothers' duration in the US.

FALSIFICATION AND ROBUSTNESS TESTS

Using our preferred specification (that is, full analysis comparing likely undocumented mothers to US-born mothers), we conducted

several falsification tests to examine whether there is any evidence of county-year confounding factors driving our findings on the association between SC removal rates and children's safety net participation. As we observed preliminary evidence ($p < .1$) of a reduction in Head Start and state preschool participation in the full sample, we conducted our tests using this

Figure 3. Predicted Program Participation Rates by SC Removal Rates for Likely Undocumented Latinas with Less than Five Years in the United States and US-Born Latinas



Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: We used the margins command in STATA to calculate the predicted program participation rates. The vertical line indicates 95 percent confidence intervals. The predicted TANF participation rates at the removal rate of three to five should be interpreted with caution since they are below zero, although their confidence intervals overlap with zero. Overall, the decreasing trends of participation rates for all programs provide evidence of reductions in children's program participation among likely undocumented mothers with less than five years in the US.

outcome. First, we considered whether lead-in removal rates (measured one year after the program participation year) are differentially related to the program participation among children of undocumented Latinas, relative to their counterparts with US-born Latina mothers. The lead removal rate can be spuriously correlated with program participation of children of undocumented mothers if the results are generated by unobserved county-year confounding factors that covary with changes in removal rates and program participation. Illustrated in column 1 in table 6, we found that the interac-

tion effect between the lead removal rate and mother's immigration status lacks statistical significance and is opposite in direction (coefficient = 0.02). Second, we examined a placebo sample (children of White US-born citizen mothers) who are unlikely to be affected by SC removal rates. As indicated in column 2 of table 6, we found no evidence of an association between removal rates and Head Start or state preschool participation in the placebo group (coefficient = 0.02), adding confidence to our results. Moreover, we tested if the removal rate is differentially related to demographic charac-

Table 5. The Role of Mother's Duration in the US in the Association Between Removal Rates and Safety Net Participation Among Likely Undocumented Latinas (RQ2)

	WIC	TANF	SNAP	Medicaid
Removal rate	0.00 (0.04)	-0.06*** (0.01)	0.01 (0.03)	-0.05*** (0.01)
Removal rate × 5–14 years (reference: <5 years)	0.00 (0.04)	0.06** (0.02)	-0.00 (0.03)	0.06*** (0.02)
Removal rate × 15+ years (reference: <5 years)	-0.02 (0.04)	0.05** (0.02)	-0.01 (0.04)	0.08*** (0.02)
<i>N</i>	1,106	2,585	2,585	2,590

Source: Authors' calculations of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: CHIS weights are applied. Only the key coefficients are presented, but all models control for mother's duration in the US, parent's education attainment, marital status, age, household poverty status, number of children in the household, child age, county unemployment rate, 287(g) implementation status, year fixed effects, year by duration in the US fixed effects, county fixed effects, and county by duration in the US fixed effects.

+ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

teristics among undocumented Latina mothers compared to US-born mothers. The absence of correlation between removal rates and observable characteristics that are relevant to program participation would alleviate our concerns about the potential endogenous correlation between removal rates and the child's program participation (Watson 2014). As indicated in table 7, there are no significant associations for most variables. Taken together, these analyses suggest that our model specification may reduce bias in the association between SC removal rates and Head Start and state preschool enrollment for children of likely undocumented Latinas.

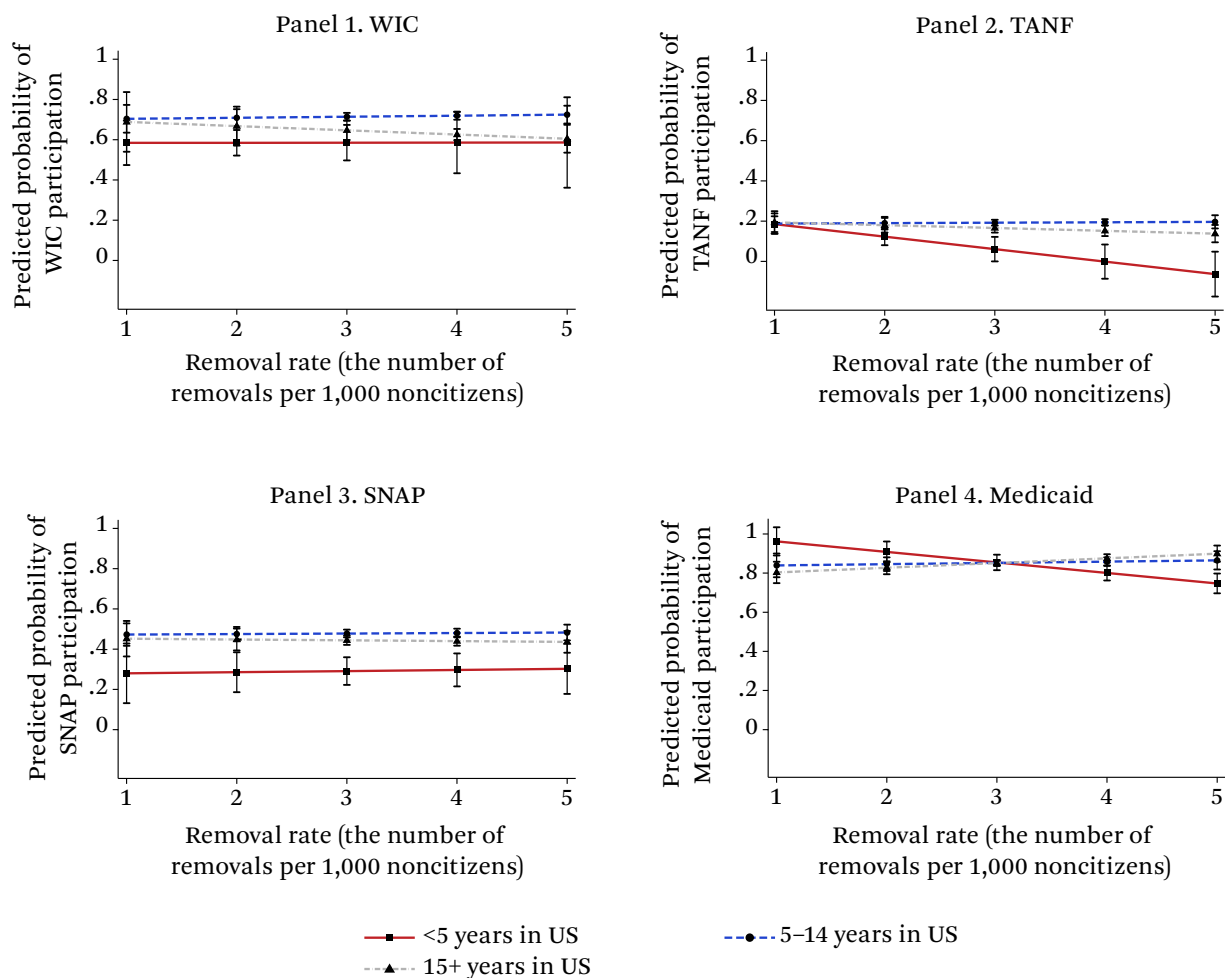
As discussed earlier, we also conducted several robustness tests (see table 6). The magnitude of reduction in the Head Start and state preschool program participation is similar (with some reduced precision) when the 2015 and 2017 survey years are removed (column 3), when the 2019 survey year is removed (column 4), and when the sample is limited to families with income below 200 percent of the FPL (col-

umn 5). These results allay concern about missing data in outcome and US duration variables. In addition, we analyzed whether our primary findings are driven by small counties by removing the twenty counties with the smallest populations in California.¹⁰ The findings are unchanged with this adjustment (column 6). Moreover, we used an alternative removal rate measure based on monthly SC removal rates in the two months prior to the survey month and year. Monthly removals capture more recent shocks, while our primary measure—total removals across all months—reflects overall exposure to deportation threats. Because of this, the effect size may be larger when using the monthly removal rate. On the contrary, precision could decrease as there is more variability in monthly removal rates and it is difficult to generalize or predict which month's removal rates influence a mother's decision to enroll her child in a program. Expectedly, according to column 7, we found a much larger, but imprecise, coefficient (coefficient = -0.36) with the monthly removal rate.¹¹ Lastly, we checked

10. They include Alpine, Sierra, Modoc, Trinity, Mono, Mariposa, Inyo, Plumas, Colusa, Del Norte, Glenn, Lassen, Amador, Siskiyou, Calaveras, Tuolumne, San Benito, Tehama, Lake, and Yuba.

11. We also used the total removals over the three-month and six-month periods leading up to and including the survey month and year. Using these measures, we find substantively similar results in both RQ1 and RQ2, except

Figure 4. Predicted Program Participation Rates by SC Removal Rates for Likely Undocumented Latinas with Different Durations in the United States



Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: We used the margins command in STATA to calculate the predicted program participation rates. The vertical line indicates 95 percent confidence intervals. The predicted TANF participation rates at the removal rate of three to five should be interpreted with caution since they are below zero, although those estimates lack statistical significance. The predicted means of children's program participation rates among undocumented mothers with less than five years in the US differ between figure 3 and figure 4. This discrepancy arises from using different samples: US-born mothers and undocumented mothers with less than five years in the US versus only undocumented mothers comprising different groups of US durations. These differences result in different coefficients for all variables and, therefore, differences in predicted means. However, the confidence intervals of predicted means for the less than five years group at a given removal rate overlap between the two figures, indicating that they are not statistically distinguishable.

whether our findings are robust to excluding July and August. To the extent that the local Head Start and state preschool programs do not operate during the summer months, there

could be a seasonality effect on participation in these programs, while such an effect is unlikely for the other programs we examine. We find qualitatively similar results (see appendix

in our RQ2 analysis of WIC participation, for which the findings are somewhat sensitive to the specific measures used. This sensitivity may partly stem from the relatively smaller sample sizes of undocumented Latinas with fewer than five years in the US in WIC analyses, compared to their sample sizes in analyses of other programs.

Table 6. Falsification and Robustness Tests for the Head Start and State Preschool Program Participation (RQ1)

	Lead Removal	White US-Born	No 2015/2017	No 2019	<200% FPL	No Small	Monthly Removal
Removal rate × Undocumented Latina	0.02 (0.05)	0.02 (0.01)	-0.07 (0.04)	-0.06 (0.04)	-0.07 ⁺ (0.04)	-0.07 ⁺ (0.04)	-0.36 (0.29)
<i>N</i>	534	416	481	487	457	507	534

Source: Authors' calculations of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: Each column is a separate regression. The monthly removal rate is merged with the CHIS sample by two months prior to the survey month/year. CHIS weights are applied. Only the key coefficient on the interaction term between removal rate measure and mother's immigration status is displayed. All models control for parent's education attainment, marital status, age, household poverty status, number of children in the household, child age, county unemployment rate, 287(g) implementation status, year fixed effects, year by mixed-status family fixed effects, county fixed effects, and county by mixed-status family fixed effects.

⁺ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table 7. Test of Correlation Between Removal Rates and Family Characteristics

	Removal Rate × Undocumented Latina
High school degree or below (reference: some college)	0.00 (0.02)
Married (reference: not married or living with partner)	0.04 (0.05)
3 or more children in household (reference: 1 or 2)	-0.08 ⁺ (0.04)
Focal child 3–5 years old (reference: 0–2 years old)	0.06 (0.05)
Adult age	0.04 (0.71)
Employed (reference: not employed)	-0.01 (0.05)
<100% of FPL	-0.03 (0.04)

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: Each row indicates a different model. We used the same equation indicated in the empirical strategy section and replaced the program participation outcome with the co-variables listed in the first column. All regression models control for year fixed effects, year by mixed-status family fixed effects, county fixed effects, and county by mixed-status family fixed effects, but do not control for child and family characteristics. Only the main coefficient on the interaction between *Removal rate × Undocumented Latina mothers* is shown in the table. $N = 534$.

⁺ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

table A.6), with increased precision and larger effect sizes (from -0.07 to -0.11), suggesting that seasonality is not spuriously driving the reduction in the Head Start and state preschool participation.

Similarly, we conducted the above robustness tests for our findings in RQ2. Overall, the results point toward the same conclusions—despite small differences in coefficient magnitudes and precision. Children of likely undocumented Latinas with less than five years in the US experience greater reductions in participation rates across various programs compared to children of US-born Latinas, while children of undocumented Latinas with longer durations show no differences in program participation relative to their US-born counterparts. Results are presented in table 8.

DISCUSSION

In this study, we found evidence that higher SC removal rates are associated with modest to large reductions in children's TANF, Medicaid, and WIC participation among likely undocumented mothers with less than five years of US residency relative to US-born Latinas. Such reductions were not observed among likely undocumented mothers with longer US durations. When undocumented mothers were compared to each other based on their duration in the US, we continued to find larger reductions in rates of TANF and Medicaid receipt among children of recently arrived mothers. These results could reflect that undocumented parents who have spent more time in the US are more familiar with the US safety net and immigration enforcement policies, leading to selective engagement with the state rather than completely eschewing enrollment (Asad 2023).

These findings are of concern given that children from mixed-status families are more likely to live in poverty, as shown in table 1, and thus may have greater need for safety net benefits, which aim to mitigate economic hardships and promote the health and well-being of socioeconomically disadvantaged families and children. Indeed, research suggests that participating in these programs has such effects. Research from the Head Start Impact Study, the nationwide randomized controlled trial of the Head Start program, demonstrates

that Spanish-speaking dual language learners were one of the subgroups that consistently experienced larger gains from Head Start participation (Lee et al. 2021). Early exposure to Medicaid positively affects health in later childhood, as well as education and adult earnings (Currie et al. 2008; Brown et al. 2015). Studies also find that WIC participation is associated with improved birth outcomes and better developmental outcomes in the first two years of life (Venkataramani et al. 2022; Guan et al. 2021). SNAP is positively associated with child health, cognitive development and attention skills, and better health and economic outcomes in adulthood (East 2020; Hong and Henly 2020; Hoynes et al. 2016). While the TANF program is small compared to the caseload sizes of our other selected programs, participants are often connected to other important resources during TANF participation, such as SNAP, childcare, and Supplemental Security Income (Zedlewski 2012; Wamhoff and Wiseman 2006). Based on these studies, our findings suggest that future work should examine whether elevated deportation threat negatively affects the health and well-being of citizen children in mixed-status families, especially those with more recently arrived parents.

We find preliminary but not definitive evidence that SC removal rates may influence Head Start or state preschool program enrollment, consistent with research by Robert Santillano and colleagues (2020). On the other hand, we did not find reductions in WIC, SNAP, Medicaid, or TANF participation among overall Latine mixed-status families. This may be because parents view the Head Start or state preschool services as supplementary to their child's and family's well-being, while programs like SNAP, WIC, Medicaid, and TANF are perceived as essential for basic needs. Hence, under heightened deportation threat, parents may be less willing to risk exposure by enrolling their child in ECE programs, as it requires ongoing parental involvement. In addition, California's supportive policy climate for immigrants may act as a protective factor, reducing the potential for reduced participation among mixed-status families. This may explain why we did not find an association between SC removal rates and participation in SNAP, WIC,

Table 8. Robustness Checks for RQ2

	<5 Years (Versus US-Born)	5–14 Years (Versus US-Born)	15+ Years (Versus US-Born)
	Removal Rate × Undocumented Latina		
Panel 1. WIC participation			
No 2015/2017	−0.08 ⁺ (0.04)	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.05 (0.03)
No 2019	−0.07 [*] (0.04)	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.05 (0.03)
<200% of FPL	−0.08 [*] (0.04)	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.05 (0.03)
No small counties	−0.08 [*] (0.04)	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.05 (0.03)
Monthly removal	−0.49 (0.44)	0.03 (0.20)	−0.20 (0.24)
Panel 2. TANF participation			
No 2015/2017	−0.04 [*] (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.02)
No 2019	−0.04 ⁺ (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	0.00 (0.02)
<200% of FPL	−0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	0.00 (0.02)
No small counties	−0.04 ⁺ (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.02)
Monthly removal	−0.34 [*] (0.15)	−0.08 (0.08)	−0.02 (0.11)
Panel 3. SNAP participation			
No 2015/2017	−0.02 (0.02)	0.00 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.02)
No 2019	−0.02 (0.02)	−0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.02)
<200% of FPL	−0.03 (0.03)	−0.01 (0.01)	−0.01 (0.02)
No small counties	−0.03 (0.02)	−0.01 (0.01)	−0.02 (0.02)
Monthly removal	−0.13 (0.22)	−0.22 [*] (0.09)	−0.06 (0.13)
Panel 4. Medicaid participation			
No 2015/2017	−0.05 ^{***} (0.01)	0.01 (0.02)	0.04 ⁺ (0.02)
No 2019	−0.06 ^{***} (0.01)	0.00 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)
<200% of FPL	−0.05 ^{***} (0.01)	0.01 (0.02)	0.03 ⁺ (0.02)
No small counties	−0.06 ^{***} (0.01)	0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)
Monthly removal	−0.33 [*] (0.14)	0.03 (0.11)	0.19 (0.17)

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data (UCLA Center for Health Policy Research 2016).

Note: CHIS weights are applied. Each column in each panel indicates a different subgroup model, and each row is a different robustness check for a given outcome. Only the key coefficient—*Removal rate × Undocumented Latina*—is displayed in this table, but all models control for parent's education attainment, marital status, age, household poverty status, number of children in the household, child age, county unemployment rate, 287(g) implementation status, year fixed effects, year by mixed-status family fixed effects, county fixed effects, and county by mixed-status family fixed effects.

⁺ $p < .1$; ^{*} $p < .05$; ^{**} $p < .01$; ^{***} $p < .001$

Medicaid, and TANF among children of undocumented or US-born Latinas in the full sample, while other studies at the national level have documented chilling effects on these programs among mixed-status families and Latine citizens (Alsan and Yang 2022; Vargas and Pirog 2016; Pedraza and Zhu 2015).

Our analyses by mothers' duration in the US add nuance to these findings. Here, we found that SC removal rates are negatively associated with the child's participation in WIC, Medicaid, and TANF programs among recently arrived undocumented Latinas relative to US-born Latinas, while children whose mothers have longer durations of US residency did not differ meaningfully from children of US-born mothers. When undocumented Latinas were compared to each other, unlike longer-settled undocumented Latinas, children of undocumented Latinas with less than five years of residency experienced reductions in TANF and Medicaid participation—again suggesting that recently arrived mothers may experience particular vulnerabilities to changes in removal rates. These findings may reflect that the breadth and scope of social networks change over time, a key factor in knowledge growth and information access. Interfacing with government through schools, policing, and medical systems over time, parents may also experience increased familiarity and develop improved skills in navigating threat within the bureaucratic face of the state (Marrow 2009). Such accumulated experience and learning may explain seemingly small or no associations between SC removal rates and safety net receipt among children of undocumented mothers with longer residency in the US.

However, the results vary by program. For WIC, we found no decline among children of recently arrived mothers themselves or among longer-settled mothers. Combining this finding with results from the full analysis comparing recently arrived mothers to US-born mothers, we conclude that, although recently arrived mothers may be more negatively affected by removal rates compared to US-born mothers, the difference is not large enough to suggest a re-

duction in WIC enrollment among their children in absolute terms. That might be because WIC is one of the few safety net programs accessible to all undocumented immigrants with children; in fact, the children of noncitizen parents participate in WIC at higher rates and for longer durations than the children of citizen parents. It is also common for WIC to be administered through nonprofit clinics and public health programs, which may be perceived as less threatening to mixed-status families (Bitler et al. 2021). For SNAP, the reason is less clear. One possible explanation is that California's CalFresh portal, the state's SNAP application system, allows a fully remote application and phone interview process, potentially reducing exposure to government agencies and mitigating fears.¹² However, since similar remote access options are available in other programs, such as Medicaid, further research is necessary on this topic. Future research would also benefit from investigating which factors—such as identity verification models, documentation requirements, or recertification intervals—help alleviate or increase fears and the chilling effects of deportation threats.

There are several limitations to this study. While our findings provide evidence of reduced program participation as removal rates increase, there may be alternative explanations. For instance, if high SC removal rates prompted undocumented Latinas to relocate to a different local area within California, they may have experienced difficulty finding new Head Start or state preschool programs with available space or services appropriate for their family situations and needs. If so, this disruption could lead to children dropping out of the Head Start and state preschool program, while such a possibility is unlikely for other programs. Second, although SC removal rates directly measure deportability under the SC program, they may not fully capture the broader effect of fear from apprehensions, which occur before the actual deportation or removal takes place. Future research could consider using county-level apprehension data to examine whether results change or remain similar to

12. See <https://www.ca.gov/departments/178/services/60/>.

our study. In addition, although we captured likely undocumented mothers more accurately than other research by leveraging the LPR status of noncitizens, there could still be measurement error. For example, noncitizens can still be documented if they are visa holders. Moreover, although we provide suggestive evidence that our analytical strategy may reduce bias in the association between SC removal rates and children's safety net receipt, future research should employ a strategy that allows for estimating a plausibly causal effect of deportation threat—such as the staggered adoption of SC across regions—to assess whether the effect on program participation varies by mothers' duration in the US. Finally, due to data limitations,¹³ it was beyond this study's scope to comprehensively analyze whether reductions in program participation vary across time periods with different political, economic, and public health characteristics (for example, by presidential administrations). However, preliminary analyses of the associations between removal rates and SNAP, Medicaid, and TANF receipt status by the

Obama and Trump administrations suggest similar relationships between those periods, as shown in appendix table A.4.

Overall, this study extends our understanding of how immigration enforcement relates to safety net participation by suggesting that routine, localized deportation threat, measured through the intensity of removal rates under the SC program, is associated with reductions in enrollment in some public benefit programs, even in a state with inclusive immigrant policies. Bridging the literatures on immigrant settlement duration with system avoidance, this study also highlights that citizen children of recently arrived undocumented mothers may be disproportionately influenced by increases in deportation threat. Our findings suggest that policymakers aiming to improve take-up among children in mixed-status households consider proactive and targeted outreach, multilingual program navigation assistance, and culturally competent public service infrastructure that explicitly address the needs of recently arrived mixed-status families.

13. For WIC and Head Start or state preschool outcomes, we lacked statistical power to examine differential chilling effects across different time periods, which prevented us from conducting an analysis that incorporates all of our outcomes.

APPENDIX A

Table A.1. Demographic Characteristics of Survey Respondents with and Without Missing Values in WIC, SNAP, TANF Receipt Status and Durations in the United States

	Not missing (91.39%) Percent / Mean (SD)	Missing (8.61%) Percent / Mean (SD)	Significance
Number of children in household			
1	18.19	16.44	
2	32.43	29.29	
3+	49.37	54.27	
Focal child's age			***
0-2	20.67	20.54	
3-5	21.23	27.4	
6-11	31.27	44.43	
12-17	26.84	7.63	
Parent's marital status			
Not married	35.87	33.2	
Married	42.91	46.39	
Living with partner	21.22	20.41	
Parent's age			+
18-29	27.1	22.75	
30-39	41.41	52.33	
40-49	23.74	19.33	
50+	7.74	5.59	
Parent's education attainment			+
Below high school	43.11	46.8	
High school degree	33.92	37.74	
Some college	22.97	15.46	
Poverty status			+
0-50% of FPL	20.7	26.41	
50-100% of FPL	32.23	31.88	
100-150% of FPL	21.26	14.42	
150-200% of FPL	13.54	10.93	
200%+ of FPL	12.27	16.35	
<i>N</i>	4,928	350	

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data.

Note: This table is generated among children of US-born and likely undocumented Latinas who do not have a college degree and have family income below 300 percent of FPL ($N = 5,278$). The "missing" group includes cases that have missing values in any of the following variables: WIC receipt, TANF receipt, SNAP receipt, and years lived in the US. Missing values in the Head Start/state preschool program outcome are not included in the missing group, because of the different nature of its missingness. Most of the missing values in the Head Start/state preschool program variable consist of families who use childcare fewer than ten hours per week as this question is only asked to those with regular childcare. Significance column shows the statistical significance of the difference between the two groups, using chi-square tests.

+ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table A.2. Sample Characteristics by Mother's Immigration Status and Duration in the United States

	Undocumented Latina, <5 Years Percent / Mean (SD)	Undocumented Latina, 5–14 Years Percent / Mean (SD)	Undocumented Latina, 15+ Years Percent / Mean (SD)	US-born Latina Percent / Mean (SD)	Significance
County removal rate	3.95 (2.55)	3.59 (2.79)	2.98 (2.45)	3.52 (3.33)	**
Received WIC	65.73	73.19	61.87	55.54	**
Received TANF	9.86	15.91	16.25	22.22	*
Received SNAP	27.18	48.53	44.47	36.32	**
Received Medicaid	80.84	86.49	84.05	69.13	***
Number of children in household					**
1	26.26	10.68	16.62	21.85	
2	28.73	34.27	30.99	32.1	
3+	45.01	55.06	52.39	46.05	
Focal child's age					***
0–2	33.98	21.82	9.17	24.79	
3–5	22.26	32.19	13.29	20.84	
6–11	12.59	32.5	30.74	32.22	
12–17	31.17	13.49	46.8	22.15	
Parent's marital status					***
Not married	48.54	28.47	29.96	40.79	
Married	45.51	45.18	46.54	40.15	
Living with partner	5.95	26.35	23.51	19.07	
Parent's age					***
18–29	28.46	24.85	4.3	37.71	
30–39	48.39	52.38	44.53	36.46	
40–49	12.79	17.87	43.58	17.29	
50+	10.36	4.9	7.59	8.54	
Parent's education attainment					***
Below high school	53.49	68.24	69.19	22.13	
High school degree	34.24	24.98	24.61	41.6	
Some college	12.27	6.77	6.2	36.27	
Poverty status					***
0–50% of FPL	20.09	22.43	23.43	19.34	
50–100% of FPL	51.97	40.64	40.66	24.47	
100–150% of FPL	13.63	21.14	22.12	20.84	
150–200% of FPL	13.00	11.54	8.72	16.44	
200%+ of FPL	1.30	4.24	5.07	18.92	
County implemented 287(g)	28.08	37.27	33.71	31.61	
County unemployment rate	8.18 (3.46)	9.24 (3.25)	8.07 (3.16)	8.65 (3.21)	***
<i>N</i>	103	1,217	1,266	2,409	

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data.

Note: This table is generated among respondents who have non-missing values in SNAP outcome ($N = 4,995$). Thus, in this table, the sample size is 4,995 for all variables except for WIC ($N = 2,190$), Head Start/state pre-school ($N = 526$), and TANF ($N = 4,925$) receipt status, as there are additional missing cases in other outcomes. Significance column shows the statistical significance of the difference between the four groups. We used chi-square tests for categorical variables and one-way ANOVA for continuous variables.

* $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table A.3. Regression Results from the Full Analysis of the Association Between Removal Rates and Safety Net Participation (RQ1)

	WIC	Head Start	TANF	SNAP	Medicaid
Removal rate	0.02 ⁺ (0.01)	0.02 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	-0.00 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented Latina	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.07 ⁺ (0.04)	0.00 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
Undocumented Latina (reference: citizen mothers)	0.29*** (0.04)	-0.15 (0.27)	0.13* (0.05)	-0.13* (0.05)	-0.05 (0.06)
County's implementation status of 287(g)	0.17*** (0.04)	-0.15 (0.10)	-0.04 (0.03)	0.01 (0.04)	0.10** (0.03)
County's unemployment rate	0.05 (0.03)	0.06 (0.06)	0.04* (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.00 (0.02)
High school degree (reference: below high school)	-0.05 (0.04)	0.03 (0.07)	-0.05 ⁺ (0.03)	-0.05 ⁺ (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)
Some college (reference: below high school)	-0.05 (0.06)	-0.01 (0.09)	-0.02 (0.04)	-0.04 ⁺ (0.02)	-0.09*** (0.02)
Married (reference: unmarried)	0.05 (0.06)	0.03 (0.06)	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.13*** (0.03)	-0.08*** (0.02)
Living with partner (reference: unmarried)	0.04 (0.05)	0.00 (0.09)	-0.07 ⁺ (0.04)	-0.03 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)
50–100% of FPL (reference: <50% of FPL)	-0.05 (0.04)	-0.16* (0.08)	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.08*** (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)
100–150% of FPL (reference: <50% of FPL)	-0.10** (0.03)	-0.10 (0.07)	-0.18*** (0.02)	-0.27*** (0.03)	-0.14*** (0.03)
150–200% of FPL (reference: <50% of FPL)	-0.05 (0.05)	-0.13 ⁺ (0.08)	-0.24*** (0.03)	-0.45*** (0.04)	-0.27*** (0.04)
200%+ of FPL (reference: <50% of FPL)	-0.24*** (0.06)	-0.17* (0.08)	-0.32*** (0.03)	-0.52*** (0.02)	-0.45*** (0.03)
Two children (reference: one child)	-0.04 (0.04)	0.01 (0.04)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.03 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)
Three or more children (reference: one child)	-0.03 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.09)	0.00 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	0.01 (0.02)
Parent's age: 30–39 (reference: 18–29)	-0.04 (0.04)	-0.08 (0.06)	-0.07** (0.02)	-0.05 ⁺ (0.03)	-0.11*** (0.03)
Parent's age: 40–49 (reference: 18–29)	-0.18*** (0.04)	0.20* (0.09)	-0.10** (0.03)	-0.10* (0.04)	-0.14*** (0.04)
Parent's age: 50+ (reference: 18–29)	0.05 (0.11)	0.07 (0.13)	-0.03 (0.04)	-0.05 (0.05)	-0.04 (0.05)
Child age: 3–5 (reference: 0–2)	-0.35*** (0.02)	0.37*** (0.09)	0.01 (0.02)	0.05* (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)
Child age: 6–11 (reference: 0–2)			0.02 (0.03)	0.05 (0.04)	-0.04** (0.02)
Child age: 12–7 (reference: 0–2)			0.01 (0.03)	0.00 (0.03)	-0.07*** (0.02)
Mean of outcome in treated group	0.69	0.32	0.16	0.45	0.85
N	2,186	534	4,924	4,995	5,051

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data.

Note: CHIS weights are applied. In addition to the control variables shown in the table, we also adjusted for the set of fixed effect described in the empirical strategy section.

⁺ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table A.4. Association Between Removal Rates and Safety Net Participation by Obama and Trump Administrations

	Obama (2009–2016)	Trump (2017–2019)
Panel 1. TANF		
Removal rate	–0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented Latina	0.01 (0.01)	0.05 (0.14)
<i>N</i>	4314	610
Panel 2. SNAP		
Removal rate	0.00 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented Latina	–0.00 (0.01)	–0.02 (0.14)
	4314	680
Panel 3. Medicaid		
Removal rate	0.00 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)
Removal rate × Undocumented Latina	0.01 (0.02)	–0.02 (0.10)
	4,325	725

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data.

Note: CHIS weights are applied. Only the coefficient on the interaction term between removal rate measure and mother's immigration status is displayed. Each panel indicates separate regressions on a given outcome and columns also indicate different subgroups. Models control for all control variables.

+ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table A.5. Sample Characteristics by Mother's Immigration Status in the Head Start/State Preschool Program Sample

	US-Born Citizen (70.26%) Percent / Mean (SD)	Undocumented (29.74%) Percent / Mean (SD)	Full Sample Percent / Mean (SD)	Significance
County removal rate	3.03 (2.17)	3.49 (2.52)	3.16 (2.29)	
Received WIC	48.64	68.82	54.76	*
Attended Head Start or state preschool program	30.24	31.69	30.67	
Received TANF	22.65	7.17	17.82	***
Received SNAP	32.01	34.81	32.86	
Received Medicaid	66.74	82.86	71.53	*
Number of children in household				
1	28.41	15.31	24.51	
2	32	31.64	31.89	
3+	39.6	53.05	43.6	
Focal child's age				
0-2	44.62	35.2	41.82	
3-5	55.38	64.8	58.18	
Parent's marital status				
Not married	40.58	34.79	38.86	
Married	35.73	40.96	37.28	
Living with partner	23.7	24.25	23.86	*
Parent's age				
18-29	54.87	30.68	47.67	
30-39	35.52	48.74	39.45	
40-49	6.52	13.29	8.54	
50+	3.08	7.29	4.33	
Parent's educational attainment				
Below high school	10.24	60.82	25.28	***
High school degree	40.25	36.38	39.1	
Some college	49.52	2.8	35.62	
Poverty status				
0-50% of FPL	16.63	13.78	15.78	***
50-100% of FPL	18.15	51.31	28.01	
100-150% of FPL	21.03	20.05	20.74	
150-200% of FPL	18.78	11.79	16.7	
200%+ of FPL	25.41	3.06	18.76	
Mother's duration in the US				
<5 years	0	6.4	1.9	***
5-14 years	0	70.97	21.11	
15+ years	0	22.63	6.73	
Born in the US	100	0	70.26	
County implemented 287(g)	33.75	34.89	34.09	
County unemployment rate	8.64 (3.04)	8.99 (3.27)	8.74 (3.12)	
N	345	189	534	

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data.

Note: This table is generated among respondents who have non-missing values in Head Start outcome ($N = 534$). Thus, in this table, the sample size is 534 for all variables except for WIC ($N = 521$), SNAP ($N = 521$), and TANF ($N = 511$) receipt status, as there are additional missing cases in other outcomes. Significance column shows the statistical significance of the difference between US-born citizen and undocumented mothers. We used chi-square tests for categorical variables and one-way ANOVA for continuous variables.

* $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Table A.6. Association Between Removal Rates and Head Start or State Preschool Program Participation Without July and August

	Head Start or State Preschool Program
Removal rate	0.02 (0.02)
Removal rate × Undocumented Latina	-0.11*** (0.03)

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data.

Note: CHIS weights are applied. Only the key coefficients are presented, but the model controls for parent's education attainment, marital status, and age, household poverty status, number of children in the household, child age, county unemployment rate and 287(g) implementation status, year fixed effects, year by mixed-status family fixed effects, county fixed effects, and county by mixed-status family fixed effects.

+ $p < .1$; * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

APPENDIX B

Table B.1 shows a breakdown of missingness in our sample sizes for each outcome.

Table B.1. Breakdown of Missing Cases in Sample Sizes

	Low-Income Latinas with Some College or Less with a Child Under Age Six or Age Eighteen	Removing Missing Cases in the Outcome	Removing Missing Cases in the US Duration	Removing Counties with Few Individuals (No Variation over Time)
WIC	2,319	2,296	2,190	2,186
Head Start/state preschool	2,319	565	539	534
TANF	5,278	5,123	4,928	4,924
SNAP	5,278	5,222	4,998	4,995
Medicaid	5,278	5,278	5,054	5,051

Source: Authors' calculation of CHIS data.

Note: This table shows a breakdown of missing cases by each category. There are $N = 1,754$ missing cases in the Head Start/state preschool variable because this question is only asked to those who have regular childcare for at least ten hours per week.

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De Facto Deportation from the United States to Mexico, 2015–2020



ERIN R. HAMILTON, CLAUDIA MASFERRER, ANGELITA REPETTO,
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De facto deportation is emigration to accompany a deported person, typically a nuclear family member. We study the recent de facto deportation of children, spouses, and parents of people deported from the United States to Mexico. We identify, quantify, and describe the characteristics of de facto deported people and compare them to those who migrated for other reasons using 2020 Mexican Census data. We also analyze data from interviews with returned migrants in Mexico City to describe experiences of de facto deportation. We estimate there were more than eleven thousand people de facto deported from the US to Mexico between 2015 and 2020. Our analysis shows the predominance of women among de facto deported adults, suggesting a strong gendering of family migration after deportation. Interviews reveal the importance of in-person caretaking in decisions about de facto deportation.

Keywords: de facto deportation, return migration, family, children, immigration policy, United States, Mexico

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Hamilton, Erin R., Claudia Masferrer, Angelita Repetto, and Nicole Denier. 2025. "De Facto Deportation from the United States to Mexico, 2015–2020." *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 176–95. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.08>. This work is supported by a grant from the National Institutes of Health (R03HD107298); the UC MEXUS-CONACYT Collaborative Grants via the University of California and the Consejo Nacional de Ciencia y Tecnología de México; a Fulbright-García Robles Scholarship; a grant from the UC Davis Academic Senate Committee on Research; the Seminar on Migration, Inequality, and Public Policies; and the Program of Postdoctoral Scholarships at El Colegio de México. The qualitative data were collected, coded, and analyzed by Nicole Denier, Francisco Flores Peña, Erin Hamilton, Claudia Masferrer, Gabriela Pinillos, Anilú Tomas, and Agnieszka Wieczorek. Direct correspondence to: Erin R. Hamilton, at erhamilton@ucdavis.edu, One Shields Avenue, Davis, CA 95616, United States. Claudia Masferrer at cmasferrer@colmex.mx, Carretera Picacho Ajusco 20, Col. Ampliación Fuentes del Pedregal, C.P. 14110, Tlalpan, Ciudad de México, Mexico. Angelita Repetto, at arepetto@msu.edu, 433A Berkey Hall, 509 E. Circle Drive East Lansing, MI 48823, United States. Nicole Denier at nicole.denier@colby.edu, 4710 Mayflower Hill Waterville, Maine 04901, United States.

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Major changes to the United States immigration law and policy since 1986 have led to large numbers of deportations of long-term, settled immigrants from the US (Golash-Boza 2015; Massey et al. 2016; Schultheis and Ruiz Soto 2017). Long-term, settled immigrants often have families in the US; in these cases, deportation causes the international separation of families. According to reports filed with the US Congress by the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) every year since 2009, the US government has deported tens of thousands of parents of children who live in the US (Capps et al. 2015; DHS 2016a, 2016b, 2016c, 2017a, 2017b, 2018, 2019a, 2019b). The number of deportations of people who have spouses or parents in the US is unknown but presumably also large.

While many families who experience the deportation of a family member remain separated, some reunify (Andrews 2023; Dreby 2015; Enriquez 2020; Valdivia 2021; Zayas 2015). When the US government departs a person away from their family in the US, the family has two options for reunification: The deported person can reenter the US, or the family can emigrate to the country of deportation (typically the country of origin, or nationality, of the deported person). These post-deportation outcomes have significant consequences for the deported person and their family. Reentry to the US after deportation can involve significant criminal and immigration penalties if the previously deported migrant is again apprehended by US immigration agents. Even if they are not apprehended, they experience what Carolina Valdivia (2025, this issue) calls “hyper-illegality.” The alternative to reentry is family migration to the country of deportation to accompany or reunite with a deported person, which is called *de facto deportation* (Kanstroom 2007; Zayas 2015). Under current US immigration law, *de facto deportation* presents a family facing separation by deportation with the only opportunity to remain together without the threat of further US legal entanglement.

A small body of research studies the scale and experiences of *de facto deportation*, focusing largely on children *de facto* deported to Mexico (Barros Nock 2019; Boehm 2016;

Caldwell 2019; Hamilton et al. 2023; Masferrer et al. 2024; Zayas 2015). One study estimated that a large share of US-born children living in Mexico in 2018—about one in seven—were there due to a parent’s deportation (Hamilton et al. 2023). Other studies have focused on the outcomes of children who have been *de facto* deported to Mexico. This research finds that children who experienced *de facto* deportation face socioeconomic hardship, schooling delays and challenges, and mental health problems (Boehm 2016; Caldwell 2019; Hamilton et al. 2023; Rodríguez-Cruz 2023; Zayas 2015; Zayas et al. 2024). These outcomes arguably emerge from the forced nature of *de facto* deportation, which requires families to emigrate from the US to preserve family togetherness and avoid legal entanglement (Zayas 2015).

In this article, we build on the emerging body of research on *de facto* deportation with an overview and update. We focus on *de facto* deportation to Mexico: how it emerged, how many people (and who) have been recently *de facto* deported to Mexico, why some families emigrate whereas others remain separated, and what questions remain unanswered. We present new results from the 2020 Mexican Census (hereafter “the Census”), giving a more recent estimate of the number of US-born children in Mexico due to *de facto* deportation from the US, as well as the first estimate of the number of *de facto* deported Mexican-born children, spouses, and parents in Mexico in 2020. We then compare the socioeconomic characteristics of *de facto* deported children and adults to those who migrated from the US to Mexico for other reasons to understand the circumstances that they face in Mexico. We find that more than ten thousand people were *de facto* deported from the US to Mexico between 2015 and 2020, including more than six thousand US citizens, almost 90 percent of them children (INEGI 2020).

We also analyze data from interviews with returned migrants in Mexico City to describe the experiences of *de facto* deportation to Mexico more fully. These interviews allow us to understand and contextualize the experiences of former US migrants who lived in the US in non-citizen status and returned to live in Mexico

City by 2019 (Masferrer et al. 2025). Among them, we discover a common pattern of family separation after parental deportation, as well as instances of *de facto* deportation. We share the stories of Carla, Lety, and Olivia, people who faced their own or a family member's deportation and were *de facto* deported or separated from their family as a result of deportation. We do not use these data to represent the population of *de facto* deported people or deported parents. Rather, our goal is instead to begin to understand a key question that the research has not yet addressed, which is when and why *de facto* deportation occurs, as opposed to forced family separation or reunification in the US. From the qualitative data, we learn that *de facto* deportation occurred in cases when deportation threatened the family's ability to provide in-person caregiving for dependent children, but decisions about migration for in-person caregiving for children depended on other family dynamics.

De facto deportation represents one important way that US immigration policy reaches people, families, and communities beyond the deported person. *De facto* deportation also reveals how US immigration policy extends beyond the borders of the US to shape the lives of people forced to live abroad to preserve family togetherness. As we will explain next, *de facto* deportation is not an inevitable outcome of immigration law. It emerged from the particular historical circumstances of US immigration policy since 1986.

THE EMERGENCE OF DE FACTO DEPORTATION FROM THE US TO MEXICO

De facto deportation from the US to Mexico is the outcome of US laws and policies created to manage undocumented migration since 1986. It began with the 1986 US Immigration Reform and Control Act (IRCA). As research on US immigration law and Mexico-US migration has shown, IRCA was a response to earlier failures and gaps in US immigration law (Bean et al. 1987, 1990; Massey and Pren 2012; Massey et al. 2016). In 1964, the US terminated the short-term labor migration program between Mexico and the US, the Bracero Program, without a replacement to account for the labor relation-

ships developed during the program. Shortly thereafter, in 1968, the US Congress introduced the first limits to legal immigration from the Western Hemisphere. These policies transformed a circular, legal migration flow between Mexico and the US in the 1950s and early 1960s into a circular, undocumented flow in the 1970s and 1980s (Massey and Pren 2012; Massey et al. 2016). The 1986 IRCA sought to address undocumented migration with a three-pronged approach: amnesty for the resident undocumented population, regulations to prevent the employment of undocumented people, and border control to prevent undocumented entry. None of IRCA's approaches curtailed undocumented migration, and the population of undocumented immigrants in the US grew for two decades after the law's passage (Bean et al. 1990; Donato et al. 1992; Massey et al. 2002, 2016).

At the same time, the US Congress steadily increased the amount of money spent controlling the US-Mexico border, the primary way the US government sought to manage undocumented migration in the 1990s (Massey et al. 2016). While border control's effectiveness at deterring undocumented migration is not straightforward or obvious, studies demonstrate that border control reduced the return migration of undocumented immigrants from the US to Mexico (Angelucci 2012; Cornelius 2001; Cornelius and Salehyan 2007; Espenshade 1994; Massey et al. 2015, 2016; Massey and Espinosa 1997). In limiting return migration to Mexico, border control transformed Mexico-US transnational family life (Hamilton and Hale 2016). Circular migration, or migration back and forth across the border, was a cornerstone of Mexico-US transnational family life through the second half of the twentieth century, as Mexican migrants worked in the US during part of the year and returned home to visit family in Mexico with some frequency (Massey 1986; Massey et al. 1987; Reichert 1981). Under an increasingly enforced border, undocumented migrant stays in the US increased in duration, as immigrants worked for longer periods to cover the cost of border crossing and avoided trips home that would incur additional costs and risks on reentry to the US (Massey et al. 2002, 2016). Instead of enduring long sepa-

rations from families left behind in Mexico, many undocumented migrants in the US reunited with spouses and children or formed families in the US (Garip 2016; Hamilton and Hale 2016; Massey et al. 2002).

Two US laws passed in 1996 vastly increased the ability of immigration officials to deport immigrants who were settled in the US: the Antiterrorism and Effective Death Penalty Act (AEDPA) and the Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act (IIRAIRA). AEDPA and IIRAIRA expanded the category of deportable offenses, mandated the detention of immigrants convicted of deportable offenses, and curtailed judicial review of the deportation of immigrants convicted of deportable offenses (Macías-Rojas 2018). In the aftermath of 9/11, US immigration policy shifted to incorporate more enforcement in the interior of the US. In the 2000s, the newly formed US Department of Homeland Security (DHS) drew on the legal framework in IIRAIRA to create formal collaborations between federal immigration agencies and local law enforcement (Pedroza 2013). The Secure Communities program, Section 287(g) agreement, the Criminal Alien Program, and the National Fugitive Operations Program authorized local law enforcement agencies to detect deportable immigrants, hold them, and transfer them into custody of Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE). Between 2004 and 2011, US congressional appropriations for these four programs increased from \$23 million to \$690 million, and the number of people arrested through the programs increased from 11,000 to 289,000 (Golash-Boza 2015). In addition to federal efforts, some states, including Arizona and Georgia, passed laws to further enable local law enforcement agencies to identify and detain immigrants.

Scholars have called the deportation of hundreds of thousands of Mexican migrants from the US in the first two decades of the twenty-first century the “Great Expulsion” (Escobar et al. 2022; Waldinger 2023; Zúñiga and Giorguli-Saucedo 2020). As a result of AEDPA, IIRAIRA, and the federal-local immigration enforcement agreements, large shares of deportations were of settled immigrants, people who had lived in the US for many years and had formed and raised families there. In 2015, almost one in six

people deported from the US to Mexico had lived in the US for six or more years, and among these deported long-term residents, almost half (47 percent) were separated from at least one minor child in the US (Schultheis and Ruiz Soto 2017).

As the Great Expulsion unfolded, a new generation of children born in the US immigrated to Mexico (Masferrer et al. 2019; Zúñiga and Giorguli-Saucedo 2020). These US citizen children accompanied their parents, who returned to Mexico for a variety of reasons, including the 2008 Great Recession and economic opportunity in Mexico, and as a result of deportation (Chort and de la Rupelle 2016; Masferrer et al. 2025; Masferrer and Roberts 2012). Between 2005 and 2015, the population of US-born children living in Mexico doubled to more than half a million (Masferrer et al. 2019). Some of these children were *de facto* deported.

THE DE FACTO DEPORTATION OF CHILDREN FROM THE US TO MEXICO

A small body of research has studied the *de facto* deportation of children to Mexico. Two studies have estimated the degree of *de facto* deportation to Mexico, one focused on children and another on *de facto* deportation as one of several causes of migration (Hamilton et al. 2023; Masferrer et al. 2024). One study found that approximately 15 percent of recent migrant US-born children of recent migrant household heads living in Mexico in 2014 and 2018 were *de facto* deported (Hamilton et al. 2023). Applying this rate to the population of all US-born children living in Mexico during those years, the study estimated that as many as 100,000 US-born children living in Mexico in 2014 and 80,000 in 2018 were *de facto* deported to Mexico. However, the survey used in the study did not identify parent-child relationships in complex households, specifically households where the parent was not the household head or the spouse of the household head. As a result, it was impossible to link some children to their parents, and the sample sizes were too small to analyze the *de facto* deportation of Mexican-born children or other family members, such as spouses and parents. A more recent study of the Census showed that among returnees and recent US-born migrants, *de facto* deportation

is most common among children and women (Masferrer et al. 2024).

A small number of studies have examined the experiences of *de facto* deported children in Mexico (Boehm 2016; Caldwell 2019; Hamilton et al. 2023; Rodríguez-Cruz 2023; Zayas 2015; Zayas et al. 2024). These are, for the most part, small-scale, qualitative studies of migrant families. They find that *de facto* deportation is a disorienting and difficult process for children. US-born children in Mexico face administrative barriers to school enrollment, which may be aggravated for families who migrate under stressful and urgent circumstances, such as deportation (Jacobo-Suárez 2017; Zúñiga and Carrillo Cantú 2020; Zúñiga and Giorguli-Saucedo 2020). Children and adolescents who are *de facto* deported experience mental health problems that emerge from the trauma of parental deportation and the “code of silence” around deportation, which refers to the inability to speak openly about deportation due to stigma and experiences of discrimination toward deported people and their families (Rodríguez-Cruz 2023). Two studies have compared *de facto* deported children to those who migrated to Mexico for other reasons (Hamilton et al. 2023; Zayas et al. 2024). They found that *de facto* deported children experience greater material disadvantages, including lower levels of health insurance coverage and school enrollment, as well as higher rates of behavioral problems, unhappiness, and parent-child conflict.

Several scholars have argued that *de facto* deportation undermines child well-being because of the forced nature of family migration in response to familial deportation (Boehm 2016; Caldwell 2019; Zayas 2015). They argue that deportation forces families to prioritize family unity over other considerations related to child and family well-being, such as housing, employment, safety, and social support—not to mention the family’s personal and social attachments to places and communities. However, deportation and *de facto* deportation do not occur randomly. To identify a causal effect, researchers must, at a minimum, identify the population targeted (or at risk) of deportation, the group among them who decides to *de facto* deport, and changes in their circumstances before and after *de facto* deportation, in compar-

ison to families who are not targeted or who make different family migration decisions under the same circumstances. Because no data identify these populations, the research still lacks causal evidence that *de facto* deportation is harmful to children and families.

We are not able to provide causal estimates of the impacts of *de facto* deportation. Instead, we build on prior work by providing new estimates of the population size and characteristics of *de facto* deported people in Mexico in 2020, including US-born and Mexican-born children of deported parents, spouses of deported partners, and parents of deported children. We then describe the experiences of three families affected by deportation to better understand when and why *de facto* deportation occurs.

DATA AND METHODS TO QUANTIFY DE FACTO DEPORTATION TO MEXICO

We identify, quantify, and describe the characteristics of *de facto* deported people in Mexico using the Census. We compare people who were *de facto* deported, as defined in more detail later in this article, between 2015 and 2020 to US- and Mexican-born people who migrated to Mexico for other reasons between 2015 and 2020, as well as to nonmigrant US- and Mexican-born people who were in Mexico in 2015. We exclude people born outside of Mexico and the US from the analysis.

We use publicly available microdata from the Census’s extended questionnaire, which was administered to a probability sample of four million private households selected to represent the state and national populations. Unlike the basic questionnaire, which is administered to all Mexican households living in both private and collective dwellings for a complete population enumeration, the extended questionnaire identifies the parents and spouse of every household member. The Mexican National Institute of Statistics and Geography (INEGI, by its Spanish acronym) administered the Census in March 2020. INEGI was nearly finished with data collection when the federal government issued a nationwide, nonmandatory lockdown in response to the COVID-19 pandemic. While a decline in the response rate was noted in the last week of March, the survey

continued and ultimately achieved a 96 percent response rate (INEGI 2020).

We identify deported and de facto deported people among recent migrants, which the Census survey defines as people who were living in the US five years before the survey and therefore migrated to Mexico between 2015 and 2020. The survey asked all recent migrants the reason for their migration (to Mexico); deported migrants are recent migrants who responded that deportation was the reason for their migration. We identify de facto deported migrants as recent migrants who did not report deportation as the cause of their migration but co-reside (in the same household) with a close family member—parent, spouse, or child—who was deported over the same period. To be clear, de facto deportation is not listed as a possible reason for migration. In defining de facto deportation as such, we assume that a recent migrant who was not deported but co-resides with a close family member who was deported over the same period migrated to accompany that family member. Most people (97 percent) who we define as de facto deported listed “family” as the reason for their migration. The remaining 3 percent listed a variety of causes, including, most commonly, “other work-related reasons” (1 percent) and “other personal motives” (0.73 percent) (INEGI 2020). Because US-born citizens cannot be deported to Mexico, we identify US-born recent migrants who stated that deportation was the reason for their migration as de facto deported, assuming that they referred to the deportation of someone else.

It is important to note a few limitations of this definition of de facto deportation. First, because we do not directly observe de facto deportation, we limit the definition to close family members—children, spouses, and parents—who migrated over the same period and co-reside with a deported family member. It seems more likely that de facto deportation occurs among nuclear family members than among people connected by extended family or nonfamily relationships. We suspect the error introduced by excluding some de facto deported people who co-reside with an unrelated or extended relative who was deported is smaller than it would be if we had included all recent migrants co-residing with a deported

person, regardless of relation. This decision means that our estimate will be conservative. On the other hand, it is possible that some recent migrants who co-reside with a deported parent, child, or spouse migrated for reasons other than accompanying the deported family member. Given that 97 percent of migrants we identify as de facto deported state that their reason for migration was family, we suspect this is a small portion.

The second limitation is that we only observe the de facto deportation of coresident household members. People who migrated to accompany a deported person but no longer live with that person cannot be identified as de facto deported in this data. There is no way to overcome this limitation, nor confidently estimate the size of the error. Again, this error means our estimates of de facto deportation will be conservative.

Third, we do not observe de facto deportation among people who migrated to Mexico more than five years before the Census, that is, before 2015. Thus, our estimates of de facto deportation of Mexican-born people refer to the period between 2015 and 2020. This means that our estimate excludes an unknown but possibly large portion of people who were de facto deported before 2015 and remained there in 2020. We compare our estimates to earlier estimates and conclude that our estimate likely represents a minority of all de facto deportees living in Mexico in 2020 because of the short-term window in which we observe migration in the Census.

Fourth, even with a focus on the period between 2015 and 2020, we do not observe de facto deported people who remigrate or return to the US in the same period. Our estimate refers only to the stock, not the flow, of de facto deported people. US-born children, who have the right to a US passport and can lawfully return to the US, may be particularly mobile. Studies suggest that return to the US among the children of deported parents as well as among all US-born minors in Mexico is common (Caldwell 2019; Cuecuecha-Mendoza et al. 2017). Given some return migration to the US, the stock is smaller than the flow.

Finally, it is important to note the special circumstance of children under age five. This

group was not asked about their place of residence in 2015 because most had not yet been born in that year. Additionally, the question about reasons for migrating to Mexico between 2015 and 2020 was asked only of people who lived outside of Mexico in 2015. US-born children under age five are, by definition, recent migrants. We consider whether they were deported based on their parents' reasons for migration if one parent was in the US at least five years prior to the survey. However, as we show, most US-born children under age five do not co-reside with parents who report that they were in the US in 2015. Among Mexican-born children under age five, recent migration cannot be identified. We therefore analyze this age group separately.

ESTIMATES OF DE FACTO DEPORTED PEOPLE IN MEXICO IN 2020

Table 1 shows that an estimated 11,427 people were de facto deported from the US to Mexico between 2015 and 2020 and lived in Mexico in 2020. The majority (52.8 percent) of this population, totaling 6,038, were the children of a deported parent. The second-largest group was spouses of deported people ($N = 4,407$), who made up 38.6 percent of the population. Smaller numbers of people were the parents ($N = 346$, 3 percent) or the parents and spouses ($N = 275$, 2.4 percent) of a deported person. This latter group refers to recent migrants who lived

in a household with both a child (of any age) and a spouse who was deported. An additional 361 people, representing 3.2 percent of the de facto deported population, were US citizens who stated that their reason for migrating to Mexico was deportation, but they did not co-reside with a deported spouse, child, or parent (INEGI 2020).

Table 2 disaggregates the population by place of birth and age among children and by place of birth and gender among adults (see panels A and B). Comparing population estimates (shown at the bottom of each panel) across groups, it is apparent that US-born children were the largest population of people de facto deported to Mexico between 2015 and 2020: There were an estimated 1,296 de facto deported US-born children under age five and 3,987 aged five to seventeen. The population of US-born de facto deported children aged five to seventeen is 9.5 times larger than the population of Mexican-born de facto deported children of the same age ($N = 420$). Among adults, de facto deportation is more common for migrants born in Mexico, with 2,766 Mexican-born adult women and 1,554 adult men, compared to 1,044 US-born women and 360 men.

Table 2, panel A focuses on children and compares US-born children under age five to US-born and Mexican-born children aged five to seventeen. As a reminder, recent migration and the cause of migration to Mexico are only

Table 1. Relationship to the Deported Person

	Population	Percent of Population	Sample Size
Child	6,038	52.8	785
Spouse	4,407	38.6	439
Parent	346	3.0	52
Spouse and parent	275	2.4	34
US-born deported	361	3.2	44
Total	11,427	100	1,354

Source: 2020 Mexican Census (INEGI 2020).

Note: De facto deported migrants are recent migrants from the US who live with a family member (parent, spouse, or child) who is a recent migrant from the US and report deportation as the reason for migration. Alternatively, they are US-born and report that their own cause for migration was deportation, regardless of the relationship with other household members.

Table 2. Rate of De Facto Deportation and Relationship to Deported Person Across Key Groups of De Facto Deported People

	US-Born De Facto Deported (0–4 Years)	US-Born De Facto Deported (5–17 Years)	Mexican-Born De Facto Deported (5–17 Years)	
Panel A. Children				
Rate of de facto deportation	1.3%	10.1%	4.6%	
Who was deported ^a				
Father	62.4	51.2	49.1	
Mother	21.2	27.9	21.0	
Both parents	16.4	21.0	30.0	
Sample	150	546	59	
Population	1,296	3,987	420	
	US-Born De Facto Deported (Women)	US-Born De Facto Deported (Men)	Mexican-Born De Facto Deported (Women)	Mexican-Born De Facto Deported (Men)
Panel B. Adults				
Rate of de facto deportation	5.3%	1.6%	3.9%	0.7%
Who was deported ^a				
Parent	13.1	34.7	1.2	18.8
Spouse	82.4	65.3	78.1	81.2
Child	4.0	0	11.0	0
Spouse & child	0.5	0	9.8	0
Sample	57	28	358	156
Population	1,044	360	2,766	1,554

Source: 2020 Mexican Census (INEGI 2020).

^a in percentages.

reported for people who were in the US in 2015 in the Census; therefore, we cannot identify recent migration among Mexican-born children under age five. It is also the case that we do not observe de facto deportation for the large majority (80 percent) of US-born children under age five whose parents were not in the US in 2015 and did not report a reason for returning to Mexico after the birth of their child (deportation or otherwise). As a result, the rate of de facto deportation among this population of young recent migrants (US-born children under age five in Mexico in 2020) was 1.3 percent, significantly lower than the rate among US-born children aged five to seventeen (10.1 percent).

Among US-born and Mexican-born children who migrated to Mexico between 2015 and 2020, 10.1 percent of US-born children were de

facto deported, and 4.6 percent of Mexican-born children were de facto deported. In other words, the rate of de facto deportation was twice as high among US-born recent migrant children than among Mexican-born recent migrant children. One in ten US-born recent migrant children living in Mexico in 2020 was de facto deported.

The modal de facto deported child migrated with a deported father. Among US-born de facto deported children under age five, 62.4 percent returned with a deported father. The share is about 50 percent among US-born and Mexican-born de facto deported children aged five to seventeen. Fewer de facto deported children (21–28 percent) migrated with a deported mother. A full 30 percent of Mexican-born de facto deported children aged five to seventeen

migrated with two deported parents, higher than the share among US-born *de facto* deported children under age five (16.4 percent) and aged five to seventeen (21 percent).

Ninety percent of deported people to Mexico in this period were men (not shown), but between 49.1 and 62.4 percent of *de facto* deported children returned with a father. This means that men (fathers) were underrepresented among the parents of *de facto* deported children in this period, as compared to their share among the population of all deported people, suggesting that deported mothers may be more likely to bring children with them than deported fathers.¹ The overrepresentation of mothers among deported parents whose children accompany them is evidence that *de facto* deportation is gendered, meaning that the patterns and processes of *de facto* deportation vary for men and women.

In panel B, we present similar information for *de facto* deported adults. Among adults, the rate is highest among US-born recent migrant women, 5.3 percent of whom were *de facto* deported. Smaller shares were *de facto* deported among US-born men (1.6 percent), Mexican-born women (3.9 percent), and Mexican-born men (0.7 percent). The most common category of *de facto* deported adult was the spouse, who made up between 65.3 and 82.4 percent of the four adult groups.

Some *de facto* deported adults migrated to accompany deported parents, but this share ranges widely—from 1.2 percent to 34.7 percent—with men more likely than women to have done so. The share of *de facto* deported adult women who accompanied parents is smaller in part because a greater share of them accompanied deported children. In fact, there were no *de facto* deported men who accompanied deported children between 2015 and 2020 and were still living together in Mexico (and counted in the Census) in 2020.

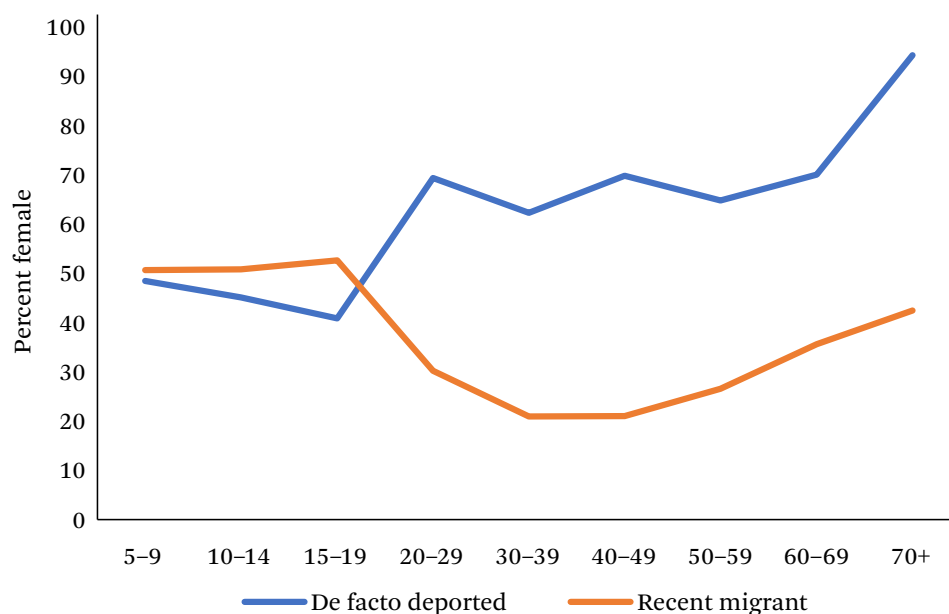
Adult men and women who were *de facto* deported between 2015 and 2020 had different

relationships to the deported person. Recent migrant men were more likely than women to have accompanied deported parents, while women were far more likely to accompany deported children. This is the second way that *de facto* deportation is gendered. Figure 1 adds further insight into these gendered patterns. It shows the percent female among recent migrants, comparing those who were and were not *de facto* deported by age group. Among adults, return migration to Mexico for reasons other than *de facto* deportation is dominated by men, whereas *de facto* deportation to Mexico is dominated by women. Among children and adolescents, the gender distribution is nearly equal across both groups. For those in their twenties, the patterns diverge: 30 percent of recent migrants were women, compared to 70 percent of the *de facto* deported. The female proportion declines to 20 percent among recent migrants in their thirties and forties but remains at 60–70 percent for *de facto* deported migrants in those age groups. Among older adults, the percent female rises in both groups, but more dramatically for those *de facto* deported: More than 90 percent of *de facto* deported migrants over seventy were women.

In table 3, we focus on children and compare *de facto* deported children to US- and Mexican-born recent migrants who moved for reasons other than *de facto* deportation, as well as to nonmigrant children.² The table includes key demographic indicators, including age, gender, ethnicity (both Indigenous and Afro-descendent, which is the terminology for Black race in Mexico), whether enrolled in school, region in Mexico, and size of locality of residence. *De facto* deported children were less likely to be Afro-descendent than the other children, but Indigenous ethnicity does not vary similarly. There are no clear patterns differentiating *de facto* deported children from the other groups on the other measures. US-born children under age five and Mexican-born *de facto* deported children were concentrated in the

1. We do not observe the population at risk of *de facto* deportation in the United States, that is, the population of mothers and fathers facing deportation. To directly assess gendered selectivity into deportation with children, one would need to compare the rates of deportation with children to the population at risk by gender.

2. All US-born children migrated to Mexico at some point in their lives, but we refer to those who are not recent migrants as nonmigrants for simplicity.

Figure 1. Percent Female by Age Among De Facto Deported and Recent Migrants in Mexico, 2020

Source: 2020 Mexican Census (INEGI 2020).

Border region, but we do not see the same pattern for US-born children deported between the ages of five and twelve.

US-born children who recently migrated to Mexico had lower rates of school enrollment than other groups, consistent with the literature on the administrative and other barriers they face to schooling in Mexico (Zúñiga and Giorguli-Saucedo 2020). This disadvantage is not apparent among US-born nonmigrants, who were enrolled at higher rates than Mexican-born nonmigrants, suggesting that the barriers are overcome with time. Although US-born de facto deported children had the lowest enrollment rate (at 82.8 percent), this is not entirely due to de facto deportation, as Mexican-born children in this group had the highest rate (at 94.3 percent; see table 3).

Table 4, which presents similar information for adults, also reveals few patterns differentiating de facto deported adults from recent migrant and nonmigrant adults. Here, we disaggregate by gender rather than place of birth and report that 27.4 percent of de facto deported women and 18.8 percent of de facto deported men were US-born. There are interesting educational differences between groups, with de facto deported men having the lowest levels of schooling (greater shares with zero to nine and ten to twelve completed years), and

recent migrant women having the highest levels (largest shares with thirteen to fifteen and sixteen or more years).

Economic activity patterns were structured more by gender than by migration status. Women in all categories were less likely to be employed or unemployed than men and more likely to be inactive. Among both men and women, nonmigrants had the highest rates of employment. De facto deported adults were concentrated in the Border region, a pattern in contrast to recent migrants and nonmigrants.

EXPERIENCES OF DEPORTATION AND FAMILY REORGANIZATION

Table 4 shows that a large share of de facto deported adults—about half—resided in cities of more than 100,000 people, similar to the share among nonmigrants in Mexico. In 2019, we interviewed thirty-four return migrants in Mexico City as part of a study on return migration among people who had been in the US in non-citizen (mostly undocumented) status (Masferrer et al. 2025). Half of the people we interviewed had been deported, and the other half had returned to Mexico for a variety of reasons, including economic, family, and health-related reasons. The people we interviewed were not representative of return migrants to Mexico living in Mexico City (or elsewhere), but the

Table 3. Characteristics of De Facto Deported Children in Comparison to Recent Migrants and Nonmigrants in Mexico, by Place of Birth and Age, 2020

	US-Born De Facto Deported (0–4 Years)	US-Born De Facto Deported (5–17 Years)	Mexican-Born De Facto Deported (5–17 Years)	US-Born Recent Migrant (5–17 Years)	Mexican-Born Recent Migrant (5–17 Years)	US-Born Nonmigrant (5–17 Years)	Mexican-Born Nonmigrant (5–17 Years)
Mean age	2.6	10.7	11.1	10.5	11.9	12.0	11
Gender^a							
Female	51.1	45.5	44.5	51.9	52.7	49.1	49.2
Male	48.9	54.5	55.5	48.1	47.3	50.9	50.8
Indigenous ^a	13.8	6.3	5.5	9.6	14.7	10.4	20.1
Afro-descendent ^a	0.2	0.2	0.2	1.3	1.9	1.5	1.6
Enrolled in school ^a	—	82.8	94.3	86.1	89.3	90.5	87.6
Region in Mexico^a							
Border	56.9	24.2	51.4	40.0	35.7	44.5	20.3
Center-West	26.1	46.9	42.4	30.4	35.0	28.5	23.7
Center	5.9	16.4	1.9	17.8	18.2	15.7	31.5
South-Southeast	11.1	12.6	4.3	11.9	11.2	11.2	24.6
Size of locality^a							
<2,500	23.2	27.3	17.9	25.6	18.3	22.8	23.8
2,500–14,999	14.7	14.9	36.2	15.5	14.4	15.0	16.3
15,000–99,999	14.6	16.3	11.7	14.6	17.0	14.5	16.3
>100,000	47.5	41.6	34.3	44.2	50.3	47.7	43.6
Sample	150	546	59	5,454	965	46,667	3,686,265
Population	1,296	3,987	420	35,345	8,803	363,307	27,891,809

Source: 2020 Mexican Census (INEGI 2020).

Note: The migration status of children under age five is only known for US-born children.

^a in percentages.

Table 4. Characteristics of De Facto Deported Adults in Comparison to Recent Migrants and Nonmigrants in Mexico, by Gender, 2020

	Women			Men		
	De Facto Deported	Recent Migrant	Nonmigrant	De Facto Deported	Recent Migrant	Nonmigrant
US-born ^a	27.4	21.7	0.2	18.8	9.3	0.2
Mean age	39.3	44.2	42.6	38.3	42.3	41.9
Indigenous ^a	10.3	12.6	19.4	10.3	20.6	19.3
Afro-descendent ^a	3.2	2	2.1	2.3	2.7	2.2
Education^a						
0–9 years	51	43.4	55.4	60.5	64.7	53.3
10–12 years	36.8	28.5	22.4	34.3	23	23.7
13–15 years	3.6	8.2	7.4	4.4	3.9	7.1
16+ years	8.6	16.9	14.8	0.8	8.5	16
Marital status^a						
Inaunion	91.7	61.2	59	77.7	65.7	64.1
Ex-union	3.5	21.2	19.3	5.8	13.2	8.9
Single	4.8	17.6	21.7	16.5	21.2	27
Economic activity^a						
Employed	37.8	36	42.6	73.6	73.2	76.4
Unemployed	0.5	1.1	1	4.1	4.2	3.1
Inactive	61.7	62.9	56.4	22.4	22.6	20.5
Region in Mexico^a						
Border	46.1	37.2	20.8	44.6	27.4	22
Center-West	30	32.9	22.5	28.9	35.5	22.4
Center	14	17.4	34.3	19.1	19.7	33.6
South-Southeast	10	12.5	22.4	7.4	17.4	22
Size of locality^a						
<2,500	21.6	22	19	25.2	31	19.5
2,500–14,999	11.7	15.4	14.5	14.1	17.2	14.4
15,000–99,999	15.7	14.5	15.7	14.5	14.6	15.5
>100,000	51.1	48.2	50.8	46.3	37.2	50.6
Sample	415	10,940	5,165,413	184	38,302	4,689,828
Population	3,810	86,580	45,348,680	1,914	240,605	41,412,774

Source: 2020 Mexican Census (INEGI 2020).

^a in percentages.

interviews contain information not commonly recorded in survey data, including about non-coresident partners and children, as well as personal accounts of the process of family migration and separation. We use illustrative interview data from three returned migrants to glean additional description and insights regarding the process of de facto deportation.

We begin with Carla's story of her own de facto deportation. We then tell Lety's story. Like Carla, Lety also fled the US to accompany a family member threatened by deportation, but they left before the order was issued, raising a conceptual question about the process. We then tell Olivia's story. Olivia was deported and separated from young children in the US;

her children could have been de facto deported, but they remained in the US with their father. The three stories reveal the kinds of considerations that families make regarding family reorganization in response to deportation or the threat of deportation, which may inform future studies of de facto deportation.

Carla's Story: De facto Deportation of a Mother

Carla's children were teenagers and young adults, and she was divorced from their father, when she was de facto deported. Carla's youngest son Luis, who, like her, was living in the US without legal documents, was apprehended by immigration agents on a high school bus trip from Houston to Los Angeles. When US Border Patrol agents boarded the bus, Luis showed them his *matrícula consular*, an identification document issued to migrants by the Mexican Consulate in the US. The agents apprehended Luis, and he signed voluntary departure orders, not understanding what it meant to relinquish his right to a legal process of deportation.

Luis called his mother from Mexico. "Mom, I'm in Mexico!" she recalls him saying. It was a tremendous shock. Carla quickly left for Mexico to accompany Luis, although doing so meant that she left her other children in Texas. Although it was a heart-wrenching decision, Carla felt Luis had greater need for his mother than her other children did because he was alone in Mexico. Luis knew only halting Spanish. US Border Patrol agents surrendered him to a border town where he had never been before, a site for transit migrants and criminal activity. He was terrified of being attacked by people assuming that migrants coming from the US have money. He did not know what to do or where to go. In contrast, Carla's other children were older and had the support of their father and one of her sisters, who were also in the US.

When we interviewed Carla in 2019, she had been back in Mexico for ten years. Luis had a difficult time at first in Mexico, experiencing severe depression and difficulty adjusting to life there. But by 2019 he had adapted. Luis worked in a call center, where he could make use of his English language skills, and he lived independently. Although he no longer

depended on Carla as he had at first, she remained in Mexico. She felt it was not possible for her, at her age, to reenter the US unlawfully because of the difficulty crossing the border without documents. She earned a living selling crocheted crafts in markets around the city.

Although Carla's de facto deportation separated her from her older children in the US, they were left in the care of trusted and settled adults. In migrating to accompany Luis, Carla made the difficult decision to prioritize the needs of her youngest son, who was alone and vulnerable in Mexico. As we will see in the next story, the dependency of children also influenced family migration decisions in Lety's case.

Lety's Story: De Facto Deportation of a Nuclear Family

Lety and Carla were de facto deported under different circumstances, but in both cases, their de facto deportation involved the need to provide in-person caregiving to their children. Lety met her husband, Alonso, at her sister's store when he was in Mexico on a trip home from the US. Alonso migrated to the US in the early 1980s and qualified for the IRCA amnesty in 1986. Alonso's green card, or lawful permanent residency, enabled him to travel back and forth between the US and Mexico. On one of those trips, Alonso asked Lety to marry him and join him in California. Although Alonso's permanent resident status meant he could have sponsored Lety for legal status in the US, she did not apply for a visa when she migrated. Instead, Lety entered the US without inspection. Lety and Alonso had two children born in the US. Their family was a mixed-status family: Alonso was a lawful permanent resident, the children were US citizens, and Lety was undocumented.

Several years after Lety migrated to join Alonso, they sought legal assistance for Lety to regularize her status. In a meeting with a lawyer, they received surprising and devastating information: Alonso was subject to deportation. Alonso had been convicted of a crime and served time in a California state prison before he married Lety. The 1996 IIRAIRA retroactively transformed Alonso's prior conviction into a deportable offense. In attempting to sponsor

Lety for a visa, the immigration consequences of Alonso's prior record became paramount. Lawyers advised Alonso to leave the US to avoid arrest, detention, and deportation.

A strict definition of *de facto* deportation may not classify Lety and her children as *de facto* deported, as Alonso was not, in fact, deported. Alonso (and his wife and children) fled the threat of deportation under the advice of a lawyer, who convinced him that he would be detained and deported if he remained in the US. While they chose to leave, the extent to which Lety and her children count as *de facto* deported is less important than the fact that their departure was compelled by forced circumstances, with little choice in the matter: They chose to leave to avoid Alonso's incarceration, forced removal, and immigration record.

When Alonso decided to flee the risk of detention and deportation, there was no doubt in Lety's mind that she and the children would accompany Alonso. As she told us, "It was never my idea to go to the US." She and Alonso were the parents of two children under five years old, and they intended to stay together as a family. Yet, she also told us that she believes staying in California might have been better for her children. She told us that she admired the bilingual education at her son's school, and benefited from food supplements provided by the Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children (WIC). Her son has a learning disability, and she believes he would have benefited from more supportive educational programs and services in California. Their choice to return to Mexico was not about where their children would receive the best education and social services; it was about remaining together as a family under the threat of forced removal and separation.

Olivia: A Mother's Separation from Family

Olivia's story is not about *de facto* deportation but about the more common outcome of parental deportation: family separation (Hamilton et al. 2023). Olivia's experience gives us additional insight into the decisions families

make when they face the deportation of a key member, and in comparing it to Lety and Carla's stories, it helps us understand the forces weighing on those decisions.

Olivia was deported without much warning in 2017. Four years earlier, she was caught driving without a license, apprehended, and detained for four months in an immigrant detention center in Colorado. Olivia had not been convicted of an aggravated felony; the grounds for her deportation were undocumented residence in the US. In 2011, President Barack Obama had instructed ICE to use greater prosecutorial discretion in granting deferred action—suspension of removal—to low priority cases, like Olivia's (DHS 2011). Because her teenage, US-born daughter was disabled, a humanitarian concern, and because she had a long record of good moral conduct in the US, Olivia successfully argued for and received deferred action, which allowed her to remain in the US conditionally with work authorization but gave her no route to lawful status. Olivia was required to check in with immigration officials each year to renew her work authorization. Shortly after his inauguration, President Donald J. Trump changed the federal immigration enforcement priorities.³ On her annual check-in in March 2017, Olivia was arrested, detained, and deported six days later. She was never able to say goodbye to her children or husband.

There was very little discussion about whether her children would remain in the US after she was deported to Mexico. Her children were teenagers and had grown up in the US. They were settled in US schools, lived in a comfortable home with their father, and had a large community of friends, neighbors, and family in Colorado. Her oldest daughter, who was born in Mexico and migrated to the US as a young child, was protected from deportation by the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) program.

Returning to Mexico was full of hardship and uncertainty for Olivia. Foremost was the emotional shock. She told us, "When I arrived here in Mexico, it dawns on you that your chil-

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dren are there [in the US], that you don't know when you will go back. I felt very strange with my siblings, who start talking to you and asking you things, and all you want to do is shut yourself in a room and cry." It had been over fifteen years since she left Mexico City for the US. She did not know where to live. Her mother was no longer alive, and she was not close to her brothers. She did not know how or where to find work in Mexico City. She had owned her own housecleaning business in Colorado, but the market was different in Mexico City. She knew it was not a safe or easy place to navigate.

Troubles in her marriage also complicated the situation. Shortly after her deportation, Olivia's husband began a new relationship. They formally separated. There was no question, at that point, that her husband would not return to Mexico to be with her. But she also knew that bringing her children with her was not the right choice. The separation of children and mother was a heartbreaking consequence of Olivia's deportation. Olivia told us that her daughters call her crying. Her oldest daughter started to suffer from depression and anxiety. Olivia told us, "Now, if you ask my children what they want for Christmas, they are not thinking, 'Ay, I hope Santa Claus brings me this.' No, they are thinking, I want to see my mother. And that is the hardest part. Because they [ICE] snatch the dreams from our children. Not just us. Our children too."

DISCUSSION

Families who face forced international separation as a result of deportation can only reunify without the threat of further legal entanglement by migrating to the country of deportation, which is the *de facto* deportation of the family. Our analysis reveals that the scale of recent *de facto* deportation is substantial, affecting more than 11,000 people who migrated to Mexico between 2015 and 2020 and remained there in 2020. *De facto* deported migrants in Mexico are mostly the children and spouses of deported men, such as Lety and her children. Still, our analysis shows that there are significant numbers of men who are *de facto* deported when they accompany a spouse. There are also some parents—all mothers in the Census—who accompany deported children to

Mexico, as Carla did. Our study shows that the post-deportation consequences of the current US immigration policy regime and its enforcement extend well beyond the individual deported and the borders of the US.

While our qualitative data with former US migrants living in Mexico City in 2019 are not representative of the population of deported parents or their children in Mexico, they give us greater understanding of the types of considerations that families make when facing parental deportation. They reveal that when deportation forces the international separation of family, deliberation about whether and how to stay together can rest on the needs of family members, the presence of other caretakers or guardians, and, in the case of parental deportation, the relationship between parents. Lety decided to accompany Alonso along with her children considering their union was strong and their children were very young. Carla accompanied her son, Luis, because he needed her support after deportation to Mexico following a childhood lived in the US. We learned from Olivia's story that parents whose union is fragile, and parents of older children who are settled in the US, may not be accompanied by their partner and children. Other considerations in whether children accompany deported parents involve the ability to provide housing and schooling in Mexico, as Olivia's story also showed us. However, Lety's story suggests that staying together as a family, when it is deemed desirable and possible, can outweigh considerations related to institutional supports such as schooling.

In the Census data, we find that women make up a far greater share of adult *de facto* deported people than they do of recent migrants. We also find that more women accompany deported spouses than men do. Of course, part of the gendering of *de facto* deportation reflects the gendering of deportation itself: Men are the overwhelming majority of deported people, so female partners are at higher risk of spousal *de facto* deportation (Golash-Boza 2016; Golash-Boza and Hondagneu-Sotelo 2013). However, women are also more likely than men to accompany deported children; in fact, no men in the Census accompanied a deported child as a *de facto* deported parent. Fur-

thermore, when children were *de facto* deported with deported parents, a greater share accompanied mothers than would be expected based on the share of all deported people who are women.

The majority of *de facto* deported children were born in the US. As Luis H. Zayas (2015) has argued, these young American citizens have been forced into exile, relinquishing their citizenship rights in childhood to retain their right to parental companionship. We find that they were less likely to be enrolled in school than others who migrated for different reasons, although this may reflect generally lower enrollment rates among recent US-born migrants compared to nonmigrants and Mexican-born children. This pattern aligns with other findings and owes to administrative and language barriers to the educational system in Mexico, or difficulty navigating bureaucracy (Jacobo-Suárez 2017; Zúñiga and Giorguli-Saucedo 2020; Medina and Menjívar 2015). Nevertheless, there appears to be an additional schooling penalty for being *de facto* deported and US-born, suggesting further complications with paperwork for families who migrate under forced circumstances. In other words, these challenges add to the other challenges already studied in the literature and have implications for students, parents, and educators (Gandara and Jensen 2021; Giorguli Saucedo et al. 2022).

Our findings highlight a neglected population in research on *de facto* deportation, which has focused on children: the partners and parents of deported people. For Mexican-born individuals who lived in the US without legal documents, *de facto* deportation to Mexico implies significant barriers to reentry to the US. For Carla, this is a significant loss, as most of her family remains there. She believes she cannot obtain a visa to travel legally to the US, and she is unwilling to attempt a border crossing. US-born children, like Lety's, on the other hand, have the right to travel to, live in, and work in the US, as well as to eventually sponsor their parents and other family members for immigration. Lety's children have mixed feelings about returning to the US; her son is eager to return, while her daughter is not. Neither one retains any English, nor any real memories of the place of their birth. What their future holds

is yet to be seen. To our knowledge, no studies following *de facto* deported children over time exist, but one study of the US-born in Mexico found a very high rate of return migration to the US, of more than 10 percent in a two-year period among eighteen-to-twenty-four-year-olds (Cuecuecha-Mendoza et al. 2017). As future studies analyze what happens to *de facto* deported people over time, it is important to note age at arrival to Mexico to consider how life-stage processes shape the experiences of *de facto* deportation for children, adolescents, and adults alike.

How does the experience of *de facto* deportation vary by place? Our results show that there is a concentration of *de facto* deported people in the northern border region and in metropolitan areas, but questions remain about how challenges and integration patterns differ by state or size of locality. Metropolitan areas such as Tijuana, Guadalajara, Puebla, and Mexico City, which have significant populations of deported people, have developed migrant organizations supporting the needs of returnees and US-born family members. It is unclear how challenges differ in places where *de facto* deported people and their families are more visible and have tighter social networks and support compared to places with a low density of returnees.

One implication of our multiple-methods analysis is that identifying *de facto* deportation in existing data sources is not straightforward. No existing data sources identify the precise timing of deported people and their family members or list *de facto* deportation (or the accompaniment of a deported person) as the reason for migration. As we explained, we assumed that nuclear family members who migrated during the same five-year period as a deported person were *de facto* deported. This presents several complications that need to be considered when using our estimates and in future work to improve upon them. First, we did not observe the reasons for return migration of most parents of US-born children under five, the majority of whom did not report being in the US in 2015. This suggests a short-term or circular family migration pattern that the Census does not capture (Vargas-Valle et al. 2022). Nor can we observe *de facto* deportation for

Mexican-born children under five if their families had short-term migrations between 2015 and 2020.

Our window of observation of migration was limited to 2015–2020, but the Census provides data on migrant stock, not flow—that is, people who migrated in that window and remained in Mexico in 2020. Some portion of migrants to Mexico between 2015 and 2020 likely returned to the US by 2020, especially among the US-born, who have US passports with which to travel (Cuecuecha-Mendoza et al. 2017). Moreover, the vast majority of US-born children in Mexico in 2020 (a population estimated to be just over 500,000) migrated to Mexico before 2015. If we apply the rate of *de facto* deportation observed among five- to seventeen-year-old US-born recent migrants (10 percent) to the population of all US-born children living in Mexico in 2020, we estimate a total of about 50,000 *de facto* deported US-born children. This is smaller than the population estimate from the 2014 and 2018 Mexican Surveys of Demographic Dynamics (known as the ENADID in Spanish; Hamilton et al. 2023). This difference could reflect changes to the risk of parental deportation in the US or the choice of children to accompany parents after a parental deportation.

Another problem with measuring *de facto* deportation is that census and household survey data like the ENADID exclude people who do not live in the same household as the person they accompanied. This would exclude both Lety and her son, who no longer live with her (now ex-) husband, as well as Carla, who no longer lives with her son. Definitional issues may also affect the reporting of deportation. For example, it is unclear how Carla's son and Lety's husband would have reported their migration experience. Carla's son signed a voluntary departure order and was removed instantly, while Lety's husband was not officially deported, yet he and his family still fled the threat (and likely inevitability) of deportation. On the whole, problems with measuring *de facto* deportation in existing data suggest our estimates are conservative, or smaller than the true number.

Two important improvements over existing Mexican survey data on deportation would be to collect migration information from people

who have ever lived outside of Mexico. This could include asking for detailed information about the last migration to Mexico, regardless of period. Another improvement would be to allow respondents to report multiple reasons for migration, including, ideally, to accompany a deported person. Incorporating information on the last migration, rather than migration in the last five years, would provide comprehensive migrant inflow information, allowing changes over time in the rate of entry to Mexico to be observed among the current stock of immigrants and return migrants in the country. It would also allow for more precise identification of migration accompaniment among co-resident family members. By allowing multiple causes of return to be listed, survey data would better reflect the multiple considerations that migrants and their family members make when moving.

Although they may not have been represented in survey data, Lety, with her children, and Carla were *de facto* deported to Mexico, along with thousands of Mexican and US-born migrants. Their migration to Mexico was not the outcome of unhindered choice but was forced by the family circumstances they faced under the particular set of US immigration laws and policies created since 1986. It is likely that a far greater number of families, like Olivia's, are separated across international borders by deportation. Olivia returned alone, just as many returnees have done (Masferrer 2021). Adding questions about nonresident children to surveys would improve the ability to identify family separation among migrants and deported people.

An additional way to consider the needs of children involves something we did not do: talking and listening to children about their own difficulties. As a vulnerable population deserving of added protection in the research process, children are usually excluded from conversations regarding parental deportation (Muruthi et al. 2024). Yet, deportation impacts *de facto* deported children and children who remain behind, as this journal issue makes abundantly clear. To identify the causal impacts of *de facto* deportation, data that allow for the comparison of parents who are deported and accompanied by children, parents

who are deported and separated from their children, and parents who are at risk of but do not experience deportation are needed. Such data would allow scholars to answer several important questions, including which parents experience deportation, who among them are accompanied by their children, and the impacts de facto deportation has on children.

It is uncertain what the future holds in relation to policies that may reduce or amplify the risk of deportation, de facto deportation, family separation, and family reunification. Families will continue to face difficult decisions to remain together or be separated as long as the US government continues to fail to accommodate them or prioritize the needs of children. This special issue showcases research on the deportation system and its aftermath. We hope our work and that of others in this issue spur future research and data on de facto deportation—not only from the US to Mexico but globally.

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Urgent Returns: The Link Between Family and the Remigration Intentions of Deported Central Americans in an Era of Border Externalization



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Research on post-deportation experiences has shown that family separation, especially separation from children and partners, shapes deported migrants' intentions to return to the US. Yet little is known about how these intentions intersect with other aspects of the remigration experience. In this article, we examine deported Central American adults' intentions to reenter the US undetected and the transit experiences of those attempting to return while traversing Mexico. Drawing on survey data from the Encuesta Sobre Migración en la Frontera Sur de México (EMIF Sur), combined with ethnographic and interview data from recently deported Central Americans traveling through Mexico, we find that deported migrants who have left behind minor children in the US are more likely to intend to return to the US—particularly those who are separated from a partner or are a single parent. In turn, the eagerness and urgency to return to their families in the US shape the way deported migrants approach their journeys through Mexico. These results underscore the central role of family in shaping remigration and highlight the broader consequences of US border externalization policies operating within Mexico.

Keywords: Central America, family, deportation, remigration, border externalization

Luis, a thirty-four-year-old man from El Salvador, was transiting through Mexico in 2019, hoping to reenter the US undetected after having been deported months earlier. He explained his motivations for returning, despite the risks:

“I have three little girls and a wife waiting for me in South Carolina. I had a good life there, but I was stopped for speeding and was deported back to El Salvador. That was a year and a half ago, and since then, I have been deported

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Escamilla García, Ángel A., and Adriana M. Cerón. 2025. “Urgent Returns: The Link Between Family and the Remigration Intentions of Deported Central Americans in an Era of Border Externalization.” *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 196–216. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.09>. This research was supported by the Qualitative and Interpretive Research Institute at the Cornell Center for Social Sciences, the Whitney and Betty MacMillan Center for International and Area Studies at Yale University, and the National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship (DGE-2139841). We are grateful to Caitlin Patler, Bradford Jones, Suzanne Nichols, and the anonymous reviewers at the Russell Sage Foundation for their valuable feedback and support. We are especially grateful to the participants, whose stories are reflected in this paper. Direct correspondence to: Ángel A. Escamilla García, at angel.escamillagarcia@yale.edu, Department of Sociology, 493 College Street, New Haven, CT 06511, United States. Adriana M. Cerón, at adriana.ceron@yale.edu, Department of Sociology, 493 College Street, New Haven, CT 06511, United States.

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[back to El Salvador] four times: three times from Mexico, and once while crossing the border wall in California.”

When asked if he was afraid of the heightened immigration enforcement at the US-Mexico border, Luis explained: “I am not afraid of crossing. My life is there. . . . My family is there [in the US].” Luis’s experience reflects the broader reality faced by all Central American migrants aiming to enter the US: They must evade both US and Mexican authorities. However, Luis’s case also points to the unique migratory experience of migrants who are en route to the US with a core motivation: to reunite with their families or loved ones following forcible separation through deportation.

While international migration is often viewed as movement toward new destinations, the inverse—migrants returning, voluntarily or involuntarily, to their home countries—has received comparatively less attention (Masferrer and Roberts 2012). Scholars have explored the consequences of return migration, including challenges of resettlement, cultural and economic reintegration, and family and governmental responses (Hagan et al. 2008; Medina and Menjívar 2015). Others have examined deported migrants’ efforts to return to countries from which they were removed (Roberts et al. 2017; Schuster and Majidi 2013, 2015), highlighting how, for many migrants, deportation and return intersect with family disruption, often separating loved ones across borders or prompting entire household relocations. But, beyond linking the desire to return with factors such as family separation, to our knowledge, no research has focused on how the experience of returning to the country of removal is shaped by deportation.

Deportation is the most common form of involuntary return from the US. Fueled by the increasing criminalization of unauthorized migration over the last few decades, deportations surged from less than 50,000 in 1996 to 348,000 by 2019 (Golash-Boza 2015; Weber and Massey

2023). Even in 2020, amid the COVID-19 pandemic and restrictive policies such as Title 42, which permitted US authorities to more easily expel migrants at the US-Mexico border, over 237,000 people were removed (DHS 2023; ICE 2020; Cerón and Kao 2025).¹ While Mexican immigrants historically made up the majority of these deportations, their numbers have declined over the years due to enforcement and demographic shifts (Flores 2020; Massey et al. 2015). This has coincided with a significant increase in the apprehension and deportation of migrants from Northern Central America (NCA), which is comprised of El Salvador, Guatemala, and Honduras (Torre Cantalapiedra 2023).² For instance, in 2014, for the first time, Border Patrol apprehended more Central Americans than Mexicans, a trend that has persisted since then (Goodman 2020; Ward and Batalova 2023). Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) data also shows a decrease in Mexican removals from 241,493 to 176,968 between 2013 and 2014, while NCA removals rose from 106,400 to 122,298 (DHS 2014).

Deported NCA migrants often return to the same or worse precarious conditions—marked by violence, inequality, and instability—that they originally left behind, and which are often rooted in the lasting impact of US-backed civil conflicts and coups in the region (Menjívar and Abrego 2012; Dingeman 2018). At the same time, deportation separates migrants from their homes, jobs, and families in the US, who often include members with mixed legal status. These losses, combined with hardship in their countries of origin, prompt many to attempt reentry without authorization (Menjívar et al. 2018). But to return to the US, NCA migrants must traverse more than 2,000 miles across Mexico, a country that has intensified its immigration enforcement since 2014, becoming a key actor in US border externalization. In Mexico, migrants face violence, xenophobia, and the risk of detention and deportation (Crocker et al. 2021; Escamilla García 2022). These dy-

1. The COVID-19 pandemic mitigation efforts also halted some ICE operations within the interior of the country. For more details, see: <https://www.ice.gov/doclib/news/library/reports/annual-report/eroReportFY2020.pdf>.

2. Throughout this paper, we use NCA and Central America interchangeably due to the predominance of NCA migrants in US-bound Central American migration flows.

namics make understanding the remigration attempts of deported NCA migrants both timely and necessary.

In this article, we examine the aftermath of deportation among deported NCA migrants, focusing on their intentions to return to the US and their experiences while transiting through Mexico on their return journeys. We approach our analysis from two complementary and methodologically diverse perspectives—the macro and the micro. First, we use 2014–2018 data from the Survey on Migration on the Southern Border of Mexico (*Encuesta Sobre Migración en la Frontera Sur de México*, hereafter EMIF Sur) to examine how involuntary transnational family structures are associated with reporting intentions to remigrate to the US in the future and the short-term, focusing on separation from minor children and partners in the US. Our quantitative analysis shows that NCA migrants separated from minor children under the age of fifteen in the US are more likely to report intentions to return to the US, especially when they also have a partner in the US or are single parents, relative to deported migrants without children and a partner. Then, to further investigate how family and parenthood affect mobility decisions, we draw on ethnographic data gathered in 2018 and 2019 from recently deported NCA adult migrants who had been separated from their families in the US and were transiting through Mexico in an attempt to reenter the US. The qualitative analysis reveals that deported parents make difficult decisions and face significant adversity while urgently moving through Mexico in order to reunite with their partners and children.

DEPORTATION, FAMILY, AND BORDER EXTERNALIZATION AMONG DEPORTED CENTRAL AMERICANS REMIGRATING TO THE US

A growing body of literature highlights the collateral consequences of deportation, the remigration intentions of deported Central Americans, the impacts on families left behind, and Mexico's expanding role as a gatekeeper for US reentry. These studies consistently show that familial ties in the US are strong motivators for

remigration. However, for Central Americans, returning to the US is increasingly complicated by Mexico's role in externalizing the US-Mexico border and the violence and risk that accompany that role. Thus, deported migrants from Central America who seek to reunite with their families must inevitably navigate these additional factors while traversing Mexico.

Central American migration to the US began in the early twentieth century, with a significant surge in the 1980s as people fled US-backed wars and coups (Abrego 2014). Since then, Central Americans have become a growing and sizable immigrant group in the US.³ As of 2019, approximately 3.8 million Central Americans were living in the country, of whom the majority (2.1 million) were undocumented (Ward and Batalova 2023). For the latter group, their precarious legal status and limited avenues for legalization have placed them at a heightened risk of deportation (Menjívar 2000). For example, deportations of Guatemalans, Hondurans, and Salvadorans rose from 80,000 in 2010 to 122,000 by 2014 (Dominguez Villegas and Rietig 2015).

One major consequence of intensified US enforcement is family separation. Between 2009 and 2013, more than half a million US-born children experienced the deportation of a parent, usually a father (Capps et al. 2015). These separations significantly harm families' emotional and financial well-being. Children often suffer from depression, anxiety, and social withdrawal (Allen et al. 2015; Dreby and Macias 2023), while mothers face increased economic pressure and housing insecurity (Dreby 2012, 2015). Meanwhile, deported fathers face stigma, social isolation, and depression upon returning to countries with limited economic prospects, which makes it difficult for them to earn enough money to support their families in the US (Andrews 2023; Dingeman 2018). These new family dynamics can strain and sever familial ties, with some fathers relinquishing their role as providers and experiencing a form of gendered stigma that negatively impacts their psychological and social well-being (Golash-Boza 2014, 2019; Andrews and Khayar-Cámara 2022).

3. For a historical context of Central America migration, see Patler and Jones (2025, this issue).

Deportation is often not the end, but rather the beginning of a series of challenging decisions for families. Families must choose whether to remain separated, attempt unauthorized reentry, or relocate to the deported parent's location—all of which involve significant trade-offs (Boehm 2017; Cardoso et al. 2016; Hamilton et al. 2023). De facto deportation—when family members emigrate from the US to reunite with a deported person—can carry unintended consequences, particularly for children, especially when relocation exposes them to violence, socioeconomic hardships, and mental health problems (Hamilton et al. 2025, this issue). Thus, deported parents may see unauthorized reentry to the US as one of the only viable options for preserving family unity.

Still, unauthorized reentry after deportation is classified as a felony under US law, punishable by up to two years in prison for a first offense and up to twenty years for repeat offenders with prior criminal records (8 U.S.C. § 1326; Cardoso et al. 2016). Despite these harsh consequences, migrants with existing deportation records are estimated to have accounted for more than half of ICE removals between 2003 and 2016 (Valdivia 2025, this issue). For deported parents in particular, the decision to risk unauthorized reentry is often driven by the desire to reunite with their loved ones and fulfill family obligations (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2015, Hagan et al. 2008; Martínez et al. 2018). Indeed, evidence shows that separation from children and spouses in the US is a major predictor of reporting remigration intentions among Salvadoran men, regardless of the reason for their removal (Cardoso et al. 2016). Gender and legal vulnerability also play significant roles in shaping remigration decisions. For instance, deported Mexican women are more likely than men to express an intent to return if they have left children in someone else's care (Vargas Valle et al. 2022). In contrast, Mexican fathers with previous failed crossing attempts or incarceration histories may be more reluctant to return, fearing prolonged detention or prosecution (Andrews and Khayar-Cámara 2022). These studies emphasize how family separation complicates the decision to return to the US.

However, more research is needed—particu-

larly on NCA migrants—who face longer and more perilous journeys than their Mexican counterparts due to the necessity of transiting through Mexico. The necessity of crossing through Mexico is a distinguishing feature of NCA migration to the US, including unauthorized reentry post-deportation. For instance, the migrant route from NCA to the US is rife with violence and precarity, and it is a route that deported migrants must inevitably confront again if they wish to return to the US (Brigden 2015, 2018; Díaz de León 2023; Vogt 2013). Since 2014, Mexico has intensified efforts to deter undocumented migrants from reaching the US-Mexico border, resulting in increased detentions and deportations at the US Southwest border (Escamilla García 2022; Leyva-Flores et al. 2019; Massey 2020). These enforcement measures have pushed migrants toward increasingly dangerous routes to avoid detention, putting them at the mercy of criminal groups and, in extreme cases, corrupt immigration officials (Menjívar 2000). This exposes migrants not only to criminal violence and extortion but also to a scarcity of basic needs like shelter and water (Escamilla García 2022; Linares 2023). Although Mexico lacks official data on most forms of violence faced by migrants, limited surveys of migrants in transit collected by the National Human Rights Commission of Mexico show that 47 percent of migrants transiting through Mexico to reach the US experienced some form of crime, with robbery being the most common (16 percent), along with extortion (4 percent) and sexual violence (2 percent), and these numbers likely undercount the actual magnitude of the violence faced by these migrants (CNDH 2021). Meanwhile, the cost of smuggling has increased, putting smugglers out of reach for many NCA migrants, and the number of deaths along the journey has also risen (Gathmann 2008; De León 2015; Vogt 2013).

Ultimately, the literature shows that deported Central Americans separated from their families face a unique experience of remigration driven by two opposing forces: the urgent desire to reunite with loved ones and the harsh realities of enforcement and violence along the journey. Yet, little is known about how these two forces intersect, and whether deported mi-

grants' motivations shape their experiences on the migrant journey, as in the case of Central Americans. This study is among the first to explore how these dual pressures shape the remigration intentions and experiences of deported Central Americans attempting to return to the US without authorization. We examine this through two guiding questions: The first asks about the association between deported migrants' involuntary transnational family structure and their intentions to remigrate to the US in both the future and the short term; the second considers how the urgency to reunite with families shape the journey experience of deported migrants. Through this framework, the article contributes to the emerging scholarship on what Caitlin Patler and Bradford Jones (2025, this issue) define as the post-deportation phase—an often-overlooked and understudied dimension of the broader deportation system, which also includes pre- and in-deportation processes.

RESEARCH DESIGN AND DATA

To answer these questions, this article uses quantitative and qualitative data on NCA migrants deported from the US to Central America. These data sources were collected independently from different projects and were not originally intended to complement each other.⁴ Thus, through the process of “triangulation,” we have leveraged the different methodologies and findings from both sources as a strength, providing a more robust answer to our research question (Olsen 2004). The triangulation of methods and data in social science is widely used to bring together “diverse viewpoints or standpoints” to cast light on a topic, including in studies of international migration, where it has led to substantial and robust findings (Small 2011; Asad and Garip 2019; Hamilton et al. 2021). In this case, an additional benefit of triangulating these data sources is that there is generally limited available data on this topic, and less that covers the same population from different methodological angles.

Our method of triangulation consisted of a two-step process of independent analysis of the

sources. First, we used EMIF Sur data to examine the association between deported migrants' transnational family structures and their intentions to remigrate to the US in the future and the short term. Once this relation was examined and patterns were observed, we analyzed the ethnographic data to understand how deported NCA migrants transiting through Mexico in an attempt to reenter the US described these factors as they related to their return journeys to the US.

Quantitative Data and Analysis

The quantitative data analyzed in our study come from the 2014–2018 EMIF Sur survey. The EMIF Sur is conducted by El Colegio de la Frontera Norte (El Colef) in conjunction with other organizations. Today, the EMIF Sur is one of the most comprehensive and robust surveys to focus on migration flows from the NCA region to Mexico and the US. Our quantitative analysis draws specifically on a subset of EMIF Sur data on a highly representative sample of Guatemalan, Honduran, and Salvadoran migrants who were deported from the US and repatriated by air to their countries of birth. Following a probabilistic sampling design, deported migrants are surveyed by trained interviewers shortly after their repatriation flights land, typically at locations where they are processed by local authorities and staff, such as airports or reception centers (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2015; Torre Cantalapiedra 2023).

Importantly, the EMIF Sur presents a rare opportunity to analyze the factors associated with deported migrants' intentions to return to the US. First, the survey contains rich and otherwise scarce data on deported individuals, including demographic and family characteristics, prior migration and deportation experiences, and future migration intentions. Although reporting intentions to remigrate does not guarantee actual migration in the future, a study on Mexican migrants found that aspirations to migrate strongly predicted subsequent migration trips to the US (Creighton 2013). Additionally, prior research has used the EMIF Sur to examine the remigration intentions of de-

4. In this sense, this research is not a mixed-methods study, which is generally understood to involve two or more different methodologies.

ported Central Americans, demonstrating the importance and reliability of this survey measure (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2015; Flores 2020). Second, because deported migrants are interviewed upon their return from the US, the data excludes those who have already initiated a return journey.

Despite its many strengths, the EMIF Sur has important limitations. First, the sample includes only migrants deported from the US to NCA, excluding those deported from the US to Mexico, from Mexico to NCA, or those de facto deported to NCA. Additionally, because the EMIF Sur captures deportation events, it is possible that a person who was deported multiple times is represented more than once in the data (Torre Cantalapiedra 2023).

From 2014 through 2018, the EMIF Sur included a total of 24,272 respondents. For this analysis, we exclude 5 respondents under the age of eighteen, as well as 2,599 who responded *not sure* when asked about their intentions to remigrate to the US, thereby limiting our analyses to the adult respondents who answered either *yes* or *no*.⁵ We also remove 1,699 respondents with missing data on variables used in the analysis, resulting in a final count of 19,969 deported migrants from NCA (92 percent of the subsample). Among them, 49 percent originated from El Salvador, 30 percent from Guatemala, and 21 percent from Honduras.

Survey Measures

We use a series of multivariable logistic regression models to examine two outcome variables: future and short-term intentions to return to the US post-deportation. The first measure asks respondents about their intentions to return to the US at some point in the future, with re-

sponses coded as 1 for *yes* and 0 for *no*. We then focus on the subset of respondents who reported intentions to remigrate in the future ($N = 10,296$) to assess their short-term intentions to remigrate to the US. Short-term remigration intentions were measured using a second survey question that asks respondents if they intend to return to the US within the next thirty days, with responses coded as 1 for *yes* and 0 for *no*.

Following the approach of Jodi Berger Cardoso and colleagues (2016), we use two explanatory variables to measure what these scholars describe as the involuntary transnational family structure of deported migrants, focusing our analyses on nuclear families—specifically, children and partners—who have been separated as a result of deportation. Specifically, we rely on two survey measures to capture respondents' transnational family structure: the geographical location of a respondent's spouse or partner (hereafter partner; 1 = US, 2 = NCA, 0 = no partner), and whether respondents left children under the age of fifteen (hereafter minor children) in the US (1 = left minor in US, 2 = left no minor in the US, 0 = nonparent).⁶

Finally, we account for key demographic and migration characteristics. Online appendix table A.1 provides information on variable operationalization.⁷ Demographic controls include gender (1 = male, 0 = female); age (in years); English proficiency (1 = yes, 0 = no); Indigenous language proficiency (1 = yes, 0 = no); level of education (1 = secondary education, 2 = high school, 3 = higher education, 0 = primary or no education); and country of origin (1 = Guatemala, 2 = Honduras, 0 = El Salvador). Migration-related controls associated with migration decisions include a continuous measure for the

5. In additional analyses not shown, we found that including *not sure* responses does not change the substantive results.

6. A limitation of the measure of child separation is that it only captures geographical information on minor children left behind in the US and does not capture data on the location of children of deported parents without minor children in the US. Another limitation is that the EMIF Sur does not capture the total number of children each respondent has. Nonetheless, prior research has relied on this measure item to examine parent-child separation and remigration intentions (Amuedo-Dorantes et al. 2015). Despite its limitations, the measure provides valuable insight into how transnational family structures are associated with the likelihood of reporting future and short-term remigration intentions.

7. The online appendix can be found at <https://www.rsfjournal.org/content/11/4/196/tab-supplemental>.

number of years spent in the US during the most recent migration spell, use of a coyote (a paid guide or smuggler) to enter the US (1 = no, 0 = yes); location of apprehension (1 = home, 2 = work, 3 = street or highway, 4 = other, 0 = desert or crossing border); the total number of deportations from the US, and a measure for deportations from Mexico (1 = one or more deportations, 0 = none), as research suggests that immigration enforcement in Mexico is associated with curbing the remigration intentions of deported migrants from NCA (Flores 2020). We also incorporate a continuous variable indicating the number of months spent in US detention prior to deportation, with values ranging from 0 to 12 months. Cases where detention exceeded 12 months are recoded as 12 months to address the skewed distribution of the data (see Saadi et al. 2025). Lastly, to control for potential time trends and seasonality, we control for the month and year of the survey, which is also the date when respondents were deported.

Qualitative Data and Analysis

The qualitative data for this article come from a larger ethnographic study focusing on how Central American youth experience violence while transiting through Mexico. During this project, the first author conducted twelve formal interviews (plus participant observation) with adult migrants who had been deported from the US at least once and were migrating through Mexico as they attempted to return to the US without authorization—the basis for their inclusion in the sample here. These interviews and field notes were collected throughout 2018 and 2019 at three different migrant shelters in Mexico, operated by civil and religious organizations. The shelters provide a range of services, including meals, basic medical attention, shelter, and legal aid, and also function as spaces where migrants can rest while traveling.⁸ The goal of the interviews was to understand migrants' motivations for migrating to the US and their experiences while migrating

through Mexico. All participants gave their consent prior to the interviews and were provided with a sheet with relevant information about the study.

Of the twelve participants, eleven were men, aged 32 to 44; seven were from Honduras, three were from Guatemala, and two from El Salvador. The twelfth participant was a woman from Honduras. All participants had lived in the US for at least a year and a half prior to their deportation and had partners and children residing there. All but one were traveling alone through Mexico; one was traveling with his cousin. None were assisted by a smuggler or other organization. Instead, they relied on their prior knowledge and experience to navigate the journey, believing that it was not worth the time or money to hire someone to help them cross to the US. Most respondents described their deportations as unexpected.

Regarding their deportations from the US, five participants were detained while driving, four in connection with domestic violence disputes, and one for drinking alcohol on the street.⁹ Two did not disclose the reasons for their apprehension and subsequent deportation. In all cases, deportation followed within weeks of being detained, and all respondents reported having little to no contact with immigration attorneys. After returning to their home countries, nine of the twelve migrants set out for Mexico within a week—two of them immediately after leaving their home country's reception facilities. Another three returned briefly to their home villages and cities to visit parents and siblings before beginning their journeys. Four participants had been deported from Mexico at least once.

The interview data and ethnographic field notes were open-coded using MAXQDA software for data analysis, and patterns were identified as central themes in the experiences of deported migrants traveling through Mexico. Data analysis followed a grounded theory approach, drawing on open-ended interviews conducted in Spanish and detailed field notes

8. Services vary greatly from shelter to shelter.

9. Four of the migrants mentioned being detained because of traffic violations. Each was initially arrested by a police officer who then turned them over to ICE.

to identify patterns related to the research question (Lareau 2021; Weiss 1995). All identifiable information was anonymized, including names, specific locations, and details related to respondents' detention and deportation from both the US and Mexico. The only participant characteristics that were not anonymized were gender, age, and nationality.

The small sample size is partly due to the methodology used and the vulnerability of the population. The first author's primary method for meeting migrants in transit through Mexico was ethnography, which emphasizes depth in sharing and understanding people's experiences before conducting formal interviews. Thus, interviews were conducted only after establishing a certain level of rapport with the respondents. This research methodology was slow and time-consuming and limited the number of migrants who could be interviewed during fieldwork. However, given the precarious and violent conditions in which these migrants move through Mexico, the first author found this approach effective in creating an ethical space where migrants felt comfortable sharing their personal experiences and views.

The method and field site also limited the scope of the sample to a specific type of migrant. Central Americans who move through migrant shelters in Mexico are, for the most part, men and are poorer than other migrants who can afford the services of smugglers (which is a faster way to arrive at the border). Thus, the sample is likely skewed toward poorer migrants and men. However, given that the sample is composed of deported migrants with family in the US, its scope helps to triangulate the quantitative findings of this study, which focuses specifically on this subsample of Central American migrants in transit through Mexico.

In the next section, we discuss the results of both analyses and conclude that separation from minor children in the US is significantly associated with reporting remigration intentions among recently deported Central Americans, especially if they are also separated from a partner in the US or are single parents, com-

pared to their single peers without children. In turn, the eagerness and urgency to return to their family in the US shape the way deported migrants approach their journeys through Mexico.

QUANTITATIVE FINDINGS

Table 1 presents summary statistics for the sample of deported migrants across family structure. Overall, the majority of respondents identified as male (83 percent), with an average age of 28. About 60 percent were apprehended on the street or highway, and, on average, had been deported 1.34 times by US authorities. Over half (52 percent) also reported intentions to return to the US in the future, with 29 percent of those reporting short-term intentions to remigrate within the next 30 days. As for respondents' transnational family structures, 54 percent of deported migrants who separated from minor children in the US also reported having a partner in the US. In contrast, deported parents without minor children in the US were more likely to have a partner in NCA (63 percent), while nonparents were more likely to report not having a partner (91 percent).¹⁰ Reporting intentions to remigrate to the US also varied by family structure: 65 percent of respondents with minor children in the US reported intentions to return in the future, compared to 51 percent and 49 percent of deported migrants without minor children in the US and nonparents, respectively. Similarly, parents separated from minor children in the US reported higher intentions to return within 30 days compared to the overall sample (36 percent versus 29 percent). Moreover, deported parents with minor children in the US had more prolonged contact with the immigration enforcement apparatus, spending an average of 4.06 months in detention prior to deportation, nearly double the average for the total sample (2.06 months).

We now turn to multivariable logistic regression models to examine the relationship between deported migrants' transnational family structure and their intentions to remigrate to the US. Table 2, model 1a estimates the asso-

10. In analyses not shown, we found that men were more likely than women to have minor children and a partner in the U.S., as well as to be a single parent with minor children living in the US.

Table 1. Summary Statistics by Transnational Family Structure

	Children		Nonparents	All
	Minor in US Percent or Mean (SD)	No Minor in US Percent or Mean (SD)	Percent or Mean (SD)	Percent or Mean (SD)
Intent to return				
In the future	0.65	0.51	0.49	0.52
Within thirty days	0.36	0.27	0.27	0.29
Partner characteristics				
Partner in US	0.54	0.05	0.02	0.10
Partner in NCA	0.07	0.63	0.07	0.30
No partner	0.39	0.32	0.91	0.61
Country of origin				
El Salvador	0.60	0.45	0.49	0.49
Guatemala	0.26	0.31	0.31	0.30
Honduras	0.14	0.24	0.20	0.21
Gender				
Male	0.92	0.82	0.81	0.83
Female	0.08	0.18	0.19	0.17
Age	32.84 (7.51)	31.52 (8.51)	23.54 (5.60)	27.89 (8.26)
Speaks English	0.46	0.11	0.12	0.16
Speaks an Indigenous language	0.07	0.09	0.10	0.09
Education level				
Primary or no education	0.40	0.46	0.28	0.37
Secondary education	0.30	0.29	0.30	0.30
High school	0.27	0.23	0.36	0.30
Higher education	0.03	0.02	0.05	0.04
Years in US (last spell)	6.75 (7.62)	0.96 (3.70)	0.94 (2.96)	1.62 (4.47)
No coyote	0.30	0.29	0.25	0.27
Months detained by US authorities	4.06 (10.26)	1.73 (7.50)	1.87 (5.21)	2.06 (6.98)
Total deportations by US authorities	1.56 (1.07)	1.37 (0.76)	1.26 (0.64)	1.34 (0.76)
Deportation by Mexican authorities	0.03	0.06	0.04	0.05
Apprehension location				
Border crossing attempt	0.16	0.37	0.35	0.34
Home	0.12	0.02	0.02	0.04
Work	0.05	0.01	0.01	0.01
Street/highway	0.64	0.59	0.61	0.60
Other	0.03	0.01	0.01	0.01
<i>N</i>	2,318	8,181	9,470	19,969

Source: Authors' compilation based on EMIF Sur 2014–2018.

Note: The number of observations for the subset of deported migrants reporting intentions to return within 30 days is smaller ($N = 10,296$). Percentages may not add up to 100 because of rounding. *Minor in US* refers to children under the age of fifteen in the US.

ciation between separation from minor children in the US and intentions to return in the future. Table 2, model 2a adjusts for partner location, and model 3a examines the interaction effect between separation from minor children and partner location. Table 2, models 1b through 3b are similar to models 1a through 3a; however, these models include results for short-term remigration intentions among the subset of respondents who reported intentions to return in the future. All models include robust standard errors to account for heteroscedasticity. They also control for the demographic and migration-related characteristics discussed above, as well as country of origin and survey month and survey year fixed effects. For parsimony, we report only the results for our two explanatory variables; full model estimates, including coefficients for covariates, are available in the online appendix table A.2. We present regression results as odds ratios (OR).

Intentions to Return in the Future: In table 2, model 1a, we observe that the odds of reporting intentions to remigrate in the future are 1.61 times higher ($p < .001$) for deported migrants separated from minor children in the US, compared to nonparents. We found no statistically significant results for parents who were not separated from minor children in the US. However, after adjusting for partner controls in table 2, model 2a, we found that parents of minor children in the US (OR, 1.44, $p < .001$) and parents without minor children in the US (OR, 1.18, $p < .001$) had higher odds of reporting intentions to return in the future than nonparents. Turning to partner characteristics, deported migrants with a partner in the US had 1.33 times higher odds of reporting intentions to remigrate compared to those without a partner, while having a partner in NCA reduced these odds (OR, 0.79, $p < .001$).

To illustrate the interaction between separation from children and partner location in table 2, model 3a, figure 1 presents the predicted probability of reporting intentions to remigrate to the US in the future, stratified by partner location and separation from minor children,

with covariates held at their means. We observe that deported migrants with a partner in the US and the non-partnered have the highest predicted probability of reporting intentions to return in the future compared to respondents with a partner in NCA. Among those with a partner in the US and the non-partnered, deported migrants separated from minor children in the US have a higher predicted probability of reporting intentions to remigrate (.46 and .36, respectively) compared to nonparents. However, the confidence intervals overlap for those with a partner in the US. The predicted probability of reporting intentions to remigrate to the US is higher for deported migrants separated from both minor children and a partner in the US, compared to singles without children (.46 vs. .29, $p = 0.001$).¹¹

Intentions to Return in the Short-Term: The results in table 2, model 1b indicate that the odds of reporting intentions to return within 30 days are 1.57 times higher among respondents with minor children in the US who reported intentions to return in the future, relative to those without minor children ($p < .001$). Table 2, model 2b continues to show a significant and positive association between being separated from minor children in the US and reporting intentions to return within 30 days, relative to nonparents (OR, 1.52, $p < 0.001$). No significant results were found for partner characteristics. The significant interaction term in table 2, model 3b shows that short-term intentions vary by the partner characteristic of deported migrants who were separated from minor children in the US.

Figure 2 shows that, among respondents who reported intentions to remigrate in the future, single parents separated from minor children in the US and deported migrants separated from both minor children and partners in the US have a higher predicted probability (.22 and .20, respectively) of also reporting short-term remigration intentions compared to singles without children. Notably, there is evidence that among deported migrants separated from minor children in the US, those with

11. In analyses not shown, we examined heterogeneity in results with subgroup analyses by gender and found consistent patterns. However, due to the small sample size, we could not examine women's short-term remigration intentions.

Table 2. Odds Ratios from Logistic Regression Analysis of Intentions to Return to the US Among Recently Deported Central Americans

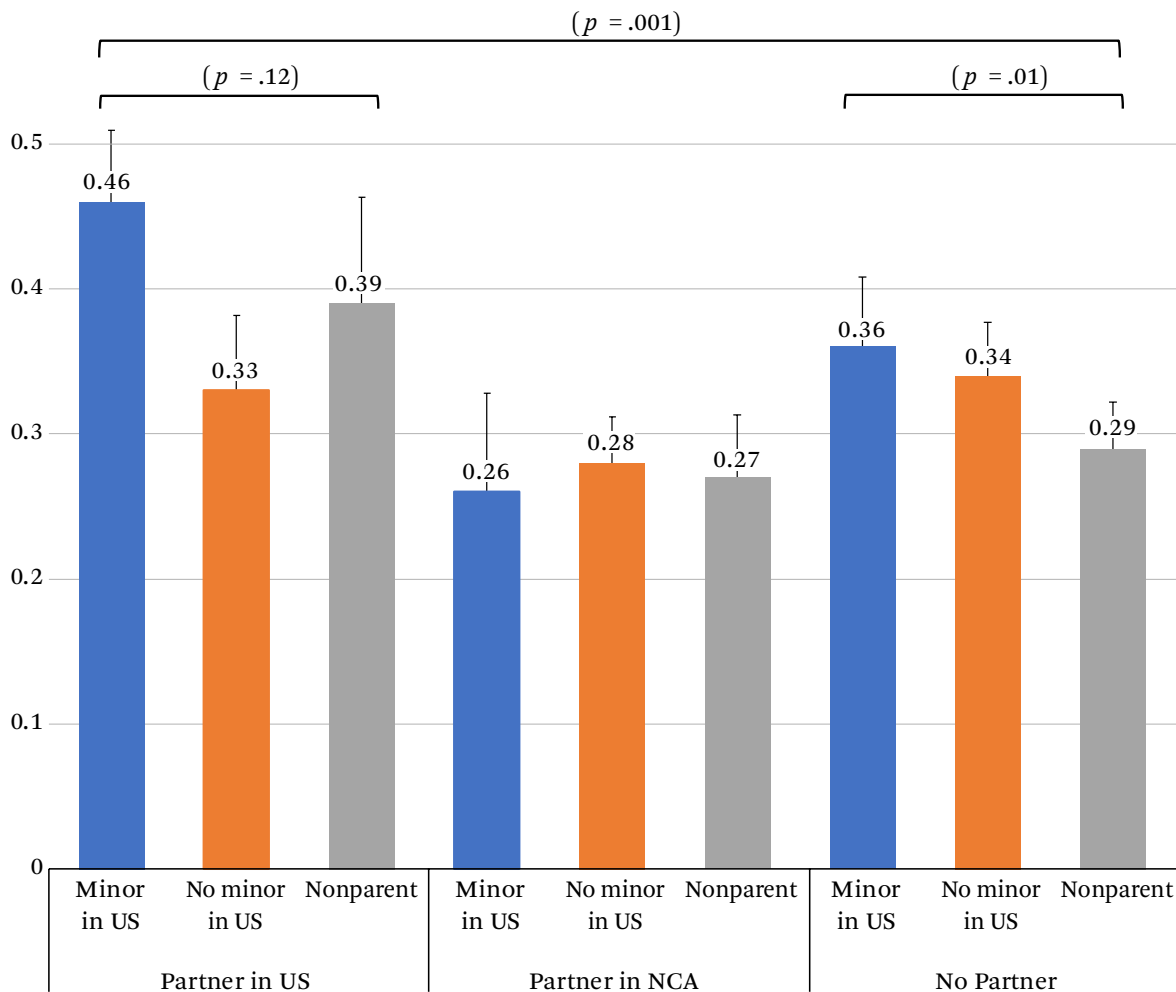
	In the Future			Within Thirty Days		
	Model 1a	Model 2a	Model 3a	Model 1b	Model 2b	Model 3b
Children characteristics						
Minor in US (reference: nonparent)	1.61***	1.44***	1.38***	1.57***	1.52***	1.77***
No minor in US	1.05	1.18***	1.26***	1.01	1.05	1.05
Partner characteristics						
Partner in US (reference: no partner)	—	1.33***	1.55**	—	1.07	1.06
Partner in NCA	—	0.79***	0.91	—	0.94	1.17
Interaction						
Partner in US × Minor in US	—	—	0.98	—	—	0.86
Partner in NCA × Minor in US	—	—	0.70	—	—	0.41**
Partner in US × No minor in US	—	—	0.60**	—	—	1.25
Partner in NCA × No minor in US	—	—	0.82*	—	—	0.80
Constant	0.36***	0.35***	0.35***	0.17***	0.17***	0.17***
Observations	19,969	19,969	19,969	10,296	10,296	10,296

Source: Authors' compilation based on EMIF Sur 2014–2018.

Note: All models control for gender, age, English, Indigenous language, education, years in the US, coyote, months detained by US authorities (values exceeding twelve months coded as 12), total deportations by US authorities, deportation by Mexican authorities, and apprehension location. All models include country of origin and survey month and survey year fixed effects. *Minor in US* refers to children under the age of fifteen in the U.S.

* $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$

Figure 1. Predicted Probability of Reporting Intentions to Return to the US in the Future, by Partner and Children Characteristics



Source: Authors' compilations based on EMIF Sur 2014–2018.

Note: Derived from table 2, model 3a. Hatched lines on bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals. Brackets and accompanying information report results of two-tailed difference in means.

a partner in NCA had the lowest predicted probability of also reporting an intention to return within 30 days (.12), compared to .22 respondents without a partner and .20 among those with a partner in the US.

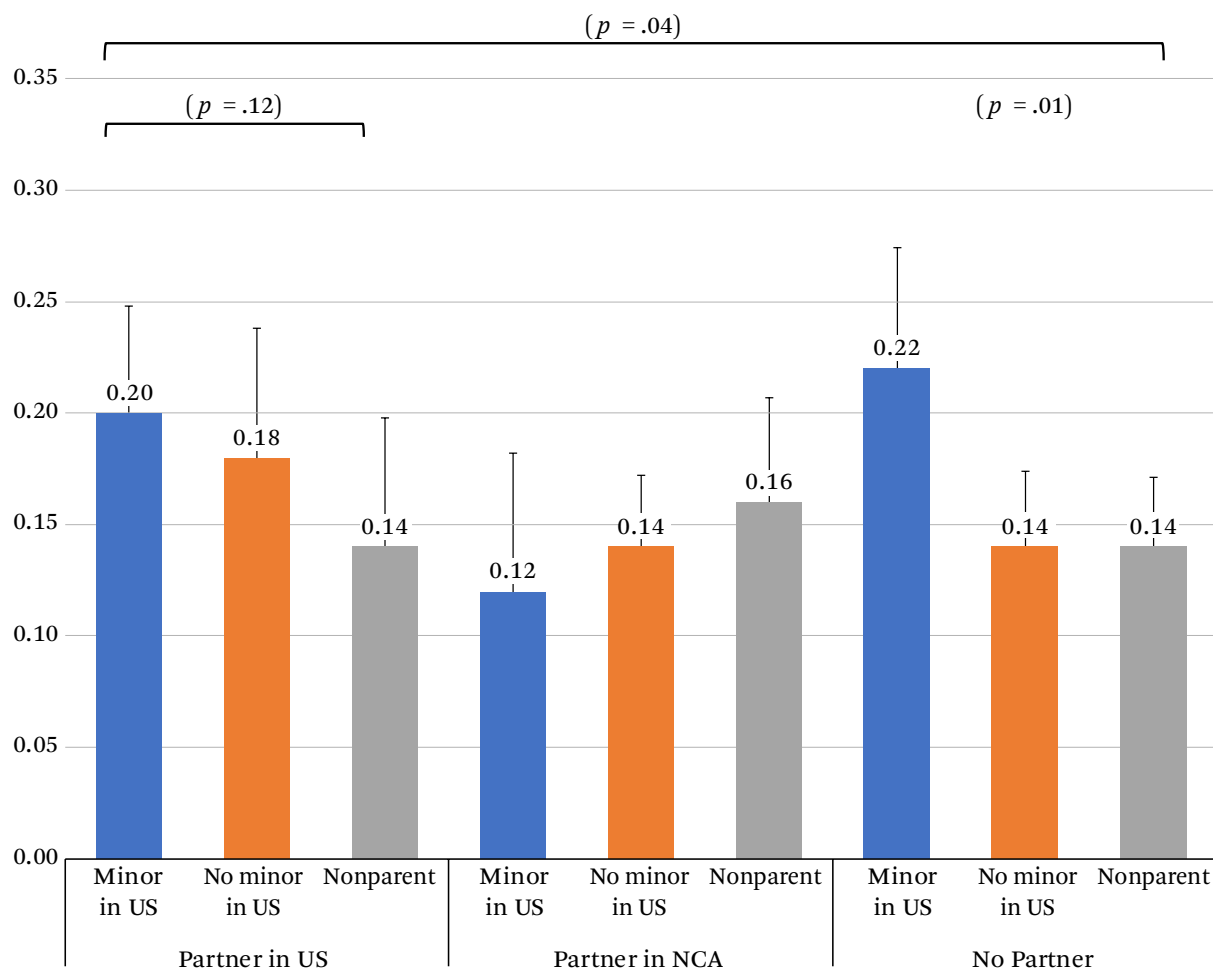
Overall, we find that deported parents separated from minor children in the US report significantly higher intentions to remigrate to the US in the future and the short-term, especially when they were also separated from a partner in the US or were single parents, compared to singles without children. In particular, separation from minor children and a partner in the US emerged as a crucial factor in increasing the probability of reporting intentions to remigrate in the future, while being a single parent of mi-

nor children in the US increased the probability of also reporting intentions to remigrate within the next thirty days.

QUALITATIVE FINDINGS

While our quantitative results are telling, they do not fully capture how and why deported parents with minor children in the US navigate the urgency of remigrating. Thus, we now turn to our qualitative results to explore the mechanisms that shape the migration journeys of these parents as they pursue their remigration intentions. For undocumented immigrants, precarity and the threat of deportation lurk at every stage of the journey through Mexico. Rising rates of detention and deportation of Cen-

Figure 2. Predicted Probability of Reporting Intentions to Return to the US Within Thirty Days, by Partner and Children Characteristics



Source: Authors' compilations based on EMIF Sur 2014–2018.

Note: Derived from table 2, model 3b. Hatched lines on bars represent 95 percent confidence intervals. Brackets and accompanying information report results of two-tailed difference in means.

tral Americans in Mexico, combined with Mexico's increasingly restrictive migration policies and pervasive violence and insecurity in the region, have transformed the journey to the US Southwest border by land into a potentially deadly passage. We identify three key ways separation from family in the US affects the transit experience of deported NCA migrants. First, sudden deportations disrupt family economic and social dynamics, often leaving loved ones in the US to grapple with the collateral consequences of deportation. This instability intensifies the deported person's urgency to remigrate as quickly as possible to stabilize their family's situation, especially when they are the primary economic provider. Second, these family pressures lead migrants in transit to take

greater risks to hasten their return journey. Third, despite facing several obstacles during their transit, including deportations, assaults, and health issues, deported parents exhibited remarkable determination throughout their journey through Mexico. These themes are explored in greater detail in the following subsections.

The Nuclear Family and Urgency to Return

Consistent with previous research, deported adults described their deportations as a shocking event for themselves and their families (Andrews 2023). This study's novel contribution lies in revealing how family separation as a result of deportation intensifies the urgency mi-

grants feel to return to the US as quickly as possible.

When asked about their main reasons for returning to the US, all twelve respondents noted the harm their absence was causing their families, especially economically. For instance, Rodrigo, a 34-year-old man from Honduras, expressed his urgent need to return to the US to stabilize his family's financial situation: "Right now, what most worries me is getting there [to Texas] as soon as possible and paying off what we owe. My wife right now is working more, but that's still not the same as me working in construction. And it's not the same either with our son, who has to stay home alone now. Our family members already gave us money, and we have to pay it back. That's what I'm thinking about right now. It's what most worries me, and the longer it takes, the worse our situation will get with all the debt."

Rodrigo further explained that if he did not return to the US soon, his wife would likely have to sell his cars to cover rent and food, and to send him money as he moved through Mexico. Since coyotes often charge Central Americans between \$15,000 and \$19,000 to travel from their home countries to their destinations in the US, many deported migrants, like Rodrigo, request only the minimum amount, typically just enough to cover the coyote fee to cross the US-Mexico border. Deported parents did this as a strategy to avoid placing additional financial strain on their families. In Rodrigo's case, he expected that once he reached the US-Mexico border, his wife and extended family (such as his cousins) would likely need to send a much larger sum to pay coyotes for his crossing and to finance the final leg of his journey to Texas. As a result, many opted for the cheapest mode of transportation through Mexico: walking without the assistance of coyotes to save money.

Given these financial pressures, migrants often prioritized returning quickly despite the precarious conditions, sometimes even hatching return plans while still in US detention centers or on their repatriation flights. Rodrigo, for

example, described his thoughts during the flight back to Honduras: "When they put me on the plane, that's when I knew they were going to kick me out. And since then, I've been thinking about what I could do to get back quickly to my family. With my wife. I got there [to Honduras], got off the plane, and the Honduran government gives you a lot of speeches. But I already knew that I wasn't going back to stay. I was going to return fast."

Even those who were no longer living with their children or had separated from their partners felt pressured to return to the US to cover their family's expenses, such as rent and car payments. They also expressed fear that their cars might have to be sold, leaving them without transportation to get to work or visit their families.¹²

While discussions about returning to the US were often centered on family finances, some deported parents also emphasized the emotional difficulty of being separated from their families. Six out of the twelve respondents mentioned feelings of loneliness and isolation due to their separation from children and partners, as well as anxiety about their loved ones' well-being. On one occasion, a man was seen leaving a migrant shelter to stand outside alone for an extended period. Later, he shared that he was trying to stay calm and hold back tears after a phone conversation with his children.

Our findings reveal that the economic concerns of deported migrants in our study are twofold: In the immediate term, they feel an urgent need to return to the US to ease financial woes; in the longer term, they fear being unable to reunite with their families and stabilize their financial situation, especially if deportation leads to job loss or forces them to sell their belongings. These economic pressures are further compounded by deep feelings of loneliness and isolation during their perilous journey back to the US. The last point is especially salient for deported migrants from NCA, who, compared to their Mexican counterparts, face a longer and more expensive journey. In the following section, we explore how this ur-

12. In addition, two men mentioned that their employers were holding jobs for them, but they were worried the jobs would not remain available for long. Thus, their urgency to return was motivated by their need for employment and their concern that they could lose their jobs and have to start over.

agency to return shapes their approach to crossing Mexico.

Balancing Risk and Reward: Approaches to the Journey

While eager to reunite with their families in the US, deported Central Americans are acutely aware of the perils of crossing Mexico. All respondents recalled their previous experiences as migrants moving through Mexico, describing the journey as arduous and tiring. They were also aware of the increasing risk of delinquency and robbery along the route. Each of the twelve respondents expressed fear and concern for their safety, noting that they would likely go hungry, sleep in fields or on the streets, and face the threat of robbery and kidnapping. This sense of insecurity was not confined to the US-Mexico border—which is often the focus of studies on Mexican migration (for example, Andrews 2023)—but persisted throughout their entire time and journey through Mexico. Despite these dangers, their strong desire to reach the border often led them to take calculated risks to keep advancing.

These opposing forces—fear and urgency—were a recurring theme in interviews. Brandon, a forty-three-year-old migrant from Honduras interviewed in Northern Mexico, explained: “Right now, all I want is to get to [the US-Mexico border city of] Tijuana and cross as soon as possible. That’s why I am not staying in this [shelter] for very long. I am not planning to rest much these days; I just want to move as fast as I can to the border.” While Brandon recognized that rest and careful planning would be beneficial as he traversed the most dangerous stretch of desert in Mexico, his urgency to reunite with his family pushed him forward. Brandon left the shelter early the next morning, after spending just one night.

In fact, many respondents chose to sacrifice rest in favor of moving more quickly, driven by the urgency of their situation. Sergio, a twenty-eight-year-old man from Guatemala, acknowledged his fatigue and the potential dangers of sleep deprivation, but he saw it as a necessary tradeoff for a faster return to the US. As he explained: “Many people here tell us about how hard the crossing is, and I’m already feeling it

this week I’ve spent traveling. But I try not to think about it because right now, my family comes first.” Others took even greater calculated risks. For example, Yoni, a forty-two-year-old man from Honduras traveling through southern Mexico, decided to join a group of men preparing to leave a shelter and head north, despite feeling that they were neither reliable nor trustworthy. He decided the risk of traveling with them was worth it if it meant reaching the US as fast as possible. Some respondents also braved harsh weather conditions, such as traveling through pouring rain or extreme heat, and traversed areas notorious for violence or danger. At a migrant shelter near the Arizona–Mexico border, for example, a group of three migrants preparing to cross the desert expressed that they were terribly afraid of what awaited them. Still, they viewed this route as the quickest way to return to the US and calculated that this path would reduce the likelihood of being apprehended by immigration authorities.

The urgency to reunite with their family as quickly as possible impacted how deported migrants approached their journey through Mexico. Most were not interested in staying in Mexico and applying for legal protection, as they believed doing so would prolong their stay in the country for at least a few months. One respondent described attempting to apply for asylum in southern Mexico but quickly becoming disheartened. The distance from his family weighed heavily on him, and he grew anxious about the suffering they were enduring in the US. Unable to endure the wait, he abandoned his asylum petition and resumed his journey north, explaining that he “couldn’t keep waiting.”

Migrant Determination

The urgency to reunite with family in the US remains strong even among those who have endured violence or forced removal while transiting through Mexico. Six of the twelve respondents had been robbed at some point in Mexico before the interview, and four had been deported from various parts of Mexico to their home countries following an earlier deportation from the US. One respondent also suffered a severe concussion after falling from a train,

likely due to exhaustion. These traumatic experiences of violence, removal, and danger are known to negatively impact migrant mobility (Díaz de León 2023; Galli 2023; Vogt 2018). Yet, despite the toll these experiences took, they did not quell migrants' overwhelming desire to continue moving and reunite with their families in the US as quickly as possible.

Being deported from Mexico and having to start over can place considerable mental strain on migrants and double the already expensive costs for those who have hired smugglers. However, for the four migrants deported from Mexico, the setback of another deportation did not deter them from their goal. While it created additional suffering and uncertainty, they viewed deportation from Mexico as merely a temporary delay in their arrival in the US. For instance, when Luis, whose story is introduced at the beginning of the article, was asked about his feelings after being deported from Mexico back to El Salvador, he described it as a depressing moment, mostly due to the need to start over and the temporary loss of communication with his family. He also knew that upon arriving in El Salvador, he would need to ask his wife for more money to restart the journey. Despite the stress and frustration, none of the migrants reported that deportation from Mexico led them to abandon their efforts. Instead, deportations from Mexico led migrants to explore alternative migration strategies. For example, Felipe, a thirty-three-year-old Honduran interviewed near the Mexico–Guatemala border, had initially attempted to migrate cheaply without borrowing money from his family in the US. However, after his deportation from Mexico, he sought a loan from his US relatives to travel more quickly, such as by bus. He believed this borrowed money would allow him to reach his destination, resume earning money, and reunite with his family more quickly. In this case, subsequent deportations increased his urgency to return by the fastest means possible.

Regarding crime, half of our interviewees reported being robbed at some point during their journey through Mexico. They were stripped of cash and cellphones, and, in some cases, they were also subjected to physical assault. Such experiences were demoralizing and stressful, making them more cautious about their move-

ments and the routes they took thereafter. However, they remained undeterred in their goal of reaching the US as soon as possible. For example, Francisco, a thirty-five-year-old Salvadoran, described being robbed near a train track in southern Mexico: "I mean, it does sting when they rob you, but at least they didn't do anything else to me. It doesn't make you want to give up. But it does make you think, like what if this keeps happening? What if I don't make it? What will happen to my family? And you think about how you have to be careful, because you *have* to make it [to the US]. You just have to keep advancing as much as you can, because you have to get there."

Francisco's account illustrates how, despite the violence and loss, the urgent need to reunite with family as quickly as possible remained a driving force. While incidents of robbery made them reconsider their approach to the journey, they did not alter their ultimate goal.

Migrants were acutely aware of the tension between moving as quickly as possible and exposing themselves to additional risks. Oscar, a forty-three-year-old from Honduras, spoke of the "contradiction" between his urgency to reach the US and the dangers that could derail his journey. He had already fallen from a train after dozing off, nearly losing a hand under the wheels of the train car. Still, he said, "I'm going to keep risking my life to get there, that's just how it is." Oscar's words reflect the pull of family reunification—strong enough to compel deported migrants to take on additional risk while transiting through Mexico, even as they remain painfully aware of the challenges involved in reaching the US–Mexico border. His words also reflect the profound legal violence that deported migrants endure under restrictive immigration policies (Escamilla García 2024; Menjívar and Abrego 2012). These policies not only separate families but also make safe and legal avenues for reunification nearly impossible, leaving many deported migrants with little to no choice but to take life-threatening risks in order to be reunited with their loved ones.

CONCLUSION

In this article, we investigate the remigration intentions of deported Central Americans and

the transit experiences that shape their perilous return journeys through Mexico as they attempt to reach the US undetected. Specifically, we examine how involuntary transnational family structures, focusing on separation from minor children and partners in the US, are associated with future and short-term intentions to remigrate, and how the urgency to reunite with these family members affects deported migrants' transit through Mexico. Findings from our analysis of survey data on recently deported NCAs, along with interviews with deported NCA migrants in transit through Mexico, tell a powerful story: Deported migrants separated from minor children in the US report greater intentions to remigrate to the US—particularly when they are also separated from a partner in the US or are single parents. Despite the perils of crossing Mexico in an era of intensified border externalization, deported parents remain determined to follow through with their plans, constantly weighing how to make the journey as quickly and safely as possible.

This article contributes to the post-deportation literature in several ways by demonstrating that deportation is neither an isolated nor a final event—it implicates entire social structures, while also affecting people at the most individual level. First, we build on existing literature that demonstrates how family separation is linked to the remigration of deported parents. We further expand on this finding by demonstrating that separation from minor children and a partner in the US significantly increases the probability of reporting intentions to remigrate to the US in the future. Of those who reported future intentions to return, being a single parent of minor children in the US increases the probability of also reporting intentions to return in the short-term, compared to single people without children. Meanwhile, deported parents with minor children in the US and a partner in NCA were the least likely to report short-term remigration intentions. These findings reveal important differences related to transnational family structures and the timing or urgency of return.

Second, this article advances the literature on remigration by examining how deported migrants navigate their return journey to the US

amid the context of border externalization. By focusing on Central American migrants' experiences as they traverse Mexico, we highlight the role of the nuclear family in motivating attempts to remigrate, even in adverse conditions. Respondents' narratives illustrate the economic and emotional disruptions caused by deportation, which spur their urgent attempts to return and alleviate their family's suffering. Furthermore, interviews reveal that migrants perceive their families' economic situations worsening the longer they are away, which contributes to a sense of urgency. However, migrants are also aware that transit through Mexico is dangerous, often leading them to move rapidly and take significant risks to minimize their exposure to violence and expedite their arrival in the US.

Future research can build on this study's contributions while addressing some of its limitations. First, future research should incorporate more dynamic measures related to the children of deported migrants, such as their age, gender, nativity, legal status, and primary place of residence. This would, for instance, allow for a better understanding of the remigration intentions of parents with minor children in NCA, who may support their children through remittances, an important question our data cannot answer. Second, future research should examine remigration experiences across different groups of deported migrants, such as women, children, the elderly, and those who reenter the US with the assistance of a coyote, as each group may have distinct motivations for remigrating that could affect their movement and transit experiences to the country of deportation. Finally, comparative studies of deported migrants who have settled in Mexico after being unable to reach the US could offer valuable evidence into the externalization of the US-Mexico border, which increasingly continues to expand into countries like Guatemala and Honduras.

Our findings challenge the assumption that deportations and border externalization effectively deter or reduce unauthorized migration to the US. Instead, they point to the need for a fundamental rethinking of how migration to the US is understood in an era increasingly defined by heightened immigration enforcement

and mass deportations. As we demonstrate, forceful removal has not curbed unauthorized migration; rather, it has produced a distinct flow of migrants—those who return to the US after deportation. As Carolina Valdivia (2025, this issue) reminds us, “for many deportees, it is often a matter of when to attempt reentry, not if.” This dynamic is especially salient for deported parents who are separated from their nuclear family in the US. Given the legal barriers that make it nearly impossible for families to reunite through legal channels, deported parents may see unauthorized reentry as their only viable option, one that exposes them to significant legal risks and dangerous conditions during their return journeys (Boehm 2017).

The need to understand the remigration intentions and experiences of deported migrants has become even more urgent amid the second Donald J. Trump administration’s intensified efforts to detain and deport undocumented immigrants, which has in turn heightened the risk of family separation. One recent example is the termination of Temporary Protected Status for Honduras, leaving nearly 72,000 Hondurans without protection from deportation (Kim 2025). This urgency is further amplified by US and Mexican immigration control policies—namely, deportation and border externalization—that create a hostile and deadly immigration environment in Mexico for migrants attempting to reenter without authorization. Thus, this study underscores the need for immigration policies that move beyond deterrence and punishment and instead focus on keeping families together.

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Hyper-Illegality, Reentry, and Everyday Life in the United States Post-Deportation



CAROLINA VALDIVIA

This article centers on the experiences of an understudied segment of the undocumented population: individuals who reenter the United States post-deportation without authorization and their family members. The state classifies unauthorized reentry after deportation as a criminal offense rather than a civil violation, thereby designating these individuals as felons. On the basis of 113 in-depth interviews with undocumented returnees and their relatives, I find that this criminal labeling leads families to internalize a sense of criminality, experience intensified fear and anxiety, and adopt more extreme strategies to evade detection. Their experiences are a prime example of what I term hyper-illegality—an enduring condition of legal precarity or liminal status whereby individuals are permanently marked by conditional inclusion and heightened vulnerability to state surveillance and punishment.

Keywords: illegality, hyper-illegality, immigration enforcement, US immigration policies, criminalization of immigrants

In the contemporary US context, migrant illegality (that is, the legal and social condition of being undocumented) represents an axis of social inequality that affects millions (Asad and Clair 2018; Flores and Schachter 2018; Massey

2007; Menjívar 2021).¹ This includes the approximately 10.3 million people who are undocumented and the estimated 16.2 million people who are part of mixed-status families where at least one member is undocumented (American

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© 2025 Russell Sage Foundation. Valdivia, Carolina. 2025. "Hyper-Illegality, Reentry, and Everyday Life in the United States Post-Deportation." *RSF: The Russell Sage Foundation Journal of the Social Sciences* 11(4): 217–37. <https://doi.org/10.7758/RSF.2025.11.4.10>. I would like to thank the individuals who confided in me and participated in this project. It is my hope that this article reflects their experiences in a way that helps humanize issues of immigration and deportation. I am also grateful to Angie Monreal, Jose Ruiz, Sussana Mendoza, Luis Gutierrez, Evelyn Jimenez, Priscilla Martinez, and Yanaisa Lopez for their research assistance. A special thank you to the organizers of this special issue, as well as Naomi Sugie, Susan Coutin, Danielle Puretz, and participants of the Socio-Legal Cultural Workshop at UC Irvine, for their helpful feedback on earlier versions of this draft. Direct correspondence to: Carolina Valdivia, at c.valdivia@uci.edu, 5300 Social and Behavioral Sciences Gateway, Irvine, CA, 92697, United States.

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1. To be sure, there are specific policies and practices that create the legal category and political identity of the illegalized (or the undocumented) (Chavez 2007; De Genova 2002; Menjivar and Kanstroom 2013; Ngai 2004; Willen 2007). In broad terms, the theoretical concept of migrant illegality captures both its production (that is,

Immigration Council 2021). As such, migrant illegality impacts how millions of people in the United States not only navigate legal and social systems but also experience everyday life as individuals and as members of families and communities (Abrego 2014; Dreby 2015; Gonzales 2015; Menjívar and Kanstroom 2013).

Illegality carries vast economic, social, and psychological consequences for undocumented immigrants and their loved ones. The lack of legal status can compel undocumented immigrants to alter their behavior and routines to avoid encounters with enforcement (García 2019; Valdivia 2019). It can also derail undocumented students' educational trajectories and aspirations (Abrego 2006; Gonzales 2015). Undocumented immigrants also contend with acute levels of fear, stress, and anxiety and face difficulty accessing health-care services (Gonzales et al. 2013; Menjívar and Abrego 2012). Its effects can extend to individuals who have been granted temporary legal protection such as Temporary Protected Status or Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) (Burciaga and Malone 2021; Hamilton et al. 2021; Menjívar 2006) or among US citizen children whose parents are undocumented (Abrego 2019; Zayas 2015). At the family level, illegality results in economic hardships and psychological distress, especially following a parent's deportation (Dreby 2015; Patler and Gonzalez 2023; Valdivia 2021).

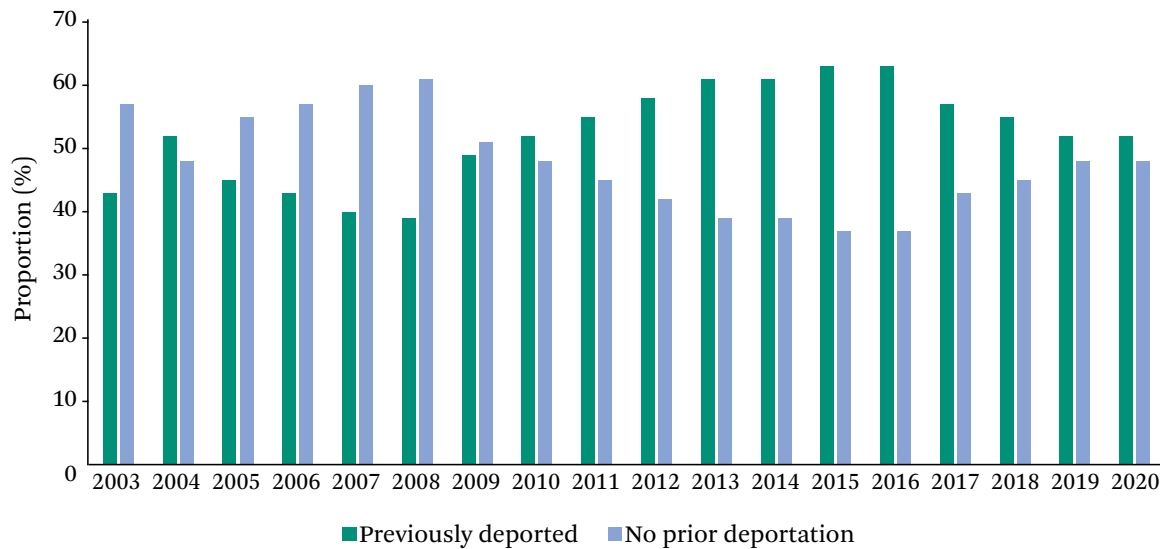
Despite great advances in the literature, existing studies on illegality have largely overlooked the unique experiences of undocumented individuals who are deported from the United States and subsequently return (that is, undocumented returnees).² This is a critical gap in the literature, given that individuals with existing deportation histories represent a growing segment of the undocumented and deportee populations. According to data obtained by the Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC) at Syracuse University, individuals with existing deportation records accounted for more than half of all deportations conducted by Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) between fiscal years 2003 and 2016.³ In fiscal year 2015 alone, 63 percent of deported individuals had an existing deportation record. This reveals that the disparity between the number of people who are deported with an existing deportation record and the number of people who are deported without one is growing (see figure 1). As the state increases deportations, a growing proportion of deportees may have been deported before. In this context, many undocumented people who enter the US may be reentering the country but with deportation records that compound the challenges and dangers of doing so.

There is an urgent need to understand the experiences of individuals who return to the United States post-deportation without autho-

the policies that make people undocumented) and its condition (that is, the practices that regulate the movement of people who are undocumented). Among scholars who closely examine the latter, the term *illegality* is typically employed to refer to an individual's awareness of their lack of legal immigration status and their experiences navigating the wide range of limitations and barriers associated with being undocumented (Abrego 2014; Dreby 2015; Gonzales 2011, 2015). Illegality must also be understood as a racialized legal status (Asad and Clair 2018; Menjívar 2021), which has become especially synonymous with Mexican-ness (Armenta 2017; De Genova 2004; Flores and Schachter 2018; Menjívar and Kanstroom 2013).

2. While the term *returnee* is typically associated with individuals who migrate to the United States and subsequently return to their countries of birth either by voluntary or coerced means (see, for example, Guzmán Elizalde 2022; Silver and Manzanares 2023), here, I employ it to refer to individuals who have returned to the US post-deportation given their deep and familial ties to the United States, as well as to recognize their hopes and intentions to live there.

3. Statistics come from TRAC's "Historical Data: Immigration and Customs Enforcement Removals," which focuses on removals conducted by ICE during the respective fiscal years (2003–2016). It is important to note that some deportations were initiated by a different agency—for example, Customs and Border Patrol or law enforcement through Section 287(g) agreements—and, at some point, those apprehensions were transferred over to ICE for removal proceedings (<https://trac.syr.edu/phptools/immigration/removehistory/>).

Figure 1. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) Removals

Source: Chart created by author using data from the Transactional Records Access Clearinghouse (TRAC), Syracuse University, <https://tracreports.org/phptools/immigration/remove/>.

rization, and for this, we must refine conceptualizations of migrant illegality to better reveal and account for new and compounded layers of illegality. To this end, this article draws on 113 in-depth interviews with individuals who have returned to the United States post-deportation or have an immediate family member who has. Given the legal consequences of deportation, which I explain in detail, individuals who attempt to return to the US post-deportation often must do so through clandestine means. This makes their status even more precarious as they become compoundingly unauthorized upon their return. That is, once they reenter without legal status post-deportation, they not only return to their former experience as undocumented immigrants but also face a changed and more severe relationship to the state. This status involves harsher legal classifications and punishments. Specifically, their reentry is no longer just a civil issue but is considered a criminal one. The state treats undocumented returnees as felons, and there are significant penalties associated with this classification.⁴

These interviews form the basis for my theorization of what I refer to as hyper-illegality—an enduring condition of legal precarity or

liminal status whereby individuals are permanently marked by conditional belonging and heightened vulnerability to state surveillance and punishment. The production of hyper-illegality involves the state's escalation from lesser to more severe legal classifications and punitive measures for specific actions (such as an unauthorized reentry after deportation) through evolving policies and enforcement practices. This escalation leads to a significant qualitative shift in the consciousness and lived experiences of those directly targeted and their immediate family members. More specifically, the state classifies unauthorized reentry after deportation as a criminal offense rather than a civil violation, thereby designating these individuals as felons—a process that constitutes the production of hyper-illegality. This legal transition not only marks a shift in an individual's enforcement status (Valdivia, forthcoming), from deportee to returnee, but also transforms an individual's consciousness and behavior: As part of the production of hyper-illegality, returnees and their family members internalize a sense of criminality. This internalization, in turn, contributes to the condition of hyper-illegality, which is marked by intensified fear and anxiety, as well as the

4. 8 U. S. C. § 1325.

adoption of more extreme strategies to evade detection. Although the concept of hyper-illegality can be applied to other segments of the population (an issue I will return to in the discussion section), the experience of undocumented returnees brings hyper-illegality into sharper focus.

In the immigration context, the concept of hyper-illegality helps us recognize the changed relationship individuals have with the state owing to their undocumented status and deportation history. This concept reveals the unique set of challenges undocumented returnees face in negotiating their lack of legal status and their deportation record. For individuals who return to the US post-deportation clandestinely, both their undocumented status and their previous deportation(s) bar them from pathways to legal protection, instill in them a sense of criminality, compound their traumas and fears, and prevent them from accessing resources otherwise available to undocumented immigrants who do not have a deportation record. In many ways, my research shows, individuals' deportation history exacerbates the barriers and worries that are typically associated with being undocumented. By distinguishing the hyper-illegalized nature of undocumented returnees' experiences, this concept offers immigration scholars, policymakers, and other stakeholders a nuanced framework from which to recognize the unique challenges faced by a growing segment of the immigrant population and the broader dynamics of (hyper-)illegalization, including its spillover effects, amid increasing deportations and post-deportation reentries.

POLICY BACKGROUND

Undocumented individuals who have been deported from the United States are generally barred from legally returning. How long a person is barred varies. Under the Immigration and Nationality Act (INA) sections 212(a)(9)(B)(i)(I) and (II), and 212(a)(9)(C)(i)(I), there are three types of unlawful presence bars for which a noncitizen may be found inadmissible unless an exception applies. There is the three- or ten-year bar, as well as the permanent bar.⁵ The three-year bar applies to individuals who "seek admission within three years of departing the United States, after having accrued more than 180 days but less than one year of unlawful presence during a single stay and before removal proceedings begin" (USCIS 2022). The ten-year bar applies to individuals who accrued a longer period of unlawful presence (one year or more) during a single stay and subsequently departed. The permanent bar applies to individuals who "accrued more than one year of unlawful presence in the aggregate during one or more stays in the United States" (USCIS 2022). Notably, these bars are triggered the moment an individual departs or is ordered to be removed from the United States, whether through a formal deportation, a removal order, or a voluntary return.⁶ Individuals who are subjected to the three- or ten-year bar are expected to wait for the duration of the bar before they can apply for an adjustment of status or other means of legal reentries such as a tourist visa if they meet all other eligibility requirements.⁷ In addition to possibly triggering an unlawful presence bar, individuals who are deported are generally barred from return-

5. See Patler and Jones (2025, this issue) for a discussion of how these bars shape migrants' entry into the US deportation system.

6. Depending on the nature of the voluntary return, immigration agencies may or may not have records of the departure.

7. On March 25, 2022, the Northwest Immigrant Rights Project (NWIRP) filed a class action lawsuit in the state of Washington known as *Velasco v. USCIS*, No. 22-cv-368, challenging USCIS's previous policy interpretation requiring noncitizens to spend the applicable statutory three-year or ten-year period outside the United States or maintain continuous lawful presence during that time. On June 24, 2022, USCIS issued new guidance recognizing that noncitizens subjected to the three-year or ten-year bar may complete the period in the United States. For details, see <https://www.nwirp.org/our-work/impact-litigation/assets/velasco/VelascoPAdraft-v.4.1final.pdf>.

ing to the United States for a minimum of five years.⁸

Because of changes in US immigration policy in the last century, individuals who clandestinely return after deportation are subjected to new legal classifications and harsher punishments. In 1929, for example, Congress enacted the Undesirable Aliens Act, which for the first time criminalized unauthorized reentry into the United States and subjected undocumented returnees to up to two years' imprisonment.⁹ Decades later, the INA built on this framework, further establishing that individuals who return or attempt to return unlawfully after deportation could be prosecuted and charged as felons.¹⁰

During recent years, the practice of prosecuting undocumented returnees has become more common. The Department of Justice, for example, has actively prosecuted reentry without inspection along the US-Mexico border through practices such as Operation Streamline, which began in December 2005 in Del Rio, Texas (Dowling and Inda 2013).¹¹ Prosecutions for entry-related violations reached an all-time high in fiscal year 2019 when the US Attorneys' Offices charged 25,426 people with a felony for reentering the country without legal documentation (US Department of Justice 2019). Tellingly, prosecutions for immigration-related offenses represent one of the leading charges in federal courts in recent years (NIJC and NIPNLG 2022).

Under an amendment set forth by the Illegal Immigration Reform and Immigrant Responsibility Act in 1996, the punishment for those who are charged with an unauthorized reentry

was increased to include a fine and up to twenty years in prison. To be sure, incarceration time can vary greatly. According to a report by the US Sentencing Commission, the average prison sentence for individuals prosecuted for unauthorized reentry was eighteen months.¹² Moreover, not everyone who is arrested post-deportation without authorization is incarcerated. They might be held in an immigration detention center or immediately deported without necessarily being sent to jail. There are a few ways through which this may happen. First, immigration officers might deport returnees under a reinstatement order of removal.¹³ In fiscal year 2020, reinstatement orders accounted for 40 percent of all removals (American Immigration Council 2022). Alternatively, immigration officers may use their discretion to detain returnees without necessarily transferring them to prison, though it is difficult to ascertain how common this practice is using data presently available. Immigration officers may also place returnees under expedited removal if they are apprehended within one hundred miles of the US border within fourteen days of entering the United States (Kanstroom 2018). Taken together, these practices arguably render undocumented returnees forever subject to immediate deportation entirely outside the purview of immigration courts (see also, for example, Koh 2018).

THE SPECTRUM OF ENFORCEMENT AND ITS CONSEQUENCES

In conversation with recent efforts to expand conceptualizations of deportation as a system consisting of multiple phases (Patler and Jones

8. See Immigration and Naturalization Act, 8 U.S.C. § 1182(a)(9).

9. For a discussion about the legislative history and racist origin and implementation of the Undesirable Aliens Act of 1929, see Eric Fish's (2021) article, "Race, History, and Immigration Crimes."

10. See 8 U.S. Code § 1326 of the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965.

11. These practices are being actively challenged because of concerns regarding immigrants' due process rights and access to adequate legal counsel (Boehm 2016).

12. "Illegal Reentry Offenses." https://www.usssc.gov/sites/default/files/pdf/research-and-publications/research-projects-and-surveys/immigration/2015_Illegal-Reentry-Report.pdf.

13. Under INA Section 241(a)(5), individuals who return to the United States unlawfully following a deportation or removal order may have their initial removal order automatically reinstated (Chacón 2005).

2025, this issue) and a corridor encompassing different sites and actors (Drotbohm and Hasselberg 2015), this article examines how hyper-illegality is experienced across a broader spectrum (or continuum) of enforcement where, upon direct contact with the enforcement apparatus, it becomes increasingly difficult—if not nearly impossible—for individuals to exit the spectrum of enforcement with some form of legal status (Valdivia 2020). Rather than treating each (re)entry attempt, arrest, detention, and deportation as separate administrative events, the concept of the spectrum of enforcement situates these as part of a larger process in which each stage introduces its own set of challenges and compounds individuals' vulnerability. As individuals advance along the spectrum, the consequences from each stage—from initial entry to detention, deportation, and reentry—accumulate and enact a type of enforcement status onto the entire family (Valdivia, forthcoming).

Undocumented returnees are particularly vulnerable during their reentry attempts as they have undergone the physical harms and financial strains associated with the journey at least twice—once during their initial migration and again while seeking to return post-deportation—and often much more than that. Such journeys have become increasingly difficult for individuals attempting to enter without authorization through the US-Mexico border (Andreas 2009; Massey et al. 2002; Slack and Whiteford 2011). This is in part because of the intensification of enforcement practices through federal initiatives such as Prevention Through Deterrence that channel migrants through increasingly dangerous routes (De Leon 2015). These changes in policy, funding, and practice at the border have exposed migrants to a growing number of risks, including dehydration, hypothermia, and even death (Abrego 2014; Coutin 2005; De Leon 2015; Holmes 2013). For most migrants who cross with the assistance of a coyote (a person who helps migrants cross the border), the costs have also significantly increased (Menjívar and Abrego 2012; Ortmeier and Quinn 2012).

Returnees are also grappling with the distress and trauma associated with deportation

proceedings, which typically entail direct contact with immigration officers (and sometimes with police officers), a period of detention or incarceration, and ultimately deportation. To be sure, interactions with police officers—even for minor traffic violations—can place undocumented individuals in deportation proceedings (Armenta 2017; Golash-Boza 2015; Varsanyi et al. 2012). Consequently, undocumented immigrants and their loved ones (regardless of their individual immigration status) have learned to fear police officers (Enriquez 2015; Valdivia 2019). Indeed, the mere sight of law enforcement can engender psychosomatic symptoms such as a rapid heartbeat, sweaty palms, or sudden emotional breakdowns, even among US citizens whose parents are undocumented (Valdivia 2019). For returnees whose deportation was the result of an initial encounter with the police, these symptoms may be even more pronounced. Similarly, direct encounters with immigration officers are traumatic for both the individual who is being apprehended and any family members who witness the arrest (Lopez 2019). Immigration officers often rely on tactics of intimidation, deceit, and physical violence to conduct an arrest (Lopez 2019; Phillips et al. 2002; Valdivia 2020). Immigrant detention, too, has been found to be traumatic (Becerra et al. 2022; Ortega et al. 2015; Saadi et al. 2020; von Wertern et al. 2018). Having lived through the often-traumatic experiences of an arrest, detention, incarceration, and deportation, returnees may be even more worried about experiencing the entire process once again.

Returnees are also contending with significant financial hardships. An immigration arrest abruptly cuts household income in half (Chaudry et al. 2010) and requires spouses and adult children to assume greater financial responsibility (Dreby 2015; Golash-Boza 2019; Gonzalez and Patler 2020; Valdivia 2021). There is also the stigma associated with deportation, which makes it difficult for deportees to secure employment even in their countries of birth (Andrews 2023; Golash-Boza 2015). These circumstances may be compounded for returnees, who often undergo prolonged and repeated periods of separation during each de-

tention, incarceration, deportation, and reentry attempt.

With respect to deportees' intentions to return to the US, Jaqueline Hagan and colleagues (2008) note that many deportees have lived in the country for years prior and formed deep social ties; nearly 79 percent of respondents indicated that they had a spouse or child who lived in the United States. In a separate study conducted among Jamaican deportees, average time in the United States was twelve years (Headley et al. 2005). These ties—to loved ones, homes, schools, work, and communities—often compel deportees to seek reentry (Martínez et al. 2018; Vargas Valle et al. 2022). Intentions to return to the US are particularly high among deportees separated from young children (Escamilla García and Cerón 2025, this issue), especially among mothers (Vargas Valle et al. 2022). Thus, for many deportees, it is often a matter of when to attempt reentry, not if.

There is a need, therefore, for new conceptual tools that consider and analyze the intensification and deepening of the legal, material, socioemotional, and physical hardships that individuals encounter as they attempt to recross the US-Mexico border and navigate everyday life unauthorized in the United States post-deportation. To some extent, these hardships certainly overlap with those encountered pre-deportation, and as such are experienced by un-

documented immigrants who live in the country without previous deportation records. There is also overlap in experiences between those who reenter post-deportation and those who have been deported and never returned. However, because of the repeated and often chronic nature of immigration arrests, detentions, deportations, and reentry attempts, I argue that we should recognize a spectrum along which there is, after deportation, a significant point of transition for individuals—from illegality to hyper-illegality—that is characterized by a new legal classification, harsher punishments, and accumulated hardships. In the remainder of this article, I utilize qualitative data to further theorize the socio-legal production of hyper-illegality and the compounding experiences of hardship and inequality that undocumented returnees and their loved ones endure.

METHODS

In this article, I draw from 113 in-depth interviews with undocumented returnees and their family members (see table 1 for a summary of participant characteristics). Data come from two separate but related studies. The first study centered on the consequences of immigration enforcement on young adults and their families, including how deportations impact their well-being, family life, and educational experiences, among other key facets of their lives.

Table 1. Participant Characteristics

Number of participants	113
Age of participants (range)	18–74 years old
Year when latest deportation occurred (range)	1995–2022
Sex	
Female	68
Male	45
Country of birth	
Mexico	64
United States	47
Central America	2
Contact with enforcement	
Directly experienced a deportation	21
Has an immediate family member who was deported	92

Source: Author's compilation.

The second study focused solely on the experiences of undocumented returnees and their families. In most cases, those deported were husbands or fathers. Notably, some individuals experienced the deportation of more than one family member (that is, both parents, or a parent and a sibling, were deported, either together or on separate occasions). Participants primarily resided in southern California, including San Diego, Orange County, and Los Angeles.

Several participants experienced one deportation and, at the time of the interview, were living in the United States without authorization once again. Others experienced anywhere from two to twelve separate deportations or reunifications. Deportations in this sample were often initiated by contact with police while driving. This parallels existing literature on enforcement that documents the police-to-immigration custody pipeline (Armenta 2017; Golash-Boza 2015). There were also instances in which employers reported individuals to immigration authorities. Given the hardships associated with seeking a legal reentry, most participants returned to the United States unauthorized. Thus, the findings primarily focus on those experiences. The very few individuals who were able to return legally had to secure legal representation, widespread public support, and approved waivers of inadmissibility.

To recruit participants, I (with support from research assistants) drew on preexisting networks and snowball sampling. This included relationships I had fostered over the years with immigrant rights organizers, teachers, counselors, social service providers, and immigration lawyers—many of whom kindly shared the recruitment flyer with the people they serve. Participants then self-selected after reviewing the flyer, which included project information and eligibility requirements. Participants were also reminded before and during the interview that they could discontinue at any time; however, no one chose to do so. At the end of each interview, participants were encouraged to share information about the project with anyone they knew who might be interested. Some participants opted not to share the flyer with family members (often because they felt their loved ones were not ready to discuss the topic) or

shared it but their relatives did not follow up to schedule an interview.

Many participants were women and young adults whose loved ones were deported. This reflects the larger population of women and adult children who are often left behind in the aftermath of a father's deportation (Dreby 2015; Golash-Boza and Hondagneu-Sotelo 2013). Because most participants were women and young adults who had lived in the US for over a decade and were part of immigrant networks, the findings in this article may be more representative of individuals who have some level of support, even if limited in many cases. Moreover, the stories captured in this study likely reflect the experiences of those who were, to some extent, emotionally able to engage in conversations about deeply distressing situations. As a result, those who endured particularly severe trauma may have been unintentionally excluded. For many participants, the interview marked the first opportunity to reflect on their encounters with enforcement—particularly with someone outside their immediate family. Many had been navigating these experiences in isolation. Consequently, the interviews illuminate the profound and often enduring harms suffered by returnees and their loved ones, both in the immediate aftermath and over time.

Given the legal and physical hardships associated with reentering the United States post-deportation without authorization, I was especially concerned with participants' privacy, safety, and confidentiality from the outset of this work. Thus, I created a robust data security plan for both studies that was approved by the Institutional Review Board (IRB). I also secured a Certificate of Confidentiality from the National Institutes of Health (NIH), which allows researchers to legally refuse to disclose information that may identify the participant in any federal, state, or local civil, criminal, administrative, legislative, or other proceedings, for example, if there is a court subpoena (National Institutes of Health 2024). I have replaced the names of participants, their relatives, and friends with pseudonyms.

A team of graduate and undergraduate research assistants, along with me, read the seventy-one transcripts closely, line-by-line,

and created labels using Dedoose (qualitative coding software) to identify emerging patterns. (The other forty-two interviews came from a separate study that I conducted alone. I read and coded through those interviews independently.) We created labels to categorize participants' responses that reflected themes within and outside the existing literature on illegality and enforcement. This included labels such as "apprehension," to capture instances where participants spoke about the nature and type of arrest; "reentry attempts," to refer to the method and costs of reentry; "deportation: housing," to capture families' decisions about where to live following a loved one's deportation; "family: strategies," to describe the set of strategies that individuals adopted to protect their families from experiencing another separation; and, "reunification: factors," to capture families' decisions about reuniting post-deportation. The analysis followed a constructivist grounded theory approach (Charmaz 2000; Glaser and Strauss 2017), as I was primarily concerned with understanding how participants made sense of their own experiences and their interpretations of their various deportations, separations, and reunifications. Through the lens of undocumented returnees and their loved ones, we can better understand the production and condition of hyper-illegality.

THE LEGAL PRODUCTION OF HYPER-ILLEGALITY: A CHANGED RELATIONSHIP TO THE STATE

Individuals who have been deported understand that returning to the United States after deportation introduces a new legal classification and additional risks. Although respondents rarely used the term "felon" to describe such classification, many used words such as "criminal," "charges," and "records," and phrases like "getting caught" or "locked up" to describe their experiences following reentry. Their sense of criminality often crystallized upon their return to the United States, particularly at the moment they were apprehended once again—frequently in their homes or workplaces—and found to be unauthorized. This experience of rearrest powerfully reinforced their internalization of criminal status. More than a dozen participants brought this up organically

during interviews—not in response to direct questions about criminality, but when reflecting on the circumstances of their arrest. Carlos, a sixty-five-year-old returnee who was arrested outside his work upon returning to the US post-deportation, recalled that during his arrest he "was freaking out. Like, 'What the hell is going on? Yeah, I came back undocumented. I didn't kill anybody. I didn't rob anybody.' I couldn't believe what was happening." While the nature of immigration arrests varies, it typically consists of armed agents surrounding a person in ways that resemble police raids (Lopez 2019). These tactics cement returnees' association with criminality. Respondents often rejected this form of criminalization by making a distinction between immigration violations, which in their view should not be considered crimes, and what they perceived to be actual crimes that involve drinking, drugs, violence, or murder.

This sense of criminality also extends to US citizens who bear witness to their loved ones' arrests. Sonia, who was born in San Diego and whose parents returned to the US post-deportation, was with them the day ICE officers rearrested them at their home. She described the moment as follows:

It was maybe a good two years since they'd returned [from their previous deportation] when I don't know how ICE found out my parents were back in the United States, and they surrounded our house. So, I witnessed them; at the moment I didn't know it was ICE. I would watch a lot of movies, so I thought it was like a squad or something else. I was just like, "What's going on, why are they here?" But I remember my parents telling me, "Duck down! Don't make noise." So, I felt like a criminal at the moment because we were hiding from the law, from these people.

When describing their new legal classification, respondents often used the terms "criminal" and "bad" interchangeably. Sonia, for example, added that ever since the arrest, she "started distrusting authority because I felt like I was the criminal, or I felt like I was the bad one on the other end of that spectrum." It is crucial to understand these distinctions within the

broader public narrative that categorizes immigrants into two groups: “good” and “bad” (Andrews 2018; Patler and Gonzales 2015). The “good immigrant” generally represents someone who is hardworking, academically driven, and possesses a clean criminal record, and is thereby deemed deserving of citizenship rights. In contrast, the “bad immigrant” is often defined by their involvement in criminal activity. However, the emergence of hyper-illegality complicates this dichotomy. Returnees—who might have once exemplified the good immigrant archetype—are now being reclassified and treated as bad immigrants, even when they continue to exhibit attributes traditionally associated with a good immigrant, such as diligence and industriousness.

As returnees and their family members struggle with this new legal characterization, they draw clear distinctions between their experiences having returned to the US post-deportation and those of people who are also undocumented but have no deportation history. Through the lens of returnees, individuals who have never been deported have a different perception. Mauricio, a sixty-nine-year-old man who had been deported on multiple occasions, explained that “while the person that has never been deported knows, ‘Oh I’m gonna [get] sent back to Mexico,’ and that’s as far as it goes. And this person probably thinks, ‘Oh I’ll go back, I [have] family here and have money in the bank . . .’ whereas a person who [has been deported] knows that they can go back to prison if they get caught.” Returnees like Mauricio are subjected to a double risk: deportation and incarceration. This important distinction characterizes the legal production of hyper-illegality for undocumented returnees and leads to a different type of consciousness when compared to undocumented individuals who have never been deported. Like Mauricio, others similarly shared examples of how undocumented individuals without deportation records may think or behave differently from them to illustrate the new legal considerations that they—as undocumented returnees—must navigate. More than two dozen participants mentioned this double risk organically, often when discussing their hesitation to reunite with family in the United States post-deportation or their height-

ened fears about encountering immigration officers.

The double risk of deportation and incarceration that returnees contend with is also compounded. Having gone through the experience of being arrested, detained, incarcerated, and deported, returnees know how traumatizing the entire process is and are fearful of having to relive it. Laura, a fifty-five-year-old mother of five children, for example, was initially deported after falling victim to notary fraud. ICE officers arrested Laura in her home and proceeded to detain her before deporting her to Mexicali, Mexico. Years later, two of Laura’s children were deported on separate occasions and for different reasons. At the time of the interview, Laura was living in the United States once again post-deportation. When asked to reflect on her experiences in the United States while undocumented—both before and after her deportation—she said, “Truthfully, I was not afraid before. I was after. After this [her deportation and subsequent return] happened, it’s when you live in fear all the time, in fear that anything can happen, and you’ll have another deportation. Additionally, I’m also suffering all the time because some of my children are over there [in Mexico].” Following her return to the United States, Laura lived in great fear of being deported once again. She recalled that her fear was particularly acute during the first few years; she suffered from deep anxiety and struggled to sleep. At one point, Laura began blocking her front door with furniture for fear that ICE officers could break into her home. Laura’s experience is illustrative of the acute fear that returnees experience. Like Laura, Carlos aptly noted, “I had gone through [a deportation] before, and to know what was ahead was terrible.” Over the course of their lives, many returnees like Laura are also impacted by the deportation of others, including that of immediate family members. Those deportations are the source of additional suffering, especially when they puncture close relationships between spouses, siblings, or parents and their children.

The double risk of deportation and incarceration is a primary concern for entire families as they contemplate the prospect of reunification. Karen, a twenty-five-year-old US

citizen whose father was deported in 2019, explained that their “biggest concern was getting caught again. Just because in 2019, my mom kept saying stuff and friends and family kept saying, ‘Oh, if he gets caught, he’s not going to get deported and sent back; he’s going to go to jail.’ So, getting caught, overall [means] getting jail time.” Aware of the risks associated with unauthorized reentries, families may be extra cautious during their loved one’s reentry attempts. They may, for example, refrain from telling others about their plans to reenter, or they may go to great lengths to try and guarantee a successful reentry.

Other returnees and their families may feel resigned to remain separated. Sergio, for example, is a thirty-eight-year-old whose ex-wife and children reside in the United States while he lives in Mexico. After his first deportation, Sergio managed to return to the US without authorization, but he was apprehended and detained again. He then served forty-four months in federal prison for unlawfully reentering post-deportation. At the time of the interview, Sergio was living in Durango, Mexico, with a new partner and had no plans of attempting to cross the border again, though he hoped that he might someday adjust his immigration status.

Many others eventually gave up hope of obtaining some type of legal protection. Roughly twenty-five participants indicated consulting with an immigration lawyer about their case (or their loved one’s) to no avail. Lawyers either refused to take their case or informed them that there were no options for adjusting under current US immigration law given their deportation history. In some cases, lawyers recommended that clients obtain their immigration records to better evaluate their situation; however, fear of being flagged in the immigration system often deterred them from doing so. Ricardo, a twenty-eight-year-old man who returned to the US post-deportation without authorization, consulted with multiple lawyers to see if he could qualify for DACA. Although Ricardo met most of the eligibility requirements, he had an existing deportation record. Every lawyer that Ricardo spoke to cautioned him against applying for DACA and encouraged him instead to obtain his immigration records to see what kind of deportation he had undergone

(that is, a voluntary departure or a formal deportation). Ricardo eventually stopped looking into DACA, adding, “Lawyers are not cheap; they’re not cheap. So, I have to pay a lawyer every time I go and talk to them just to tell me that they can’t help me because of the letters [of deportation]. There was no point for me to continue, so I just gave up.” The inability to apply for some form of legal protection represents a legal consequence—or punishment—for returnees who have strong ties to the United States. Many often reach a point where they give up hope and stop seeking consultations. This type of legal barrier marks an important distinction and a turning point among undocumented returnees—many of whom held on to the hope of being able to adjust their immigration status before their deportations and shortly after—with harmful repercussions on their well-being and long-term prospects.

Similarly, Raúl, a forty-seven-year-old man, eventually felt hopeless about his ability to legally return to the United States post-deportation. He was initially deported after applying for his driver’s license in California under Assembly Bill 60 (AB 60). At the time, immigration officers issued him the ten-year bar and warned him against attempting to return. Raúl explained, “[Immigration officers] told me that if I returned, they would detain me in prison, but they didn’t. It’s a deportation when they say, ‘you’re deported, and you can’t come back.’ And they told me that I had ten years [of a bar], and I went again, but they didn’t send me to prison.” During his attempt to reenter the United States without authorization, immigration officers apprehended Raúl and proceeded to deport him. Since then, Raúl has lived in Mexico, but struggles with securing employment and making ends meet. At the time of the interview, Raúl had given up hope that he would one day be able to adjust his status because of his deportation history.

Carrying the responsibility of securing a loved one’s safe return or resolving their immigration status—and coping with the disillusionment that can follow—can be an overwhelming burden for the children of undocumented returnees. When Agustin, a US citizen, turned twenty-one-years-old, he consulted with an immigration attorney about the

possibility of adjusting his parents' immigration status. This is when Agustin learned that it would be safer for them to submit only his mother's application because she did not have a previous deportation, whereas his father did. Agustin described this painful recognition as follows: "I remember after the immigration [lawyer] appointment, I went to go talk to my dad, like, 'Oh this is what they told us.' He didn't say anything. So, I felt like a bad son, or I don't know how to . . . putting in the paperwork for my mom and excluding my dad. I don't know. That guilt made me not want to go and proceed with the paperwork anymore." Agustin's experience mirrors existing studies that discuss the ripple effects of illegality on the entire family (Abrego 2019; Castañeda 2019; Dreby 2015; Gonzales 2015; Valdivia 2019), and young adults' unique role in seeking legal immigration-related advice and services for their parents (Delgado 2020; García Valdivia 2022; Valdivia 2021). At a deeper level, the experiences of young adults like Agustin reveal how hyper-illegality creates a new type of division within undocumented and mixed-status families—one based not only on an individual's immigration status but also on whether the individual has a previous deportation record. In the context of hyper-illegality, the guilt that US citizen children may internalize when they are prevented from extending their citizenship privileges to a loved one is further complicated by the realization that, while they may be able to seek an adjustment of status request for one parent (who is undocumented and has never been deported), they cannot extend the same privilege to the other parent (who is undocumented and has an existing deportation record).

THE CONDITION OF HYPER-ILLEGALITY: COMPOUNDING BARRIERS AND HARMS

Having established hyper-illegality as an emerging sociolegal category that is characterized by harsher legal classifications and punishments, I next turn to its condition from the perspective of undocumented returnees and their loved ones. Just as hyper-illegality can be understood as representing a changed structural relationship to the state in legal terms, my

research suggests that it alters social norms marked by heightened financial instability, emotional and psychological trauma, and social exclusion.

Hyper-illegality often deepens and intensifies families' already precarious conditions. Upon returning to the US post-deportation, individuals take great caution to avoid potential encounters with law or immigration enforcement. To this end, some refrain from driving altogether and rely instead on rides or public transportation. This poses significant challenges to their ability to work in occupations that require extensive travel. Others are concerned about returning to their previous jobs for fear of being detected again and either refrain from working altogether or opt for jobs that are relatively safer. Alyssa, a twenty-four-year-old US citizen whose mother returned to the United States in 2011 after being deported that same year, explained, "Before she was deported, she was working at a different job. At that job, I believe ICE showed up. She was working at a restaurant job, and when she got there one morning to get to work, that's when she was deported. And then when she came back, she didn't want to work there anymore because she didn't want that situation to happen again, so she took some time off work to find a better and safer job where immigration raids don't happen." While Alyssa's mother was ultimately able to secure employment in the service industry once she returned to the US post-deportation, this did not come without a cost. Following reentry, undocumented returnees often undergo periods of unemployment as they search for jobs that may be safer. While these new jobs may afford them some level of protection, they are often characterized by lower wages or vulnerable working conditions. Some, for example, felt safer working in jobs that paid in cash. This allowed them to avoid having their names and other personal information stored in employment records, yet it exposed them to the possibility that their employer would not compensate them adequately or on time.

In concert with, but also in addition to, such financial hardships, undocumented returnees are coping with accumulated trauma alongside added distress and anguish when attempting

to reunite. Financial and emotional hardships can coexist in ways that prevent the hyper-illegalized from returning to their previous roles. When asked about the main challenges that her family encountered following her father's return to the United States post-deportation, Alexis (a twenty-five-year-old) recounted:

I think one thing was the financial difficulties. I think the arrest really affected my dad. I'm not sure. I wouldn't say self-esteem. I just think his persona. I think he also lived with this fear that he couldn't just get any job anymore. I don't know. I think just a level of stress. Maybe he was just scared to have to experience what he went through because obviously we don't . . . he didn't share with us, as we got older, all the stuff that happened to him and then things like that. But I think he was probably experiencing some form of PTSD from what he experienced. So, he was probably emotionally just going through a lot, and I think it just took a lot from him to be able to live in the United States. I think there was this fear of not wanting to go to places because of whatever it is. So, I think it did take time for him to step into this financially providing role once again.

These conditions compelled Alexis's mother to continue working additional jobs even after her father returned to the United States. The financial and emotional toll of each subsequent arrest can linger and intensify as members grapple with the legal ramifications of a deportation history.

Although individuals with an unauthorized entry or reentry endure the omnipresent threat of deportation, subjective levels of risk can vary according to several factors, such as age at migration, city and state of residence, gender, race-ethnicity, and their perceived (in)visibility to record-keeping institutions (Abrego 2011; Asad 2020; García 2019; Schmalzbauer 2014; Simmons et al. 2021). I demonstrate that another key point of divergence stems from whether the individual has an existing deportation history. Participants frequently made comparisons to their previous selves (that is, as undocumented immigrants without deportation

records) and explained that they began to experience "more," "added," "different," or "extra" fears the moment they returned to the US post-deportation without authorization. Through their lens, the moment of reentry marked a significant shift in their subjective levels of fear and vulnerability.

Family members, too, observed these changes. Ponce, a twenty-four-year-old whose parents returned to the US after deportation, explained, "I guess each time that they came . . . they came back more worried." Claribel, a mother of four whose partner is in the US post-deportation without authorization, similarly explained that "when we arrived in this country . . . it's the fear of the police and ICE. You see a sheriff and you're scared. The fear that stays after a deportation is double." Ana, a forty-year-old woman, also noted, "You can imagine, without papers you already live with that fear, and then having a deportation record—it is like adding even more to the fear." More than forty participants directly expressed their (or their loved one's) added fears and worries following reentry after deportation, including instances of becoming more "reserved," "obsessive" (about knowing their loved one's whereabouts to ensure their safety), "paranoid," "vigilant," and, for one person, "aggressive."

When Ricardo, a father of four, reunited with his family in the US post-deportation, there was a brief period of sheer joy, relief, and hope that things would return to normal. Yet it was difficult for the family to feel entirely safe and relieved. Ricardo's son, Victor, recalled, "We were just overwhelmed with happiness. We wanted to be back with our old routine . . . having coffee . . . but my dad was always paranoid. He's like, 'hold on,' He would always be following his instincts, just looking around. I just think the way his behavior was, in a way, just like the military . . . PTSD." Victor and his sister (Karina) both described noticeable changes in their father's mindset and behavior upon his return. They spoke about the way their father started to question unfamiliar vehicles that parked near their home and became suspicious that there were cameras inside those vehicles spying on them. These preoccupations did not exist before Ricardo's deportation. Rather, they began the moment

he returned to the United States without authorization. Others similarly noticed that their loved ones “never came back the same” or that it was not “the same person that returned.”

Tellingly, even formerly undocumented returnees who eventually gain a legal reentry into the United States may grapple with the effects of hyper-illegality, including a set of heightened fears. In 2022, I interviewed Rosa (a US citizen who was formerly undocumented for more than five years) and her daughter Sophia (a US-born citizen). They both recounted how Ismael (the head of the household) was deported on two separate occasions. After his first deportation, he returned unauthorized. At that point, Rosa and Sophia explained, it was relatively easier to cross the US-Mexico border clandestinely. After his second deportation, it took extensive help (from an immigration lawyer, media coverage, more than one hundred letters of support from community members who had come to know Ismael, and his family, who gathered supporting evidence about his moral character and contributions to the country) for immigration officers to allow Ismael to legally return through parole. Yet the Mireles family continued to live in fear. Rosa described these mixed emotions: “We cried a lot, but even though we had that victory, because it was a victory that no one could believe, even then there was a void. An awful fear. He didn’t want to leave the house. He said he felt strange. We were all living with an awful fear even though he was able to legally return.” The Mireles family continued to live with this awful fear for at least another year and a half while Ismael awaited a decision about his ability to stay in the country permanently. Under the terms of his parole, he had been granted only a one-year period of lawful stay, after which the family had to apply for a more permanent solution. However, before the Mireles family heard about the results of Ismael’s application, he was diagnosed with terminal cancer and passed away shortly after. The doctor and family did not know the exact cause of Ismael’s cancer (he was otherwise healthy). Nevertheless, they agreed that the extreme stress he endured while undocumented—facing deportation proceedings twice and navigating reentry twice—had a severe impact on his mental and physical health.

In the present era of mass deportations and diminishing pathways to US citizenship (Chen 2020; Golash-Boza 2015), the effects of hyper-illegality are likely felt on a larger scale and for longer periods, with even legal reentry unable to shield returnees from its detrimental impact. This is especially the case if individuals are allowed to return only on a temporary basis such as through parole. If individuals are allowed to reenter on a more permanent basis, or with the promise of future security, the effects of hyper-illegality may be significantly reduced.

The acute level of fear, vigilance, and paranoia that is associated with hyper-illegality can impact the entire family for prolonged periods, regardless of members’ individual immigration status. Participants and their loved ones experienced sudden emotional breakdowns, recurrent immigration nightmares, and increased levels of stress. Esmeralda, a college student, shared that her younger brother, who is a US citizen, continues to have immigration-related nightmares even years after their father’s return to the United States. In chilling detail, Esmeralda described one of his recent nightmares: “I think two days ago my little brother woke up scared. He said that he dreamt that everybody was gone. I was like, ‘What do you mean?’ He’s like, ‘Yeah, I got home, and everybody was gone.’ And I was like, ‘Well, what do you mean we were gone?’ He’s like, ‘Yeah, I dreamt that nobody was home.’ Esmeralda interpreted this nightmare as a sign that her brother was still grappling with their father’s deportation and subsequent return. Now that their father had returned, so did the fear that he could be taken away once again. Rather than creating a sense of relief and closure, their father’s return instead engendered acute fear and anxiety.

These increased levels of fear and vigilance following reentry impact family members’ ability to access various services, resources, and opportunities. Families avoid interacting with a wider range of institutions, including hospitals and dental clinics. Ana Paola powerfully described her partner “as a ghost” because he was absent from key institutions, records, and public spaces even though he was back in the country. Others are careful not to leave traces

of their loved one's whereabouts. They remove pictures of them from social media. They leave out their contact information from school or medical forms. In other instances, they leave out their names from apartment leases and insurance plans. Some of the young adults I interviewed refrained from including their parent's name, address, employment, and income information on their Free Application for Federal Student Aid application even though they qualified and needed the financial assistance.

Such added fears frequently prevent undocumented returnees from applying for a driver's license. Alma, a twenty-nine-year-old US citizen, told her mother—who returned to the US post-deportation without authorization—not to apply for a driver's license: “My fear is if she goes to try and attempt to get a driver's license that ICE can come and pick her up if they find her location due to her not having legal status. I just feel like they can come pick her up from home.” Notably, Alma and her mother live in California, where eligible undocumented immigrants can receive a driver's license under AB 60 as of January 5, 2015.¹⁴ However, I find that families like Alma's, who are subjected to hyper-illegality, are especially vigilant about their interactions with social service providers and government authorities. This is in part because they have heard from news media outlets or others that immigration officers have access to databases maintained by the Department of Motor Vehicles (the agency responsible for issuing driver's licenses, including those under AB 60) and that they use the information to target individuals who have returned to the US post-deportation without authorization.¹⁵

Awareness about this differential treatment and criminalization compels returnees and their loved ones to forgo opportunities otherwise available to undocumented immigrants without a deportation record. Laura explained the difference in treatment and fears (and ultimately in the ability to obtain a driver's license) based on whether an individual has a deportation record or not. She noted, “I haven't gone

because I'm scared to apply. Because they [the DMV] can share my information with immigration. In my case, because I have a previous deportation, I feel like it's more complicated. If I hadn't gone through a deportation, I would apply. I know people who don't have papers but haven't gone through a deportation, and they have their licenses. Because I know that here in California, a person can apply for a license. But I'm scared because of what I went through.” Like Laura, other participants drew comparisons between what undocumented immigrants could do depending on whether they had an existing deportation record. They also frequently made comparisons across their own life spans—between their “pre” and “post” reentry experiences. Having a deportation record marked an important transformation in their own legal and relational consciousness that uniquely shaped their participation—or lack thereof—across various social institutions.

From the literature on system avoidance, we know that individuals who have some type of contact with the criminal legal system limit their interaction with other social service institutions (Brayne 2014, 2021; Goffman 2009; Haskins and Jacobsen 2017). A similar pattern emerges in the immigration context, where individuals from undocumented and mixed-status families limit their engagement with surveillance institutions (Asad 2020; Desai et al. 2019; Patler and Gonzalez 2021). In the context of hyper-illegality, families are particularly concerned that information about their immigration status and their deportation history may be revealed to immigration authorities during the process of accessing resources. As they navigate everyday life in the US after deportation, returnees and their families come to develop a unique frame of reference, where an existing deportation record represents a source of new barriers and limitations, and subsequently requires a new set of strategies. Thus, the concept of hyper-illegality reveals the potential for segments of the immigrant popula-

14. Under AB 60, eligible undocumented immigrants can receive a driver's license in the state of California.

15. These fears are not unfounded. As the geographies of deportability expand and intensify, an increasing number of settings and social actors are becoming implicated in the enforcement of immigration law (Valdivia 2019).

tion to endure more extreme forms of system avoidance.

DISCUSSION

The concept of hyper-illegality makes visible how the growing criminalization of immigrants—and other particular groups within the context of incarceration—produces cyclical and compounding forms of legal and social exclusion. For instance, undocumented returnees often face escalating legal penalties with each deportation and subsequent clandestine reentry, moving from five- to ten-year bars and eventually to permanent exclusion. Similarly, in the context of incarceration, individuals released on probation or parole risk accumulating sanctions or punishments if they violate the terms of their release, further entrenching their criminalized status (Alexander 2010; Lin 2010). These dynamics contribute to an enduring condition of legal precarity among noncitizens and citizens alike, whereby individuals occupy a liminal status akin to being “citizens-with-an-asterisk”—permanently marked by conditional belonging and heightened vulnerability to state surveillance and punishment (see also, for example, Chacón 2015). These findings reveal the stickiness of deportation and criminal histories in an individual’s life course.

The political climate also matters for how hyper-illegality is produced and experienced. In the case of Donald J. Trump’s second presidential administration, the implementation of the Alien Registration Requirement (ARR) revives Section 262 of the INA that requires noncitizens fourteen years or older who are “present in the United States without admission or parole” to register, have their fingerprints taken, and carry with them registration documents (USCIS 2025). Among scholars, immigration lawyers, policymakers, and organizers alike, the ARR raises significant concerns about the ability of the state to identify and criminalize individuals who fail to register or carry proof of registration with them. Notably, noncitizens who do not register could be charged with a fine of up to \$5,000 or up to six months’ imprisonment, and those who do not carry proof of registration face similar punishments (a fine of up to \$5,000 or up to 30 days’ imprisonment)

(NILC 2025). The ARR represents a recent and clear example of hyper-illegality—in this case, by subjecting both undocumented immigrants and green card holders who may have never been in contact with either law or immigration enforcement to the criminal justice system. In this scenario, the revival of Section 262 of the INA represents the state’s attempt to enact harsher punishments for a growing segment of the immigrant population—namely, noncitizens who are in the US without admission or parole, and those who are lawfully present but fail to carry proof of registration.

The concept of hyper-illegality allows us to gain a deeper understanding of the process through which individuals internalize and contest notions of criminality. Among undocumented returnees, their sense of being treated as a criminal or bad person often solidified at the moment immigration officers arrested them once again after reentering the country. Notably, it was not the initial arrest that instilled a sense of criminality; rather, the subsequent arrest(s) following reentry did. Relatedly, many of them rejected the state’s attempt to criminalize their behavior and drew a line between immigration-related violations (such as an unauthorized entry or reentry) and criminal charges involving alcohol or drug use, murder, or violence.

By focusing on the experiences of undocumented returnees and their loved ones, we also come to see that individuals benchmark changes in their legal conditions over the course of their lives in ways that scholars have not yet fully appreciated. Returnees are often cognizant of their undocumented experience both pre- and post-deportation, including changes in their perception, emotions, and behaviors. They also compare their legal circumstances to those of others who may be undocumented but do not have a deportation record. This type of personal benchmarking helps returnees make sense of their current situation, including their prospects for legalization.

To be sure, participants in this study knew that they had an existing deportation history and could remember aspects of their deportation experience. Although it is outside the scope of this article, there is another group af-

affected by hyper-illegality that warrants further attention. This includes individuals who have been deported in absentia. That is, they may have been ordered deported but never attended court. This group may be living in the United States unaware they have a deportation order, or outside the country, having unknowingly executed their deportation order when they left for an emergency (Caldwell 2019). Future studies can explore the role that self-awareness of one's enforcement status plays in how people experience the effects of hyper-illegality.

Another dimension of hyper-illegality that necessitates further research concerns the use of surveillance and technology to increasingly target individuals with existing deportation histories. Here, the work of legal scholar Anil Kalhan (2014) on the "immigration surveillance state" and sociologist Ana Muñoz (2022) on "borderland circuitry" can be particularly helpful. Research questions requiring additional attention include: How do immigration agencies collect, store, share, and utilize information about an individual's arrest, detention, and deportation records? How does the fact that an individual's deportation history follows them throughout their life shape their interaction with—or avoidance of—various social institutions over the long term?

As an emerging sociolegal construct, hyper-illegality presents significant themes that warrant further investigation. For example, analyses on the benefits and limitations of DACA, which has helped to ease some of the fear associated with deportation (Abrego 2018; Aranda et al. 2021; Gonzales et al. 2014; Gonzales 2015; Patler et al. 2021; Wong and Valdivia 2014), could be deepened by incorporating the experiences of those who are excluded because of criminal or deportation records (see, for example, Muñoz 2022 for a discussion on how young men who were profiled and labeled in gang databases were left out of DACA). Similarly, our understanding of processes of disclosure and concealment as they relate to one's immigration status (Cebulko 2014; Patler 2018) could be enriched by examining how families affected by hyper-illegality engage in double disclosures and concealments (see, for example, Valdivia and Monreal 2024). Future research could also examine how political rhetoric may mitigate or

exacerbate the production and condition of hyper-illegality. In other areas of scholarship, the concept of hyper-illegality can facilitate conversations about the state's ability to impose harsher punishments on select groups and, in turn, shape consciousness and behavior among those directly targeted and their families. For all these avenues of inquiry, and more, the theorization of hyper-illegality offers an important step toward better understanding an understudied yet growing segment of the undocumented—and more broadly, criminalized—population.

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